

A MEMOIR OF PROTECTING USERS, RESILIENCE,
AND THE FOUNDING OF BINANCE



Freedom Of Money

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Preface

This book is written in the first person, from my perspective. I dictated most of it during late-night sessions in Dubai, recorded on my phone, then worked with Patrick Hillmann to organize and polish the material. Rachel Conlan helped with research and fact-checking. Yi He reviewed every chapter for accuracy. The stories, opinions, and experiences are entirely mine. The editors helped make it readable—I tend to ramble when I talk.

I am an engineer, not a professional writer. My English is functional but not elegant. I learned it at 12 in Vancouver, and I still think in a mix of Chinese and code. If this book reads too smoothly in places, that's Patrick's work. If some parts sound like an engineer explaining things, that's the real me.

When I describe events that are publicly documented—dates of regulatory actions, court filings, company announcements, published news reports—I have verified them against primary sources. Where there are discrepancies in public records, I have noted them. Where I am uncertain, I have said so.

When I describe my own thoughts, feelings, and motivations, I have tried to be honest. This is harder than it sounds. I don't remember everything perfectly. I was running on 3 hours of sleep for most of 2017. Some details are hazy. I've tried to distinguish between what I knew at the time and what I learned later, between what I felt then and what I feel now.

When I describe conversations or interactions with others, I am working from memory unless direct quotes are sourced from public records. I have not invented dialogue. Where I cannot recall specifics with confidence, I

have described the general nature of the exchange rather than putting words in anyone's mouth.

Some details—particularly about my family, my specific whereabouts during certain periods, and the precise mechanics of my personal finances—are not included here. This is not because they are scandalous or because I am hiding anything. It is because they are private, and because the story I want to tell does not require their disclosure.

The chapters about my prison experience (48–52) deserve special mention. The facts of my incarceration—where I was held, for how long, under what conditions—are matters of public record. The internal experience of that time is mine alone. I have tried to convey what it felt like without overstating what I can know or claiming insights I did not have. If other inmates recognized me, I have not named them. If guards treated me well or poorly, I have described the experience without attributing motives I cannot verify.

I have also tried to be fair to those who opposed me. Regulators, prosecutors, journalists, competitors—I may disagree with their conclusions or their methods, but I have tried to represent their positions accurately. Where I quote from legal documents or news reports, I have done so carefully, with attention to context.

Finally, a word about the title. “Freedom of Money” has been Binance’s stated mission since the early days: to increase the freedom of money globally. I believed in this mission when I wrote it, and I believe in a version of it still. But this book is also about the limits of that freedom, the responsibilities that come with it, and the price one pays for confusing the freedom to build with freedom from consequence.

If you are reading this hoping for confirmation that cryptocurrency will replace traditional finance, or that I was unjustly persecuted, or that the system is rigged against innovators—you will not find simple answers

here. What you will find is a story about building something, watching it grow beyond your intentions, and ultimately being held accountable for its failures.

That story is mine. But I hope it has lessons for others who are building, or who will build, in the uncertain space between what technology makes possible and what society decides to permit.

—CZ

Dubai, 2025

Acknowledgments

Writing a memoir is a solitary act, but the life it describes was not lived alone. I owe debts to many people, some of whom I can name and some of whom I cannot.

To Patrick Hillmann, who worked with me on this book, who listened to hours of my recorded ramblings and helped turn them into something organized. You found the structure in my stories.

To Yi He, who has been my partner in every sense of the word—for your patience, your honesty, and your willingness to tell me when I am wrong. You have saved me from myself more times than I can count. You also reviewed every chapter to make sure I didn't misremember too badly.

To Rachel Conlan, who helped with research and fact-checking. Your attention to detail saved me from several embarrassing errors.

To my parents, who left everything familiar behind so that I might have opportunities they never had. I did not always understand the sacrifices you made. I understand them better now.

To the early Binance team—the engineers who stayed up all night during the 2017 bull market, the customer support staff who answered thousands of tickets a day, the security researchers who treated every bug report as a potential catastrophe. You built something extraordinary. I hope the compromises I made did not damage it beyond repair.

To my legal team, who guided me through the most difficult period of my life with professionalism and integrity. You taught me that the law is not an obstacle to be engineered around, but a framework within which one must operate.

To the friends who wrote letters to the court on my behalf, and to the many more who offered support privately. Your belief in me exceeded my belief in myself at times.

To the readers who have followed my journey through social media posts and news articles, who have criticized me when I deserved it and defended me when they thought I didn't—your engagement, even when negative, has forced me to think more clearly about what I am doing and why.

To the prosecutors and regulators who investigated Binance and me. I do not agree with all of your conclusions, but I understand now that you are doing your jobs. The system you represent is imperfect, but it is not arbitrary. I wish I had understood that sooner.

To the inmates I met in prison, whose names I will not disclose. You taught me more about resilience and dignity than any business book ever could.

To the team at Giggle Academy, who have taken a vague idea and turned it into something real. Your work represents the future I want to build.

And to the readers of this book, whoever you are. You have given me your time, which is the most valuable thing any of us has. I have tried to make this book worth that investment.

Any errors of fact or judgment in these pages are mine alone.

—CZ

1

Prologue: I Don't Want Others to Write My Story

On November 21, 2023, I stepped down as CEO of Binance.

I wrote those words on X at 2:47 PM Pacific Time, sitting in a hotel room in Seattle. The statement was brief, professional, the kind of corporate communication I had drafted hundreds of times before. What it didn't capture—what no press release could capture—was the strange silence that followed after I hit send. The notification sounds stopped. The phone stopped buzzing. For the first time in six years, I was not responsible for the world's largest cryptocurrency exchange.

The Department of Justice had announced the settlement that morning: \$4.3 billion in penalties, the largest corporate resolution in Treasury Department history. I had pleaded guilty to one count of violating the Bank Secrecy Act. The press releases used words like “willfully failed” and “inadequate compliance program.” They were not wrong. I had made mistakes. I had prioritized growth over compliance in ways that, looking back, I should have recognized would lead us here.

But I am getting ahead of myself. This book is not a defense. It is not an apology tour, nor is it a victory lap. It is simply my attempt to tell my own story before others tell it for me—because they will, and they have, and many of them have gotten important details wrong.

The structure of this memoir follows three tracks, and I want to be transparent with you about what each contains.

The first track consists of verifiable facts. These are events that can be confirmed through public records: court documents, DOJ press releases, mainstream media reports, official company announcements. When I describe my guilty plea on November 21, 2023, I am describing something that happened in a federal courtroom with transcripts and filings. When I mention the \$50 million personal penalty I agreed to pay, that figure comes directly from the settlement documents. When I note that I was sentenced on April 30, 2024, to four months in federal prison, that sentence is a matter of public record.

The second track contains my personal recollections—my memories of how events felt, what I was thinking, why I made certain decisions. These are true to the best of my ability to remember them, but memory is imperfect. I have tried to be careful about distinguishing between what I know happened and what I believe happened. When I describe the silence in that hotel room after I resigned, I am telling you what I experienced. When I describe conversations from years ago, I am reconstructing them from memory, and I will flag when specific details are uncertain.

The third track acknowledges what is not publicly disclosed or remains unknown to me. There are aspects of the government’s investigation that I was not privy to. There are business negotiations whose details remain confidential. There are personal relationships whose privacy I will respect. I will not fabricate details to fill these gaps. I will simply tell you: this part, I do not know.

On October 23, 2025, President Donald Trump granted me a full and unconditional pardon. I learned about it the way many people did—through a news alert on my phone, while I was on a flight. The White House described it as recognizing my “pioneering role in blockchain technology and financial inclusion.” Critics called it something else entirely. Representative Maxine Waters labeled me a “crypto criminal” and decried the pardon as favoritism. Both perspectives exist in the public record, and I will not pretend to resolve that debate here.

What I can tell you is how it felt to receive that news at 35,000 feet, looking out at clouds that obscured any view of the ground. It felt unreal. It felt, in some ways, anticlimactic. Four months in a low-security facility in Lompoc, California, had already ended. I had already been released in September 2024. The pardon erased the felony conviction from my record, but it did not erase the experience of those months, or the years of legal proceedings that preceded them, or the decisions that had led me there in the first place.

The sentencing hearing on April 30, 2024, was a strange experience. The prosecution had requested a thirty-six-month sentence. My defense had argued for probation. The judge settled on four months—significantly less than what the government had sought, but more than I had hoped. I sat in the courtroom in Seattle, listening to the judge explain his reasoning, aware that my life was about to change in ways I could not fully predict. The sentence was for violating the Bank Secrecy Act—specifically, for failing to establish and maintain an effective anti-money laundering program at Binance. This was a charge I had accepted as part of my plea agreement, acknowledging that I had made mistakes in how I approached compliance during the early years of the company's growth.

I am aware that some readers will come to this book looking for confirmation of their existing views. Some will want me to be a villain. Others will want me to be a hero. I am neither. I am a software engineer who built something larger than I ever intended, who made mistakes in the process, who learned from some of them and is still learning from others.

The cryptocurrency industry I helped build is now a multi-trillion-dollar ecosystem that touches every corner of global finance. That fact still surprises me sometimes. When I first read the Bitcoin whitepaper in 2013, I was a 36-year-old programmer with a failed startup behind me and a modest apartment in Shanghai. I had no idea that within four years, I would be running the world's largest exchange for these new digital assets. I had no idea that within six years, I would be one of the wealthiest people on the planet. And I certainly had no idea that within ten years, I would be pleading guilty to federal crimes and resigning from the company I had built from nothing.

This book is my attempt to make sense of that journey—not just for you, but for myself. I have spent much of the past two years in reflection, in conversation with family and friends, in reading the thousands of articles written about me and recognizing how many of them missed the point. Some portrayed me as a visionary. Others portrayed me as a reckless cowboy. The truth, as always, is more complicated and more mundane.

I am someone who likes to build things. I am someone who struggles with bureaucracy and regulation, not because I oppose them in principle, but because my instinct is always to solve problems through code rather than through compliance. I am someone who moved twelve times before I turned eighteen, who learned to adapt quickly to new environments, who perhaps never fully developed the instinct to stay in one place and follow all the rules.

If you are reading this book hoping for a roadmap to crypto riches, you will be disappointed. I cannot tell you which tokens to buy or which projects will succeed. If you are reading this book hoping for a tell-all exposé of the crypto industry's dark underbelly, you will also be disappointed. I will not violate confidences or settle scores.

What I can offer is an honest account of how one person navigated the most turbulent period in the history of money—from the first time I tasted fresh milk in Vancouver as a child, to the first time I wrote code that moved real financial value, to the first time I understood what it meant to build a system that operated without intermediaries, to the moment I realized that building such a system would bring me into conflict with the most powerful governments on Earth.

That is the story I want to tell. Not because it is unique—though parts of it are—but because it is mine, and I would rather you hear it from me than from anyone else.

So let us begin at the beginning, in a coastal city in China, in the late 1970s, when the world was a very different place and I was just a child who liked to take things apart to see how they worked.

2

From Lianyungang to Vancouver: The Weight of a Plane Ticket

I was born in 1977 in Lianyungang, a coastal city in Jiangsu Province, China. The name means “port connected to the clouds,” which sounds poetic until you realize it was primarily a shipping hub for coal and iron ore. My father was a university professor. My mother was a teacher. We were, by the standards of that time and place, an educated family—which meant we were also a family under suspicion.

The Cultural Revolution had ended only a year before I was born, but its shadow lingered. My father had been labeled a “bourgeois intellectual,” a designation that carried consequences I was too young to understand. What I understood was that we moved. A lot. By the time I was twelve, I had lived in at least twelve different places. I stopped bothering to make close friends. I learned to pack quickly, to adapt to new schools, to become fluent in the local dialects that shifted every few years.

In 1984, my father went to Canada to study. He was part of a small wave of Chinese academics allowed to pursue graduate degrees abroad. Five years later, in 1989, the rest of our family joined him. I was twelve years old.

The details of that transition are hazy in my memory. I remember the flight was long. I remember arriving in Vancouver in late summer, when the light seemed impossibly bright and the air smelled of pine and ocean. I remember

my father meeting us at the airport, looking both older and younger than I remembered—older because of the years apart, younger because the stress of living in China had begun to lift from his shoulders.

What I remember most clearly, though, is the milk.

In an interview with *Fortune* Chinese years later, I mentioned this: the first taste of fresh milk in Vancouver. It seems like a strange detail to fixate on, but for a child who had grown up on powdered milk and occasional treats of sweetened condensed milk, fresh milk from a carton was revelatory. It was cold. It was creamy. It tasted like abundance in a way I could not have articulated then but can recognize now.

That detail—the milk—has been repeated so often in profiles of me that it has become almost a punchline. “The crypto billionaire who was amazed by milk.” But I mention it here because it captures something essential about that transition: the smallness of the things that signal a larger change. We did not arrive in Canada as refugees fleeing war. We arrived as immigrants seeking opportunity, carrying suitcases and academic credentials and a cautious hope that this new country would allow us to build something better.

We lived in a university dormitory at the University of British Columbia, where my father had a position as a teaching assistant. The housing was subsidized, which was necessary because my parents’ income, combined, was barely enough to cover basic expenses. My mother found work at a sewing factory, her limited English confining her to jobs that required no customer interaction. She would come home with her fingers stained from fabric dye, too tired to do much more than heat up simple meals.

I enrolled in school. The language barrier was immediate and overwhelming. I had studied English in China, but textbook English and conversational English are different languages. I remember sitting in a classroom, understanding perhaps one word in ten, nodding along as if I comprehended while desperately trying to piece together meaning from context and body language.

What saved me was mathematics. Numbers are universal. In math class, I could participate without fluent English. I could demonstrate understanding

through problem-solving rather than verbal explanation. This was the beginning of a pattern that would repeat throughout my life: when language or culture created barriers, I found refuge in systems that operated on logic rather than nuance.

The other thing that saved me was work. At fourteen, I got my first job at McDonald's. I will write more about that experience in the next chapter, but for now, what matters is this: work gave me a place where I belonged. At McDonald's, my accent did not matter. My unfamiliarity with Canadian customs did not matter. What mattered was whether I could flip burgers quickly and accurately, whether I could count change correctly, whether I showed up on time.

This period taught me something I have carried with me ever since: the ability to tolerate uncertainty. When you move twelve times before you turn twelve, you stop expecting stability. You learn to build provisional structures—friendships, routines, identities—that you know may not last. Some people find this exhausting. I found it liberating. It meant I was never fully invested in any particular version of myself. I could experiment. I could fail and start over. I could walk away from situations that weren't working without feeling like I was abandoning my true self, because my true self was still being formed.

There is a tendency in immigrant narratives to emphasize the hardship, the struggle, the overcoming of adversity. I do not want to romanticize our experience, but I also do not want to exaggerate it. We were not poor by global standards. We had food, shelter, education. My parents' sacrifices were real, but they were the sacrifices of people choosing a difficult path toward a better future, not the sacrifices of people with no choices at all.

What I gained from those years was not resilience in the face of tragedy, but adaptability in the face of change. I learned to read new environments quickly, to identify the unwritten rules, to find the leverage points where effort translates into results. These skills would prove invaluable when I entered the technology industry, where the ground shifts constantly and the ability to learn new frameworks quickly matters more than mastery of any particular one.

I also learned the value of education as a tool for mobility. My parents had both been teachers. They believed in the transformative power of learning, not as an abstract ideal but as a practical strategy for navigating an uncertain world. When my father bought me a 286 DOS computer—an extravagance we could barely afford—he was making a bet that technical skills would open doors that social connections could not.

That computer changed my life. I spent hours on it, teaching myself to code from books borrowed from the library. I wrote simple programs, then more complex ones. I broke things and fixed them. I learned that software was something you could build with nothing more than time, intellect, and access to a machine. This was power I could control, unlike the social capital that seemed to determine so much of success in the offline world.

By the time I finished high school in 1995, I was ready to leave Vancouver. Not because I disliked the city—it had become home in ways I was only beginning to recognize—but because I had absorbed the lesson my parents had modeled: if you want to grow, you have to be willing to move.

I applied to universities across Canada. I chose McGill in Montreal, three thousand miles away, partly for its academic reputation and partly because I wanted to experience a different part of the country. I wanted to test whether the adaptability I had developed was portable, or whether it was specific to the particular ecosystem of Vancouver's immigrant communities.

The answer, I would discover, was that it was portable. The skills I had learned—observing before acting, finding the logic in unfamiliar systems, building competence before confidence—transferred to new contexts. They would transfer again when I moved to Tokyo, then New York, then Shanghai. They would transfer when I entered the cryptocurrency industry, where the rules were being written in real time and no one had more than a few months of experience.

But all of that was still ahead of me. In 1995, I was an eighteen-year-old packing his belongings for a move across a continent, leaving behind the only country I had ever really known as home, heading toward a city where the winters were so cold that much of downtown was connected by underground tunnels.

I did not know then that I would spend the next two decades moving between countries and industries, building systems for moving value around the world. I did not know that I would eventually create a platform that would handle trillions of dollars in transactions. I only knew that I was ready for whatever came next, because I had been ready for whatever came next since I was twelve years old, stepping off a plane into bright Vancouver sunlight, tasting fresh milk for the first time.

3

McDonald's and Gas Stations: My First Paychecks

I started working at McDonald's when I was fourteen. This was not unusual in my social circle—many of my friends from immigrant families had jobs in high school. What we earned went toward family expenses, not personal spending money. The concept of an allowance was foreign to me. If I wanted something, I worked for it.

The McDonald's was on a busy street in Vancouver, close enough to the university that we got a mix of students, professors, and local residents. I started on the grill, flipping burgers during the lunch rush. The work was repetitive but not mindless. There was a rhythm to it: the timing of the patties, the coordination with the assembly line, the constant awareness of how many orders were backing up.

What I learned at McDonald's was not how to make a hamburger. Anyone can learn that in an afternoon. What I learned was the weight of money when it is earned by the hour.

At minimum wage—which in the mid-1990s was around five dollars an hour in British Columbia—a Big Mac meal cost roughly an hour of labor. I remember making this calculation explicitly, standing at the register during a slow period, looking at the menu board. The meal I could assemble in ninety seconds took me sixty minutes to earn the money to buy. This was

not a complaint. It was simply a fact that shaped how I thought about value.

I also worked night shifts at a Chevron gas station. This was a different kind of job. At McDonald's, I was part of a team, surrounded by people, constantly interacting. At the gas station, I was often alone for hours at a time, especially on weeknights. I would sit behind the counter, doing homework when it was slow, watching the security monitors, waiting for the occasional customer.

The gas station taught me about trust and verification. We had protocols for everything: how to handle cash, how to process credit cards, how to respond if the alarm went off. I learned that systems are only as strong as their weakest points, and that the weakest point is usually a human being who is tired or distracted or simply not paying attention.

There was a night—I remember it clearly—when a man came in and tried to pay for gas with a counterfeit twenty-dollar bill. I caught it, not because I was especially vigilant, but because I had developed a habit of feeling the texture of bills, checking the security features without really thinking about it. The man left quickly when I questioned the bill. I never found out if he was genuinely mistaken or intentionally trying to pass fake currency. What stuck with me was how close I had come to accepting it, how easily the system could have been compromised.

These were not profound lessons at the time. They were simply observations, accumulated over hundreds of shifts, filed away in some mental archive I did not know I was keeping. Only later, when I was building financial systems that moved billions of dollars, would I recognize their relevance.

There is a particular kind of humor that develops among people who work service jobs, a gallows humor that acknowledges the absurdity of the situations you encounter without quite surrendering to despair. My coworkers at McDonald's were mostly students or recent immigrants, people who were working these jobs not because they lacked ambition but because they were in transition, building toward something else. We joked about difficult customers, about the manager's latest unreasonable demand, about the gap between the cheerful marketing and the reality of fast-food work.

This humor was never cruel, or at least I do not remember it as cruel. It was

a way of maintaining dignity in circumstances that did not naturally confer it. When a customer yelled at you for getting an order wrong, you could either absorb the insult as a personal failure or you could share the story later with coworkers who understood that sometimes people just needed someone to yell at, and you happened to be standing behind the counter.

I have sometimes been accused of being detached, of treating business decisions as purely technical problems without sufficient attention to their human consequences. There may be some truth to this. But I would argue that my early work experience gave me a different kind of human understanding. I knew what it meant to stand on your feet for eight hours, to deal with people who were having bad days, to follow procedures that seemed arbitrary because someone higher up had decided they were necessary.

When I later built companies, I tried to remember this. I tried to design systems that respected the people who operated them, that did not assume unlimited availability or perfect attention. I was not always successful. The scale of Binance eventually made it impossible to know most employees personally, to understand their individual circumstances. But the impulse was there, rooted in those early years of hourly work.

The other thing I learned from these jobs was the value of competence. At McDonald's, there were people who flipped burgers and there were people who flipped burgers well. The difference was noticeable. The good grill operators kept the patties at the right temperature, managed the queue efficiently, communicated clearly with the assembly team. They made the whole operation run more smoothly.

I wanted to be one of those people. Not because I loved flipping burgers, but because I hated being bad at things. This was a pattern I would repeat throughout my career: identify the skills that mattered in a given context, then work systematically to develop them. Sometimes this meant formal education. More often it meant self-directed learning, reading documentation, experimenting, failing, trying again.

At the gas station, competence meant something different. It meant being able to handle the unexpected: a customer who locked their keys in their car, a pump that malfunctioned, a suspicious person hanging around

the parking lot. I learned to stay calm under pressure, to follow protocols without panicking, to recognize when a situation was beyond my training and required calling for help.

These skills—technical competence, calm under pressure, awareness of system vulnerabilities—would prove directly relevant to my later work in financial technology. When you are building trading systems, you are constantly dealing with edge cases, with situations that should not happen but sometimes do. The ability to think clearly when things go wrong is not something you can learn from a textbook. You learn it from experience, from being in situations where the stakes are real and the consequences of mistakes are immediate.

I do not want to overstate the case. Working at McDonald's and a gas station did not prepare me to run a global cryptocurrency exchange. The scale is different by orders of magnitude. But the fundamentals are not entirely different. Money moves through systems. Systems are operated by people. People make mistakes. The job of good system design is to minimize the impact of those mistakes, to create structures that are resilient to human fallibility.

There is a Canadian style of humor—dry, understated, slightly self-deprecating—that I absorbed during these years. Canadians do not boast. They apologize when someone else bumps into them. They treat success with suspicion and failure with sympathy. I have tried to maintain this perspective even as my public profile grew, even as I became the subject of profiles and documentaries and endless social media commentary.

It is not always easy. The cryptocurrency industry attracts people who are comfortable with self-promotion, who understand that attention is a form of currency. I have never been entirely comfortable with this aspect of the business. I would rather write code than give interviews. I would rather solve technical problems than attend conferences. But I have learned that building something significant requires engaging with the world as it is, not as you wish it to be.

The jobs I worked as a teenager taught me that value is created through effort, that systems matter, that competence is its own reward. They

also taught me that I did not want to spend my life flipping burgers or pumping gas. Not because those jobs were beneath me— they were not—but because I had other skills that could create more value, that could solve more interesting problems.

Finding those problems, and developing those skills, would take me to Montreal, then Tokyo, then New York, then Shanghai. Each move was a step up in complexity and compensation. Each move also taught me something new about how financial systems work, about how technology can transform them, about how the world of money is simultaneously more rigid and more malleable than most people realize.

But before any of that, there was just the grill, the counter, the late-night shifts at the gas station, the slow accumulation of competence and confidence that comes from showing up and doing the work, hour after hour, paycheck after paycheck.

4

Montreal Winter: Learning to Code in Classrooms

I arrived at McGill University in the fall of 1995, three thousand miles from Vancouver, in a city where French was the official language and winter temperatures regularly dropped below minus twenty degrees Celsius. The campus was beautiful—old stone buildings, tree-lined paths, the mountain visible in the distance—but what I remember most clearly is the cold.

Montreal winters are not like Vancouver winters. In Vancouver, winter means rain and gray skies. In Montreal, winter means snow that stays on the ground for months, wind that cuts through any jacket, a darkness that settles in by four in the afternoon. Much of downtown Montreal is connected by underground tunnels for a reason: without them, the city would be nearly uninhabitable for several months each year.

I had chosen McGill partly for its academic reputation, partly because I wanted to experience a different part of Canada. I started as a biology major, influenced by a friend's mother who suggested that medicine offered a stable, well-compensated career path. After one semester, I switched to computer science. The reason was simple: in high school, biology had been about the human body, which I found fascinating. In university, the focus shifted to animals and cellular processes, which I did not.

Computer science, by contrast, was immediately compelling. It was logic

made tangible. You wrote instructions, and a machine executed them. If the results were wrong, the error was in your thinking, not in the machine's interpretation. This clarity appealed to me. I had always been someone who preferred systems with clear rules to systems that depended on social negotiation or subjective judgment.

The computer science program at McGill in the mid-1990s was not particularly prestigious. We were not MIT or Stanford. Our labs ran on aging equipment, and many of our professors were more interested in theory than in practical applications. But I did not need prestige. I needed access to machines and time to learn.

I spent hours in the campus computer labs, often staying late into the night. I would rollerblade to the lab in the evening—Montreal's underground tunnels made this possible even in winter—and work until the early morning hours, fueled by coffee and the particular satisfaction that comes from solving a difficult problem.

There was a group of us who became regulars in the lab. We were not close friends in the traditional sense—we did not socialize outside of school, did not know much about each other's personal lives—but we recognized each other as members of the same tribe. We spoke the same language of algorithms and data structures. We competed to solve the hardest problems in the shortest time. We shared techniques and shortcuts, building on each other's discoveries.

I was not a standout student academically. My grades were good but not exceptional. I did not participate in the social life of the university in any meaningful way—no fraternities, no clubs, no campus politics. What I had was focus. When I was working on a coding problem, everything else faded away. Hours would pass without my noticing.

This focus was not always healthy. I would forget to eat, forget to sleep, forget that there was a world outside the screen. But it produced results. I became proficient in the languages that mattered at the time: C, C++, some Java as it emerged. I learned about databases, about networking, about the principles of software engineering.

The fear of writing wrong code was constant. Every programmer knows

this fear. You write something, you think it is correct, but you cannot be sure until you test it. And testing can only prove the presence of bugs, never their absence. This uncertainty was uncomfortable for me. I wanted to be certain, to know that my code was correct through logic alone.

Over time, I developed strategies for managing this uncertainty. I learned to write tests first, before writing the code itself. I learned to break problems into smaller pieces, to verify each piece independently. I learned to read other people's code, to understand how they had solved similar problems, to incorporate their insights into my own work.

These habits—testing, decomposition, learning from others—would serve me well throughout my career. They are not specific to any particular technology or domain. They are ways of thinking that apply to any complex system, whether it is a trading engine or a cryptocurrency exchange.

Toward the end of my time at McGill, I had an opportunity that would prove significant. I co-authored an academic paper on artificial intelligence with Professor Jeremy Cooperstock. The topic was machine learning, specifically neural networks, though this was long before the deep learning revolution that would make AI a household term. The paper was published in 1999. It would be twenty years before the techniques we were exploring became mainstream.

The project began when Professor Cooperstock invited me to join his graduate seminar, even though I was still an undergraduate. He needed someone with strong programming skills to implement the algorithms he was researching. I needed an opportunity to work on something more challenging than the standard coursework. It was a good match. We spent months experimenting with neural network architectures, training them on various datasets, documenting what worked and what did not. The experience taught me that research is mostly failure—failed hypotheses, failed experiments, failed approaches—with occasional moments of insight that make the failures worthwhile.

Professor Cooperstock later described me as “very smart” but expressed surprise at my eventual success. I was not the most impressive student he had taught, not the one most likely to become famous or wealthy. This

assessment does not bother me. I have never been interested in being impressive in academic settings. I have been interested in building things that work.

The paper itself is not important except as a marker of my growing confidence. I could contribute to the academic discourse. I could write code that other people found useful. I could operate in the world of ideas and technology that I had discovered in that university computer lab.

I did not graduate from McGill in the traditional sense. I completed my degree requirements through an online education program, which was unusual at the time but fit my circumstances. I was eager to start working, to apply what I had learned to real problems, to earn money that would allow me to be independent.

The decision to leave formal education was not difficult for me. I had never been someone who thrived in structured learning environments. I learned by doing, by building, by making mistakes and correcting them. The academic world valued credentials and publications. The industry I was entering valued results.

My first job after leaving McGill was an internship in Tokyo, working on software for the Tokyo Stock Exchange. This was 1997, and Japan was still recovering from the economic collapse that had begun earlier in the decade. The exchange was modernizing its systems, replacing older technology with newer, faster alternatives. I was a small part of that effort, but it was my first exposure to the world of financial technology, and it would shape everything that came after.

Before I left Montreal, I spent some time reflecting on what I had learned there. Not the specific technical skills—those would become obsolete within a few years, replaced by new languages and frameworks—but the deeper habits of mind. The ability to focus for extended periods. The comfort with uncertainty. The willingness to stay up all night solving a problem that seemed impossible at midnight.

These were the real products of my education. They were not listed on any transcript. They could not be certified by any institution. But they were what allowed me to build the systems I would later build, to navigate the

challenges I would later face, to keep going when others might have stopped.

Montreal in winter is a test of endurance. The cold forces you indoors, forces you to find ways to occupy yourself in confined spaces, forces you to develop patience for conditions you cannot control. I left Montreal in the summer of 1997, heading to Tokyo with a single suitcase and a job offer that paid more money than I had ever earned. I was twenty years old. I thought I knew what I was doing. I did not, not really. But I was ready to learn.

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Tokyo's Matching Engine: First Touch of Finance's Skeleton

I arrived in Tokyo in the summer of 1997, twenty years old, with a computer science degree completed through correspondence courses and a job offer from a subcontractor of the Tokyo Stock Exchange. I did not speak Japanese. I did not understand Japanese business culture. What I understood was code, and the Tokyo Stock Exchange needed code.

The project was straightforward in description: develop software for matching trade orders. When a buyer wants to purchase shares at a certain price and a seller wants to sell at that same price, the exchange needs to match them. This matching must happen quickly—within milliseconds—and it must happen correctly. A mistake in the matching engine does not just lose money. It undermines confidence in the entire market.

What I discovered in Tokyo was that financial markets are, at their core, systems of rules. Every transaction operates within boundaries: price limits, volume limits, time limits. There are rules about who can trade, when they can trade, how their orders must be formatted. These rules exist for reasons—some historical, some regulatory, some practical—but to a programmer, what matters is that they exist and must be implemented precisely.

The matching engine I worked on was written in C++, a language I

knew well from my time at McGill. But knowing the language was only the beginning. I had to understand the business logic: how orders were prioritized, how partial fills were handled, what happened when multiple orders arrived at the same price point. I had to understand the edge cases: what if an order arrived exactly at market close? What if two orders with the same timestamp needed to be ranked? What if the system crashed in the middle of processing a trade?

These edge cases were where the real work happened. The normal case—buyer meets seller, trade executes—was simple. Anyone could implement that. What separated a reliable system from a dangerous one was how it handled the unusual situations, the one-in-a-million scenarios that most people never thought about until they happened.

I spent months on these edge cases. I would sit with the business analysts, asking endless questions about what should happen in situations they had never considered. I would write tests that simulated these scenarios, watching the system fail, then fixing it, then finding new ways it could fail. It was tedious work, and it was essential work.

The Tokyo Stock Exchange operated under constraints that seemed arbitrary to me at first. There were price limits—stocks could only move a certain percentage in a single day. There were trading halts—if prices moved too quickly, the market would pause to allow people to catch their breath. There were restrictions on short selling, on program trading, on foreign ownership.

Over time, I came to understand that these constraints were not arbitrary. They were the accumulated wisdom of decades of market crashes, of panics and bubbles and collapses. Each rule represented a lesson learned at great cost. The price limits existed because unchecked volatility could destroy wealth faster than it could be created. The trading halts existed because speed, unchecked, could amplify errors into catastrophes.

This was my first exposure to what I would later call the skeleton of finance: the underlying structure of rules and boundaries that makes markets possible. Most people see only the surface—the prices moving on screens, the news about mergers and earnings. But beneath that surface

is a complex system of constraints, each designed to prevent some failure mode that someone, somewhere, had experienced.

I also learned about the culture of financial technology in Tokyo. It was conservative in ways that frustrated me. Changes required extensive documentation and approval. New ideas were viewed with suspicion. The priority was stability, not innovation. A system that worked reliably was valued more highly than a system that worked better but had not been proven.

This conservatism was not irrational. The Tokyo Stock Exchange handled enormous volumes of money. A bug in the matching engine could cost billions of yen. The people who managed the exchange had seen what happened when systems failed—the market crashes, the regulatory investigations, the loss of public trust. They were not interested in being pioneers. They were interested in not being responsible for the next disaster.

I respected this perspective even as I chafed against it. I was young and impatient. I wanted to build things that were faster, more efficient, more elegant. The exchange wanted to build things that would not break. Both perspectives were valid. The tension between them would define my entire career in financial technology.

My time in Tokyo also taught me about working across cultures. I was one of the few non-Japanese employees in my division. I had to learn to communicate in ways that were effective in that context: indirect rather than direct, respectful of hierarchy, patient with processes that seemed unnecessarily slow. I made mistakes. I offended people without meaning to. I learned to apologize and adapt.

The technical work itself was absorbing. I would spend days tracking down a bug that appeared only under specific conditions: when the order book was exactly full, when the timestamp rolled over at midnight, when two particular types of orders arrived simultaneously. These bugs were like puzzles, and solving them gave me the same satisfaction I had felt in the McGill computer lab, but amplified by the knowledge that real money depended on my solutions.

The matching engine itself was a study in algorithmic efficiency. At its core was a data structure that maintained the order book—the collection

of all outstanding buy and sell orders, organized by price level. The structure needed to support several operations efficiently: inserting new orders, canceling existing orders, finding matches when orders crossed, and updating the display of current market prices. We used a combination of priority queues and hash maps, carefully tuned to minimize memory allocations and cache misses. Every microsecond mattered when millions of orders were flowing through the system daily.

I learned about the different types of orders and how each required specific handling. Market orders executed immediately at the best available price. Limit orders only executed at a specified price or better. Stop orders triggered when certain price thresholds were reached. Each type had its own logic, its own edge cases, its own ways of interacting with the order book. The complexity came not from any individual feature but from the interactions between them—how a stop order might trigger a cascade of other orders, how a large market order might sweep through multiple price levels, how the system needed to maintain consistency even when multiple operations were happening simultaneously.

There was an incident—I will not give details because I do not remember them precisely and do not want to misrepresent what happened—where a bug in testing caused a simulated market to behave incorrectly. It was caught before deployment, but the investigation that followed consumed weeks. Every line of code was reviewed. Every assumption was questioned. The experience taught me that in financial systems, the cost of a mistake is not just the immediate loss. It is the loss of confidence, the regulatory scrutiny, the endless meetings and reports required to demonstrate that the problem has been fixed.

I left Tokyo in 2001, after four years. I had learned what I came to learn: how financial markets work at the technical level, how to build systems that handle real money, how to think about edge cases and failure modes. I had also learned that I was not suited for the conservative culture of traditional finance. I wanted to move faster, to try new things, to accept more risk in exchange for more innovation.

This desire would take me to New York, to Bloomberg Tradebook, where

I would work on futures trading systems. It would eventually take me to Shanghai, where I would start my own company. And it would ultimately lead me to cryptocurrency, where the rules were still being written and the edge cases were still being discovered.

But all of that was in the future. In 2001, as I packed my belongings for the move to New York, I took with me a set of principles that would guide my work for the next two decades: respect the rules, but understand why they exist. Test everything. Handle the edge cases. And never forget that behind every transaction is real money, real people, real consequences for getting it wrong.

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Tradebook: Writing Futures Software in New Jersey

I joined Bloomberg Tradebook in 2001, moving from Tokyo to New York to work on futures trading software. The transition was significant. Tokyo had been conservative, hierarchical, deliberate. New York was fast, competitive, obsessed with performance. At Bloomberg, the culture was driven by a simple metric: speed. The firm that executed trades faster captured more market share. Everything else was secondary.

Bloomberg Tradebook was an electronic trading platform that allowed institutional investors to execute futures trades across multiple exchanges. My role was to develop the software that powered this platform: the order management systems, the connectivity to exchanges, the algorithms that determined how large orders should be broken up and routed for optimal execution.

The technical challenges were substantial. Futures markets operate on tight margins. A delay of a few milliseconds could mean the difference between capturing a price and missing it. We were constantly optimizing: rewriting critical paths in assembly language, co-locating servers at exchange data centers, finding ways to reduce network latency.

But the technical challenges were only part of the job. I was also managing teams, coordinating work across multiple offices—New York, London,

Tokyo. I received three promotions in less than two years, eventually managing an eighty-person organization spread across three continents. This was my first experience with management at scale, and I learned quickly that managing engineers is different from engineering.

An engineer solves problems directly. A manager solves problems by helping other people solve problems. This requires different skills: communication, delegation, the ability to tolerate outcomes that are not exactly what you would have produced yourself. I was not naturally good at these skills. I wanted to write the code myself, to control the quality directly. Learning to let go, to trust others to do work I would have done differently, was a gradual and sometimes painful process.

What I observed at Bloomberg, and what would become increasingly relevant to my later work, was the contrast between traditional finance's approach to risk and the approach I would later encounter in cryptocurrency. In traditional finance, risk control was paramount. Every system had multiple layers of validation. Every change required extensive testing. Every failure was analyzed in detail to prevent recurrence.

This approach had virtues. It prevented catastrophic losses. It maintained market stability. It satisfied regulators. But it also had costs. It slowed innovation. It made systems complex and difficult to change. It created organizational cultures that were resistant to new ideas.

I remember a specific project where we wanted to implement a new trading algorithm. In a startup environment, this might have taken weeks. At Bloomberg, it took months. There were compliance reviews, risk assessments, backtesting against historical data, sign-offs from multiple departments. By the time we deployed, competitors had already launched similar features.

This was not incompetence. It was the natural result of an industry that had learned, through painful experience, that mistakes in financial systems could have devastating consequences. The 1987 stock market crash, the 1998 Long-Term Capital Management collapse, the various trading errors that had cost firms billions—all of these had shaped the culture of risk management in traditional finance.

What I did not fully appreciate at the time was that this culture was a response to specific conditions: centralized systems, regulated markets, institutions that could be held accountable for failures. The cryptocurrency industry would operate under different conditions, and would develop different approaches to risk.

At Bloomberg, I also learned about the global nature of financial markets. Our systems connected to exchanges in Chicago, London, Frankfurt, Tokyo, Singapore. Trading happened around the clock, following the sun from one market to the next. A problem in one location could cascade to others. A regulatory change in one jurisdiction could affect operations globally.

Managing teams across time zones was challenging. I would start my day with calls to London, continue with meetings in New York, end with calls to Tokyo. I learned to be effective in short bursts, to make decisions with incomplete information, to trust my teams to handle situations I could not directly observe.

The futures markets themselves were fascinating in their complexity. Unlike stocks, which represent ownership in companies, futures are contracts to buy or sell assets at predetermined prices on future dates. They are used for hedging—protecting against price movements—or for speculation. The futures markets I worked with included commodities like oil and gold, financial instruments like Treasury bonds and stock indices, and currencies. Each market had its own characteristics: trading hours, tick sizes, margin requirements, delivery mechanisms.

Building software that worked across all these markets required abstracting the common patterns while respecting the specific requirements of each. We developed a core trading engine that could be configured for different markets, with plugins for exchange-specific connectivity and rules. This architecture allowed us to add new markets quickly while maintaining the reliability of the core system. It was my first experience with building platforms rather than point solutions, and the lessons would prove valuable when I later built cryptocurrency exchanges.

The work was rewarding in many ways. Bloomberg was a successful company with talented people. I was well compensated. I was learning

skills that would be valuable throughout my career. But I was also becoming restless. The pace of innovation felt too slow. The layers of approval felt unnecessary. I wanted to build something of my own, something that could move faster.

This restlessness was not unique to me. Many of the people I worked with at Bloomberg had similar frustrations. Some left to join hedge funds, where the culture was more entrepreneurial. Some left to start their own companies. The financial technology industry was full of people who had learned their craft at large institutions and then sought environments where they could apply that craft more freely.

I left Bloomberg in 2005, after four years. My departure was amicable. I had been successful there, and they would have been happy for me to stay. But I was ready for something different. I was twenty-eight years old, with experience building trading systems for two of the world's major financial centers. I had saved some money. I had ideas about what the next generation of trading technology should look like.

What I did not have was experience running a company. I had managed teams, but I had never been responsible for revenue, for hiring, for making payroll, for selling to customers. These were skills I would have to learn, and I would learn them the hard way, through mistakes and failures and the occasional success.

The contrast between my time at Bloomberg and what came next would be stark. Bloomberg was a large, established company with processes and procedures for everything. My next venture would be a startup, where nothing was established and everything had to be invented. Bloomberg had risk management departments whose entire job was to prevent mistakes. My startup would have me, making decisions quickly and hoping they were right.

Both approaches have their place. Both produce different kinds of outcomes. Understanding when to apply each, and how to balance the competing demands of innovation and stability, would become one of the central challenges of my career. I did not understand this fully in 2005, as I packed my belongings for a move to Shanghai. I only knew that I was ready to try

something new, to test myself against challenges I had not yet faced.

Back to Shanghai: Fusion Systems and Entrepreneurship's First Lesson

I moved to Shanghai in 2005. I was twenty-eight years old, with eight years of experience building trading systems in Tokyo and New York, and I was starting my first company. The company was called Fusion Systems, and it would specialize in high-frequency trading technology for brokers.

The decision to start a company in China was not obvious. Most of my contacts were in North America and Japan. My Mandarin was functional but not fluent. But I had a theory: the Chinese financial markets were developing rapidly, and there would be demand for modern trading technology. I also had a personal connection—my family was originally from Jiangsu, and some part of me wanted to return to the country I had left at age twelve.

Shanghai in 2005 was a city in transformation. The Pudong skyline, now iconic, was still under construction. The metro system had only a few lines. Foreigners were relatively rare outside the central business district. But the energy was palpable. Everywhere you looked, something was being built. The optimism was infectious.

I started Fusion Systems with a small team—mostly engineers I recruited from local universities and from my network in the industry. Our value proposition was simple: we would build high-frequency trading systems that were faster and more reliable than what was currently available in China.

We would serve both domestic brokers and international firms looking to access Chinese markets.

The first months were exhilarating. I was doing everything: writing code, meeting potential clients, managing the team, handling administrative tasks I had never thought about before. There was no separation between work and life. I would wake up thinking about technical problems and go to sleep thinking about cash flow. The adrenaline carried me through the long hours.

I remember the first time I had to make payroll. It was a small amount by later standards—just a handful of employees—but it represented a commitment I had never made before. These people had chosen to work for my company, to trust me with their livelihoods. If I failed, it would not just be my failure. It would affect their families, their careers, their futures. This weight was something I had not fully anticipated when I decided to start a company.

What I discovered quickly was that my technical skills, while necessary, were not sufficient. I could build excellent software, but building excellent software does not automatically create a successful business. I had to learn to sell, to negotiate contracts, to manage people who were not engineers and did not think like engineers.

My first major client was a large international investment bank. Landing that contract was a validation of everything we had been working toward. But delivering on the contract was harder than winning it. The client's requirements were complex and constantly changing. Their compliance requirements were extensive. Their timeline was aggressive.

We delivered the project, but it took longer than planned and cost more than budgeted. We made money on the contract, but not as much as I had projected. More importantly, I learned that enterprise sales cycles were long, that requirements were fluid, and that the gap between what a client says they want and what they actually need is often substantial.

Fusion Systems grew over the next few years. We hired more engineers. We opened an office in a better location. We added clients, including some major names: Credit Suisse, Goldman Sachs, Deutsche Bank. The company was profitable, though not spectacularly so. We were building a solid business,

but not the kind of transformative company I had imagined.

What I struggled with most was management. My technical intuition was strong—I could look at a system and understand where the bottlenecks were, what the failure modes might be, how the architecture should be structured. My management intuition was weak. I made classic mistakes: I hired people who were technically excellent but did not fit the company culture. I avoided difficult conversations about performance. I tried to do too much myself instead of delegating effectively.

There was a period in 2007 when we lost two major clients in quick succession. Both losses were related to service issues—our systems had experienced downtime at critical moments, and the clients lost confidence in our reliability. I spent weeks investigating what had gone wrong, and the answer was uncomfortable: our testing processes were inadequate, our deployment procedures were too manual, our monitoring did not catch problems early enough.

These were all fixable problems, but fixing them required changes to how we worked, and those changes were difficult to implement. Some of my senior engineers resisted the additional process. They saw it as bureaucracy, as slowing down the work they enjoyed. I had to navigate between their concerns and the reality that our current approach was not working.

The experience taught me something important about entrepreneurship: technical excellence and business success are correlated but not identical. You can build the best product in the world and still fail if you cannot sell it, support it, and deliver it reliably. The skills required to start a company are different from the skills required to scale a company, and I was still learning both.

By 2010, Fusion Systems was stable but not exciting. We had a solid client base, predictable revenue, a team of competent engineers. But I was becoming restless again. The high-frequency trading space was becoming crowded. Margins were compressing. The big banks were building their own technology rather than buying from vendors. I could see the trajectory, and it was not toward the kind of growth I wanted.

I started looking for new opportunities. I invested some of my earnings

from Fusion Systems in various ventures—some successful, most not. I explored different industries, different technologies, different geographies. Nothing quite clicked until 2013, when a friend mentioned something called Bitcoin during a casual conversation.

But that is getting ahead of the story. What matters about the Fusion Systems years is that they taught me the fundamentals of entrepreneurship: how to hire, how to fire, how to sell, how to manage cash flow, how to make decisions with incomplete information. These lessons were expensive—Fusion Systems never became the success I had hoped for—but they were necessary.

I also learned about myself. I learned that I was better at building systems than managing people, better at solving technical problems than navigating organizational politics. I learned that I preferred fast-moving environments to stable ones, even if the fast-moving environments were riskier. I learned that I was willing to bet on my own judgment, even when others disagreed.

These characteristics would prove essential in the years to come. They would also prove problematic at times. The same willingness to trust my own judgment that allowed me to start Fusion Systems would later lead me to make decisions at Binance that regulators would question. The same preference for speed over process that made Fusion Systems agile would later create compliance gaps.

Understanding these trade-offs—understanding that every strength has a corresponding weakness, that every decision involves costs as well as benefits—has been one of the ongoing challenges of my career. I do not claim to have mastered it. But the Fusion Systems years were where I first became aware of it, where I first had to confront the gap between who I wanted to be and who I actually was.

Fusion Systems continued to operate after I stepped back from day-to-day involvement. It was eventually acquired by a larger technology company, providing a modest return for the investors and employees who had stuck with it. I moved on to other ventures, other opportunities, other failures and successes. But the lessons of those Shanghai years stayed with me, shaping how I approached every subsequent challenge.

A Poker Table: Bitcoin Entered My World

I first heard about Bitcoin in 2013. The setting was a private poker game, the kind of casual gathering where friends and acquaintances trade stories and advice while cards are dealt and chips move across the table. I was there with Bobby Lee, then CEO of BTC China, and Ron Cao, a venture capitalist who had been an early investor in several technology companies.

The conversation turned to this new digital currency that had been making headlines. Bitcoin had been around since 2009, but it was only in 2013 that it started gaining significant attention outside of niche technical circles. The price had risen from under \$100 to over \$1,000 at its peak that year. There were stories of early adopters becoming millionaires. There were also stories of hacks, scams, and regulatory crackdowns.

Bobby and Ron were both enthusiastic. They recommended that everyone at the table consider investing a portion of their net worth in Bitcoin—Ron suggested 10 percent. Their reasoning was straightforward: Bitcoin represented a new kind of money, one that operated without central banks or government control. Even if the probability of success was low, the potential upside was enormous.

I listened. I asked questions. And then I did something that would define the rest of my career: I went home and printed out the Bitcoin whitepaper.

The poker game itself was unremarkable—a friendly game among people who knew each other from the technology and finance circles in Shanghai.

We played Texas Hold'em, drank whiskey, talked about markets and startups. It was the kind of evening I had participated in many times before. What made this one different was the conversation about Bitcoin, which Bobby and Ron approached with an enthusiasm I had not seen them display for other topics.

Bobby was particularly animated. As CEO of BTC China, he had a front-row seat to the growing interest in Bitcoin among Chinese investors. He described the trading volumes, the price movements, the regulatory ambiguity that both created risk and opportunity. Ron brought the venture capital perspective: the technology was still early, the market was inefficient, the potential returns justified significant risk. Their combined enthusiasm was infectious, but what convinced me was not their excitement—it was the technology itself, which I needed to understand on my own terms.

The whitepaper is nine pages long. It was written by someone using the pseudonym Satoshi Nakamoto, published in 2008, describing a system for electronic cash that would allow online payments to be sent directly from one party to another without going through a financial institution. I read it carefully, twice.

What struck me was not the potential for getting rich. I had been in the financial technology industry long enough to be skeptical of get-rich-quick schemes. What struck me was the technical elegance of the solution. Satoshi had solved a problem that computer scientists had been working on for decades: how to create digital scarcity without a central authority.

The key insight was the blockchain—a distributed ledger that recorded all transactions, maintained by a network of computers that reached consensus through a mechanism called proof-of-work. This meant that no single entity controlled the system. It meant that transactions could be verified by anyone. It meant that value could be transferred across the internet without intermediaries.

This was not just a new kind of money. It was a new kind of financial infrastructure. And as someone who had spent fifteen years building financial infrastructure, I recognized its significance immediately.

I spent the next six months studying Bitcoin in depth. I read everything I

could find: technical documentation, forum discussions, academic papers, news articles. I engaged with the early community of developers and enthusiasts. I tested the technology myself, sending small amounts of Bitcoin between wallets, examining how the transactions were recorded on the blockchain.

What I concluded was that Bitcoin was not perfect. It had limitations: the transaction throughput was low, the energy consumption was significant, the user experience was poor. But the fundamental concept—decentralized, censorship-resistant digital money—was sound. And the limitations were solvable, or at least improvable, through technical innovation.

This was the moment when I decided to go all-in. I sold my apartment in Shanghai—approximately \$900,000—and invested the proceeds in Bitcoin. This was not the 10 percent that Ron had recommended. This was essentially everything I had accumulated over fifteen years of work.

Looking back, this decision seems reckless. At the time, it seemed logical. I had studied the technology. I understood its potential. I believed that the probability of success was higher than the market was pricing in. And I was willing to accept the risk of total loss in exchange for the possibility of outsized returns.

My timing was not perfect. I bought Bitcoin at an average price of around \$600, after the price had already fallen from its peak of over \$1,000. Then it fell further. By early 2014, Bitcoin was trading below \$400. My investment had lost more than half its value. My mother called me a “stupid boy.” She was not entirely wrong.

But I did not sell. I had not invested in Bitcoin as a short-term trade. I had invested because I believed in the technology and its potential to transform the financial system. A price decline did not change that belief. If anything, it made me more convinced, because it meant I could buy more at lower prices.

I did buy more. As the price continued to fall through 2014, I accumulated additional Bitcoin, averaging down my cost basis. I also started looking for ways to work in the industry full-time. I was no longer content to be an investor. I wanted to be a builder.

This decision—to sell my apartment, to invest everything in Bitcoin, to

commit my career to this new technology—has been described in many ways by journalists and commentators. Some have called it visionary. Others have called it reckless. The truth is that it was both. It was a calculated risk based on deep technical understanding, but it was also a gamble with consequences I did not fully anticipate.

What I have tried to explain, in interviews and now in this book, is that my motivation was not primarily financial. Yes, I wanted to make money. But more than that, I wanted to be part of building something important. I had spent fifteen years working on trading systems that moved money within the existing financial infrastructure. Bitcoin offered the possibility of building new infrastructure entirely, of creating systems that operated on different principles, that were open to anyone with an internet connection.

This vision—of financial systems without gatekeepers, of value transfer without intermediaries, of economic opportunity without geographic boundaries—was what drove me. The money was a side effect. The real reward was the work itself: the challenge of building systems that had never existed before, the satisfaction of solving technical problems that others thought were unsolvable, the opportunity to participate in the creation of a new industry.

I am aware that this sounds idealistic, perhaps even naive. The cryptocurrency industry has since become associated with speculation, scams, and regulatory evasion. Many of the early idealists have been replaced by people whose primary motivation is profit. But in 2013, at that poker table, listening to Bobby and Ron describe this new technology, what I felt was not greed. It was curiosity. It was excitement about the possibilities. It was the recognition that something important was happening, and I wanted to be part of it.

That curiosity would lead me to Blockchain.info, where I would work on one of the first Bitcoin wallets. It would lead me to OKCoin, where I would serve as CTO of one of China's largest exchanges. And it would eventually lead me to found Binance, which would become the world's largest cryptocurrency exchange. But all of that was still ahead of me in 2013, as I watched the price of Bitcoin fall and fall, wondering if I had just made the biggest mistake of

my life.

The Cost of All-In: Sold the House, Price Crashed

I sold my apartment in Shanghai in late 2013. It was a nice place, purchased with earnings from Fusion Systems and my earlier career. It represented security, stability, a foothold in one of the world's most dynamic cities. I sold it for approximately \$900,000. I used the proceeds to buy Bitcoin.

The price at which I bought averaged around \$600 per Bitcoin. This was already down from the peak of over \$1,000 that Bitcoin had reached earlier in 2013. I was not buying at the top. I was buying on the way down, which seemed like good timing. It was not.

By early 2014, Bitcoin was trading below \$400. My investment had lost more than a third of its value. By mid-2014, it was below \$300. At the lowest point, my \$900,000 investment was worth less than \$400,000. I had lost over half a million dollars on paper.

This was not my only asset. I had some savings, some investments in other ventures. I was not going to starve. But the apartment had been my safety net, my retreat if everything else failed. Without it, I was exposed. I had no place to go back to. No foundation to rebuild from.

Psychologists have a term for this: loss aversion. People feel losses more intensely than equivalent gains. Losing \$500,000 feels worse than gaining \$500,000 feels good. This is a well-documented phenomenon, and I experienced it intensely in 2014.

But I also experienced something else. Without the safety net, I had to make this work. There was no option to retreat to a stable job, to a comfortable apartment, to a predictable life. I had burned those bridges. The only path forward was through.

This is what I mean when I talk about psychological accounting. When you sell your retreat, you change your relationship with risk. You become someone who operates in volatility not by choice but by necessity. You develop a tolerance for uncertainty that others might find pathological.

I do not recommend this approach. It is stressful. It affects your sleep, your relationships, your ability to think clearly. There were nights in 2014 when I would wake up at 3 AM, check the Bitcoin price on my phone, and lie awake until morning, calculating how much more I had lost, wondering if I had made a terrible mistake.

But there were also moments of clarity. I would remind myself why I had made this decision. I would review my analysis of the technology, my assessment of the long-term potential, my conviction that blockchain represented a fundamental shift in how financial systems could operate. The price was down, but the technology had not changed. The vision was still valid.

So I held. And I bought more. As the price continued to fall, I accumulated additional Bitcoin at lower prices, reducing my average cost basis. This is called averaging down, and it is a controversial strategy. If you are wrong about the fundamental value of the asset, averaging down just means losing more money. But if you are right, it means increasing your returns when the price eventually recovers.

I was betting that I was right. I was betting that Bitcoin's price decline was temporary, a correction after the speculative bubble of 2013, not a permanent collapse. I was betting that the underlying technology would continue to develop, that adoption would continue to grow, that the long-term trajectory

was upward.

These bets were not certain. Nothing in financial markets is certain. But they were informed by my technical understanding of the system, my experience in financial technology, my assessment of the competitive landscape. I was not just hoping. I was analyzing.

The other thing I did in 2014 was commit to working in the cryptocurrency industry full-time. I left my previous roles and joined Blockchain.info as head of development. This was a significant pay cut from what I could have earned in traditional finance. But it gave me something more valuable: direct involvement in building the infrastructure of this new industry.

Working at Blockchain.info taught me about the practical challenges of cryptocurrency adoption. The technology was difficult to use. The user experience was poor. Security was a constant concern—wallets were hacked, funds were lost, users were confused. These were not abstract problems. They affected real people who were trying to use this new system.

I also learned about the community. The early cryptocurrency space was small, passionate, often fractious. There were intense debates about the direction of the technology: how to scale, how to govern, how to balance innovation with stability. I participated in these debates, sometimes heatedly. I developed relationships with people who would become collaborators and competitors in the years to come.

Through all of this, the price of Bitcoin remained depressed. It would not return to \$600 until 2016. It would not exceed its 2013 peak until 2017. For three years, my investment was underwater. For three years, I had to justify my decision to myself, to my family, to anyone who asked why I had sold a perfectly good apartment to buy internet money that had lost half its value.

The psychological pressure was real. I developed coping mechanisms. I stopped checking the price daily. I focused on the work, on building things, on contributing to the ecosystem. I reminded myself that I had made this decision with open eyes, that I had accepted the risk, that I was responsible for the outcome.

What I did not do was panic sell. This is easier to say in retrospect than it was to execute at the time. Every price drop created pressure to cut losses,

to admit the mistake, to move on. Every news story about Bitcoin's demise reinforced the narrative that I had been foolish, that the technology was a fad, that the skeptics had been right all along.

I held because of my conviction in the technology. I held because I had no better alternative—selling would have locked in the loss. I held because, on some level, I had committed to this path and could not imagine turning back.

The price eventually recovered. By 2017, Bitcoin was trading above \$1,000 again. By the end of that year, it would reach nearly \$20,000. My investment, which had been worth less than \$400,000 at its lowest point, would be worth tens of millions. The apartment I had sold would seem like a trivial cost in comparison.

But I do not tell this story as a triumph. The outcome was favorable, but the process was painful. I made a decision that subjected me to years of stress and uncertainty. I exposed myself to risks that, in retrospect, were larger than I had fully appreciated. I was lucky that my analysis was correct, that the technology developed as I expected, that the market eventually validated my conviction.

Not everyone who made similar bets in 2013 and 2014 was so lucky. Many people bought Bitcoin at high prices and sold at lows, locking in losses. Many people invested in projects that failed entirely. Many people were scammed or hacked or simply made bad decisions. The fact that my story had a happy ending does not mean the approach I took was correct, only that it happened to work in this particular case.

What I learned from this experience is that risk tolerance is not just a financial concept. It is a psychological one. It is about how you handle uncertainty, how you manage stress, how you maintain conviction in the face of evidence that suggests you might be wrong. These are skills that can be developed, but they have costs. The cost of developing them is experiencing the situations that require them.

I paid that cost in 2014. I paid it in sleepless nights, in strained relationships, in the constant background anxiety of watching my net worth fluctuate by hundreds of thousands of dollars on a daily basis. Whether that cost

was worth the eventual return is not a question I can answer objectively. It depends on what you value, what you are willing to endure, what you believe about the nature of risk and reward.

What I can say is that the experience changed me. It made me someone who is comfortable with volatility, who can make decisions under uncertainty, who can maintain long-term conviction despite short-term setbacks. These characteristics would prove essential in the years to come, as I built Binance and navigated the challenges of running a global cryptocurrency exchange. But they also created blind spots, tendencies toward overconfidence, a willingness to take risks that others would consider irresponsible.

Understanding these trade-offs—recognizing that every strength has a corresponding weakness—is an ongoing process. I am still learning. But the foundation was laid in 2014, in a small apartment in Shanghai, watching numbers on a screen go down and down, wondering if I had made the biggest mistake of my life.

The Person Writing the Chain: Days at Blockchain.info

In the spring of 2014, I joined Blockchain.info as head of development. The company was one of the earliest and most popular Bitcoin wallet services, allowing users to store, send, and receive Bitcoin through a web interface. It was not a glamorous job. The pay was modest. The team was small. But it gave me something I needed: direct involvement in building the infrastructure of the cryptocurrency ecosystem.

I met Yi He that same spring, at a public blockchain event at a school in Shanghai. The organizers discovered that I worked for Blockchain.info—the most popular Bitcoin wallet at the time—and invited me on stage to share my thoughts. I spoke about blockchain technology, about Bitcoin’s principles, about how this new system could bring positive changes to the world.

Yi He was in the audience. She would later write about this moment in a letter to a judge: “His speech was full of idealism about how blockchain technology could bring positive changes to the world, which greatly influenced and inspired me.” At the time, I did not know who she was or what role she would play in my future. I was simply explaining technology I found fascinating to anyone who would listen.

What I did not mention in that speech, but what was true, was that I had just sold my apartment to buy Bitcoin. My assets had shrunk significantly

due to the price decline. But this did not dampen my enthusiasm for the technology. If anything, it reinforced my commitment. I was not in this for short-term gains. I was in this because I believed in what we were building.

Blockchain.info was a different kind of challenge from my previous work. At the Tokyo Stock Exchange and Bloomberg Tradebook, I had built systems for trading traditional financial instruments—stocks, futures, derivatives. These systems moved value within established frameworks, governed by regulations, supervised by authorities. At Blockchain.info, I was building systems that operated outside those frameworks, that allowed users to be their own banks, to control their own money without intermediaries.

The technical work was absorbing. A Bitcoin wallet is not just a place to store funds. It is a tool for interacting with the blockchain: creating transactions, managing private keys, verifying balances. Every design decision had implications for security, usability, and privacy. Get it wrong, and users could lose their money. Get it right, and you were enabling a new form of financial freedom.

I spent my days writing code, reviewing pull requests, discussing architecture decisions with the team. I spent my evenings engaging with the Bitcoin community: forums, mailing lists, IRC channels. The pace was intense. The technology was evolving rapidly. Every week brought new challenges, new ideas, new debates about how the system should work.

One of the things I focused on was the user experience. Early Bitcoin wallets were difficult to use. The concepts—private keys, addresses, confirmations—were unfamiliar to most people. The interfaces were technical, intimidating. I believed that for Bitcoin to achieve mainstream adoption, it needed to be accessible to non-technical users.

This was harder than it sounds. Security and usability are often in tension. The most secure system is one that no one can use. The most usable system is one that makes dangerous operations too easy. Finding the right balance required constant iteration, constant testing with real users, constant refinement based on feedback.

I also worked on performance. As Bitcoin's usage grew, the blockchain grew with it. Wallets needed to synchronize with an ever-larger dataset.

Transactions needed to be processed quickly even during periods of high network congestion. These were technical problems I understood from my previous work in trading systems, but the constraints were different. In traditional finance, you could optimize for speed by adding hardware, by co-locating servers, by paying for premium connectivity. In Bitcoin, you were limited by the protocol itself, by block size limits, by the decentralized nature of the network.

What I learned at Blockchain.info was that building for cryptocurrency was not just a technical challenge. It was a philosophical one. Every design decision embodied assumptions about how financial systems should work. Should users control their own keys, or should a service hold them? Should transactions be reversible, or should they be final? Should privacy be the default, or should transparency be prioritized?

These were not questions with objectively correct answers. They were value judgments, trade-offs between competing priorities. The Bitcoin community had strong opinions about them, often expressed in heated debates that lasted for months or years. I participated in these debates, developing my own views, learning to articulate them, learning to respect views I disagreed with.

The work was not always smooth. There were technical failures—bugs that caused problems for users, downtime that prevented access to funds. There were interpersonal conflicts—disagreements about direction, about priorities, about who should make decisions. These are normal in any technology company, but they felt more intense in the cryptocurrency space, where the stakes seemed higher and the community was more passionate.

What sustained me was the sense of purpose. I believed that what we were building mattered. Not because it would make us rich—though that was possible—but because it would change how people interacted with money. Traditional financial systems excluded billions of people: those without bank accounts, those in countries with unstable currencies, those who could not meet the requirements for opening accounts. Bitcoin offered an alternative. It was not perfect, but it was a start.

This perspective shaped how I approached my work. I was not just writing

code. I was contributing to a movement, to a vision of financial systems that were more open, more accessible, more resistant to censorship and control. This sounds grandiose, and I am aware of that. But it was genuinely how I thought about what I was doing.

My time at Blockchain.info lasted about six months. In late 2014, I moved to OKCoin, one of China's largest cryptocurrency exchanges, as Chief Technology Officer. The move was motivated by a desire to work more directly on trading systems, to apply my experience in financial technology to the emerging cryptocurrency exchange market.

But the lessons from Blockchain.info stayed with me. I had learned that money is not just a medium of exchange. It is a form of human choice, a way of expressing values and priorities. When you build systems for moving money, you are not just building infrastructure. You are shaping how people can exercise those choices.

This insight would become central to my work at Binance. The exchange we built was not just a platform for trading. It was a tool for accessing a new financial system, for participating in a global economy that operated on different principles from the traditional one. Whether that was good or bad, whether the benefits outweighed the risks, whether the idealism was justified by the outcomes—these are questions that reasonable people can disagree about.

What I can say with confidence is that my time at Blockchain.info shaped how I thought about these questions. It gave me a foundation of technical knowledge and philosophical perspective that I would draw on in everything that came after. It introduced me to people who would become collaborators and friends. And it reinforced my conviction that the work we were doing was important, even when the price of Bitcoin was falling and the future seemed uncertain.

The person I was in 2014, writing code for a Bitcoin wallet, believing in the transformative potential of blockchain technology, is not fundamentally different from the person I am today. The context has changed. The scale has changed. The challenges have changed. But the core motivation—the desire to build systems that expand human freedom, that give people more

control over their financial lives—remains the same.

This is why I have written this book. Not to defend my decisions or to justify my actions, but to explain them, to provide context that is missing from news reports and court documents, to give readers a view from inside the process of building something new. Whether you find that view persuasive or not is up to you. But it is my view, honestly presented, and that is all I can offer.

OKCoin: Technology, Speed, and People

I joined OKCoin in 2014 as Chief Technology Officer. It was not a decision I made lightly. After leaving Blockchain.info, I had options. The cryptocurrency space was small then, and experienced engineers were in demand. But OKCoin offered something specific: the chance to build infrastructure at scale, to understand how an exchange actually worked under the hood.

People sometimes ask me what I learned at OKCoin. The honest answer is: almost everything that would later matter. Not just technical knowledge, though that was substantial. I learned about pressure. Real pressure. The kind that comes when thousands of people are trying to execute trades simultaneously, when a millisecond of latency can mean the difference between profit and loss, when system downtime doesn't just inconvenience users—it costs them money they may not be able to afford to lose.

An exchange is not like other technology companies. It is infrastructure in the most literal sense. When you build a social media platform, people get annoyed if it goes down. When you build an exchange, people can lose their life savings. The responsibility is different. The stakes are different. I understood this intellectually before joining OKCoin. I understood it in my bones after the first major system overload.

The technical challenges were substantial. Matching engines, order books, wallet security, withdrawal processing—each component had to work flawlessly, and they all had to work together. I spent my first months deep

in the codebase, understanding how the system handled high-frequency trading, how it managed cold and hot wallets, how it processed the constant stream of deposits and withdrawals that never stopped, not even at night.

Speed was everything. In traditional finance, I had built low-latency systems for Bloomberg, for Fusion Systems. I understood microseconds. But cryptocurrency added another dimension: the blockchain itself. Bitcoin blocks confirm every ten minutes on average. That is an eternity in trading time. So you build layers—internal ledgers that update instantly, reconciliation systems that settle on-chain when needed. The architecture becomes a compromise between speed and security, between convenience and trustlessness.

I also managed the international expansion at OKCoin. This was where I began to understand the regulatory complexity that would later define so much of my career. Each country had different rules, different banking relationships, different expectations. Japan was not Singapore was not the United States. Building a global exchange meant navigating this maze, finding local partners, understanding local compliance requirements. It was slow, painstaking work.

The team at OKCoin was talented. There were engineers who understood distributed systems, traders who understood market dynamics, operations people who could keep everything running through chaos. I learned from all of them. I also learned what happened when technical excellence wasn't matched by operational transparency. This would become important later, when I started thinking about building something of my own.

My time at OKCoin was relatively brief—I left in early 2015. The departure was not without conflict. I have spoken about this publicly in interviews, including with Unchained, where I noted that I was OKCoin's CTO. The disagreements were fundamental, about how users should be treated, about what transparency meant in practice. I won't rehash the details here. What matters is that I left with a clear understanding of what I wanted to build, and perhaps more importantly, what I did not want to build.

I learned that technology alone is not enough. You can have the fastest matching engine, the most secure wallet architecture, the most scalable

infrastructure. But if users don't trust you, none of it matters. Trust is built through actions, not words. Through transparency in fees, through consistent uptime, through fair treatment when things go wrong. These seem like obvious principles, but in the early days of cryptocurrency, they were not universally practiced.

I also learned about myself. I learned that I could lead technical teams through crisis. That I could make decisions under pressure, when the system was failing and every minute of downtime meant angry users and lost revenue. That I could stay calm when others panicked. These were useful skills. They would be tested many times in the years to come.

The OKCoin period was formative in another way: it was where I first worked closely with Yi He. But that story deserves its own chapter. For now, what matters is that by the time I left OKCoin, I had a clear picture of what a cryptocurrency exchange should be. I had seen the mistakes. I understood the technical requirements. I knew the regulatory landscape, at least as well as anyone could in 2015.

What I did not yet have was the opportunity to build it myself. That would come, but not immediately. First, there was another chapter: Bijie Technology, a different kind of company, a different set of lessons. The technology I had built and refined at OKCoin would find new applications. The understanding I had gained would inform new decisions.

Looking back, my time at OKCoin was like an accelerated education in exchange operations. Everything moved fast. The industry was young, the technology was raw, the users were passionate and unforgiving. It was the perfect training ground for what came next. I am not sure I would have been ready to build Binance without that experience. The technical knowledge was essential, but so was the understanding of pressure, of responsibility, of what it meant to hold other people's money.

When I left OKCoin, I took with me more than technical expertise. I took a philosophy, still forming, about what cryptocurrency exchanges could be. Not just profit centers. Not just trading venues. But infrastructure for a new kind of financial system. This vision was naive in some ways, incomplete in others. But it was a starting point. And from starting points, you can build.

The years 2014 and 2015 were busy ones. The cryptocurrency industry was growing, changing, maturing in fits and starts. I was growing with it, learning, making mistakes, adjusting my understanding. By the end of 2015, I knew what I wanted to do next. The only question was when the right moment would come. As it turned out, I would not have to wait long.

There were specific technical problems I wrestled with at OKCoin that would inform my later work. The issue of order matching fairness, for instance—how do you ensure that when thousands of orders arrive simultaneously, they are processed in a way that does not advantage some users over others? In traditional finance, this problem had established solutions. In cryptocurrency, with its 24/7 markets and unpredictable volume spikes, new approaches were needed. I experimented with different matching algorithms, different queue management strategies, different ways of handling the edge cases that inevitably arise in high-volume trading environments.

Wallet security was another area of deep focus. The distinction between hot wallets and cold storage seems simple in theory—keep most funds offline, only keep what you need for daily operations accessible. In practice, the implementation is complex. How do you determine the right balance? How do you handle withdrawal requests when the hot wallet is depleted? How do you protect the private keys that control millions of dollars in user funds? These questions kept me awake at night. They still do, though the scale is now vastly larger.

I also spent considerable time thinking about the user experience of trading. Most exchanges in 2014 had interfaces that were clearly designed by engineers for engineers—functional, but intimidating to newcomers. I believed that cryptocurrency trading could be accessible to ordinary people, not just to those with technical backgrounds. This belief would later shape Binance's interface design, but its roots were in my observations at OKCoin, watching users struggle with complexity that could have been simplified.

The regulatory education I received at OKCoin was equally valuable. I learned that compliance was not just about following rules—it was about building relationships with regulators, understanding their concerns, find-

ing ways to operate within frameworks that were often unclear or contradictory. I learned that different jurisdictions had different risk tolerances, different priorities, different timelines for action. What was acceptable in Hong Kong might not be acceptable in New York. Navigating this landscape required patience, flexibility, and a willingness to adapt quickly as conditions changed.

Departure and New Beginning: Bijie Technology's Exchange Infrastructure

In August 2015, I founded Bijie Technology. The name means nothing special in English—it was simply a company name, practical and unremarkable. What mattered was what the company did: we built exchange infrastructure for other businesses. After leaving OKCoin, I had accumulated knowledge about how cryptocurrency exchanges worked. Bijie was a way to apply that knowledge without running an exchange myself.

The business model was straightforward. We provided white-label exchange solutions—software that other companies could use to launch their own trading platforms. The technology stack I had developed and refined at OKCoin became the foundation. Matching engines, wallet management systems, user interfaces, risk controls—all the components necessary to operate a functional exchange, packaged and sold to customers who wanted to enter the market without building everything from scratch.

This was not glamorous work. We were not a consumer brand. Most people who used exchanges powered by Bijie technology never knew our name. We were behind the scenes, infrastructure providers, the kind of company that makes headlines only when something goes wrong. I was comfortable with that. I have always been more interested in building systems than in being famous for building them.

The team was small but capable. Roger Wang, who would later become Binance's co-founder and CTO, joined from Nomura and Morgan Stanley. He brought deep experience in traditional finance technology—credit scoring systems, bond matching engines, data warehouses supporting thousands of traders. Combined with my cryptocurrency exchange experience, we had a strong technical foundation. We understood both worlds: the legacy financial infrastructure and the new blockchain-based systems that were beginning to challenge it.

Bijie operated in a complicated regulatory environment. China had not yet banned cryptocurrency trading—that would come later—but the rules were unclear. We positioned ourselves as a technology provider, not a financial services company. We built software. What our customers did with it was their responsibility. This distinction mattered legally, even if the practical reality was more nuanced.

Media reports have linked Bijie to various platforms over the years. Some of these reports are accurate; others contain speculation. I am not going to address every claim here. What I will say is that Bijie was a technology company. We sold software. We provided technical support. We did not operate exchanges ourselves, did not hold customer funds, did not make trading decisions. The separation was important to us, both legally and ethically.

The work was demanding. Each client had different requirements—different trading pairs, different fee structures, different compliance needs. We customized our platform for each deployment while trying to maintain a coherent core architecture. It was good practice for what would come later. Building one exchange is hard. Building a platform that can be configured into many exchanges is harder. You have to abstract the common patterns while preserving the flexibility to handle edge cases.

I learned a lot during the Bijie years. I learned about sales, about managing client relationships, about the challenges of being a vendor rather than an operator. When you run an exchange, your users are your customers. When you sell exchange software, your customers are other businesses, with their own priorities and pressures. The dynamic is different. The skills required

are different.

I also learned about patience. Bijie was profitable but not explosive. We grew steadily, adding clients, refining our technology, building a reputation in the industry. There were no viral moments, no dramatic breakthroughs. Just consistent work, day after day, improving the product, serving customers, keeping the lights on. This is how most businesses operate. The startup mythology of sudden success is just that—mythology. Real companies are built through sustained effort over time.

The Bijie period also gave me space to think. Running an exchange is all-consuming. The market never closes. There is always a crisis somewhere—a system issue, a customer complaint, a regulatory inquiry. As a technology provider, the pressure was lower. I had time to read, to follow developments in the broader cryptocurrency space, to think about what might come next. This would prove valuable.

By 2017, the landscape was changing. The ICO boom was beginning. Interest in cryptocurrency was surging. I started to see an opportunity to build something bigger—not just sell software to other people, but create a platform of my own. The timing felt right. The technology was mature. The market was ready. And I had learned enough to believe I could do it better than what existed.

The decision to pivot from Bijie to Binance was not made lightly. Bijie was a functioning business with revenue and customers. Starting an exchange meant starting over, taking on new risks, competing in a crowded market. But the opportunity was real. The existing exchanges had problems—performance issues, customer service failures, regulatory challenges. I believed I could build something faster, more reliable, more user-focused.

So I made the leap. Bijie's technology became the foundation for Binance. The team I had built came with me. The lessons I had learned about exchange operations, about customer needs, about regulatory complexity—all of it informed the new venture. Bijie was not a detour. It was preparation.

Looking back, I am grateful for those years. They taught me that sustainable businesses are built on solid foundations, not hype. They gave me the technical platform and the team I would need for the next phase. And they

reminded me that the most important work often happens invisibly, behind the scenes, without recognition or glory. This is how infrastructure gets built. This is how industries mature. Not through dramatic announcements, but through persistent, unglamorous effort.

Bijie Technology existed for less than two years as an independent entity. But its impact was lasting. The code we wrote, the systems we built, the team we assembled—all of it carried forward into what came next. Sometimes the most important chapters in a story are the quiet ones, the transitions between the dramatic moments. Bijie was that for me. A time of consolidation, of preparation, of getting ready for what I somehow knew was coming.

The technical architecture we developed at Bijie proved remarkably adaptable. The modular design—matching engine as a separate service, wallet management as another, user interface as a third—meant that components could be upgraded or replaced without disrupting the whole system. This was not accidental. I had learned at OKCoin that monolithic systems became unwieldy as they grew. I was determined to build something more flexible.

We also developed expertise in deployment and operations. Running software for external clients is different from running it for yourself. The stakes are higher when someone else's business depends on your code being available. We built monitoring systems, alerting mechanisms, failover procedures. We learned how to push updates without downtime, how to diagnose problems remotely, how to communicate with clients during incidents. These operational disciplines would serve us well when Binance launched and the scale increased by orders of magnitude.

The client relationships taught me something about the diversity of the cryptocurrency market. Our customers had different visions—some wanted to serve retail traders, others focused on institutional clients, still others were building specialized platforms for specific use cases. Each required different configurations, different features, different approaches to compliance. This exposure to variety broadened my understanding of what was possible, of the many ways that cryptocurrency infrastructure could evolve.

Meeting Yi He: Someone Better at Telling Stories

I met Yi He in the spring of 2014, at a blockchain event at a school in Shanghai. The details of the event itself are not important—it was one of many such gatherings in those years, enthusiasts and entrepreneurs coming together to discuss Bitcoin and its possibilities. What mattered was the person I met there.

I was not scheduled to speak. I attended as a participant, someone interested in the technology, eager to learn and connect. But the organizers recognized my name from Blockchain.info, where I was working at the time. They asked if I would say a few words. I agreed. I spoke about Bitcoin, about blockchain technology, about the potential for decentralized systems to change how people interact with money. It was not a particularly remarkable speech. I am not a natural orator. My strength has always been in systems, in architecture, in understanding how things work under the surface.

After the talk, Yi He approached me. She had already joined OKCoin as Vice President, responsible for branding and marketing. She was direct, confident, clearly skilled at reading people and situations. We talked about the industry, about where it was headed, about the challenges facing early cryptocurrency companies. She asked good questions. She listened. And then she made an offer: come join OKCoin as CTO. Help us build something.

I was flattered but cautious. I had only recently joined Blockchain.info. I was learning, contributing, finding my place in the industry. But Yi He was persuasive. She had a vision for OKCoin, for what it could become. She understood marketing in a way that I did not—understood how to communicate complex ideas to general audiences, how to build brand recognition, how to create excitement around a product. These were not my strengths. I recognized their value.

We stayed in touch. Over the following months, we had many conversations—some about business, some about technology, some about our personal backgrounds and motivations. I learned that she had come from television, had worked as a host on travel programs, had built a career through persistence and adaptability. She learned about my background in finance technology, my time at Bloomberg, my growing conviction that cryptocurrency would transform the world.

The partnership that developed was complementary. I focused on technology, on building systems that worked. She focused on communication, on telling the story of what we were building. Together, we helped OKCoin grow. She led the marketing efforts that put the company on the map—the Times Square billboard, the magazine features, the brand partnerships. I built the infrastructure that kept the platform running. It was a productive collaboration, even if it was sometimes tense, even if we did not always agree on priorities or methods.

Yi He later wrote about our first meeting in a letter to a judge, which was made public. In that letter, she described how I arrived at the event and was invited to speak impromptu. She noted my enthusiasm for blockchain, my willingness to explain complex concepts to anyone who would listen. She mentioned that I had recently sold my house to buy Bitcoin, that my assets had shrunk due to price declines, but that my conviction remained strong. Her description captures something true about that time: I was all in, committed completely to this technology, willing to take risks that others considered foolish.

What Yi He brought to our partnership was something I lacked: the ability to translate technical achievement into narrative momentum. I could build

the fastest matching engine in the industry, but I could not explain why that mattered to someone who had never traded cryptocurrency. She could. She could take a technical improvement and turn it into a story that people cared about, that they remembered, that they shared. This skill is undervalued in technology circles, but it is essential. Products do not succeed on merit alone. They succeed when people understand them, when they see themselves in the story being told.

Our paths diverged after I left OKCoin in 2015. Yi He stayed longer, eventually leaving to join Yixia Technology as Vice President, leading brand strategy and marketing operations. She was successful there too—helped build Miaopai into a leading short-video platform, drove the company's valuation to over \$3 billion. I focused on Bijie, on building technology, on preparing for whatever would come next. We stayed in touch, but we were not working together. Not yet.

In August 2017, I asked Yi He to join Binance. By then, the company was taking shape. We had a team, a plan, a timeline. What we needed was someone who could tell our story, who could build our brand, who could help us stand out in an increasingly crowded market. I knew who I wanted for that role. I knew her capabilities. I knew we worked well together, that our skills complemented each other, that we shared a vision for what cryptocurrency could become.

She accepted. On August 8, 2017, she officially joined as co-founder and Chief Marketing Officer. It was one of the most important decisions in Binance's history. Yi He brought not just marketing expertise but strategic thinking, operational discipline, an understanding of how to build organizations. She became my partner in the truest sense—someone who shared the risks and the rewards, who cared as deeply as I did about making Binance succeed.

People sometimes ask about our relationship. Yi He addressed this directly in her statement to Fortune: "My personal life is independent from my professional life. My achievements and capabilities as co-founder are often overlooked with my personal life in question." I will respect that boundary here. What matters for this story is the professional partnership,

the collaboration that helped build Binance into what it became.

Yi He was right about something she once said: “When there are no heroes, the little ones become famous.” We were both little ones when we met—ambitious, capable, but unknown outside a small circle of blockchain enthusiasts. Together, we built something larger than either of us could have created alone. That is the power of complementary partnerships. That is what I found when I met Yi He at that blockchain event in 2014—not just a colleague, but someone whose strengths filled gaps in my own abilities, whose vision aligned with mine even when our methods differed.

I am grateful for that meeting. Grateful that she saw something in my awkward technical presentation worth pursuing. Grateful that she convinced me to join OKCoin, where I would learn lessons essential for what came next. Grateful that she agreed to join Binance when I asked, that she committed her considerable talents to our shared venture. Partnerships like this are rare. I have been fortunate to find one that worked.

The dynamic between us has always been one of mutual respect combined with direct communication. Yi He is not afraid to disagree with me, to challenge my assumptions, to push back when she thinks I am wrong. This is invaluable. Leaders need people around them who will tell them the truth, who will not simply agree with everything they say. Yi He has always been that person for me.

I have watched her work countless times—crafting messaging for a product launch, managing a crisis, negotiating with partners, building a team. Her approach is different from mine. Where I tend to analyze, she tends to intuit. Where I focus on systems, she focuses on people. Where I see patterns, she sees stories. These differences used to frustrate me occasionally. Now I understand that they are precisely what makes our partnership effective.

The cryptocurrency industry has changed dramatically since we first met in 2014. The people who were there at the beginning have taken different paths—some have left the industry entirely, some have become competitors, some have faded into obscurity. Yi He and I have stayed, have continued building, have adapted to each new phase of the market’s evolution. There

is something to be said for persistence, for staying power, for the ability to keep going when others give up.

When I think about what Binance became, I know that my technical contributions were important. But I also know that without Yi He's ability to communicate our vision, to build our brand, to create excitement around what we were doing, the technical excellence would not have mattered. People cannot use what they do not know exists. They cannot trust what they do not understand. Yi He made sure they knew about us, made sure they understood what we were trying to build.

Why I Wanted to Build an Exchange: From Slow to Fast

By early 2017, I knew what I wanted to build. The decision was not sudden. It emerged from years of observation, from my time at OKCoin, from my work at Bijie, from watching the cryptocurrency ecosystem evolve. I wanted to build an exchange. Not just any exchange—the best exchange. Fastest, most reliable, most user-focused. An exchange that could handle the growth I believed was coming.

My motivation was not primarily financial. This may sound strange from someone who later became wealthy through cryptocurrency, but it is true. I had already made money in my career. I had sold my Shanghai apartment to buy Bitcoin in 2013, and while that decision looked foolish when prices dropped, I had survived. I was not desperate. I was not building an exchange because I needed to get rich. I was building it because I believed the existing exchanges were not good enough.

The problems were clear to anyone who used cryptocurrency exchanges in 2016 and early 2017. They were slow. They crashed during high-volume periods. Their customer service was nonexistent or terrible. They lost user funds to hacks with depressing regularity. They treated customers as annoyances rather than as the foundation of their business. I had seen this from the inside at OKCoin. I had heard the complaints from Bijie clients.

I knew what users wanted because I was a user myself.

The existing exchanges had grown quickly during the early years of Bitcoin, when competition was limited and users had few alternatives. They had not been forced to improve. They were profitable despite their flaws, so they saw no reason to change. This created an opportunity. A new exchange, built with modern technology, focused on user experience from the ground up, could compete. Could win.

I was not interested in being the best storyteller. Yi He would handle that. I was interested in building the most resilient system. Infrastructure that would not fail under load. Security that would protect user funds. Performance that would make trading feel instant rather than delayed. These were technical problems, and I believed I could solve them better than anyone else.

The timing mattered. The ICO boom was beginning. Ethereum had made it easy to create new tokens, and projects were raising millions by selling them to investors. This created demand for exchanges that could list these tokens, that could provide liquidity for new assets. The existing exchanges were overwhelmed. They could not add new trading pairs fast enough. Their systems groaned under increased volume. Users were frustrated.

I saw a window. If we moved quickly, we could capture this growing market. We could become the go-to exchange for new tokens, for users who wanted access to the latest projects. This required speed—not just in our technology, but in our operations. Fast listing processes. Fast customer support responses. Fast withdrawals and deposits. Speed would be our differentiator.

The decision to build was also philosophical. I believed that cryptocurrency represented something important: a new way of thinking about money, about value transfer, about financial freedom. Exchanges were the gateways to this new world. They were where people converted their traditional currency into cryptocurrency, where they discovered new projects, where they participated in the emerging digital economy. If the gateways were broken, the whole ecosystem suffered.

I wanted to build an exchange that respected users. That treated them

fairly. That was transparent about fees and policies. That admitted mistakes and fixed them quickly. These seem like basic requirements for any business, but they were not common in the cryptocurrency exchange world of 2017. Many exchanges operated with a sense of entitlement, as if users should be grateful for the opportunity to trade on their platforms. I wanted to invert that relationship.

The technical vision was specific. I wanted a matching engine that could handle millions of transactions per second. I wanted wallet architecture that kept most funds in cold storage while maintaining instant withdrawal capability for reasonable amounts. I wanted a user interface that was clean, intuitive, accessible to newcomers while powerful enough for professional traders. I wanted systems that would scale automatically as volume grew, without requiring manual intervention.

Building this would require a strong team. I had started assembling one at Bijie—engineers who understood both traditional finance and cryptocurrency, who had experience with high-performance systems, who shared my commitment to quality. Roger Wang was central to this effort. His background at Morgan Stanley and Nomura gave us credibility in financial technology circles. His technical skills were essential to the architecture we were designing.

I also knew we would need capital. Building an exchange is expensive. Servers, security infrastructure, compliance systems, legal frameworks—these all require investment. I was prepared to invest my own money, to work without salary, to do whatever was necessary to get started. But for real growth, we would need more. We would need to raise funds.

The plan came together in early 2017. We would build the exchange. We would launch a token, BNB, to raise capital and align incentives with our users. We would move fast, taking advantage of the ICO boom while building something more durable than the typical token project. We would focus on execution, on delivering what we promised, on building trust through consistent performance.

When I told people what I was planning, some thought I was crazy. The exchange market was crowded, they said. The incumbents were too

established. The regulatory risks were too high. I listened to these concerns but was not deterred. I had seen the incumbents up close. I knew their weaknesses. And I believed that in a rapidly growing market, there was room for a new entrant who could execute better than the existing players.

The “why” of Binance was simple: because the existing exchanges were not good enough. Because users deserved better. Because I had the skills and experience to build something superior. Because the timing was right and the opportunity was real. These were sufficient reasons. They carried me through the difficult months ahead, through the fundraising, through the launch, through the explosive growth that followed.

I did not have a grand vision of transforming the global financial system, not at the beginning. That came later, as Binance grew and my understanding of what was possible expanded. In early 2017, my goals were more modest: build a better exchange. Serve users well. Create something that would last. Everything else grew from that foundation.

The specific technical decisions we made in those early months reflected this philosophy. We chose to build our matching engine from scratch rather than using off-the-shelf solutions, because we needed performance that existing systems could not provide. We designed our database architecture for horizontal scaling from day one, knowing that if we succeeded, growth would be rapid. We implemented security measures that exceeded industry standards, because I had seen what happened to exchanges that cut corners.

I also thought carefully about the business model. The traditional exchange model—charge high fees, provide minimal service, rely on network effects to keep users captive—was profitable but exploitative. We would do the opposite. Lower fees, better service, faster execution. We would make money through volume rather than margin, through efficiency rather than extraction. This model required scale to work, which created risk. But if we achieved scale, the advantages would compound.

The regulatory strategy was similarly considered. We would not operate in jurisdictions where cryptocurrency trading was clearly illegal. We would obtain licenses where they were available. We would work with regulators rather than against them, providing transparency and cooperating with

reasonable requests. This approach was slower than the “ask forgiveness rather than permission” strategy some competitors pursued. I believed it was more sustainable.

When I look back at the early planning documents, I am struck by how much of what we envisioned actually came to pass. The matching engine performed as designed. The scaling worked. The user interface was well-received. The business model proved viable. This was not luck. It was the result of careful thinking, of learning from others’ mistakes, of applying lessons accumulated over years of working in technology and finance.

Whitepaper and 16 Days: Memories of BNB Fundraising

The BNB token sale began on June 26, 2017, and ended on July 3, 2017. Sixteen days. That was all the time we had to raise the capital needed to launch Binance. Looking back, it seems both impossibly short and impossibly long—short in terms of what we needed to accomplish, long in terms of the stress and intensity of those days.

I wrote the whitepaper myself. This is not unusual in the cryptocurrency world—founders typically write their own whitepapers, explaining the project, the token economics, the roadmap. But I am not a natural writer of marketing documents. My background is in code, in systems, in technical architecture. Writing the whitepaper forced me to translate technical concepts into language that potential investors could understand, to explain not just what we were building but why it mattered.

The document was straightforward. We were creating a utility token that would provide discounts on trading fees, would be used for services within the Binance ecosystem, would be burned quarterly based on trading volume. The total supply was fixed at 200 million tokens. Half would be sold in the ICO. Forty percent would be reserved for the team, subject to a vesting schedule. Ten percent would go to angel investors who had supported us early.

The price was set at \$0.15 per BNB, or 2,700 BNB for 1 ETH. This pricing was

based on our capital needs and the market conditions at the time. We were not trying to maximize the valuation. We were trying to raise enough to build the exchange properly—about \$15 million, according to public records—while leaving room for the token to appreciate as the platform grew.

The response was overwhelming. Within days, we had commitments exceeding our target. The cryptocurrency community was hungry for new projects, for opportunities to participate in the emerging ecosystem. Our timing was fortunate—the ICO boom was at its peak, and investors were looking for serious teams with real experience. We had that. My background at OKCoin and Bloomberg, Roger Wang’s experience at Morgan Stanley and Nomura, Yi He’s marketing expertise—these credentials mattered in a space filled with anonymous developers and unproven claims.

But I was not celebrating. I was afraid. This is not something I talked about publicly at the time, but it is true. When you raise millions of dollars from thousands of people, the weight of that responsibility hits you immediately. These were not institutional investors with diversified portfolios. Many were retail participants, individuals who believed in the project enough to send their cryptocurrency to an unproven team. They were trusting us with their money. That trust felt heavy.

I remember the night the ICO closed. We had hit our target. The team was excited, relieved, ready to celebrate. I went home and could not sleep. I kept thinking about all the things that could go wrong, about the ways we could fail these people who had placed their faith in us. The exchange might not launch on time. The technology might not work as promised. Regulatory authorities might shut us down. There were so many risks, so many ways this could end badly.

The fear was not paralyzing. It was motivating. I channeled it into work, into making sure we delivered what we had promised. Every line of code we wrote, every system we built, every process we designed—I approached it with the knowledge that thousands of people were counting on us. Their investment was not just financial. It was emotional. They believed in cryptocurrency, in the future we were describing, in our ability to make it real.

The whitepaper became a contract, not in the legal sense but in the moral sense. We had made promises about what Binance would be, what BNB would do. Now we had to fulfill them. The 16 days of fundraising were just the beginning. The real work lay ahead—building the exchange, launching it, operating it, growing it. The token sale gave us resources. It also gave us obligations.

I learned something important during those 16 days. I learned that collective trust is a powerful force. When thousands of people believe in something simultaneously, when they act on that belief by contributing their resources, something changes in the world. A project that existed only in whitepaper and prototype becomes real. It has capital. It has a community. It has momentum.

But I also learned that this trust is fragile. It can be lost in an instant through bad actions, through failed promises, through the simple inability to deliver. I resolved that we would not lose the trust that had been placed in us. Whatever it took, we would build the exchange we had described. We would make BNB valuable not through marketing tricks but through genuine utility. We would treat our users as partners, not as marks to be exploited.

The ICO process itself was chaotic. The Ethereum network was congested. Transactions failed or took hours to confirm. Our website struggled under the load of visitors. We had to improvise, to communicate constantly with participants, to reassure them that their contributions were safe. It was good preparation for what would come—operating an exchange under pressure, dealing with issues in real-time, maintaining calm when systems were not working as expected.

When the sale ended, we had raised approximately \$15 million. The exact figure varies in different reports—some sources cite slightly different numbers—but the order of magnitude is correct. It was enough. Enough to build the exchange properly, to hire the team we needed, to establish operations in multiple jurisdictions. Not so much that we could be wasteful, that we could afford to make expensive mistakes. We still had to be careful, still had to prioritize, still had to execute efficiently.

The 16 days changed my life. They transformed me from an entrepreneur

with a plan into the leader of a funded project with thousands of stakeholders. They taught me about the psychology of markets, about how people make decisions under uncertainty, about the power of narrative in driving action. They showed me both the best and worst of the cryptocurrency community—the genuine enthusiasm for innovation, and the speculative frenzy that sometimes overwhelmed rational analysis.

Most importantly, they gave me a sense of responsibility that has never left me. Every BNB holder was someone who had chosen to believe in what we were building. That belief was a gift. It was also a burden. I carry both with me to this day.

Looking back at the whitepaper now, I am struck by both what we got right and what we did not anticipate. The core mechanism—using BNB for fee discounts, burning tokens quarterly—worked as designed. The token gained value as the platform grew, rewarding early supporters. But we did not fully anticipate how the BNB ecosystem would expand, how the token would become central to so many different products and services beyond the original vision.

The 16 days of the ICO were also a lesson in global participation. Contributors came from dozens of countries, from time zones spread across the planet. Some were experienced cryptocurrency investors who had participated in many token sales. Others were newcomers, drawn by the promise of a new exchange built by a team with credible backgrounds. This diversity was both a strength and a challenge—strength in the breadth of our community, challenge in the complexity of communication across languages and cultures.

I remember specific moments from those days with unusual clarity. The first time our contribution tracker crossed one million dollars. The moment we realized we would hit our target. The late-night conversations with team members about how to handle the influx of interest. The anxiety when the Ethereum network slowed and transactions backed up. These moments were intense, formative, burned into memory in a way that ordinary days are not.

The contrast between my internal state and external appearance during the ICO was stark. Publicly, I was confident, optimistic, projecting the certainty

that investors want to see in a founder. Privately, I was calculating risks, identifying failure modes, preparing contingency plans. This duality was necessary. No one wants to invest in a project whose leader seems uncertain. But the uncertainty was real, and managing it required constant effort.

The fundraising success also changed how others perceived me. Before the ICO, I was a relatively unknown figure in the cryptocurrency world—someone with relevant experience, but not a prominent one. Afterward, I was a founder who had raised \$15 million, who was building something significant, who was worth watching. This shift in perception brought new opportunities and new pressures. People wanted to meet me, to partner with us, to get early access to what we were building. Managing these relationships while staying focused on execution was a new challenge.

July 14, 2017: The Moment the Exchange Went Live

July 14, 2017. The date is burned into my memory. Binance went live on that day. After months of preparation, after the ICO, after building and testing and rebuilding, we opened for trading. I was nervous. Not visibly—I have learned to control my external reactions—but internally, my heart was racing.

The launch was not glamorous. There was no big event, no press conference, no celebration. We flipped a switch. The trading engine started. Users could log in. Orders began to flow. It was anticlimactic in the moment, but that was exactly what we wanted. A quiet launch meant no disasters. A quiet launch meant the systems were working.

We had chosen July 14 deliberately. Eleven days after the ICO ended. We needed time to prepare, to make sure everything was ready. But we also knew that speed mattered. The market was moving. Other exchanges were launching. Every day of delay was a day of lost opportunity. July 14 was the earliest date we could be confident in our readiness.

The core issue was system stability. This is what I worried about most. Not user acquisition. Not marketing. Not even regulatory compliance, though that was a close second. I worried about whether our systems would hold up under real trading volume. Test environments are not the same

as production. Simulated load is not the same as real users making real decisions with real money.

We had built for scale. The matching engine was designed to handle millions of transactions per second. The wallet architecture separated hot and cold storage, with most funds kept offline. The frontend was optimized for speed, with trades executing in milliseconds. But design is not reality. Until real users started trading, we would not know if our design was correct.

The first hours were quiet. A few users logged in. Some test trades executed. Everything worked as expected. I allowed myself to breathe. Then volume started to increase. Word spread that a new exchange had launched. Users who had participated in the ICO began to explore the platform. The order books started to fill.

By the end of the first day, we had processed thousands of trades. No system failures. No security breaches. No major bugs. It was a successful launch by any reasonable standard. But I did not relax. I knew that the real test would come when volume spiked, when the market moved suddenly, when everyone tried to trade at once. That test would come soon enough.

The team worked in shifts around the clock. Someone was always watching the systems, monitoring performance metrics, ready to respond if anything went wrong. I took my share of night shifts. There is something surreal about watching trading data flow across your screen at 3 AM, knowing that each transaction represents a person somewhere in the world making a decision about their money.

We had chosen to launch with a limited set of trading pairs. Bitcoin, Ethereum, and a few other major cryptocurrencies. We would add more over time, but for the launch, we wanted to keep things simple. Fewer trading pairs meant less complexity, less risk, easier monitoring. It was the right decision. Focus on doing a few things well before expanding.

The user interface was clean, minimalist. I had insisted on this. Other exchanges cluttered their screens with information, with charts, with indicators, with promotional banners. We kept it simple. Price. Order book. Trade history. Your balances. That was it. Everything else was optional, accessible through menus but not forced on users. This design philosophy—

simplicity first—would become a hallmark of Binance.

Customer support was another priority. We had a team ready to respond to user inquiries, though in those early days, the volume was manageable. I read many of the support tickets myself. I wanted to understand what users were asking, what confused them, what frustrated them. This feedback loop was essential. It shaped the improvements we made in the first weeks and months.

Security was never far from my mind. Every exchange that had come before us had been hacked, or had lost funds, or had suffered some security failure. I was determined that Binance would be different. We implemented multi-factor authentication from day one. We used hardware security modules for key management. We conducted regular security audits. We knew we would be targeted—we wanted to be ready.

The first week passed without major incident. Trading volume grew steadily. User registrations accelerated. We started to receive feedback, both positive and negative. We fixed bugs. We optimized performance. We added features that users requested. The platform was alive, evolving, improving.

I remember the first time we had a significant traffic spike. A major cryptocurrency announced a partnership, and the price moved rapidly. Users flooded in to trade. Our systems handled it. The matching engine kept up. The website stayed online. Deposits and withdrawals processed normally. When the spike ended, I felt something I had not expected: disappointment. I had been prepared for a crisis, and there was no crisis. The systems had just worked.

This became a pattern. We would prepare for the worst, and the worst would not come. Not because we were lucky, but because we had built well. The preparation was not wasted. It was what allowed us to survive the challenges that did come, later, when the stakes were higher and the problems more complex.

By the end of July, Binance was a functioning exchange. We had users. We had volume. We had revenue from trading fees. We had proven that the concept worked, that the technology held up, that there was demand for what we had built. The launch phase was over. The growth phase was

beginning.

I look back on July 14, 2017, with mixed emotions. Pride, certainly. We had done what we set out to do. Relief, that the systems had worked. Anxiety, because I knew this was just the beginning. Gratitude, for the team that had made it possible, for the users who had trusted us with their business.

Mostly, I remember the feeling of watching something come to life. An exchange is not a physical thing. You cannot touch it or see it. But it is real. It exists in the interactions between people, in the flow of orders and trades, in the trust that users place in the platform. On July 14, 2017, that trust began. It has never stopped.

The days immediately following the launch were a blur of activity. We monitored every metric—active users, trading volume, deposit and withdrawal patterns, system performance. Each data point told us something about how the platform was being used, where users were encountering friction, what was working well and what needed improvement. This data-driven approach was not unique to us, but we applied it with unusual intensity.

I also spent significant time in those early days communicating with users directly. I responded to questions on social media, participated in forum discussions, joined Telegram groups where Binance was being discussed. This was partly marketing—having the founder visible and accessible created goodwill. But it was also genuine curiosity. I wanted to hear directly from users, to understand their experience without the filtering that comes through formal support channels.

The feedback we received in those first weeks shaped our roadmap significantly. Users wanted more trading pairs, so we accelerated our listing process. They wanted faster withdrawals, so we optimized our wallet operations. They wanted mobile access, so we prioritized our app development. This responsiveness became part of our identity, a differentiator from the established exchanges that seemed indifferent to user requests.

Looking back, I am struck by how much we accomplished in such a short time. From ICO to launch in eleven days. From launch to a functioning, growing exchange in weeks. The pace was unsustainable in the long term,

but it was necessary in the moment. The market was moving quickly, and we needed to move with it. Speed was our advantage, and we used it fully.

Explosive Growth: No Daytime in a Bull Market

The fourth quarter of 2017 was unlike anything I had experienced. Bitcoin, which started the year under \$1,000, approached \$20,000 by December. Ethereum surged from under \$10 to over \$700. New tokens launched daily, raising millions in hours. The cryptocurrency market, which had been a niche interest for technologists and libertarians, became a global phenomenon.

Binance rode this wave. Our user base grew from thousands to hundreds of thousands to millions. Trading volume increased tenfold, then hundredfold. We added new trading pairs as fast as we could integrate them. Every day brought new records—highest volume, most new registrations, largest single trade. It was exhilarating. It was terrifying.

I stopped sleeping normally. There was no day or night, only market hours that never closed. I would wake up at 3 AM to check system status, respond to urgent messages, review the latest metrics. The team worked the same way. We were all running on adrenaline and caffeine, caught in a current that carried us forward whether we were ready or not.

The technical challenges were immense. Our systems, which had handled early volume comfortably, began to strain. We upgraded servers, optimized databases, rewrote critical code paths. Every improvement we made was immediately consumed by more growth. It was like running up an escalator

that was accelerating beneath you. You had to move faster just to stay in place.

I became arrogant. This is not easy to admit, but it is true. I started to believe that our growth was inevitable, that we were destined to become the largest exchange in the world, that our success was proof of our superiority. When the systems held up under load, I took credit. When user numbers increased, I saw it as validation of my vision. I confused correlation with causation—our growth was driven by market conditions more than by anything we were doing, but I did not see that clearly at the time.

The arrogance manifested in small ways. I was less patient with dissenting opinions. I made decisions more quickly, with less consultation. I took risks that, in retrospect, were unnecessary. We moved fast, which was good, but we sometimes moved carelessly, which was not. We were lucky that none of these decisions caused major problems. Luck is not a strategy.

The team grew rapidly. We hired dozens of people per week, sometimes per day. Onboarding became a challenge—how do you integrate new employees when everyone is already overwhelmed with work? We made mistakes in hiring, brought on people who were not a good fit, who did not share our values. Some of these people caused problems later. The rapid growth masked organizational weaknesses that would take years to address.

Customer support was a constant crisis. With millions of users, even a small percentage having issues meant thousands of tickets. We could not hire support staff fast enough. Response times stretched from hours to days to weeks. Users were frustrated, angry, vocal on social media. I read their complaints. Some were justified. Some were not. All of them represented real people having real problems with our service.

I told myself that growth solved everything. If we could just keep growing, we could hire more people, build better systems, improve customer service. This was partially true—growth did provide resources. But it also created new problems faster than we could solve the old ones. The debt accumulated: technical debt, organizational debt, reputational debt. We would pay for it later.

The market euphoria was contagious. Every day brought news of new

all-time highs, of traders becoming millionaires, of institutions entering the space. It felt like being part of a revolution, like we were building the future of finance in real-time. The energy was addictive. I understood why people got caught up in bubbles, why rational analysis gave way to emotional excitement. I was caught up in it too.

Yi He was a stabilizing force during this period. While I was focused on technology and operations, she was building the brand, managing communications, thinking about long-term positioning. She understood that the bull market would not last forever, that we needed to prepare for harder times. I listened to her, sometimes. Not often enough.

We launched new features rapidly. Futures trading. Margin trading. Lending products. Each expansion brought new complexity, new risks, new regulatory considerations. We did not always think these through completely. We were moving too fast for careful analysis. In some cases, we launched products that we later had to modify or discontinue. The speed was both our strength and our weakness.

I remember specific moments from that period, though they blur together in memory. The first time we processed a billion dollars in daily trading volume. The first time our systems went down under load—we recovered quickly, but the experience shook me. The first time a major influencer mentioned Binance on Twitter. Small milestones that felt enormous in the moment.

What I remember most is the feeling of being overwhelmed. Of having too much to do and not enough time. Of making decisions with incomplete information because waiting for complete information meant missing the moment. Of trusting my instincts because there was no time for careful analysis. Some of these decisions were good. Some were not. The ratio was favorable enough that we survived and grew.

The bull market peaked in December 2017. Bitcoin hit nearly \$20,000. Then it began to fall. The correction was sharp, painful for those who had bought near the top. For Binance, it was a test. Would users leave? Would volume collapse? Would we survive the downturn?

We survived. In fact, we continued to grow, though more slowly. The bear

market that followed was difficult, but it taught me lessons that the bull market could not. It humbled me. It forced me to focus on fundamentals rather than momentum. It showed me which of our strengths were real and which were artifacts of favorable conditions.

Looking back on Q4 2017, I am grateful for the experience. It showed me what rapid growth feels like, what it does to an organization, how it can distort judgment. It gave me perspective that would be valuable in later years, when Binance faced other challenges. And it taught me that speed, while essential, must be balanced with care. Growth without foundation is fragile. I knew this intellectually before. I knew it in my bones after.

After 9/4: Leaving China, Learning to Be Rootless

September 4, 2017. The date is known in Chinese cryptocurrency circles simply as “9/4.” On that day, the People’s Bank of China, along with several other government agencies, issued a joint statement declaring Initial Coin Offerings illegal. The statement identified ICOs as unauthorized fundraising activities that posed risks of fraud, money laundering, and financial instability. All ongoing ICO projects were ordered to cease immediately and return funds to investors. Cryptocurrency exchanges were told to stop operations.

I was in Shanghai when the announcement came. I remember reading the document, reading it again, trying to understand what it meant for Binance. We had launched less than two months earlier. We had raised funds through an ICO. We were operating as a cryptocurrency exchange. Every element of our business was now, effectively, illegal in China.

The initial response was confusion. The announcement was clear in its prohibition but vague in its implementation. What exactly were we required to do? By when? What would happen if we did not comply? These questions had no immediate answers. We consulted lawyers, reached out to contacts in government, tried to understand the practical implications. The uncertainty was almost worse than a clear ban would have been.

Within days, we made the decision to leave China. This was not easy. I

had lived in Shanghai for years. The team was largely based there. Our servers were there. Our banking relationships were there. Leaving meant abandoning infrastructure we had built, relationships we had cultivated, a market we understood. But staying was not an option. The regulatory risk was too high. We could not operate a business knowing that authorities might shut us down at any moment.

The relocation was rapid and chaotic. We identified jurisdictions that were more welcoming to cryptocurrency businesses—Japan, Singapore, Malta. We began moving servers, establishing new legal entities, opening new bank accounts. Team members who were willing to relocate made travel arrangements. Those who were not had to be transitioned out. It was painful. It was necessary.

I became rootless. This is the word that best describes my condition after 9/4. I had no fixed location, no permanent residence, no country I could call home in the traditional sense. I traveled constantly—Tokyo one week, Singapore the next, then Europe, then back to Asia. My possessions fit in a carry-on bag. My office was wherever I had an internet connection.

There was freedom in this rootlessness. I could go anywhere, work from anywhere, live anywhere. I was not tied to a particular city or country. I could follow the business, follow the opportunities, follow the regulatory clarity wherever it emerged. This flexibility was valuable. It allowed Binance to survive and grow when other exchanges that stayed in China were shut down.

But there was also cost. Personal relationships suffered. I could not maintain normal friendships when I was never in the same place for more than a few weeks. Family connections became strained. I missed birthdays, holidays, ordinary moments that give life texture and meaning. The people who cared about me learned not to expect my presence. I became a visitor in my own life.

The team experienced similar dislocation. Those who relocated had to build new lives in unfamiliar places. They left behind families, friends, communities. They learned new languages, adapted to new cultures, navigated new bureaucracies. Some thrived in this environment. Others

struggled. A few returned to China, unable to sustain the nomadic lifestyle.

I learned that flexibility and security are often in tension. The rootless existence gave us flexibility—we could move quickly to favorable jurisdictions, avoid unfavorable regulations, respond rapidly to changing conditions. But it deprived us of security—the comfort of knowing where we belonged, of having a stable base from which to operate, of being anchored in a community.

The psychological impact was subtle but real. I found myself becoming detached, not just from places but from people. When every relationship is temporary, when every interaction might be the last, you stop investing emotionally. You keep people at arm's length. You become efficient at goodbyes. This protected me from the pain of constant departure, but it also limited the depth of connection I could experience.

Binance as an organization became rootless too. We had no headquarters, no central office where employees gathered. We operated as a distributed network, with teams scattered across time zones, communicating through Slack and Zoom. This structure had advantages—it made us resilient, difficult to shut down, able to operate even if individual locations were disrupted. But it also made cohesion difficult. We were not a tribe. We were a diaspora.

The 9/4 ban was not the end of China's relationship with cryptocurrency. The government continued to issue regulations, to crack down on mining, to prohibit trading. Each new announcement sent ripples through the market, forced adjustments to our operations, reminded us that we were operating in a space where the rules could change overnight. We learned to live with uncertainty, to make decisions with incomplete information, to build systems that could adapt quickly.

I do not blame the Chinese government for the ban. They acted based on their understanding of the risks—fraud, financial instability, capital flight. These were real concerns. Many ICOs were scams. Many investors lost money. The government saw cryptocurrency as a threat to financial order, and they responded accordingly. I disagreed with their assessment of the technology's potential, but I understood their reasoning.

What 9/4 taught me was that building in the cryptocurrency space required accepting regulatory uncertainty as a permanent condition. We would never have the clarity that traditional financial institutions enjoyed. We would always be operating at the edge of what was permitted, adapting to new rules as they emerged, sometimes moving faster than regulators could keep up with, sometimes being forced to move by regulatory action.

The rootlessness that began on 9/4 continued for years. I did not establish a permanent residence until much later. Binance remained a distributed organization, without a formal headquarters. This became part of our identity, part of what made us different from traditional companies. We were citizens of the internet, bound by shared purpose rather than shared location.

There are times when I miss having a home. When I see friends with houses, with gardens, with children in local schools, I feel a twinge of something—regret, perhaps, or just curiosity about a life I did not choose. But then I remember why we made the choices we did. The rootlessness was not a mistake. It was a necessary adaptation to the environment we operated in. It enabled Binance to survive when others failed. It allowed us to continue building toward the vision that had motivated us from the beginning.

9/4 was a turning point. Before it, we were a Chinese company operating in China. After it, we were something else—global, distributed, adaptable, rootless. This transformation was painful. It was also, I believe, essential to our survival and growth. The cryptocurrency industry would face many more regulatory challenges in the years to come. Our rootlessness prepared us to meet them.

Users First: A Slogan Becomes Self-Constraint

“Users First.” It is a simple phrase, two words that appear on our website, in our marketing materials, in internal presentations. Like many corporate slogans, it could be dismissed as empty rhetoric—something companies say because it sounds good, not because they mean it. But for me, these words have become something more. They have become a constraint, a principle that shapes decisions, a standard against which actions are measured.

The phrase emerged early in Binance’s history. We needed a way to describe what made us different from other exchanges. “Users First” captured something essential: our belief that the people who used our platform were not just sources of revenue but partners in building something valuable. Without users, there was no Binance. Their trust, their loyalty, their success—these were the foundation of everything we built.

But saying “Users First” is easy. Living it is hard. The phrase creates obligations. When you claim to put users first, users expect you to actually do so. They judge your actions against that standard. They call out hypocrisy when they see it. The slogan becomes a target on your back, inviting scrutiny that would not exist if you had never made the claim.

I have learned this through experience. There have been times when we failed to live up to the “Users First” principle. Times when system

outages cost users money. When customer support was inadequate. When communication was unclear or misleading. When we made decisions that benefited Binance at users' expense. Each of these failures was noted, criticized, remembered. The slogan amplified the backlash.

This is as it should be. If you claim a principle, you should be held accountable to it. The discomfort of failing publicly, of being called out for hypocrisy, is a necessary part of the process. It creates pressure to improve, to align actions with words, to close the gap between aspiration and reality. I am grateful for the users who hold us to our stated values, even when their criticism is painful.

The evolution from “growth priority” to “long-term trust priority” was gradual. In the early days, we focused on growth above all else. More users, more volume, more market share. This was not wrong—growth was essential to survival, to building the network effects that make exchanges valuable. But growth without trust is fragile. Users who come for promotions leave when promotions end. Users who stay because they trust you become the foundation of sustainable business.

I began to understand this more deeply after the 2017 bull market ended. When prices were rising, growth was easy. Users came regardless of service quality, drawn by the promise of profits. When prices fell, the difference between exchanges that had built trust and those that had merely captured attention became clear. We survived the bear market in part because we had users who believed in us, who stayed even when trading was unprofitable, who became advocates for the platform.

Trust is built slowly and lost quickly. A single security breach can undo years of careful work. A single misleading communication can destroy credibility that took months to establish. I have seen this happen to other exchanges. I have seen it almost happen to us. The vigilance required to maintain trust is exhausting. It is also essential.

“Users First” has shaped specific decisions over the years. When we discovered security vulnerabilities, we disclosed them promptly rather than trying to hide them. When we made mistakes that affected users, we compensated them even when not legally required to do so. When

we designed new products, we prioritized user protection over revenue optimization. These were not always the decisions that maximized short-term profit. They were the decisions that aligned with our stated values.

The slogan has also created tensions. “Users First” does not mean “users always right.” Some users abuse the platform—attempt fraud, manipulate markets, harass other users. Protecting the majority sometimes requires actions against individuals. These decisions are difficult. They require judgment, balance, a willingness to accept that perfect solutions do not exist.

There have been times when I questioned whether “Users First” was the right framing. Perhaps “Users and Binance Together” would be more accurate, acknowledging that our interests are aligned but not identical. Perhaps “Sustainable Value Creation” would better capture what we are trying to achieve. But I have kept the original phrase, partly because changing it would look like retreat, partly because the simplicity has power. Two words. Easy to remember. Easy to judge.

The principle has personal meaning for me. I have been a user of financial services my entire adult life. I know what it feels like to be treated as a number, to have problems ignored, to be charged fees that seem arbitrary and unfair. I built Binance partly because I wanted an exchange that treated users the way I wanted to be treated. The “Users First” slogan is a promise to my past self, to the young man who was frustrated by the banks and brokerages he had to use.

I do not want to present this as more noble than it is. “Users First” is also good business. Users who trust you stay longer, trade more, recommend you to friends. The principle aligns self-interest with ethical behavior, which makes it sustainable. If putting users first consistently harmed profitability, the slogan would be empty within months. The fact that it does not harm profitability—indeed, that it enhances long-term value—is what makes it genuine rather than performative.

The challenge is maintaining this alignment as the organization grows. When Binance had ten employees, “Users First” was intuitive. Everyone knew users personally, understood their needs, felt their pain. With

thousands of employees, the connection becomes abstract. Users become statistics, segments, metrics on a dashboard. Keeping the principle alive requires constant effort—stories of individual users, direct exposure to customer feedback, reminders that behind every ticket number is a real person with real concerns.

I have tried to model this personally. I read user complaints on social media. I respond to direct messages when I can. I make decisions based on what I believe users would want, even when those decisions are unpopular internally. This is not altruism. It is the only way I know to keep the principle real, to prevent it from becoming just another corporate slogan that employees recite without believing.

“Users First” has become a constraint in another sense: it limits what we can do. There are business models we have rejected because they would violate user trust. Partnerships we have declined because the counterparty’s values did not align with ours. Growth opportunities we have passed because the cost to user experience would be too high. These constraints sometimes frustrate colleagues who see competitors taking the paths we have rejected. I understand their frustration. But I believe the constraints are what make Binance what it is. Remove them, and we become just another exchange.

The slogan will outlast me. Long after I have stepped back from day-to-day involvement, “Users First” will remain part of Binance’s culture, for better or worse. Future leaders will interpret it differently, apply it in ways I cannot predict. This is as it should be. Principles must evolve to remain relevant. What matters is that the core commitment—to build trust through consistent, user-centered action—endures.

A Company Without Headquarters: Remote, Travel, and Boundaries

“Exchange the World.” It began as a marketing slogan, something catchy for a billboard or a conference banner. But like many phrases that stick, it took on weight over time. People repeated it. Employees used it to describe what we were building. Users adopted it as a kind of shorthand for Binance’s ambition. And eventually, I found myself interrogating it seriously, asking what it actually meant.

When you say “Exchange the World,” what are you exchanging? Currencies, obviously—dollars for Bitcoin, euros for Ethereum, one token for another. That is the surface meaning, the literal function of an exchange. But the phrase suggests something larger. It implies transformation, a changing of the world through the act of exchange itself. This is where it becomes interesting, and where it becomes complicated.

The official mission of Binance is “to increase the freedom of money.” This is more precise than “Exchange the World,” more grounded in a specific value. Freedom of money means that people should be able to access, move, and use their wealth without arbitrary restrictions. It means that financial services should be available to anyone with an internet connection, not just to those who live in the right countries or have the right documentation. It means that individuals should control their own funds, not be dependent on

institutions that can freeze accounts or block transactions.

These ideas are not new. They have been part of the cryptocurrency movement since Bitcoin's whitepaper. What Binance contributed was infrastructure—practical tools that made these ideals accessible to ordinary people. You can believe in financial freedom abstractly, but to actually achieve it, you need exchanges where currencies can be traded, wallets where funds can be stored, payment systems where crypto can be spent. We built these things. We are still building them.

But I want to be honest about the limitations. "Exchange the World" sounds grand, transformative, revolutionary. The reality is more mundane. We operate a trading platform. People come to speculate, to invest, to hedge risk. Most are not thinking about financial freedom or the future of money. They are thinking about returns, about timing the market, about making profits. This is not wrong. It is human. But it does not match the rhetoric.

I have struggled with this tension. On one hand, I genuinely believe that cryptocurrency has the potential to increase human freedom, to reduce the power of gatekeepers, to create a more open financial system. On the other hand, I am aware that most of what happens on Binance is trading, much of it speculative, some of it harmful. We facilitate price discovery and liquidity, which have value. We also facilitate gambling, which does not.

When I say "Exchange the World," I am making a claim about what is possible, not just about what is. The world as it exists has barriers—borders, regulations, institutions that control access to financial services. The world as it could exist, the world we are trying to build, has fewer of these barriers. People can participate in the global economy regardless of where they were born or what passport they hold. They can store value in assets that cannot be seized by failing governments. They can transact directly with each other, without intermediaries taking cuts or collecting data.

This vision is not inevitable. It requires work—technical work to build better systems, regulatory work to create clear frameworks, educational work to help people understand what is possible and what is risky. It also requires honesty about the challenges. Cryptocurrency is not a magic solution to financial exclusion. It creates new risks—volatility, fraud,

technical complexity—that can harm the very people it claims to help.

“Exchange the World” also carries a double meaning that I have come to appreciate. To exchange is to trade, yes. But to exchange is also to transform, to replace one thing with another. When we say we want to exchange the world, we are saying we want to change it, to replace old systems with new ones, to transform how value flows through human societies. This is ambitious to the point of arrogance. I accept that. But ambition is necessary if you want to achieve anything significant.

The transformation we are working toward is not violent or sudden. It is gradual, incremental, happening through millions of individual decisions. A person in Nigeria uses Bitcoin to receive remittances because it is faster and cheaper than Western Union. A developer in Vietnam builds a DeFi protocol that provides lending services without banks. A student in Argentina saves in stablecoins to protect against inflation. Each of these actions, small in itself, contributes to a larger shift.

I am sometimes asked whether I still believe in this mission, given everything that has happened—the regulatory challenges, the market crashes, the scams and failures that have plagued the industry. The answer is yes, but with more nuance than I had in the early days. I believe in the potential of cryptocurrency to increase freedom. I also believe that realizing this potential requires more than technology. It requires institutions that people can trust, regulations that protect without stifling, education that helps people navigate complexity.

Binance has a role to play in this, but it is not the only role. We are one company among many, one part of a larger ecosystem. Our job is to provide reliable infrastructure, to operate with integrity, to continue building toward the vision that motivated us from the beginning. We will make mistakes. We have made mistakes. The measure of our success is not whether we are perfect but whether we learn, improve, and keep moving in the right direction.

“Exchange the World” is ultimately a statement of optimism. It says that change is possible, that the current arrangement of financial power is not permanent, that individuals can have more control over their economic lives

than they do today. This optimism is not naive. It is aware of obstacles, of setbacks, of the long history of failed attempts to create alternative financial systems. But it persists because the alternative—accepting the status quo as unchangeable—is worse.

I think often about the young man I was in 2013, selling his apartment to buy Bitcoin, convinced that something important was happening but not knowing exactly what. That conviction has carried me through many difficulties. It has also evolved. I am less certain about specific outcomes than I was then. I am more aware of complexity, of trade-offs, of the ways that good intentions can lead to bad results. But the core belief remains: that technology can expand human freedom, that financial systems can be more open and equitable, that the world can be exchanged for something better.

When I look at what Binance has built—the millions of users, the billions in daily trading volume, the ecosystem of products and services—I see both achievement and unfinished work. We have created something significant. We have also fallen short of the vision in many ways. The gap between what is and what could be is where the work remains. It is where I focus my energy, where the team focuses theirs, where the next chapter of this story will be written.

“Exchange the World” is not a destination. It is a direction. It points toward a future where financial freedom is more widely distributed, where access to economic opportunity is less dependent on geography or status, where individuals have more control over their own wealth. Whether we reach that future depends on many factors beyond our control. But the direction matters. It shapes our decisions, our priorities, our sense of what we are trying to accomplish.

I am grateful to everyone who has joined us on this journey—the team members who built Binance, the users who trusted us with their business, the partners who worked with us to expand access. The slogan may be ours, but the vision belongs to everyone who believes that a more open financial system is possible. Together, we are exchanging the world. Not all at once, not perfectly, but persistently, day by day, trade by trade, block by block.

The Compliance Hurdle: From Unimportant to Essential

People often ask me where Binance is headquartered. The honest answer is: we don't have one. Not in the traditional sense. No gleaming skyscraper with our logo on top, no corporate campus with manicured lawns, no reception desk where visitors sign in. This wasn't a marketing gimmick or a regulatory dodge—it was simply how we grew.

When we launched Binance in July 2017, we were a team of fifty people scattered across multiple time zones. Most of us had worked together at Blockchain.info or OKCoin, and we were already accustomed to distributed work. The crypto industry never slept; why should we? Our users were everywhere—Tokyo, São Paulo, Lagos, Berlin—so our team needed to be everywhere too.

I remember the early days clearly. I was in Shanghai, then Tokyo, then Malta. Our CTO was in a different city every month. Our customer support team worked from coffee shops in Eastern Europe, from apartments in Southeast Asia, from co-working spaces in Latin America. We communicated through Slack and Telegram, held meetings across time zones at odd hours, and somehow made it work. The blockchain itself has no headquarters, I would tell reporters. Why should a blockchain company?

According to public data compiled from professional networking plat-

forms, Binance employees eventually came from 69 different countries and regions. Singapore hosted the largest concentration with 176 people, followed by the UK with 78 and the UAE with 75. By city, Dubai led with 65 employees, then London with 64. We were, by some measures, the largest remote-first organization in the world—larger even than GitLab, which had long claimed that title with just over 2,000 employees.

But being distributed wasn't just about geography. It was about mindset. We hired people who could work autonomously, who didn't need to be micromanaged, who understood that in crypto, speed mattered more than process. If a server went down at 3 AM, someone was awake somewhere to fix it. If a regulatory announcement dropped on a Sunday, our policy team was already analyzing it. The sun never set on Binance because the sun never set on our users.

This approach had advantages. We could hire the best talent regardless of location. We weren't constrained by visa policies or local labor markets. We could scale quickly without leasing office space or furnishing cubicles. When the market surged in late 2017, we added hundreds of employees in weeks, not months. No HR department in a traditional company could move that fast.

The cost savings were substantial as well. Without physical offices, we avoided rent, utilities, maintenance, security, and all the other expenses that come with real estate. We could redirect those resources toward engineering, toward customer support, toward the things that actually mattered to our users. Our burn rate was lower than competitors with similar headcount, giving us more runway to weather market downturns.

But I need to be honest about the downsides too. Looking back, I can see how our distributed structure created problems we didn't fully appreciate at the time.

Regulators, understandably, found us confusing. When the Financial Conduct Authority or the Japan Financial Services Agency wanted to speak with "Binance," who should they call? Which entity represented us? Where were our records kept? Our answer—that we were a decentralized organization without a traditional headquarters—sounded evasive even when it was true.

I understand now why it frustrated officials who were accustomed to dealing with companies that fit neatly into regulatory frameworks.

There was also the question of culture. Remote work can foster independence, but it can also erode cohesion. When you rarely see your colleagues in person, when you don't share meals or coffee breaks, when your only interactions are transactional—discussing a bug fix, reviewing a deployment—something intangible gets lost. I spent years traveling constantly, meeting teams in different cities, trying to maintain a sense of unity. But I was always the visitor, the outsider dropping in for a day or two before flying somewhere else.

The personal cost was significant as well. I was living out of suitcases, spending more time in airports than in any single home. My family saw me sporadically. My sleep schedule was dictated by time zones I wasn't in. The romantic image of the digital nomad—working from beaches and cafes around the world—didn't match the reality of constant jet lag, missed connections, and the isolation of always being somewhere new.

I used to rationalize our wandering as a feature, not a bug. We were following the money, I would say. Crypto was global, so we needed to be global. If one jurisdiction became unfriendly, we could move. If another opened its doors, we could expand. This flexibility was genuine, and it served us well in the early years when regulatory frameworks were still forming.

But here's what I eventually had to admit: wandering doesn't solve compliance. Being distributed doesn't exempt you from rules. Having no headquarters doesn't mean you have no responsibilities.

The reality is that every country has its own laws, its own expectations, its own definitions of what constitutes a financial service provider. You can't simply opt out of these frameworks by declaring yourself "stateless." Users in the UK are protected by UK law. Users in Japan are protected by Japanese law. Pretending otherwise doesn't make the obligations disappear—it just makes them harder to meet.

In 2020, when the COVID-19 pandemic forced most companies to adopt remote work, we published blog posts explaining that this had been our reality "for most of our journey." We shared tips, offered advice, positioned

ourselves as veterans of distributed work. And in some ways, we were. But the pandemic also highlighted something important: even remote companies need structure. They need clear reporting lines, documented processes, compliance frameworks that function regardless of where employees are located.

We began building that structure, slowly at first, then with more urgency as regulatory pressure mounted. We appointed regional heads. We established legal entities in jurisdictions where we operated. We hired compliance officers, risk managers, people whose entire job was to ensure we were following rules I had once dismissed as bureaucratic obstacles.

The truth is that “decentralized” and “unregulated” are not synonyms. You can have a distributed team and still be accountable. You can have no headquarters and still have standards. The blockchain may be borderless, but the people who use it live in countries with governments, and those governments have legitimate interests in protecting their citizens.

I don’t regret building Binance as a remote-first company. The flexibility it gave us in our early years was invaluable. The talent we could access was world-class. The resilience we built—no single point of failure, no office that could be raided, no server room that could be unplugged—proved its worth multiple times.

But I do wish I had understood sooner that structure and freedom are not opposites. That compliance is not the enemy of innovation. That having a headquarters—a place where regulators can find you, where users can reach you, where responsibility ultimately resides—is not a betrayal of crypto’s decentralized ideals. It’s a recognition that ideals must be grounded in reality to survive.

Today, Binance has put down deeper roots in cities where we’ve won regulatory approval. Dubai has become a regional hub. Paris has become another. We still have employees working remotely from 86 cities around the world, but we also have offices now, actual physical spaces where people gather and collaborate. The company has evolved, as companies must.

I still believe in the vision that drove us in those early days: that blockchain technology can increase the freedom of money for people everywhere. But

FREEDOM OF MONEY

I've learned that freedom requires foundations. And sometimes, those foundations look a lot like the structures we once thought we were disrupting.

The Compliance Hurdle: From Unimportant to Essential

On January 3, 2023, I posted a tweet that would become something of a mantra for the year ahead. I wrote that I would focus on four things: education, compliance, products and services, and ignoring FUD. The fourth point—“ignore FUD, fake news, attacks, etc.”—got the most attention at the time. Crypto Twitter latched onto it, turning “4” into a meme that would follow me for months. But looking back, the second point was the one that mattered most: compliance.

I need to be direct about this: for much of Binance’s early history, I didn’t take compliance seriously enough. Not because I wanted to break laws or harm users, but because I genuinely misunderstood its importance. I saw compliance as decoration—something companies added after they built their products, like paint on a house. I thought the technology was what mattered. If we built something useful, something that worked, the regulatory details would sort themselves out.

This was wrong. Not slightly wrong, not arguably wrong—fundamentally, dangerously wrong.

The crypto industry emerged from a cypherpunk tradition that viewed regulation with suspicion. Many of us came from backgrounds where we’d seen financial systems fail ordinary people, where we’d watched banks get

bailed out while homeowners lost everything. There was a natural inclination to see regulators as obstacles, as representatives of a broken system we were trying to improve upon. I shared this inclination. I believed, sincerely, that blockchain technology could create a more transparent, more equitable financial system, and that regulation would only slow this progress.

But here's what I failed to appreciate: regulation exists for reasons. Yes, some rules are outdated, poorly designed, or captured by special interests. But the core principles—knowing who you're doing business with, monitoring for suspicious activity, maintaining records, protecting customer funds—these aren't arbitrary constraints. They're the foundations of trust. And without trust, no financial system can function.

The turning point came gradually, then suddenly. In 2023, the regulatory pressure that had been building for years reached a breaking point. The Commodity Futures Trading Commission filed suit against Binance in March, alleging "willful evasion of U.S. law." The Securities and Exchange Commission followed in June with sweeping accusations of operating unregistered exchanges and creating "an extensive web of deception." Then, in November, came the settlement that would reshape everything: \$4.3 billion in penalties and forfeitures to the Department of Justice, FinCEN, and OFAC.

According to the DOJ's court filings, Binance had failed to report over 100,000 suspicious transactions tied to designated terrorist organizations. We had not filed a single Suspicious Activity Report with FinCEN. We had willfully failed to establish an effective anti-money laundering program. Treasury Secretary Janet Yellen stated publicly that Binance had chosen to "prioritize growth over compliance with U.S. legal requirements."

Reading those words stung. Not because they were unfair—they weren't—but because they were true. We had prioritized growth. We had moved fast and broken things, and some of those things should never have been broken.

The settlement required us to make sweeping changes. An independent monitor would review our compliance for three years. We had to strengthen customer due diligence, implement automated transaction monitoring, and fundamentally restructure how we approached regulatory obligations. I had

to step down as CEO. These were painful consequences, but they were also necessary.

What I learned through this process was that compliance isn't a cost center or a bureaucratic burden. It's the foundation upon which sustainable businesses are built. When you skip it, when you treat it as optional decoration, you might grow faster in the short term. But you're building on sand. Eventually, the foundation cracks, and everything above it comes crashing down.

The AML deficiencies identified in the settlement weren't abstract violations. They represented real failures to detect and prevent harmful activity. Every transaction we should have flagged but didn't, every suspicious pattern we missed, every report we failed to file—these had consequences in the real world. Money moved that shouldn't have moved. People were harmed who shouldn't have been harmed. I can't undo those failures, but I can acknowledge them and work to ensure they don't happen again.

Since the settlement, Binance has transformed its approach to compliance. We've hired hundreds of compliance professionals. We've invested in sophisticated monitoring systems. We've built relationships with regulators in dozens of jurisdictions, seeking licenses and registrations rather than avoiding them. The company that emerges from this process will be stronger, more resilient, and more trustworthy than the one that entered it.

But I want to be clear about something: this transformation didn't happen because we were forced into it. The settlement accelerated it, certainly. The external monitor ensures we follow through. But the recognition that compliance matters—that it matters fundamentally—came from within. It came from looking at what we'd built and asking whether it could last. Whether it deserved to last.

The crypto industry is maturing. The wild west phase is ending. This is painful for some, who cherished the freedom of operating without rules. But it's necessary for the industry to achieve its potential. Mainstream adoption requires mainstream trust. And mainstream trust requires demonstrating that you can meet mainstream standards.

I still believe in the transformative potential of blockchain technology.

I still believe that decentralized systems can create more equitable access to financial services. But I've learned that these goals aren't achieved by ignoring regulation—they're achieved by engaging with it, by helping to shape it, by demonstrating that innovation and compliance can coexist.

The tweet I posted in January 2023 wasn't just a list of priorities. It was a recognition that something needed to change. The fourth point about ignoring FUD became a meme because it was easy to understand and fun to repeat. But the second point about compliance was where the real work lay. It's where the real work still lies.

If you're building something in crypto today, learn from my mistakes. Don't treat compliance as an afterthought. Don't assume that good technology excuses bad processes. Don't wait for a crisis to force you into doing what you should have been doing all along. Build compliance into your foundation. Make it part of your culture, not just your legal department.

The companies that survive and thrive in the next phase of this industry will be the ones that figured this out. The ones that understood that freedom without responsibility isn't freedom at all—it's just recklessness with better marketing.

I think often about the engineers and product managers who joined Binance in those early years. They were drawn by the mission, by the technology, by the chance to build something that mattered. Most of them weren't thinking about AML regulations or suspicious activity reports. They were thinking about how to make the product better, how to serve users, how to move fast. I was the same way. We were all products of a culture that celebrated disruption and viewed compliance as someone else's problem.

Changing that culture has been the hardest part of this transformation. It's not enough to hire compliance officers or implement new systems. You have to change how people think about their work, about their responsibilities, about the relationship between what they build and the world it operates in. That takes time. It takes consistent messaging from leadership. It takes real consequences when people get it wrong, and real recognition when they get it right.

We're making progress. I see it in the questions engineers now ask before

shipping features. I see it in the way product managers think about regulatory implications. I see it in the pride compliance professionals take in their work, no longer seen as obstacles but as partners in building something sustainable. The culture is changing, slowly but surely.

The lesson I hope others take from our experience is that compliance isn't the enemy of innovation—it's the foundation that makes innovation possible. When users trust that their funds are protected, that the platform follows rules, that someone is watching for bad actors—they're more willing to engage. They're more willing to try new products, to deposit larger amounts, to recommend the platform to friends. Compliance builds the trust that enables growth.

We learned this lesson the hard way. I hope others can learn it more easily.

SAFU: I'm Willing to Pay for Security

In July 2018, we created something that would become as much a part of crypto culture as HODL and moon. We called it SAFU—the Secure Asset Fund for Users. The name came from a meme, as so many things in crypto do. During an unplanned maintenance in early 2018, I had tweeted to users that their “funds are safe.” A YouTuber named Bizonacci created a video titled “Funds Are Safu,” and the phrase went viral. By July, when we announced our emergency insurance fund, SAFU had already entered the crypto lexicon.

But the fund itself was no joke. We committed to allocating 10% of all trading fees to SAFU, storing the assets in a separate cold wallet, building a reserve that could protect users in case of extreme circumstances. At the time, this was unusual. Most exchanges didn't have insurance funds. Some didn't even have proof-of-reserves. The industry operated on trust—users trusted exchanges to safeguard their funds, and exchanges trusted themselves not to lose them.

I understood the fragility of this arrangement better than most. Before founding Binance, I'd been in crypto long enough to see multiple exchanges fail. Mt. Gox was the most famous, losing 850,000 bitcoins in 2014, but there were others—Bitstamp, Bitfinex, countless smaller platforms that disappeared with user funds. Each failure eroded trust in the entire ecosystem. Each made it harder for ordinary people to believe that crypto was safe.

SAFU was our attempt to address this problem directly. Not with marketing slogans about being “secure” or “trusted,” but with actual reserves that could be deployed if something went wrong. The fund was designed to be transparent—users could verify its existence on the blockchain. It was designed to be substantial—10% of fees sounds small until you realize how much volume a major exchange processes. And it was designed to be accessible—if users lost funds due to a platform issue, not their own mistakes, SAFU would cover the loss.

There's a paradox in building security systems: the more you understand about how fragile systems are, the more you want to build safeguards. Every security engineer I've known has been slightly paranoid. They see attack vectors everywhere because they've spent their careers thinking about how things break. I became that way about exchange security. The more I learned about our systems, the more I worried about what we might have missed.

We built multiple layers of protection. Cold wallets stored the majority of user funds, air-gapped from the internet. Hot wallets held only what was needed for daily operations. Multi-signature requirements meant no single person could move funds unilaterally. Regular audits checked that our records matched reality. And SAFU sat at the bottom of this stack, the final backstop if everything else failed.

Some people misunderstood the purpose of SAFU. They thought it meant users could never lose money, that any loss for any reason would be covered. This was never the case. If you sent funds to the wrong address, if you fell for a phishing scam, if you gave your private keys to someone who stole your funds—SAFU wouldn't help you. These were user errors, not platform failures. The fund was designed to cover losses that were our responsibility, not yours.

This distinction matters because it defines the boundary of what an exchange can reasonably promise. We can promise to secure the funds you entrust to us. We can promise to maintain systems that don't lose your assets through our negligence. We can't promise to protect you from every risk in the crypto ecosystem, because that ecosystem extends far beyond any single platform.

Over the years, SAFU grew substantially. By January 2022, the fund was valued at \$1 billion. In April 2024, we converted the entire fund to USDC, a move we framed as a stability measure. Then in January 2026, we announced a different approach: converting the entire fund to Bitcoin over 30 days. The rationale was straightforward—we believe Bitcoin is the core asset of the crypto ecosystem and represents long-term value. We also committed to maintaining the fund at a minimum of \$800 million, adding more Bitcoin if price fluctuations pushed the value below that threshold.

These changes reflect evolving thinking about what SAFU should be. Initially, it was a stablecoin reserve—predictable, conservative, designed to be there when needed. The move to USDC reinforced this approach. But the conversion to Bitcoin represents something different: a belief that the fund should align with the asset class it protects. If we’re building infrastructure for a Bitcoin-based financial system, shouldn’t our insurance fund be denominated in Bitcoin?

Critics pointed out the volatility risk. If Bitcoin dropped significantly, the fund’s dollar value would drop too. This was true, which is why we committed to the \$800 million floor. If the fund fell below that level, we would add more Bitcoin to bring it back to \$1 billion. This creates an interesting dynamic—essentially, we’ve committed to buying Bitcoin if the price drops significantly. Some analysts interpreted this as a form of price support, though that was never the primary intention.

What strikes me now, looking back at SAFU’s evolution, is how it reflects broader changes in the industry. In 2018, the idea of an exchange maintaining a billion-dollar insurance fund was almost unthinkable. Today, users expect it. They expect proof-of-reserves, regular audits, transparent reporting. The standards have risen, and exchanges that don’t meet them struggle to compete.

This is how industries mature. What was exceptional becomes expected. What was innovative becomes baseline. Users become more sophisticated, more demanding, less willing to accept assurances without evidence. This is good. It means the industry is growing up.

But I also worry about something else: the temptation to treat security as

a marketing tool rather than an engineering discipline. I've seen exchanges announce elaborate security measures that seem designed more for press releases than for actual protection. I've seen "insurance funds" that exist on paper but would be inadequate in a real crisis. Security theater, we might call it—performing safety without actually being safe.

SAFU was never meant to be theater. It was meant to be real. When we said we would cover user losses, we meant it. When we said the funds were in a cold wallet, they were. When we published the wallet address, anyone could verify it. This kind of transparency isn't just good ethics—it's good business. Users who trust you stay. Users who don't, leave.

The deeper lesson of SAFU, for me, is about responsibility. When you build a platform that holds billions of dollars of other people's money, you accept an obligation. Not just a legal obligation, though that's real too, but a moral one. These people trusted you with their savings, their investments, their hopes for financial improvement. You owe them your best effort to protect what they've entrusted to you.

Sometimes that protection fails. No system is perfect. Hackers are persistent, mistakes happen, edge cases emerge that no one anticipated. When failures occur, what matters is how you respond. Do you make users whole? Do you learn from what happened? Do you improve your systems so it doesn't happen again?

SAFU exists because I believed—and still believe—that the answer to these questions should be yes. Yes, we'll cover the losses. Yes, we'll investigate what went wrong. Yes, we'll make our systems better. This is what it means to take responsibility. Not just when things are easy, but when they're hard. Not just when the amounts are small, but when they're large enough to hurt.

I'm willing to pay for security. Not just in dollars allocated to SAFU, but in the engineering time spent on safeguards, in the compliance costs of maintaining proper controls, in the opportunity cost of moving more slowly to ensure we move safely. These costs are real. But the cost of not paying them—lost trust, lost users, lost opportunity to build something lasting—is higher.

The meme that gave SAFU its name was funny. The fund itself is serious.

Both reflect something true about crypto culture: we can laugh at ourselves while still taking our responsibilities seriously. We can acknowledge our mistakes while working to prevent them. We can build systems that learn, that improve, that become stronger through adversity.

That's what SAFU represents to me. Not just an insurance fund, but a commitment. A promise that we're in this for the long term, that we understand what's at stake, that we'll do what it takes to earn and keep your trust.

The engineering behind SAFU is relatively simple. Ten percent of trading fees flow into a designated wallet. The funds are held in cold storage, requiring multiple signatures to access. The balance is published regularly, allowing anyone to verify that the fund exists and is properly funded. When an incident occurs that requires deployment, the funds are moved to cover user losses, and the allocation resumes to rebuild the reserve.

But the simplicity is deceptive. The real complexity isn't in the mechanism—it's in the decisions. What constitutes a qualifying loss? How do we verify that users are who they claim to be? How do we prevent fraudulent claims while ensuring legitimate ones are processed quickly? These questions don't have algorithmic answers. They require judgment, policy, human oversight.

We've refined our policies over time, learning from each incident, each edge case, each attempt to game the system. The policies aren't perfect, and they never will be. But they've gotten better, more fair, more robust. Each iteration reflects lessons learned from the previous one.

The existence of SAFU has also influenced how we think about other protections. We implemented proof-of-reserves, allowing users to verify that their assets are backed. We built insurance partnerships for additional coverage. We invested in security infrastructure that makes incidents less likely in the first place. SAFU was the foundation, but it was never the whole structure.

I think about what would have happened if we hadn't created SAFU. The 2019 hack would have been devastating—not just financially, but to user trust. We might have survived, but we would have been permanently dam-

aged. The fund gave us a way to make users whole quickly, to demonstrate that our commitments were real, to turn a potential catastrophe into a demonstration of responsibility.

That's worth far more than the cost of maintaining the fund. It's worth more than the engineering time, the opportunity cost, the complexity of managing a large reserve. It's worth it because trust is the most valuable asset any exchange can have. And SAFU is one of the ways we build and maintain that trust.

2019 Hack Incident: The Night of 7000 BTC

May 7, 2019. The timestamp is burned into my memory: 17:15:24. That's when our systems detected the breach. That's when everything changed.

I was in Singapore when the alerts started coming in. Multiple notifications, escalating severity, the kind of pattern that makes your stomach drop before your brain fully processes what you're seeing. Our security team was already mobilizing, but I knew immediately this was different from the routine incidents we'd handled before. The scale was wrong. The pattern was wrong.

Seven thousand bitcoins. Approximately \$40 million at the time. Taken in a single transaction. The attackers hadn't just found a vulnerability—they'd executed a sophisticated, multi-vector attack that combined phishing, viruses, and social engineering to obtain user API keys, two-factor authentication codes, and potentially other information. They knew our systems well enough to bypass multiple layers of protection.

The hours that followed were a blur of emergency calls, forensic analysis, and difficult decisions. We had to determine the full scope of the breach. We had to secure our remaining systems. We had to decide what to tell users, and when. Every minute we delayed public disclosure increased the risk that attackers might still be active, that more funds might be at risk. But every

minute we rushed increased the risk of getting the facts wrong, of making statements we'd have to retract.

At 20:00 UTC, we published our first announcement. We disclosed what we knew: that hackers had withdrawn 7,000 BTC, that they had obtained a large number of user API keys and 2FA codes, that other information may have been compromised. We also disclosed what we were doing: suspending deposits and withdrawals while we reviewed our security, working with forensic teams to trace the stolen funds, and preparing to use SAFU to cover the losses.

The response was immediate and intense. Media coverage exploded. Social media filled with speculation, accusations, and—perhaps most painfully—expressions of betrayal from users who had trusted us. Some called it the end of Binance. Others saw it as proof that centralized exchanges were fundamentally flawed. A few suggested we should hard fork Bitcoin to recover the funds, a proposal that revealed how little some people understood about how Bitcoin actually works.

What I felt in those hours wasn't anger at the attackers, though that came later. It was shame. Pure, cold shame. We had failed our users. Not through negligence—our security was industry-leading by any objective measure—but through insufficient paranoia. We hadn't imagined an attack this sophisticated. We hadn't prepared for adversaries this determined. We had been good, but good wasn't good enough.

Security isn't a marketing word. It's not something you put on a website to reassure users. It's a math problem at 3 AM, when you're calculating how many funds are at risk, how quickly you can isolate compromised systems, whether your cold wallet reserves are truly air-gapped. It's the difference between sleeping soundly and waking up in a cold sweat, wondering if you missed something.

We made the decision to cover all losses from SAFU within hours of discovering the breach. There was never any real debate about it. The fund existed for exactly this scenario. Users who had lost funds through no fault of their own would be made whole. This wasn't generosity—it was obligation. It was the minimum standard of behavior for any exchange that wanted to

maintain trust.

But covering losses is only the first step. The harder work came after: understanding how the attack happened, identifying every vulnerability the attackers exploited, rebuilding our systems to prevent similar attacks in the future. Our security team worked around the clock for weeks. We brought in external auditors. We reviewed every line of code, every access log, every system that touched user funds.

What we found was sobering. The attackers had been planning this for months. They had conducted extensive reconnaissance, mapping our systems, identifying key personnel, crafting phishing campaigns specifically designed to bypass our defenses. They had obtained access to multiple user accounts with elevated privileges, then used those accounts to gradually escalate their access until they could initiate the withdrawal. The sophistication was beyond anything we had faced before.

This is the reality of running a cryptocurrency exchange: your adversaries are smart, patient, and well-funded. They have nothing but time to find your weaknesses. They can afford to fail dozens of times if they succeed once. You, on the other hand, must succeed every time. One failure is all it takes.

In the weeks after the hack, I thought constantly about what we could have done differently. Should we have required more verification for large withdrawals? Yes, and we implemented that. Should we have had more granular access controls for administrative functions? Yes, and we rebuilt those. Should we have detected the reconnaissance activity earlier? Probably, and we invested heavily in improved monitoring.

But I also thought about what we did right. Our cold wallet architecture had worked—the attackers never touched the vast majority of user funds. Our incident response had been rapid and effective—we contained the breach within hours. Our decision to use SAFU had demonstrated our commitment to users. These things mattered. They didn't make the failure acceptable, but they showed that our foundation was solid even if our execution had gaps.

The crypto industry has a short memory for failures. Within months, other exchanges had suffered their own breaches, diverting attention from our

incident. Within a year, our trading volumes had recovered and then grown. Users who had sworn never to use Binance again quietly returned, drawn by liquidity, by features, by the simple reality that all exchanges carried similar risks.

But I didn't forget. I still haven't. Every security improvement we've made since 2019 traces back to that night. Every additional safeguard, every enhanced monitoring system, every policy change—they all carry the memory of 7,000 lost bitcoins. The shame I felt then still motivates me now.

Some people in crypto treat security breaches as inevitable, as the cost of doing business in a wild west industry. I reject this framing. Breaches are not inevitable. They are the result of specific failures—of imagination, of execution, of commitment. They can be prevented, or at least made so difficult that attackers move on to easier targets. This requires resources, yes. It requires expertise. It requires a culture where security is valued above speed, above features, above growth.

Building that culture at Binance took time. It required hiring people who thought differently than I did—people who saw risks I missed, who asked questions I hadn't considered, who weren't afraid to tell me that something wasn't ready to ship. It required accepting that security would sometimes slow us down, that perfect security was impossible but good security was mandatory, that the cost of getting it wrong was measured not just in dollars but in trust.

The 2019 hack taught me that security is not a destination but a journey. You don't achieve it and then move on. You maintain it, you improve it, you adapt it as threats evolve. The attackers who came for us in 2019 were sophisticated, but the attackers who might come tomorrow will be more sophisticated still. They will have learned from what happened. So must we.

I don't talk about this incident often. Not because I'm trying to hide it—the facts are public, well-documented, analyzed by security researchers and journalists. But because talking about it brings back the feelings: the shame, the fear, the crushing sense of responsibility for other people's losses. These feelings don't serve me well in day-to-day operations. They're too intense,

too distracting.

But they're also valuable. They remind me what's at stake. Every time I start to think that we've solved security, that our systems are robust enough, that we can relax our vigilance—I remember May 7, 2019. I remember 17:15:24. And I know that we can never relax. Not completely. Not ever.

The attackers took 7,000 bitcoins. They couldn't take our commitment to doing better. They couldn't take the lessons we learned. They couldn't take the resolve we built in the aftermath. These things remain. These things are what security really means.

Looking back at the incident with the perspective of several years, I can see patterns that weren't obvious in the moment. The attack wasn't just a technical failure—it was an organizational one. Our systems had been designed with the assumption that individual security measures would be sufficient. What we learned is that determined adversaries don't attack single points—they attack the gaps between systems, the handoffs between teams, the assumptions that everyone makes but no one questions.

The phishing campaign that preceded the attack was sophisticated. The emails looked authentic, the websites were convincing, the social engineering was subtle. Even experienced employees might have fallen for it. This taught us that user education, while important, isn't enough. You need technical controls that don't depend on users making perfect decisions every time. You need defense in depth, multiple layers that each provide protection even if others fail.

The response to the hack also taught us about communication. In a crisis, transparency is essential but difficult. You want to tell users everything you know, but you don't want to share information that could help attackers. You want to be fast, but you don't want to be wrong. Finding the right balance requires preparation, protocols, practice. We had some of these in place. We needed more.

We now run regular incident response drills, simulating various attack scenarios and practicing our response. We have communication templates prepared for different types of incidents. We have relationships with external security firms who can provide immediate support when needed. These

preparations feel excessive until you need them. Then they feel inadequate.

The financial cost of the hack was significant—\$40 million covered by SAFU, plus millions more in security improvements, forensic investigations, and operational disruption. But the reputational cost was harder to measure. Some users left and never returned. Some potential users chose competitors instead. The trust we had built over two years was damaged in a single evening.

Rebuilding that trust took longer than rebuilding our systems. Every security announcement, every audit report, every transparent disclosure about our protections—it all contributed to slowly restoring confidence. But the process was gradual, and some damage was permanent. There are users who will never trust us again, and I understand why.

What I hope they understand, though, is that we took the lesson seriously. The 2019 hack wasn't a footnote in our history—it was a turning point. It changed how we thought about security, how we organized our teams, how we made decisions about what to build and how to build it. The Binance that emerged from that incident was different from the one that entered it. I believe it was better.

The attackers were never caught. The stolen funds were traced through various wallets and mixers, but eventually the trail went cold. This is common in cryptocurrency hacks—the pseudonymity that protects legitimate users also protects criminals. We reported the incident to law enforcement, cooperated with investigations, but ultimately had to accept that recovery was unlikely.

This too was a lesson. In traditional finance, stolen funds can sometimes be recovered through chargebacks, court orders, or law enforcement action. In crypto, once funds leave your control, they're gone. This makes prevention even more critical. You don't get second chances.

The 7,000 bitcoins lost in 2019 would be worth hundreds of millions of dollars today. The attackers, if they held onto them, made a fortune. This is one of the perverse incentives in crypto security—the people who breach exchanges are often rewarded enormously for their crimes. This makes the security challenge even harder. You're not just defending against bored

hackers looking for a challenge. You're defending against sophisticated criminals motivated by potentially life-changing money.

I think about this every day. Every decision about security architecture, every investment in monitoring systems, every policy about access controls—it all happens in the shadow of that knowledge. We're defending against the smartest, most motivated adversaries in the world. We have to be better than them, not just once, but every day, indefinitely.

It's exhausting. It's expensive. It's necessary.

Binance Chain and DEX: Breaking the Exchange into Blocks

In April 2019, we did something that many people thought was crazy. We launched our own blockchain—Binance Chain—and with it, a decentralized exchange that would compete directly with our main platform. Why would the largest centralized exchange in the world build a decentralized competitor? The answer is simple: because we believed it was the future, and we wanted to be part of building it.

The crypto industry has always had a tension between centralization and decentralization. Centralized exchanges offered speed, liquidity, and user-friendly interfaces. Decentralized exchanges offered self-custody, censorship resistance, and alignment with crypto's core values. Most exchanges picked a side. We decided to build both.

Binance Chain was designed for one primary purpose at launch: to support Binance DEX. This was different from general-purpose blockchains like Ethereum. We weren't trying to build a platform for every possible application. We were building a specialized chain optimized for trading—fast settlement, low fees, simple token issuance. The trade-offs were deliberate. We sacrificed some flexibility for performance, some generality for speed.

The mainnet launched on April 18, 2019. Validators began producing blocks from the genesis block, with BNB planned to be issued in that first block.

Five days later, on April 23, we completed the mainnet swap. Users who held ERC-20 BNB tokens on Ethereum could convert them to native BEP-2 tokens on Binance Chain. The process was straightforward: deposit your ERC-20 tokens to Binance, withdraw BEP-2 tokens to your Binance Chain address. We committed to burning the corresponding ERC-20 tokens to maintain a constant total supply.

Alongside the chain launch, we opened access to Binance DEX. The interface would feel familiar to anyone who had used our centralized platform—order books, price charts, trading history. But underneath, everything was different. Users connected their own wallets. They held their own private keys. The exchange never took custody of their funds. Trades executed through smart contracts on the blockchain, transparent and verifiable by anyone.

This was the self-disruption I had been thinking about since Binance's earliest days. Clayton Christensen's "Innovator's Dilemma" was required reading in tech circles: successful companies often fail because they're too focused on protecting their existing business to embrace disruptive innovations. I didn't want Binance to fall into that trap. If decentralized exchanges were going to replace centralized ones eventually—and I believed they would—we should be the ones building the replacement.

The technical architecture of Binance Chain reflected our priorities. We used Tendermint consensus, which offered fast finality—transactions were confirmed within seconds, not minutes. Block times were one second, compared to Ethereum's roughly fifteen. Fees were low enough that small trades made economic sense. And the validator set was initially limited to eleven nodes, chosen by BNB holders through staking. This was less decentralized than some blockchains, but it enabled the performance we needed for a trading-focused chain.

Some critics called this "centralized decentralization," and they weren't entirely wrong. Binance DEX was more decentralized than our main platform, but less decentralized than fully open systems like Ethereum. We made trade-offs that reflected our beliefs about what users actually wanted: speed and usability over maximum decentralization. Not everyone agreed with these

trade-offs, and that was fine. The beauty of an open ecosystem is that users can choose the approach that aligns with their values.

The DEX interface launched with support from multiple wallets—Trust Wallet (which we had acquired in 2018), Ledger, Enjin, Coinomi, and others. Users could trade directly from their hardware wallets, never exposing their private keys to any internet-connected device. This was security at a level that centralized exchanges simply couldn't match. We could be hacked—our systems had been compromised before—but if users controlled their own keys, their funds were safe regardless of what happened to us.

Launching a DEX while running a successful centralized exchange created interesting internal dynamics. Some team members worried we were cannibalizing our own business. Others questioned whether we were spreading ourselves too thin, diverting resources from our core product to build something that might never achieve significant usage. These were legitimate concerns, and I took them seriously.

My response was always the same: the future belongs to those who build it. If we didn't create a DEX, someone else would. If decentralized trading was going to become mainstream, we wanted to be the ones defining what mainstream decentralized trading looked like. And if it turned out that users preferred centralized exchanges after all—well, we'd still have our main platform. The experiment had asymmetric upside.

The token issuance mechanism on Binance Chain was another deliberate design choice. Anyone could issue tokens on the chain, with a simple process and minimal fees. This lowered the barrier to entry for projects that wanted to create their own cryptocurrencies. Combined with the DEX's listing mechanism—where any token could be traded once enough community support emerged—it created a genuinely permissionless environment for token creation and exchange.

Of course, permissionless doesn't mean consequence-free. We quickly discovered that easy token creation led to easy scam creation. Projects would issue tokens, pump their prices through coordinated buying, then dump on unsuspecting users. This wasn't unique to Binance Chain—it happened on every platform that enabled easy token issuance—but it was

our responsibility to address it. We implemented warnings, educational materials, and eventually more restrictive listing policies for the DEX.

The relationship between Binance Chain and our main platform was always complex. They were separate products with separate user bases, but they shared the BNB token, which now existed in multiple forms: ERC-20 on Ethereum, BEP-2 on Binance Chain, and eventually BEP-20 on Binance Smart Chain. Users could move between these environments, but the process wasn't always seamless. We were asking people to understand concepts—token standards, cross-chain bridges, wallet compatibility—that many found confusing.

This complexity was the cost of our self-disruption strategy. We weren't just building one product; we were building an ecosystem. Ecosystems are messy. They have overlapping components, competing priorities, user experiences that don't always align. But they also have resilience. If one part fails, the others can continue. If one approach proves wrong, you can pivot to another.

Looking back at the 2019 launch, I'm proud of what we built. Binance Chain and DEX weren't perfect—no blockchain is—but they represented a genuine attempt to push the industry forward. We took risks. We made trade-offs. We learned from both our successes and our failures. And we demonstrated that a centralized company could contribute to decentralized infrastructure without hypocrisy.

The DEX never achieved the volume of our main platform. That was always likely—centralized exchanges offer advantages that matter to most users. But it found its audience: users who valued self-custody, who lived in jurisdictions with restrictive financial regulations, who simply preferred the transparency of on-chain trading. For them, Binance DEX provided something important: a bridge between the performance they needed and the principles they believed in.

Building that bridge was worth the effort. It was worth the internal debates, the resource allocation, the complexity of maintaining multiple products. Because at the end of the day, our mission wasn't just to build the biggest exchange. It was to increase the freedom of money. And freedom sometimes

means giving people choices they didn't have before—even if those choices compete with your core business.

The engineering effort required to build Binance Chain and DEX was substantial. We had to develop a new blockchain from scratch, design consensus mechanisms, build wallet integrations, create user interfaces, establish validator relationships, and ensure everything worked together seamlessly. This wasn't a side project—it was a major undertaking that consumed significant engineering resources at a time when our main platform was growing rapidly.

Some competitors questioned our priorities. Why spend so much effort on a DEX that might never compete with our main platform? Why launch a new blockchain when Ethereum already existed? These were fair questions, and I understood why people asked them. But I believed then, and still believe, that building for the future is always worth the investment, even when the payoff is uncertain.

The lessons we learned building Binance Chain and DEX informed our later projects. When we launched Binance Smart Chain in 2020, we applied many of the lessons from the first chain—what worked, what didn't, what users wanted, what they didn't. The DEX experience taught us about the importance of user experience in decentralized applications, about the challenges of key management, about the trade-offs between security and convenience.

These lessons weren't abstract—they were earned through real user feedback, real incidents, real successes and failures. You can't learn them from whitepapers or conference talks. You have to build, launch, iterate, and pay attention to what happens.

The Binance Chain ecosystem continues to evolve. The original chain still operates, supporting DEX trading and token issuance. The broader BNB Chain ecosystem has grown to include Binance Smart Chain, opBNB, and other components. What started as a single-purpose blockchain has become a diverse ecosystem serving millions of users.

This evolution wasn't planned in detail. We had a vision, but the specific path emerged through experimentation, user feedback, and adaptation to

changing market conditions. This is how technology ecosystems develop—not through perfect foresight, but through continuous learning and adjustment.

I'm proud of what the team built in 2019. They took a risk on an unproven concept, executed against a tight timeline, and delivered something that has stood the test of time. Not every project works out this way. Many fail. The fact that Binance Chain and DEX are still operating years later, still serving users, still contributing to the ecosystem—that's a testament to the quality of the work.

The self-disruption strategy isn't right for every company. It requires resources, conviction, and a willingness to cannibalize your own business before someone else does. But for companies operating in rapidly evolving industries, I think it's essential. If you're not willing to disrupt yourself, someone else will disrupt you. Better to be the architect of your own transformation than the victim of someone else's.

Launchpad and IEO: Boom and Responsibility

In early 2019, we launched something that would reshape how crypto projects raised capital. We called it Binance Launchpad, and the model was called IEO—Initial Exchange Offering. The concept was straightforward: instead of projects conducting their own token sales directly to the public, they would work with an exchange that would handle the sale, vet the project, and provide immediate liquidity through a listing.

The first IEO on Launchpad was BitTorrent in January 2019. The sale sold out in less than fifteen minutes—50 billion BTT tokens, gone almost instantly. The success was immediate and dramatic. Other exchanges quickly followed with their own launchpads. The IEO model became the dominant fundraising mechanism in crypto, replacing the ICO boom that had collapsed in 2018 amid scams, regulatory crackdowns, and widespread investor losses.

I watched this unfold with mixed feelings. On one hand, Launchpad was succeeding beyond our expectations. We were helping legitimate projects raise capital, providing users with access to vetted opportunities, and creating a new revenue stream for Binance. The projects that launched through us gained immediate credibility and liquidity. Users who participated in sales often saw significant returns. Everyone seemed to be winning.

On the other hand, I felt a growing unease about the power we were

accumulating. When you control access to capital, when you decide which projects get to raise funds and which don't, you become a gatekeeper. And gatekeepers have responsibilities that go beyond simply maximizing returns.

The original IEO model had a problem: it favored large investors. Whales could buy unlimited amounts of tokens, concentrating allocation in the hands of a few while smaller participants were shut out. This wasn't the inclusive vision we claimed to support. So we changed the rules. In mid-2019, we introduced a lottery system based on BNB holdings.

Here's how it worked: we would take snapshots of users' BNB balances over a period—initially 20 days, later adjusted to 15 or 30 days depending on the sale. Based on their average holdings, users would receive lottery tickets. More BNB meant more tickets, which meant higher chances of winning an allocation. But everyone with at least the minimum BNB holding had a chance, not just the whales.

The lottery system was more fair than unlimited sales, but it wasn't perfect. It still favored users who could afford to hold large BNB balances. It created perverse incentives—users would buy BNB just for the lottery, then sell immediately after, creating volatility. And it tied access to token sales to investment in our own token, raising questions about conflicts of interest.

We iterated on the model repeatedly. We adjusted the snapshot periods. We changed the ticket allocation formulas. We introduced additional requirements—completing KYC, holding BNB for longer periods, participating in educational modules about the projects. Each change was an attempt to address legitimate criticisms while maintaining the core value proposition: giving users fair access to token sales.

But the deeper question kept nagging at me: by what right did we decide who could list? What made us qualified to judge which projects were legitimate and which were scams? We had a team that conducted due diligence, certainly. We reviewed whitepapers, checked team backgrounds, assessed tokenomics. But we weren't infallible. Projects we approved sometimes failed. Sometimes they turned out to be fraudulent despite our review. When that happened, users who trusted our vetting process lost money.

This is the paradox of platform power. Users come to you because you offer curation—you separate the signal from the noise, the legitimate projects from the scams. But the more you curate, the more responsibility you take for the outcomes. If a user buys a token on your platform and loses money, they're not just angry at the project. They're angry at you.

I thought about this constantly as Launchpad grew. We launched dozens of projects through the platform. Some became major successes—Polygon, which would eventually reach a multi-billion dollar valuation, started as a Launchpad project. Others faded into obscurity. A few turned out to be outright failures, their tokens worth essentially nothing. Each outcome taught me something about the limits of what we could promise.

The IEO boom also attracted regulatory attention. Securities regulators in multiple jurisdictions began asking whether these token sales constituted securities offerings. The answer, in many cases, was probably yes. But the regulatory framework was unclear, and different countries took different approaches. Some banned IEOs entirely. Others allowed them with restrictions. Most were still figuring out how to think about them.

We tried to navigate this complexity carefully. We restricted access to users from jurisdictions with clear prohibitions. We worked with legal counsel in multiple countries. We adjusted our processes to address regulatory concerns as they emerged. But I'll be honest: the regulatory landscape was so fragmented and uncertain that perfect compliance was probably impossible. We did our best with the information we had.

What troubled me most was the psychological impact on users. The IEO model created a lottery mentality. Users would buy BNB, hold it for the snapshot period, hope to win lottery tickets, then hope the project they invested in would moon. When it worked—when they won allocations and prices rose—they felt brilliant. When it didn't, they felt cheated. The emotional swings were intense, and they were directly connected to our platform.

I started asking myself harder questions. Were we helping users, or were we exploiting their FOMO? Were we providing genuine investment opportunities, or were we running a sophisticated gambling operation with

better branding? The answers weren't clear-cut. Some users absolutely benefited from early access to promising projects. Others would have been better off simply holding Bitcoin and ignoring the IEO circus entirely.

The power to list is the power to shape the industry. When we decided to support a project, we were making a statement about what we thought crypto should become. The projects we chose—DeFi protocols, infrastructure plays, gaming tokens, social platforms—reflected our vision for the ecosystem's evolution. Other exchanges had different visions, supported different types of projects. Together, these choices shaped what got built.

This is a heavy responsibility. I don't think we always got it right. Sometimes we were too focused on short-term metrics—how quickly a sale would sell out, how much trading volume it would generate. Sometimes we missed projects that turned out to be important because they didn't fit our model. Sometimes we listed projects that, in retrospect, we shouldn't have.

But I also believe we got some things right. We created a more accessible fundraising mechanism than the ICO free-for-all. We gave users tools to participate in project launches that would otherwise have been restricted to venture capitalists. We demonstrated that exchanges could play a constructive role in capital formation, not just trading.

Launchpad continues to operate today, though the model has evolved significantly. The crypto industry has moved on to new fundraising mechanisms—IDOs on decentralized exchanges, NFT drops, community sales through DAOs. Each has its own advantages and problems. The fundamental challenge remains: how do you allocate scarce opportunities fairly while protecting participants from harm?

I don't have a perfect answer. I'm not sure one exists. What I know is that platforms that concentrate power must accept responsibility. If you're going to be a gatekeeper, you need to think carefully about who you're keeping out and why. You need to be transparent about your criteria, accountable for your mistakes, and willing to change when the evidence shows you're wrong.

The IEO boom taught me that success can be as dangerous as failure. When everything is going up, when users are making money, when competitors

are copying your model—it's easy to believe you've figured something out. But the real test comes when things go wrong. When projects fail. When users lose money. When regulators come knocking. That's when you find out whether you built something sustainable or something that only worked in favorable conditions.

I hope we built something closer to the former. But I'll let history be the judge.

The evolution of Launchpad reflects broader changes in the crypto industry. What started as a simple token sale platform has become a more sophisticated ecosystem for project launches. We've added research reports, educational content, and more robust due diligence processes. We've adjusted our criteria based on what we've learned. The platform has matured along with the industry.

But the fundamental tension remains. Exchanges occupy a unique position in the crypto ecosystem. We're gatekeepers, curators, infrastructure providers, and market participants all at once. This concentration of roles creates both opportunities and obligations. The opportunities are obvious—we can build integrated experiences, capture value across the user journey, shape the direction of the industry. The obligations are less visible but no less real.

Every project we list, every token we support, every feature we launch—these are choices with consequences. They affect what gets built, who gets funded, how users interact with crypto. We don't make these choices in a vacuum. We're influenced by market conditions, competitive pressure, regulatory constraints, and our own biases. But we do make them, and we're responsible for them.

This is what I mean when I talk about platform responsibility. It's not just about following rules or avoiding scams. It's about being thoughtful about the power you have and how you use it. It's about recognizing that your decisions shape the ecosystem in ways that affect millions of people. It's about accepting that with great power comes great responsibility—not as a slogan, but as a daily practice.

Launchpad has been a learning experience for me. It taught me about

the complexities of capital formation in a decentralized ecosystem. It taught me about the challenges of due diligence at scale. It taught me about the psychology of retail investors and the risks of creating lottery-like experiences. These lessons have informed how I think about other products, other decisions, other aspects of running a platform.

The IEO model may eventually fade away, replaced by newer mechanisms that better serve the ecosystem's needs. But the lessons from Launchpad will remain relevant. The questions about platform responsibility, about the ethics of gatekeeping, about balancing access with protection—these aren't going away. They're fundamental to what it means to build infrastructure in a decentralized world.

Acquiring CoinMarketCap: Data, Trust, and Neutrality

In April 2020, we announced the acquisition of CoinMarketCap for a reported \$400 million. The deal made headlines throughout the crypto industry and beyond. CoinMarketCap was the most visited cryptocurrency data site in the world, the default destination for anyone checking prices, market caps, or exchange volumes. And now it was owned by Binance, the largest cryptocurrency exchange in the world.

The reaction was immediate and divided. Supporters saw it as a logical combination—Binance’s resources could help CoinMarketCap expand its offerings, while CoinMarketCap’s data expertise could enhance Binance’s products. Critics saw something more concerning: a conflict of interest that threatened the neutrality of crypto’s most trusted data source. How could a site owned by an exchange remain objective about that exchange’s competitors?

I understood both perspectives. The acquisition made strategic sense for us. CoinMarketCap had built something valuable—a brand that represented trust and authority in an industry often lacking both. But the trust concerns were legitimate too. If users believed CoinMarketCap’s data was influenced by its ownership, the site’s value would erode. We had to navigate this carefully.

The fundamental challenge was this: CoinMarketCap's business model depended on being seen as neutral. Exchanges and projects wanted to be listed because the listing carried credibility. Users visited because they believed the data was accurate and unbiased. If that credibility disappeared, so would the visitors. And without visitors, the advertising revenue that sustained the business would dry up.

But neutrality is expensive to maintain. It requires investment in data verification, in systems that can't be easily manipulated, in editorial independence that resists commercial pressure. CoinMarketCap had built these capabilities over years, but they needed reinforcement. The crypto data landscape was becoming more complex, with wash trading, fake volume, and sophisticated manipulation schemes becoming increasingly common.

Our public commitment after the acquisition was clear: CoinMarketCap would operate independently. We promised to maintain the site's editorial independence, to preserve its data methodology, to avoid any interference in how exchanges were ranked or projects were evaluated. Brandon Chez, CoinMarketCap's founder, would remain in a leadership role. The team would continue working from their existing locations.

These weren't just words. We structured the deal to create genuine separation. CoinMarketCap maintained its own offices, its own engineering team, its own product roadmap. I didn't review their editorial decisions. I didn't ask for special treatment for Binance in their rankings. The site continued to list competitors, continued to report data that sometimes showed Binance in a less favorable light than we would have preferred.

But I need to acknowledge something: structural independence isn't the same as perceived independence. No matter how many firewalls we built, users knew that CoinMarketCap was owned by Binance. When CoinMarketCap changed its volume calculation methodology in a way that affected exchange rankings, some users assumed we were behind it. When Binance topped certain rankings, others questioned whether the data was manipulated.

This perception problem was real, and I don't think we ever fully solved it. We could demonstrate that CoinMarketCap's methodology was transparent

and auditable. We could point to instances where the site reported negative information about Binance. We could publish detailed explanations of how rankings were calculated. But for some users, the ownership connection was enough to create doubt.

The data verification challenge was substantial. CoinMarketCap aggregated information from hundreds of exchanges, thousands of trading pairs, millions of transactions. Verifying the accuracy of this data was a massive undertaking. Wash trading—exchanges artificially inflating their reported volumes to appear more liquid than they were—was rampant in the industry. Detecting it required sophisticated analysis, and even then, some manipulation inevitably slipped through.

We invested heavily in improving CoinMarketCap's data quality. We built new systems to detect anomalous trading patterns. We developed confidence scores that indicated how reliable we believed different exchanges' reported volumes were. We added new metrics—liquidity scores, web traffic estimates—that provided alternative ways to assess exchange importance beyond raw volume numbers.

These improvements were genuine, but they also created new controversies. When we adjusted how volumes were calculated, some exchanges saw their rankings drop. They complained, publicly and privately, that the changes were unfair. They accused us of manipulating the data to benefit Binance. We defended our methodology, published our reasoning, but the accusations continued.

This is the paradox of being both a data provider and a market participant. Any decision you make can be interpreted through the lens of self-interest. Adjust your methodology to improve accuracy? You're trying to hurt competitors. Don't adjust it? You're allowing manipulation to continue. There's no neutral ground because your very existence as an exchange-owned data site is seen as a conflict.

I thought about this problem constantly. Should we have acquired CoinMarketCap at all? Would the industry have been better off with an independent data provider, even if that meant less investment in data quality? I don't have a definitive answer. What I know is that data

infrastructure in crypto was underinvested before the acquisition, and CoinMarketCap was able to expand its capabilities significantly with our support. Whether that justified the trust trade-offs is for others to judge.

The acquisition also raised questions about consolidation in the crypto industry. Binance was already the largest exchange. Now we owned the largest data site. We would later acquire other companies—Trust Wallet, CoinMarketCap, and others—expanding our reach across the ecosystem. Some saw this as building a comprehensive platform. Others saw it as creating a monopoly that could stifle competition.

I believed then, and still believe, that vertical integration can create value for users. When you control multiple parts of the user journey, you can create smoother experiences, better integrations, more coherent products. But I also recognize that concentration of power creates risks. When one company controls too much of an ecosystem, it can abuse that control, intentionally or unintentionally.

Our response to these concerns was to emphasize openness. We continued to support industry standards that allowed interoperability. We didn't block competitors from accessing our services. We contributed to open-source projects that benefited the entire ecosystem. Whether this was sufficient to offset the concentration concerns is a matter of perspective.

CoinMarketCap continues to operate today as one of the most visited crypto sites in the world. It provides data, analysis, educational content, and news to millions of users. The team has expanded significantly since the acquisition, adding capabilities that wouldn't have been possible as an independent company. And the site maintains its commitment to neutrality, even when that neutrality produces results that aren't favorable to Binance.

Looking back, I think the acquisition was the right decision, but I also think we underestimated the trust challenges it would create. We focused on what we could control—structural independence, transparent methodology, investment in data quality—and hoped that would be enough. It was enough for many users, but not for all. Some skepticism was healthy, even necessary. But some of it reflected a deeper challenge: in an industry built on trustlessness, trust is paradoxically essential.

The lesson I take from this experience is that ownership creates obligations that go beyond what's written in contracts. When you acquire a trusted brand, you inherit the trust, but you also inherit the responsibility to maintain it. That responsibility can't be discharged through structures and processes alone. It requires consistent behavior over time, demonstrating through actions that the trust is warranted.

We've tried to do that with CoinMarketCap. The site remains independent in its operations, neutral in its data, valuable to its users. Whether we've fully earned the trust that the acquisition placed at risk is a question that only time—and users—can answer.

The data business is harder than it looks. Everyone wants accurate information, but accuracy is expensive to produce. You need to collect data from hundreds of sources, verify it, clean it, present it in ways that users can understand. You need to detect manipulation, filter out noise, identify anomalies. You need to do all of this in real-time, because crypto markets never sleep.

CoinMarketCap had built impressive capabilities in these areas, but they were operating on a relatively small budget. The acquisition gave them resources to expand—invest in better infrastructure, hire more data scientists, develop new products. This was good for the ecosystem. Better data benefits everyone, not just CoinMarketCap users.

But the resources came with strings, even if they were invisible ones. Every decision about what to build, what to prioritize, what metrics to emphasize—these were now being made within a company owned by an exchange. The people making these decisions were committed to independence, and I believe they maintained it. But the structural tension remained.

I think about this tension often. It's not unique to CoinMarketCap or Binance. It exists throughout the crypto industry, wherever companies have multiple roles, multiple products, multiple incentives. The question is how you manage it—how you create systems and cultures that prioritize user trust even when it's not in your immediate commercial interest.

We've tried to do this through transparency. We publish our methodology. We acknowledge our limitations. We respond to criticism, even when it's

uncomfortable. These practices don't eliminate the structural tension, but they help manage it. They give users information they need to make their own judgments about what to trust.

The CoinMarketCap acquisition taught me that trust is fragile and hard to rebuild once lost. We entered the acquisition with the benefit of the doubt from many users. Some of that doubt eroded over time, despite our best efforts. This is the reality of operating in a skeptical industry. You have to earn trust every day, through every decision, every action.

I believe CoinMarketCap is better today than it was before the acquisition. The data is more accurate, the products are more sophisticated, the team is stronger. Whether that improvement was worth the trust costs is a judgment that users will make individually. Some will say yes. Some will say no. Both perspectives are valid.

BSC Mainnet Launch: A Faster Path for Developers

In September 2020, we launched Binance Smart Chain—BSC—a parallel blockchain to Binance Chain that added smart contract functionality and EVM compatibility. The timing was deliberate. DeFi summer was in full swing on Ethereum, but so were its limitations: congested networks, skyrocketing gas fees, transactions that cost more than the value being transferred. Developers and users were desperate for alternatives. We built one.

The technical approach was straightforward. BSC used a Proof of Staked Authority consensus mechanism—21 validators elected by BNB stakers, producing blocks every three seconds. This was faster than Ethereum’s ~15 second block times and far faster than Bitcoin’s ten minutes. More importantly, transactions cost cents rather than dollars. A simple token swap on Ethereum might cost \$50 in gas fees; on BSC, it cost pennies.

Critics immediately pointed out the trade-offs. Twenty-one validators wasn’t very decentralized. The validator set was limited, and the barriers to entry were substantial—becoming a validator required significant BNB holdings and technical expertise. This was a permissioned system masquerading as a public blockchain, some said. We were sacrificing decentralization for performance.

They weren't wrong about the trade-offs. They were wrong about whether those trade-offs were worth making. Here's what I believed then and still believe now: developers need something that runs. Perfection isn't the starting point; functionality is. If your blockchain is perfectly decentralized but too expensive to use, it doesn't matter how pure its architecture is—people won't use it.

Ethereum was struggling with exactly this problem in 2020. Its vision of a world computer was inspiring, but the reality was that simple operations had become prohibitively expensive. Developers who wanted to build applications for ordinary users—not just wealthy speculators—needed alternatives. Some moved to layer-2 solutions. Others looked to different layer-1 chains. And many came to BSC.

The EVM compatibility was crucial. Developers could deploy Ethereum smart contracts on BSC with minimal or no modifications. The tooling was familiar—MetaMask, Remix, Truffle, Hardhat—all worked with BSC. Users could use the same wallets they used for Ethereum. The learning curve was essentially flat. This wasn't an accident; it was deliberate design.

We published the BSC whitepaper in April 2020, five months before mainnet launch. It laid out our thinking clearly: BSC would run parallel to Binance Chain, providing smart contract functionality while the original chain continued to focus on fast trading. The two chains would communicate through a cross-chain mechanism, allowing assets to move between them. BNB would be the native token for both, used for gas fees and staking.

The launch itself was relatively quiet. No massive marketing campaign, no token sale, no hype cycle. We announced it, made the documentation available, and let developers decide whether it met their needs. They decided it did. Within months, BSC had significant DeFi protocols running on it—PancakeSwap, Venus, Autofarm, and dozens of others. Total Value Locked grew rapidly. Transaction volumes surged.

Some of this growth was speculative, driven by yield farming and token incentives. Some of it was users fleeing Ethereum's high fees. Some of it was genuine product-market fit—developers building applications that simply couldn't have existed on more expensive chains. All of it validated our core

thesis: there was demand for a faster, cheaper smart contract platform, even if it made different trade-offs than Ethereum.

The validator economics were designed to be sustainable. Validators earned transaction fees and block rewards, creating incentives to maintain reliable infrastructure. Users who staked BNB with validators earned a share of these rewards, creating demand for the token beyond simple speculation. The system was designed to be self-sustaining, with economic incentives aligned across participants.

Not everything went smoothly. The rapid growth exposed scalability challenges we hadn't anticipated. Some nodes struggled to keep up with the transaction volume. The blockchain size grew quickly, making it harder for ordinary users to run full nodes. We had to optimize, upgrade, and occasionally scramble to address issues that emerged under real-world load.

There were also security incidents. Smart contracts that worked fine in testing failed in production, sometimes with significant user losses. Some of these were bugs in the protocols themselves. Some were exploits by sophisticated attackers who found vulnerabilities the developers missed. Each incident was a learning opportunity, though the lessons sometimes came at high cost.

I watched the ecosystem develop with a mixture of pride and concern. Pride in what developers were building—DEXs, lending protocols, yield aggregators, NFT marketplaces, games, social platforms. Concern about the risks users were taking, often without fully understanding them. The low transaction costs that made experimentation possible also made it cheap to deploy scams. For every legitimate project, there seemed to be ten that were either incompetent or fraudulent.

We tried to address this through education and tooling. Binance Academy published guides on how to evaluate DeFi projects. We built interfaces that made it easier to understand what smart contracts were doing. We added warnings when users interacted with contracts that hadn't been audited. But the fundamental challenge remained: in a permissionless system, you can't prevent people from making bad decisions. You can only try to help them understand the risks.

The pace of innovation was relentless. New concepts emerged weekly: automated market makers, flash loans, governance tokens, liquidity mining, vault strategies, insurance protocols, synthetic assets. Each built on what came before, creating composable primitives that could be combined in novel ways. The composability was beautiful—protocols interacting with protocols, creating emergent behaviors no single team had designed. It was also dangerous—one vulnerability could cascade through multiple interconnected systems.

I spent hours each day reading about new projects, trying to understand what they did, how they worked, what risks they carried. It was impossible to keep up. The space moved faster than any individual could follow. This was exciting—it meant the ecosystem was vibrant, creative, full of energy. It was also exhausting. There was always something new to learn, some new risk to assess, some new opportunity to evaluate.

The question of responsibility became increasingly pressing. When a protocol failed and users lost money, who was responsible? The developers who wrote the code? The auditors who reviewed it? The platforms that listed the token? The users who chose to deposit their funds? In traditional finance, these questions have established answers—regulatory frameworks, legal precedents, insurance systems. In DeFi, they were still being worked out.

Our approach was to be clear about what we were and weren't responsible for. We listed tokens, but we didn't endorse the underlying protocols. We provided information, but we didn't give investment advice. We built tools to help users manage risk, but we couldn't eliminate the risk itself. This clarity was important, but it didn't satisfy everyone. Some users expected us to protect them from all harm, which was simply impossible in a permissionless ecosystem.

The BSC launch in September was partly a response to these challenges. Ethereum's congestion and high fees were driving users away from DeFi just as interest was peaking. By offering a faster, cheaper alternative, we could keep users engaged with the ecosystem, give developers a platform where experimentation was affordable, and contribute to the broader DeFi movement. The timing was deliberate—we wanted to capture the

momentum of DeFi Summer and extend it.

The results exceeded our expectations. Developers who had been priced out of Ethereum flocked to BSC. Users who couldn't afford Ethereum gas fees found they could participate on BSC for pennies. New protocols launched, some copying successful Ethereum projects, others experimenting with novel approaches. The DeFi ecosystem on BSC grew from nothing to billions in TVL in months.

But the rapid growth also created new problems. The low barriers to entry that made BSC accessible also made it cheap to deploy scams. For every legitimate project, there seemed to be multiple fraudulent ones. Users who were new to crypto, attracted by the low fees and high yields, often couldn't distinguish between real protocols and fake ones. The education gap was real, and we struggled to close it.

I thought constantly about the balance between accessibility and safety. Making DeFi easier to use meant more people could participate, which was good. But it also meant more people who didn't understand the risks were exposing themselves to potential losses, which was bad. There was no clean answer to this tension. We had to navigate it case by case, trying to expand access while being honest about the risks.

DeFi Summer ended, as all summers do. The yield farming rewards decreased as token distributions completed. The speculative fever cooled. Some protocols failed, their tokens becoming worthless. Others proved their staying power, continuing to operate and grow. The ecosystem that emerged was more mature than the one that had entered the summer—more diverse, more sophisticated, more aware of both the opportunities and the risks.

What I took from this period was a deeper appreciation for the complexity of building financial infrastructure. DeFi wasn't just about writing smart contracts and deploying them. It was about creating systems that could handle real economic activity, that could scale to meet demand, that could protect users without preventing innovation. These challenges were hard. They would take years, not months, to fully address.

But the potential was real. I saw users from countries with limited banking access earning yields, trading assets, participating in global finance in ways

that simply weren't possible before. I saw developers building applications that challenged traditional financial intermediaries, creating new models for lending, borrowing, trading, insurance. I saw an ecosystem learning, adapting, improving.

DeFi Summer was chaotic, risky, and occasionally painful. It was also one of the most exciting periods in crypto's history. The choices we made during those months—what to build, what to list, what to warn users about—shaped what came after. Some of those choices I stand by. Others I would make differently with hindsight. All of them taught me something about the responsibility that comes with building in this space.

The BSC architecture reflected our engineering philosophy. We prioritized performance and compatibility over theoretical purity. The 21-validator model was criticized by decentralization purists, but it delivered the speed and reliability that users needed. The EVM compatibility meant developers didn't have to learn new tools or rewrite their contracts. These were practical choices made for practical reasons.

Looking back, BSC's launch represented a maturation of Binance's blockchain strategy. We weren't just building an exchange anymore. We were building infrastructure—platforms that other people could build on, ecosystems that could grow beyond our direct control. This was riskier than running an exchange. It was also more impactful.

The chain has evolved significantly since 2020. We've added new features, improved performance, expanded the validator set. The ecosystem has grown to include thousands of projects, millions of users, billions in value. Some of the early protocols failed. Others became major players. The pattern is familiar to anyone who's watched technology platforms develop: experimentation, selection, evolution.

What I learned from BSC's launch is that perfect is the enemy of good in infrastructure development. If you wait until your system is flawless before releasing it, you'll wait forever. If you release something that's good enough and iterate based on real-world feedback, you can create something genuinely valuable. The key is being honest about the trade-offs, clear about the limitations, and committed to continuous improvement.

BSC wasn't perfect at launch. It's not perfect now. But it runs. Developers build on it. Users interact with it. It contributes to the broader crypto ecosystem in ways that matter. For an engineer, that's success.

DeFi Summer: Traffic, Congestion, and Choices

The summer of 2020 changed everything. What started as a few experimental protocols on Ethereum exploded into a movement that would reshape how people thought about finance. We called it DeFi Summer, and it was exhilarating, terrifying, and transformative all at once.

I watched it unfold from the front lines. At Binance, we saw the data before most people understood what was happening. Trading volumes on decentralized exchanges started climbing in June. By July, they were surging. By August, they were exploding. Uniswap, which had processed \$8 million in daily volume in late 2019, was now handling hundreds of millions. Compound's lending protocol had hundreds of millions in total value locked. New projects launched weekly, sometimes daily, each promising some innovation on the basic primitives of decentralized finance.

The yield farming phenomenon was the catalyst. Protocols began distributing their governance tokens to users who provided liquidity or used their services. Suddenly, simply depositing assets into a smart contract could generate returns of 50%, 100%, sometimes even 1000% annualized. These yields were unsustainable—everyone knew that—but they created a flywheel of attention, capital, and experimentation that propelled the entire sector forward.

Our response at Binance was multifaceted. We listed DeFi tokens rapidly, sometimes within days of their launch, giving our users access to projects they were reading about on Twitter. We launched staking products that allowed users to earn yields without directly interacting with complex smart contracts. We built educational content explaining what DeFi was and how it worked. And we accelerated our own DeFi initiatives, including the BSC launch that would happen in September.

But the growth created problems we hadn't fully anticipated. More users meant more transactions. More transactions meant more congestion. Ethereum's network, already strained, ground to a halt during peak periods. Gas fees—the cost of executing transactions on the network—spiked to absurd levels. A simple token swap that might have cost \$5 in June cost \$50 in August and \$100 or more in September. For ordinary users, DeFi became unusable.

This congestion revealed a fundamental tension in crypto's growth. The more successful we were at attracting users, the more we strained the infrastructure those users needed. Each new person who wanted to try DeFi added to the load on already-overloaded systems. The very success of the movement threatened to undermine its accessibility.

We faced choices at every turn. Should we list a new DeFi token immediately, giving users access but potentially exposing them to unaudited contracts? Should we promote yield farming opportunities that offered high returns but carried significant risks? Should we build our own DeFi products, competing with the protocols we were also listing? Each decision had trade-offs, and we didn't always get them right.

The incident reports started coming in. Users who had deposited funds into smart contracts that were subsequently exploited. Users who had fallen for phishing scams impersonating popular protocols. Users who had misunderstood how liquidation worked in lending protocols and lost their collateral. Each incident was a reminder that DeFi's permissionlessness cut both ways—it enabled innovation, but it also enabled harm.

We tried to address this through transparency. When we listed a DeFi token, we included warnings about the risks. We published articles explaining how

different protocols worked, what the risks were, how users could protect themselves. We built tools that made it easier to track positions, monitor health factors, understand what was happening with deposited funds. But the fundamental challenge remained: in a permissionless system, you can't prevent people from making mistakes. You can only try to help them understand the risks.

The pace of innovation was relentless. New concepts emerged weekly: automated market makers, flash loans, governance tokens, liquidity mining, vault strategies, insurance protocols, synthetic assets. Each built on what came before, creating composable primitives that could be combined in novel ways. The composability was beautiful—protocols interacting with protocols, creating emergent behaviors no single team had designed. It was also dangerous—one vulnerability could cascade through multiple interconnected systems.

I spent hours each day reading about new projects, trying to understand what they did, how they worked, what risks they carried. It was impossible to keep up. The space moved faster than any individual could follow. This was exciting—it meant the ecosystem was vibrant, creative, full of energy. It was also exhausting. There was always something new to learn, some new risk to assess, some new opportunity to evaluate.

The question of responsibility became increasingly pressing. When a protocol failed and users lost money, who was responsible? The developers who wrote the code? The auditors who reviewed it? The platforms that listed the token? The users who chose to deposit their funds? In traditional finance, these questions have established answers—regulatory frameworks, legal precedents, insurance systems. In DeFi, they were still being worked out.

Our approach was to be clear about what we were and weren't responsible for. We listed tokens, but we didn't endorse the underlying protocols. We provided information, but we didn't give investment advice. We built tools to help users manage risk, but we couldn't eliminate the risk itself. This clarity was important, but it didn't satisfy everyone. Some users expected us to protect them from all harm, which was simply impossible in a permissionless ecosystem.

The BSC launch in September was partly a response to these challenges. Ethereum's congestion and high fees were driving users away from DeFi just as interest was peaking. By offering a faster, cheaper alternative, we could keep users engaged with the ecosystem, give developers a platform where experimentation was affordable, and contribute to the broader DeFi movement. The timing was deliberate—we wanted to capture the momentum of DeFi Summer and extend it.

The results exceeded our expectations. Developers who had been priced out of Ethereum flocked to BSC. Users who couldn't afford Ethereum gas fees found they could participate on BSC for pennies. New protocols launched, some copying successful Ethereum projects, others experimenting with novel approaches. The DeFi ecosystem on BSC grew from nothing to billions in TVL in months.

But the rapid growth also created new problems. The low barriers to entry that made BSC accessible also made it cheap to deploy scams. For every legitimate project, there seemed to be multiple fraudulent ones. Users who were new to crypto, attracted by the low fees and high yields, often couldn't distinguish between real protocols and fake ones. The education gap was real, and we struggled to close it.

I thought constantly about the balance between accessibility and safety. Making DeFi easier to use meant more people could participate, which was good. But it also meant more people who didn't understand the risks were exposing themselves to potential losses, which was bad. There was no clean answer to this tension. We had to navigate it case by case, trying to expand access while being honest about the risks.

DeFi Summer ended, as all summers do. The yield farming rewards decreased as token distributions completed. The speculative fever cooled. Some protocols failed, their tokens becoming worthless. Others proved their staying power, continuing to operate and grow. The ecosystem that emerged was more mature than the one that had entered the summer—more diverse, more sophisticated, more aware of both the opportunities and the risks.

What I took from this period was a deeper appreciation for the complexity of building financial infrastructure. DeFi wasn't just about writing smart

contracts and deploying them. It was about creating systems that could handle real economic activity, that could scale to meet demand, that could protect users without preventing innovation. These challenges were hard. They would take years, not months, to fully address.

But the potential was real. I saw users from countries with limited banking access earning yields, trading assets, participating in global finance in ways that simply weren't possible before. I saw developers building applications that challenged traditional financial intermediaries, creating new models for lending, borrowing, trading, insurance. I saw an ecosystem learning, adapting, improving.

DeFi Summer was chaotic, risky, and occasionally painful. It was also one of the most exciting periods in crypto's history. The choices we made during those months—what to build, what to list, what to warn users about—shaped what came after. Some of those choices I stand by. Others I would make differently with hindsight. All of them taught me something about the responsibility that comes with building in this space.

The congestion on Ethereum during DeFi Summer was a wake-up call for the entire industry. It demonstrated that success could be its own enemy—too many users trying to use a system designed for fewer. The solutions were varied: layer-2 scaling, alternative chains, more efficient protocols. Each had trade-offs. Each addressed part of the problem.

Our contribution was BSC, but we weren't the only ones building alternatives. Solana launched its mainnet. Polygon grew its layer-2 solution. Other chains emerged, each with its own approach to the scaling challenge. This diversity was healthy. It meant that if one approach failed, others might succeed. It gave users and developers choices.

What struck me about DeFi Summer was the speed of innovation. Ideas that would have taken years to develop in traditional finance were implemented in weeks. Protocols launched, iterated, pivoted, sometimes failed, all in the span of months. This pace was exhilarating but also dangerous. There wasn't time for thorough auditing, for careful risk assessment, for the kind of due diligence that traditional finance would require.

The result was a mix of genuine innovation and outright scams, often hard

to distinguish in the moment. Projects with impressive whitepapers turned out to have no real development. Anonymous teams disappeared with user funds. Smart contracts that passed audits were still exploited. The risks were real, and many users learned about them the hard way.

I thought a lot about our role in this environment. We were a platform, not a regulator. We couldn't prevent all harm, and trying to would have meant blocking legitimate innovation along with scams. But we also couldn't ignore the risks. We had to find a middle path—providing access while being clear about dangers, enabling innovation while encouraging caution.

This middle path was hard to walk. Every decision was second-guessed. List a token too quickly, and we were enabling scams. List it too slowly, and we were gatekeeping innovation. Warn users too strongly, and we were spreading FUD. Warn them too weakly, and we were being irresponsible. There was no approach that would satisfy everyone.

What I learned was to be transparent about our reasoning. When we made decisions, we explained why. When we got things wrong, we acknowledged it. When we changed our minds based on new information, we said so. This transparency didn't eliminate criticism, but it helped users understand our thinking. It turned abstract complaints into specific disagreements that could be discussed.

DeFi Summer changed how I thought about crypto's potential. Before, I saw blockchain primarily as a better payment system—a way to move money more efficiently. After, I saw it as the foundation for an entirely new financial system, one that could be more open, more accessible, more innovative than what existed before. The primitives that emerged during those months—lending, borrowing, trading, derivatives—are the building blocks of that new system.

Whether that potential is realized depends on many factors: regulation, technology, user adoption, market conditions. But the foundation has been laid. DeFi Summer proved that decentralized financial applications could work at scale, could attract real capital, could create real value. The question now is how to make them work for more people, more safely, more sustainably.

2021 Warning Lights: UK FCA and Global Regulatory Wave

June 26, 2021. The UK's Financial Conduct Authority issued a consumer warning against Binance Markets Limited, stating that the firm was not permitted to undertake any regulated activity in the UK without prior consent. The warning was stark, public, and impossible to ignore. It was also, I would later realize, the beginning of something much larger.

I was in Dubai when the news broke. My phone started buzzing with messages—colleagues, journalists, friends all asking the same thing: what did this mean? The FCA's statement was carefully worded. It didn't accuse us of crimes. It didn't freeze our assets. It simply stated that Binance Markets Limited, our UK entity, lacked authorization for regulated activities. But the impact was immediate and severe.

The timing was significant. Just two months earlier, in April 2021, we had launched stock tokens on Binance, with Tesla as the first underlying asset. The product allowed users to gain exposure to traditional stock price movements with fractional ownership, backed by actual shares held by our partners. We thought it was innovative, lowering barriers to access for users who couldn't afford whole shares. Regulators saw it differently.

The FCA wasn't the only regulator concerned about stock tokens. Germany's BaFin had already issued a notice stating it had "reasonable suspi-

cion” that we were violating securities laws. The core issue was straightforward: if an asset carries the economic rights of a stock—price exposure, potential dividends—then it’s a security, regardless of what you call it or what technology you use to represent it. Securities require registration, disclosure, compliance with investor protection rules. We hadn’t done those things.

We responded to the regulatory pressure by ending the stock token program. On July 16, 2021, just three months after launch, we announced we would cease support for stock tokens and completely phase out the business by October. It was a painful defeat, a recognition that we had moved too fast, that our innovation had outpaced our regulatory compliance. But it was also the right decision. The product wasn’t worth the regulatory risk.

What I didn’t fully appreciate at the time was that the FCA warning wasn’t an isolated incident. It was part of a coordinated global regulatory response that would intensify throughout 2021 and beyond. The warning lights were flashing not just in the UK, but around the world. And they were all connected.

In March 2021, Japan’s Financial Services Agency had warned that Binance was operating without proper registration. In April, Germany’s BaFin challenged our stock tokens. In June, the FCA issued its warning. Two days later, Canada’s Ontario Securities Commission ordered us to stop serving Ontario users. In July, the Cayman Islands Monetary Authority stated it would not allow us to operate there. Singapore’s MAS announced it would conduct enhanced supervision of our local subsidiary. Thailand’s SEC filed a criminal complaint against us. The list went on.

Each warning, each enforcement action, each public statement was reported as a separate story. Binance banned here, warned there, investigated somewhere else. But looking at them together, a clear pattern emerged. Regulators were communicating with each other, sharing concerns, coordinating their approaches. The crypto industry had always been global, but now the regulatory response was becoming global too.

This was my first serious realization that regulation wasn’t one country’s affair. It transmitted through financial system gaps, through regulatory networks, through the shared concerns of officials who saw the same risks

we did. A warning in London could affect our operations in Singapore. A restriction in Tokyo could influence decisions in Dubai. The regulatory landscape was interconnected in ways I hadn't fully appreciated.

The FCA warning specifically highlighted something that would become a recurring theme: the challenge of supervising a “global group” that offered “complex and high-risk financial products.” The FCA noted that Binance Markets Limited was part of a wider group, that no other entity in the group held UK authorization, and that this structure made effective supervision difficult. This concern—that our distributed, decentralized organization was designed to evade oversight—would follow us for years.

Our public response at the time emphasized that the FCA notice had “no direct impact” on services provided through Binance.com, which wasn't UK-based. This was technically true but missed the larger point. The warning wasn't just about our UK entity. It was about our entire operating model. And the fact that UK users could still access our global platform didn't mean the regulatory concerns were invalid. It meant we hadn't addressed them.

I spent much of 2021 in conversations with regulators around the world. Some were genuinely curious about crypto, wanting to understand how it worked and how it might be regulated effectively. Others were hostile, seeing crypto as a threat to financial stability or a tool for criminals. Most were somewhere in between—cautious, skeptical, trying to balance innovation with protection. I learned that regulatory attitudes weren't fixed; they could be influenced by engagement, by demonstration of good faith, by concrete commitments to compliance.

But I also learned that trust, once lost, is hard to rebuild. Regulators who had watched us grow rapidly, who had seen us launch products first and ask permission later, who had read about our compliance failures in the news—they weren't going to be swayed by a few meetings or press releases. They needed to see sustained change, structural reform, genuine commitment to operating within the frameworks they were responsible for enforcing.

The global nature of the regulatory pressure created coordination challenges for us. Each jurisdiction had its own rules, its own expectations, its own timeline for engagement. What satisfied regulators in one country

might not satisfy those in another. Some wanted us to obtain specific licenses. Others wanted us to cease certain activities. Still others wanted structural changes to how we organized our operations. Meeting all these demands simultaneously was complex and resource-intensive.

What struck me most about 2021 was the speed of the shift. For years, crypto had operated in a regulatory gray zone—neither fully legal nor explicitly illegal, tolerated if not embraced. That zone was shrinking rapidly. Regulators were drawing clearer lines, establishing clearer expectations, taking clearer action against those who crossed them. The industry was being forced to grow up, and not everyone was ready.

I thought frequently about our users during this period. The regulatory warnings were scary for them. They read headlines about Binance being “banned” in various countries and worried about their funds. Many didn’t understand the distinction between a consumer warning and an actual service shutdown. Some withdrew their assets preemptively, not wanting to take risks they didn’t fully understand. This was understandable, even rational, but it also created stress and uncertainty for people who had trusted us with their money.

Our communication strategy evolved throughout 2021. We became more proactive about explaining what regulatory actions meant and didn’t mean. We emphasized the security of user funds, the continuity of our services, our commitment to compliance. But we also had to be honest about the challenges we faced. We couldn’t promise that every regulatory issue would be resolved quickly or easily. The landscape was too complex, the issues too significant.

By the end of 2021, the pattern was clear. The regulatory wave that had started with isolated warnings was becoming a sustained pressure system. More jurisdictions were joining the effort. The expectations were rising. The margin for error was shrinking. What had been acceptable in 2019 or 2020 was no longer acceptable in 2021. And what was acceptable in 2021 would likely not be acceptable in 2022.

This realization was sobering. It meant that our entire operating model needed to change. The speed-at-all-costs approach that had driven our

early growth was no longer viable. The launch-first-regulate-later mindset that had characterized our product development was no longer defensible. We needed to become a different kind of company—slower, more careful, more compliant.

Making this transition was painful. It required changing how we made decisions, who was involved in those decisions, what criteria we used to evaluate opportunities. It required hiring people with different skills—compliance professionals, lawyers, regulatory affairs specialists. It required investing in systems and processes that didn't directly generate revenue but were essential for sustainable operation. It required saying no to opportunities that would have been easy yeses in the past.

The FCA warning of June 2021 was a wake-up call, but it wasn't the end of the story. It was the beginning of a longer process of transformation that would continue for years. The regulatory wave that started in 2021 hasn't receded. If anything, it has intensified, with more jurisdictions, clearer rules, and stronger enforcement. The companies that survive and thrive in this environment will be those that adapted to it, that accepted the reality that regulation is not an obstacle to overcome but a framework to operate within.

I don't complain about this transformation. I don't see regulators as villains or compliance as a burden. I see them as the necessary conditions for an industry to mature, to gain mainstream acceptance, to fulfill its potential. The crypto industry of 2021 was like a teenager—full of energy, creativity, and potential, but also reckless, impatient, and convinced it knew better than everyone else. The regulatory pressure forced us to grow up.

Growing up isn't fun. It involves accepting limits, taking responsibility, doing things you don't want to do because they're necessary. But it's also the only path to building something lasting. The companies that emerge from this period of regulatory pressure will be stronger, more resilient, more trustworthy than those that existed before it. They'll be better positioned to serve users, to contribute to the global financial system, to fulfill the promise of blockchain technology.

The warning lights of 2021 were painful to see, but they were necessary. They showed us where we were going wrong, what we needed to change, how

we needed to evolve. I'm grateful for them, even as I acknowledge the costs they imposed. Without them, we might have continued down a path that would have ended badly—for us, for our users, for the industry as a whole.

The FCA's specific concerns about Binance Markets Limited reflected broader worries about the entire crypto industry. Regulators everywhere were struggling with the same questions: How do you supervise companies that operate across borders? How do you protect consumers from risks they don't understand? How do you prevent illicit finance without stifling innovation? These aren't easy questions, and the answers vary by jurisdiction. But the fact that regulators were asking them seriously marked a shift in how crypto was viewed.

I spent many hours in 2021 thinking about what responsible innovation looks like. It's not just about building cool technology. It's about considering the consequences, thinking about who might be harmed, planning for what happens when things go wrong. It's about engaging with regulators not as enemies but as partners in creating frameworks that allow innovation while protecting users. This mindset was new for me, and I can't claim to have mastered it. But I was learning.

The global coordination among regulators was something I hadn't anticipated. I had assumed that each country would make its own decisions based on local conditions. And to some extent, they did. But there was also clear communication, shared intelligence, coordinated timing. Regulators were learning from each other, adopting best practices, avoiding the mistakes others had made. This was professionalization of regulatory oversight, and it meant the industry couldn't play jurisdictions against each other as easily as before.

What I came to understand is that regulation is a form of infrastructure. Like roads or electricity, it enables activity by creating predictable rules and reliable enforcement. Yes, it can be poorly designed, captured by special interests, or applied too heavily. But the solution to bad regulation isn't no regulation—it's better regulation. And better regulation requires engagement, not evasion.

The 2021 regulatory wave taught me that the crypto industry had reached

a tipping point. We were no longer a fringe experiment that regulators could ignore. We were a significant part of the financial system, and we would be regulated accordingly. The only question was whether we would help shape that regulation or have it imposed on us.

I chose engagement. It was harder than evasion, slower than moving fast and asking forgiveness later. But it was the only path to building something that could last. The companies that tried to evade regulation, that moved to the next jurisdiction every time they faced pressure—these companies would eventually run out of places to go. The ones that engaged, that built genuine compliance capabilities, that demonstrated they could be responsible actors—these companies would survive.

The FCA warning was a moment of clarity for me. It stripped away any remaining illusions that we could continue operating as we had. It forced me to confront the gap between how we saw ourselves and how regulators saw us. And it set in motion the changes that would eventually transform Binance into a more mature, more compliant organization.

That transformation is still ongoing. The work we started in 2021 continues today. But the direction is clear, and I'm committed to it. The warning lights showed us the way. We just had to be willing to see them.

Media and Narrative: You're Writing Me, I'm Responding

There is a peculiar asymmetry in being written about. You read words attributed to you that you never spoke. You see motives assigned to you that you never felt. And then you are asked—or expected—to respond. The media writes; you react. They set the frame; you try to climb out of it. After a while, you begin to wonder whether any response is actually communication, or merely a form of emotional self-protection.

I learned this lesson slowly, across years of headlines that grew increasingly creative. In the early days, the coverage was straightforward: Binance is a new exchange, it has low fees, it grew quickly. Journalists asked about our technology, our matching engine, our security architecture. I could answer those questions. The conversation was technical, and I am comfortable with technical conversations.

But somewhere around 2020, the narrative shifted. We were no longer just an exchange. We were “the world’s largest crypto exchange,” a phrase that appeared in nearly every article regardless of relevance. With that label came a different kind of scrutiny. Every market movement became something we allegedly caused. Every project that listed on our platform became something we allegedly endorsed. Every user in every jurisdiction became our responsibility to police.

The headlines accumulated like sediment. “Binance Under Investigation.” “Regulators Target Binance.” “Is Binance Too Big to Regulate?” I would read these pieces and recognize fragments of truth wrapped in assumptions I could not recognize. An inquiry becomes an investigation. An investigation becomes a probe. A probe becomes a crisis. The transitive property of journalism.

I developed responses. At first, I tried to engage directly. A journalist would publish something I believed contained errors, and I would reach out to correct the record. Sometimes this worked. More often, the correction would appear as a single sentence buried at the end of a follow-up piece, while the original headline continued its independent life on social media, stripped of all nuance. The damage was done in the first paragraph; the correction was read by no one.

So I adjusted. I became more cautious in my public statements. I learned to speak in carefully constructed sentences that could not be easily excerpted and weaponized. I stopped giving spontaneous interviews. I started using Twitter more strategically, treating it as a direct channel to users who might actually read my words rather than filtered through someone else’s interpretation.

This is how the “4” emerged. In January 2023, I posted about my focus for the year: education, compliance, product and services, and—fourth—“ignore FUD, fake news, attacks, etc.” The Binance Academy later explained this framework as a prioritization exercise: three areas of active investment, one area of active non-investment. The fourth item was not a command to others but a note to myself. I was spending too much time responding to noise. I needed to stop.

The number became a shorthand. When something absurd appeared in the media—a rumor about my personal safety, a speculation about Binance’s solvency, an anonymous source claiming knowledge of our internal operations—I would post “4.” It was efficient. It was also, I now recognize, a form of surrender. I had accepted that I could not control the narrative, so I would simply opt out of engaging with it.

The community adopted the symbol with enthusiasm. Memes prolifer-

ated. The number appeared in profile pictures, in comment threads, in merchandise. What began as a personal productivity hack became a cultural phenomenon. I should have anticipated this. In crypto, symbols spread faster than explanations. The gesture became more important than the meaning behind it.

There was a defensive quality to the adoption that I found both touching and troubling. Users would deploy “4” against any criticism of Binance, any skeptical analysis, any regulatory concern. The symbol that was meant to help me focus had become a shield against legitimate inquiry. I had intended to ignore noise, but the community was using it to ignore signal.

I want to be clear about what the “4” was and was not. It was not a dismissal of all media. It was not a claim that every critical story was fake news. It was not an instruction to our users to stop thinking critically. It was simply a personal acknowledgment that I had limited time and that responding to every headline was not the best use of it.

But I also need to acknowledge the limitations of this approach. Responding is not always communication, but sometimes not responding is also a form of communication. Silence can be read as arrogance, as dismissal, as confirmation of the worst suspicions. When I posted “4” in response to serious regulatory developments, some interpreted it as evidence that I did not take the concerns seriously. That was never my intention, but intention does not control interpretation.

The media ecosystem in which we operate has structural incentives that I do not control and cannot fully understand. Outrage generates engagement. Uncertainty generates clicks. The most successful crypto coverage often sits at the intersection of fear and greed, amplifying both to capture attention. I do not blame individual journalists for this. They work within systems that reward certain behaviors. But I have had to learn to navigate within this ecosystem without being consumed by it.

There were moments when I broke my own rule. When a story contained what I believed to be a genuine factual error that could cause real harm—confusion about our proof of reserves, misinformation about our regulatory status in a specific jurisdiction—I would respond in detail. These responses

were rarely picked up with the same enthusiasm as the original errors. Corrections do not travel.

I have come to believe that the relationship between public figures and the media is fundamentally adversarial in a way that neither side fully acknowledges. Journalists need stories that generate attention. Public figures need stories that generate trust. These needs are not always compatible. The result is a kind of ritualized combat in which both sides perform their roles while privately wishing for a different kind of conversation.

What I have tried to do, imperfectly, is maintain direct communication with our users. If the media narrative and the user experience diverge, I trust the user experience more. A trader who has successfully used our platform for years has more relevant knowledge about Binance than a journalist who has spent a week researching the company. This is not anti-media sentiment. It is simply a prioritization based on proximity to truth.

The “4” will probably outlast my use of it. Symbols acquire their own momentum. But for me, it remains what it always was: a reminder that attention is finite, that not every battle is worth fighting, and that sometimes the most productive response to noise is to return to work. The media will write what it writes. I will build what I build. These are separate activities, and conflating them serves neither.

I do not expect the media to stop writing about Binance. I do not expect the coverage to become uniformly positive. What I have learned to expect is that the narrative will follow its own logic, shaped by forces that have little to do with our actual operations. My job is not to control that narrative. My job is to ensure that the reality underneath it remains sound. If we do our work well, the gap between story and substance eventually becomes apparent. Not immediately. Not to everyone. But eventually.

That is the lesson, I think. You cannot win at media. You can only opt out of playing the game on terms you did not set. The “4” was my opt-out. Imperfect, misunderstood, sometimes counterproductive—but honest about the limits of what any response can achieve when the frame has already been established by someone else.

I Don't Buy Houses: Liquidity and Security

I do not own a house. I have not owned one since 2014, when I sold my apartment in Shanghai to buy Bitcoin. At the time, the decision seemed obvious. Bitcoin was trading around \$600, down from its peak but still carrying what I believed to be extraordinary upside. The apartment was a concrete box in a city where I no longer planned to spend my life. The trade made sense mathematically.

What I did not anticipate was how that decision would shape my psychology for the next decade. I became someone who does not own real estate. Not because I cannot afford it. Not because I have philosophical objections to property. But because I have internalized a particular relationship with liquidity that makes illiquid assets feel uncomfortable in a way that is difficult to fully explain.

The media has found this amusing. Profiles of me consistently note that I own no house, no car, no physical possessions of significance. The implication is usually that this is either eccentricity or performance—a billionaire playing at asceticism. I understand why this reading is tempting. But it mistakes effect for cause. I do not avoid possessions to make a statement. I avoid them because they do not fit how I have learned to think about security.

Liquidity is not just a financial concept for me. It is a psychological state. An asset that can be converted to cash in hours provides a different quality

of rest than an asset that requires months of process, lawyers, agents, negotiations. I have spent too much of my career in situations where the ability to move quickly mattered. When a regulator changes its interpretation of the law overnight. When a bank decides to terminate a relationship with forty-eight hours' notice. When a market moves in a direction that requires immediate response. In these moments, the person who needs to sell a house is trapped. The person who holds liquid assets has options.

This is not a prediction about how the world will treat me. It is a recognition of how the world has already treated me. I have been the subject of regulatory inquiries in multiple jurisdictions. I have had banking relationships terminated without explanation. I have watched governments change their policies toward cryptocurrency with minimal warning. Each of these experiences reinforced a particular lesson: the ability to adapt quickly is more valuable than the ability to accumulate impressively.

Real estate is the opposite of quick adaptation. It is commitment made concrete. When you buy a house, you are betting on a location, a jurisdiction, a set of tax policies, a neighborhood trajectory. These bets can be smart. They have made many people wealthy. But they are bets I am temperamentally unsuited to make. I do not have confidence in my ability to predict which jurisdiction will treat me well in ten years. I barely have confidence in my ability to predict which jurisdiction will treat me well in two years.

There is also a simpler explanation that I should acknowledge. I am lazy about things that do not interest me. The process of buying a house—finding an agent, viewing properties, negotiating price, managing renovations, dealing with maintenance—holds no appeal. I would rather spend that time reading about zero-knowledge proofs or talking to developers about cross-chain bridges. This is not virtue. This is preference, and preferences are not interesting enough to warrant much discussion.

But the preference reveals something, I think, about how different people construct security. For many, security is rooted in place. The owned home is the foundation of stability, the physical manifestation of having arrived. For others, security is rooted in relationships. The family network, the community ties, the professional reputation. For me, security has become

rooted in optionality. The knowledge that I can leave any situation, any jurisdiction, any arrangement with minimal friction. This is not the same as wanting to leave. It is the comfort of knowing I could.

The crypto I hold provides this optionality in its purest form. Private keys are weightless. They can be memorized, stored in multiple jurisdictions, accessed from anywhere with an internet connection. This is not to say crypto is without risk. The volatility is extreme. The regulatory uncertainty is real. The technical risks—lost keys, hacked wallets, smart contract vulnerabilities—are substantial. But these are risks I understand. I can reason about them. I can manage them. The risk of a government deciding to seize my apartment because of a policy change I did not anticipate is not a risk I know how to price.

I have been criticized for this perspective. It is unpatriotic, some say, to refuse to put down roots. It is irresponsible, others suggest, to keep one's wealth in such volatile assets. These criticisms are not without merit. If everyone thought as I do, communities would not form. Cities would not develop. The long-term investments that require commitment would not be made. I am not proposing my approach as a model. I am simply describing it as mine.

There is also the question of what I am optimizing for. If I wanted to maximize my expected net worth, I would probably own real estate in several jurisdictions, diversify across traditional asset classes, build the kind of portfolio that wealth managers recommend. But I am not optimizing for expected net worth. I am optimizing for something more like peace of mind, defined in my particular way. The peace that comes from knowing I can move. The peace that comes from assets that do not require my physical presence. The peace that comes from a form of wealth that is difficult to seize, difficult to tax without consent, difficult to freeze through bureaucratic process.

This peace is worth something to me that is hard to quantify. I have watched too many people lose assets through processes they did not control. Bank accounts frozen pending investigation. Properties seized through civil forfeiture. Businesses destroyed by regulatory changes that applied retroactively. The legal systems in most jurisdictions are designed to make

asset seizure easy and recovery difficult. I do not assume I will be exempt from these systems. I simply try to structure my affairs so that their application to me would be more difficult.

The irony, of course, is that my approach has made me a target of a different kind. Because I hold my wealth in crypto, I am accused of hiding assets, of operating in shadows, of refusing to participate in the transparent financial system. The criticism is not entirely wrong. I do value privacy. I do believe that financial surveillance has gone too far in most jurisdictions. But the criticism also misses the point. My preference for liquid, private assets is not a rejection of society. It is a response to my experience of how society treats people in my position.

I do not know if I will ever buy a house. Perhaps when I am older, when the desire for stability exceeds the fear of constraint. Perhaps never. What I do know is that the decision will not be driven by financial optimization. It will be driven by a shift in how I think about security, about commitment, about what it means to be at home. For now, I remain someone who can pack a bag and be anywhere in the world within twenty-four hours. This is not freedom in any grand philosophical sense. It is simply the form of security I have learned to trust.

2022 Opening: Cooling Down Isn't Bad

The year began with a feeling I could not quite name. Markets were still elevated from the pandemic-era stimulus. Bitcoin had touched \$69,000 the previous November. Institutional adoption seemed to be accelerating. And yet, something felt off. The macro environment was shifting in ways that I suspected would matter more than most crypto participants wanted to acknowledge.

The Federal Reserve had begun signaling its intention to tighten monetary policy. Inflation prints were coming in higher than expected. The era of near-zero interest rates was ending. I have been in markets long enough to understand that liquidity drives asset prices, and liquidity was being withdrawn. This was not crypto-specific. This was global. But crypto, being the most speculative and least income-generating asset class, would feel it most acutely.

I wrote internal memos in early 2022 suggesting that we prepare for a prolonged cooling period. Not a crash, necessarily. Not a crypto winter, though that term would become fashionable later. Just a return to more rational valuations after a period of excess. Cooling down is not bad, I told the team. It clears out leverage. It separates projects with genuine utility from those sustained only by momentum. It reminds everyone that prices can go down as well as up.

What I did not anticipate—what I do not believe anyone fully anticipated—

was how the cooling would interact with the structural fragility that had built up in the crypto ecosystem. The real risk, I would come to understand, was not the price drop itself. It was the trust run that the price drop would trigger.

Traditional finance understands bank runs. A rumor spreads that a bank is insolvent. Depositors rush to withdraw their funds. The bank, which holds only a fraction of deposits as reserves, cannot meet the demand. The rumor becomes self-fulfilling. What happened in crypto in 2022 was similar but different. It was not a run on deposits in the traditional sense. It was a run on trust. Users stopped believing that the institutions holding their funds were sound. And in crypto, where there is no deposit insurance, no lender of last resort, no regulatory backstop, this lack of belief is fatal.

The first major crack appeared in May. Terra, the algorithmic stablecoin ecosystem that had grown to over \$40 billion in market capitalization, lost its peg. I will discuss the mechanics of this collapse in more detail later. What matters for understanding the opening of 2022 is the sequence: a project that appeared stable revealed itself to be fragile, and the revelation triggered contagion. Three Arrows Capital, one of the largest crypto hedge funds, had significant exposure to Terra. When Terra collapsed, 3AC faced margin calls it could not meet. Its lenders, including Voyager and Celsius, found themselves with holes in their balance sheets. Celsius froze withdrawals. Then it filed for bankruptcy. Then Voyager. Then 3AC itself.

Reuters market overviews from this period documented the cascading effect. The total crypto market capitalization fell from over \$3 trillion in late 2021 to under \$1 trillion by June 2022. Bitcoin declined more than 60% from its peak. Ethereum fell even further. The correlation between assets approached one—everything moved down together, suggesting that the selling was driven by forced liquidations and risk reduction rather than project-specific concerns.

Our risk management team at Binance had prepared for volatility. We had stress-tested our systems against various scenarios. What we had not fully prepared for was the speed of trust erosion. When Celsius froze withdrawals, users across all platforms became anxious. The rational response for any

individual user was to withdraw funds from any centralized platform and self-custody. The collective result of these rational individual decisions was a liquidity crisis for the entire CeFi sector.

Binance experienced significant outflows during this period. Not catastrophic—we had sufficient reserves to meet all withdrawal requests. But large enough to require active management. We moved funds between wallets, optimized our hot wallet balances, communicated transparently with users about our solvency. The experience reinforced a lesson I had first learned in 2018: in a crisis, transparency is not just a virtue. It is a survival strategy.

I spent much of this period in risk control meetings, reviewing our exposures, monitoring our counterparties, stress-testing our systems against increasingly extreme scenarios. The mood was not panicked. It was focused. We had built Binance to withstand volatility. The question was whether we had built it to withstand a systemic loss of confidence.

The answer, it turned out, was mostly yes. We had no exposure to Terra. We had no lending to 3AC. Our business model was simple—exchange fees—and did not depend on the solvency of other crypto institutions. This simplicity was not accidental. I have always believed that complexity is the enemy of resilience. The more moving parts a system has, the more ways it can fail.

But I also recognized that our resilience was partly luck. We could have easily been more exposed. We could have offered yield products backed by Terra. We could have lent to 3AC. The fact that we did not was a combination of conservative risk management and fortunate timing. I am not comfortable attributing too much to skill when luck played such a significant role.

The macro tightening continued through 2022. The Fed raised rates from near zero to over 4% by year-end. The dollar strengthened against virtually every currency. Risk assets of all types—tech stocks, emerging market debt, crypto—declined. The correlation between crypto and traditional risk assets, which had been low in earlier cycles, approached one. Bitcoin was trading like a high-beta tech stock.

This was disappointing to those who had believed crypto would be an uncorrelated asset, a hedge against traditional financial instability. I had

never fully subscribed to this view. Crypto is a risk asset. It attracts the same investors who buy growth stocks and speculative ventures. When those investors reduce risk, they reduce crypto along with everything else. The long-term case for crypto does not depend on short-term correlation dynamics. But the short-term dynamics were painful for many.

By the end of 2022, the industry was in a different place than it had been at the beginning. Leverage had been flushed out. Many of the most aggressive yield products had collapsed. The projects that remained were, on average, more substantial than those that had dominated the conversation in 2021. The builders were still building. The speculators had moved on.

Cooling down is not bad. I believed this in January 2022, and I believe it more strongly now. The heat of 2021 had created distortions—unsustainable yields, unjustified valuations, projects valued in billions with no users. The cooling forced a return to fundamentals. What problem does this solve? Who uses it? How does it generate sustainable revenue? These questions, which had been drowned out by the noise of bull market exuberance, became relevant again.

But I also learned that cooling can trigger chain reactions that go beyond what fundamentals would predict. The collapse of Terra was not inevitable. It was triggered by specific selling pressure that may or may not have been coordinated. The resulting contagion was not inevitable either. It was amplified by leverage, by interconnectedness, by the speed of information flow in crypto markets. Understanding these dynamics—understanding that the real risk is not price but trust—is essential for anyone building in this space.

The year 2022 was not the end of crypto. It was not even the beginning of the end. It was, perhaps, the end of the beginning—a transition from an experimental phase to something more mature. The cooling was necessary. The question was what would grow in the colder climate.

Bridge Breached: BNB Chain October 2022 Vulnerability

Security incidents never make appointments. They arrive unannounced, usually at inconvenient moments, and always with the same message: you were not as careful as you thought you were. The BNB Chain bridge exploit in October 2022 was no exception.

I remember where I was when I received the first alert. It was early morning, and I was reviewing the previous day's metrics when my phone began delivering notifications at a frequency that indicated something serious. The BSC Token Hub, the cross-chain bridge connecting BNB Beacon Chain and BNB Smart Chain, had been exploited. The attacker had minted two million BNB tokens—approximately \$570 million at the time—out of thin air.

The technical details would emerge over the following days. According to research analysis that would later be published, the attacker had exploited a vulnerability in the bridge's proof verification mechanism. The BSC Token Hub used a Merkle tree implementation to verify cross-chain messages. The attacker discovered that the bridge did not fully verify the Merkle tree to the root hash, allowing them to forge proof messages that the bridge would accept as valid. By registering as a relay and crafting forged proofs based on earlier legitimate ones, they were able to convince the bridge to mint new

BNB directly to their wallet.

What made this attack unusual was that the attacker did not steal existing funds. They created new ones. This is a subtle but important distinction. In most exploits, users lose money—funds are drained from wallets, removed from pools, transferred without authorization. In this case, the users' funds remained untouched. The damage was to the system itself, to the integrity of the BNB supply, to the trust in the bridge mechanism.

My first priority was containment. We asked validators to temporarily suspend the BNB Smart Chain. This is not a decision made lightly. Halting a blockchain is a serious intervention, one that affects thousands of applications and millions of users. But the alternative—allowing the attacker to continue minting and moving funds—was worse. Bloomberg reports from the time noted that approximately \$7 million of the exploited funds were quickly frozen through the cooperation of validators, community members, and security partners. The majority of the remaining funds were isolated on the BNB Chain, unable to be bridged out to other networks.

The hours following the discovery were a blur of coordination. Calls with the core development team. Communications with validators. Updates to the community. Every decision had to be made quickly and with incomplete information. Should we attempt to freeze the attacker's funds through a network upgrade? What would be the legal implications? How would the community respond to such an intervention?

I have been through security incidents before. At OKCoin, we dealt with attempted intrusions. At Binance, we had faced phishing campaigns, social engineering attacks, various attempts to compromise our systems. But this was different. This was not an attack on our exchange infrastructure. This was an attack on the blockchain itself, on the fundamental mechanism that allowed assets to move between chains. The feeling was heavier, more personal in a way I struggled to articulate.

The decision to pause the chain triggered the expected criticism. Some in the community argued that a blockchain that can be paused is not truly decentralized. They were not wrong, exactly. BNB Chain has always occupied a middle ground between the full decentralization of Ethereum and the

complete centralization of traditional finance. The validator set is limited. The threshold for making changes is lower. These were design choices made for practical reasons—faster finality, lower fees, easier coordination. The exploit forced us to confront the trade-offs those choices entailed.

I published a blog post I had written three years earlier about centralization versus decentralization. My views had not fundamentally changed. I still believe that security, ease of use, and freedom matter more than any abstract commitment to decentralization as an end in itself. But I also recognize that this view is contestable, and that many in the crypto community hold different values. The exploit became a referendum on our design choices, with critics arguing that a more decentralized chain would have been more resilient.

Perhaps. But a more decentralized chain might also have been slower to respond. The attacker would have had more time to move funds. More damage would have been done. There is no perfect system, only systems with different failure modes. The question is which failure modes you consider acceptable.

In the days following the exploit, we worked on a recovery plan. The community would vote on whether to offer a 10% bounty for the return of the funds. We would establish a bug bounty program with rewards up to \$1 million for critical vulnerabilities. We would conduct a comprehensive security review of all bridge contracts. These were necessary steps, but they felt insufficient. The vulnerability had existed for years. Why had we not found it earlier?

This question haunted me. We had conducted audits. We had run bug bounty programs. We had a security team that I believed to be competent. And yet, a flaw of this magnitude had remained undiscovered until an attacker exploited it. The uncomfortable truth is that security is not a state you achieve. It is a process you maintain, and the process is never complete. Every system has vulnerabilities. The only question is whether they are found by white hats or black hats first.

The BNB price fell on the news, as expected. From around \$293 to \$280, a decline of roughly 4.5%. Not catastrophic, but noticeable. More concerning

was the reputational damage. The exploit became another data point in the narrative that cross-chain bridges are inherently insecure. Chainalysis data from 2022 showed that cross-chain bridge hacks accounted for 69% of all crypto hacks that year, with more than \$2 billion stolen. We had become a statistic.

I thought about the users who had chosen to build on BNB Chain. The DeFi protocols, the NFT projects, the gaming applications. They had trusted our infrastructure, and that trust had been violated. Not by malice on our part, but by insufficient caution. The distinction matters little to those affected. They experienced the consequences regardless of our intentions.

The recovery took time. The chain resumed operations after the vulnerability was patched. The governance votes passed. The bug bounty program launched. But the memory of the pause remained. Users who had believed in the unstoppable of blockchain had watched a chain stop. The ideal had collided with reality, and reality had won.

What I learned from this incident, more than any technical lesson, was about responsibility. When you build infrastructure that others depend on, their dependence becomes your obligation. The decisions you make in a crisis affect not just your organization but everyone who has built on top of your platform. This weight is not always comfortable. But it is real, and it does not go away.

Security incidents never make appointments. But they do keep appointments they never made. The question is not whether you will face one. The question is whether you will face it with the humility to recognize your own fallibility and the resolve to do what needs to be done despite the criticism that will follow. The October 2022 exploit taught me that I could do both, but that doing both would never feel like enough.

Binance and War, Sanctions, and Moral Dilemmas

The Russian invasion of Ukraine in February 2022 created a situation that no one building a global cryptocurrency platform wants to face. War is the ultimate test of principles because it forces choices that cannot be avoided through ambiguity. When your product enables financial transactions across borders, and borders suddenly become lines of conflict, you must decide what your product means.

I have always believed in what I call “freedom of money”—the idea that people should be able to transact without permission from intermediaries, that financial access is a human right, that the ability to store and transfer value is as fundamental as freedom of speech. These beliefs are easy to hold in the abstract. They become complicated when the person exercising that freedom is on a sanctions list, or when the transaction might fund activities you find abhorrent.

In April 2022, Binance announced that we would stop serving cryptocurrency wallets worth 10,000 euros or more that were registered to Russian passport holders. This was a significant step, one that affected a substantial portion of our user base. But it was also a limited step. It did not affect smaller wallets. It did not affect Russian users who held non-Russian documentation. And it did not address the deeper question of what we owed to ordinary

Russian citizens who had no involvement in their government's decisions.

Reuters reporting from this period documented the complexity of the situation. The publication noted that Binance had processed Iranian transactions valued at over \$8 billion since 2018, the majority flowing from an Iranian exchange called Nobitex. This was not a secret. We had publicly stated our commitment to comply with sanctions, and yet the transactions continued. Part of the problem was technical—"indirect" flows that inserted intermediary transactions to obfuscate origin. Part of it was jurisdictional—we are not a U.S. company and do not have the same obligations as U.S. entities. And part of it was philosophical—we genuinely believed that ordinary Iranians should not be cut off from the global financial system because of their government's actions.

This belief is not unique to me. The U.S. Treasury Department has itself acknowledged the humanitarian concerns with broad sanctions. When you freeze an entire country's access to financial infrastructure, you harm civilians more than you harm regimes. The question is where to draw the line. How do you distinguish between a regime official and an ordinary citizen? How do you prevent sanctions evasion without collectively punishing entire populations?

By August 2023, the pressure had intensified. Bloomberg and The Wall Street Journal reported on a U.S. Justice Department investigation into whether Binance had violated financial sanctions on Russia. The same day, we announced new restrictions: Russian users could trade only in rubles on our peer-to-peer platform. All other fiat currencies were prohibited. We also removed five Russian banks under U.S. sanctions from our P2P platform—including Sber and Tinkoff, which had reportedly been renamed to "green" and "yellow" in our payment options.

The renaming was embarrassing. It suggested that we had been attempting to obscure the identity of sanctioned banks, which was not our intent but was certainly how it appeared. I ordered an immediate review of our P2P payment option naming conventions. The result was the removal of the renamed options and stricter controls on which banks could be listed.

But the deeper question remained. Why had those banks been listed

in the first place? The answer, I believe, lies in the gap between policy and implementation. Our policy was clear: no sanctioned entities. Our implementation was imperfect. The people building the P2P platform were focused on user experience, on making it easy for Russians to find counterparties. They were not sufficiently focused on the compliance implications of every payment method listed. This was a failure of process, not of intent. But failures of process have consequences regardless of intent.

I have been asked whether I regret offering services in Russia, in Iran, in other sanctioned jurisdictions. The honest answer is that I do not know. I believe that financial exclusion is a form of violence. I believe that cryptocurrency can be a tool of liberation for people trapped in failed states or oppressive regimes. But I also believe that this tool can be misused, that it can enable evasion of legitimate sanctions, that it can fund activities that cause real harm.

The “freedom of money” philosophy does not provide easy answers to these questions. It provides a framework for thinking about them. The framework starts from the premise that financial access is a right, but it does not end there. Rights can be abused. Rights can conflict with other rights. The exercise of rights comes with responsibilities.

What I have learned is that the line between legitimate use and abuse is often not visible in advance. You cannot know, when you build a platform, every way it will be used. You can only respond when misuse becomes apparent. This reactive posture is uncomfortable. It means you are always behind, always responding to problems rather than preventing them. But I do not see a better alternative. Perfect prediction is impossible. The best you can do is build systems that allow you to respond quickly and effectively when problems emerge.

The sanctions issue also revealed something about the nature of global regulation. The U.S. sanctions regime is extraterritorial—it applies not just to U.S. entities but to any entity that touches the U.S. financial system. Since virtually all global banks have U.S. operations, this effectively means U.S. sanctions apply globally. This is not a criticism of U.S. policy. It is simply a description of how the system works. But it creates a situation where

companies like Binance must navigate multiple, sometimes conflicting regulatory frameworks.

What is legal in one jurisdiction may be prohibited in another. What is required by one regulator may be forbidden by another. There is no global arbiter to resolve these conflicts. Each company must make its own judgments, knowing that any judgment will be criticized by someone.

I have tried to navigate this by being transparent about our principles and our limitations. We believe in financial access. We also believe in complying with applicable law. When these beliefs conflict, we try to find the least harmful resolution. Sometimes this means restricting services in ways that disappoint users. Sometimes this means accepting legal risk to maintain services we believe are legitimate. There is no algorithm for these decisions. They require judgment, and judgment is fallible.

The war in Ukraine continues as I write this. The sanctions regime continues to evolve. Binance continues to operate in a gray zone that satisfies no one completely—not the regulators who want more compliance, not the users who want fewer restrictions, not the advocates who want clearer principles. I have come to accept that this dissatisfaction is inevitable. The questions we face have no clean answers. The best we can do is remain engaged, remain transparent, and remain willing to adjust as we learn.

“Freedom of money” is not a slogan. It is a commitment that creates obligations. One of those obligations is to think carefully about when that freedom should be limited. I do not claim to have found the right balance. I only claim to be searching for it, openly and honestly, in a world that makes such searches difficult and thankless.

Internal Patching: Compliance Team's Struggle

Organizations have inertia. This is a physical truth that applies to human systems as much as to mechanical ones. An organization in motion tends to stay in motion along its established trajectory. Changing that trajectory requires force—often more force than the people trying to effect change can generate. I understood this intellectually long before I understood it viscerally. The CFTC allegations in 2023 forced visceral understanding.

The complaint, filed in March 2023, contained multiple references to internal communications that the CFTC had obtained. Signal messages between me and employees. Discussions about U.S. users. References to compliance efforts that were described as inadequate. Reading these excerpts was a strange experience—seeing my own words quoted back at me, stripped of context, arranged to support a narrative I did not recognize.

I do not dispute that we had compliance gaps. Any organization growing as fast as Binance had gaps. The question was whether those gaps represented deliberate evasion or the inevitable friction of scaling. The CFTC's complaint argued the former. My experience suggested the latter. But I recognize that my perspective is not neutral.

What I want to address here is not the legal merits of the complaint but the organizational dynamics it revealed. The CFTC alleged that we had

instructed employees to use Signal for communications about “U.S. bans.” The allegation was true in a narrow sense—I had encouraged the use of Signal for sensitive communications because I believed it was more secure. But the framing suggested intent to hide evidence, which was not my intent at all. I was concerned about security, not concealment. The gap between these two interpretations is where much of our legal trouble resided.

Organizational inertia manifested in several ways. Our compliance team was understaffed relative to our growth. This was not a deliberate choice to ignore compliance. It was a failure to anticipate how quickly compliance requirements would multiply as we expanded into new jurisdictions. We hired as fast as we could, but hiring takes time. Training takes time. Building systems takes time. Meanwhile, the business was growing exponentially.

The compliance team often felt like they were trying to apply brakes to a vehicle that was already accelerating downhill. They would identify a risk, propose controls, and by the time those controls were implemented, the business had moved on to new activities that created new risks. This is not an excuse. It is a description of a structural problem that many fast-growing companies face.

I have thought a lot about what we could have done differently. Earlier investment in compliance infrastructure, certainly. More aggressive hiring, even at the cost of diluting our culture. Slower expansion, accepting that we could not serve every market immediately. These are easy to say in retrospect. At the time, the pressure was always to grow, to capture market share, to build before competitors did. The compliance team was seen as a brake on this growth—not by me specifically, but by the organization as a whole. And brakes are not popular in racing cars.

The OFAC agreement that would eventually be reached required us to implement significant changes to our sanctions compliance program. We had to invest in transaction monitoring systems, expand our compliance team, establish more rigorous policies and procedures. These were changes we should have made earlier. The agreement forced us to do what we had been unable to do through internal motivation alone.

This is the tragedy of organizational inertia. The changes that would have

prevented the crisis are obvious after the crisis occurs. But they are not obvious before. Or rather, they are obvious to some people—the compliance officers, the risk managers, the lawyers—but not to the people with the authority to allocate resources. By the time the authority figures recognize the need, the crisis is often already in motion.

I take responsibility for this failure. I was the CEO. The allocation of resources was ultimately my decision. I could have prioritized compliance more highly. I could have slowed growth. I could have listened more carefully to the people warning about risks. I did not, and the consequences followed.

But I also want to offer this reflection to future leaders of fast-growing organizations. The lesson is not simply “compliance matters.” Everyone knows compliance matters. The lesson is that compliance must be built into the growth model, not added as an afterthought. If your organization views compliance as a cost center that slows down the business, you have already lost. Compliance must be understood as essential infrastructure, like servers or security teams—something that enables sustainable growth rather than inhibiting it.

This requires more than rhetoric. It requires structural changes. Compliance leaders must have direct access to the CEO, not be buried in the organization. Compliance budgets must be protected from the pressure to cut costs. Compliance metrics must be tracked and rewarded with the same seriousness as revenue metrics. These are easy to write and hard to implement, especially when growth is rapid and competition is fierce.

The CFTC complaint forced us to confront these structural issues. We made changes. We hired a new Chief Compliance Officer with extensive regulatory experience. We invested tens of millions of dollars in compliance technology. We established clearer lines of communication between compliance and business teams. Whether these changes were sufficient would be tested by future events.

What I learned from this period is that organizational culture is not something you declare. It is something you demonstrate through resource allocation, through who you promote, through what you celebrate and what you punish. If you celebrate deal-makers and ignore compliance officers,

your culture is clear regardless of what values you publish on your website. Changing culture requires changing these signals, which is harder than changing policies.

The compliance team's struggle was not just against external regulators. It was against internal momentum, against the accumulated weight of decisions made over years, against the invisible force of "how we do things here." Overcoming that force required more than good intentions. It required crisis—the kind of external shock that makes the invisible visible and forces reconsideration of what had been taken for granted.

I wish we had not needed that shock. I wish we had built differently from the beginning. But I also recognize that building differently would have required knowledge we did not have, priorities that seemed less urgent at the time, and a willingness to sacrifice growth that the competitive environment did not encourage. These are the constraints that real leaders face. Not the constraints of perfect information and unlimited resources, but the constraints of partial information, limited resources, and competing pressures.

To the compliance professionals who struggled within Binance during this period: I see your work now more clearly than I did then. I understand the frustration of raising concerns that were not fully heard, of proposing solutions that were not fully implemented, of watching risks accumulate while waiting for resources that arrived too late. Your warnings were correct. I wish I had listened sooner.

“4”: Ignore FUD, or Learn to Listen

In January 2023, I posted a simple framework for my focus in the coming year. Four priorities: education, compliance, product and services, and—fourth—“ignore FUD, fake news, attacks, etc.” The phrasing was casual, almost thrown in as an afterthought. I did not anticipate that this fourth item would become the most memorable part of the post, or that the number itself would take on a life beyond my original intention.

The crypto community seized on the number with characteristic enthusiasm. “4” became a meme, a shorthand, a rallying cry. When negative news appeared, users would flood the comments with the digit. When I posted anything at all, the replies would include “4” regardless of relevance. The symbol had escaped its context, becoming something I no longer fully controlled.

I found this amusing at first. The community’s ability to turn anything into a meme is one of crypto’s defining traits. It reflects a culture that does not take itself too seriously and that finds humor in adversity. Personally, my meme equation is simple: meme = community + fun. The community around 4 impressed me, and I joined the joke, posting selfies with four fingers raised. I came to love that community and started using 4 more often.

But I also began to worry about what the symbol was becoming. “Ignore FUD” is good advice for individual focus, but it is dangerous as a collective ethos. Not all criticism is FUD. Not all negative news is fake. Some concerns

are legitimate. Some warnings should be heeded. When “4” becomes the automatic response to any challenge, it stops being a tool for focus and becomes a mechanism for dismissal.

I saw this dynamic play out repeatedly. A journalist would publish a story raising legitimate questions about our compliance practices, and the community response would be “4”—ignore it, it’s FUD. A regulator would express concerns about consumer protection, and the response would be “4”—ignore it, they’re just protecting banks. A competitor would point out a genuine vulnerability, and the response would be “4”—ignore it, they’re just jealous.

The problem with this reflexive dismissal is that it prevents learning. If you automatically categorize all criticism as FUD, you lose the ability to distinguish between noise and signal. You build an immune system so aggressive that it attacks not just pathogens but also vaccines. You protect yourself from false alarms but also from real ones.

I want to be clear about what I originally meant by “ignore FUD.” I meant that I, personally, would try to spend less time responding to every negative headline. I meant that I would focus on building rather than debating. I did not mean that all criticism should be dismissed. I did not mean that concerns should not be addressed. The distinction between ignoring noise and ignoring problems is crucial, and the “4” meme often blurred this distinction.

The original English phrase I used was specific: “Ignore FUD, fake news, attacks, etc.” Each word had meaning. FUD—fear, uncertainty, doubt—refers to the deliberate spreading of negative information to manipulate markets. Fake news refers to demonstrably false claims presented as fact. Attacks refer to personal or professional attacks not grounded in substantive criticism. The “etc.” was meant to cover similar categories of unproductive negativity. It was not meant to cover all criticism, all regulatory concerns, all competitive analysis.

But symbols, once released, are interpreted by their users, not their creators. The community took “4” and made it mean what they needed it to mean. For some, it was a genuine tool for maintaining perspective

during volatile markets. For others, it was a way to shut down uncomfortable conversations. For still others, it was simply a joke, a way to participate in crypto culture. All of these uses coexisted, and I had limited ability to influence which predominated.

What I learned from this experience is that communication in public is not about intention. It is about reception. You can carefully craft a message with precise meaning, but once it enters the public sphere, it will be interpreted through filters you do not control. The gap between what you meant and what is heard is not a failure of communication. It is the nature of communication at scale.

This has implications for how I think about public statements now. I am more cautious. I recognize that anything I say can be excerpted, memed, weaponized, or misunderstood. This caution is sometimes criticized as excessive—why not just speak freely? But the criticism ignores the reality of my position. Words from the CEO of the world’s largest crypto exchange carry weight. They move markets. They influence behavior. The responsibility that comes with this influence requires care.

I also learned that humor can be a double-edged sword. The “4” meme was funny. It diffused tension. It built community. But it also trivialized serious issues. When regulators are investigating your company, responding with a number and a selfie can be read as dismissive, even if that is not the intent. The same playfulness that makes crypto culture appealing can also make it appear immature to outsiders.

The question I have struggled with is how to maintain the lightness that I believe is important while also conveying the seriousness that the situation demands. I do not have a perfect answer. I have tried to be more explicit about when I am joking and when I am not. I have tried to follow “4” posts with more substantive responses when the underlying issues warrant them. I have tried to model the distinction between ignoring noise and ignoring problems.

But I also recognize that my modeling has limited effect. The community will use “4” however they choose. The symbol has become independent of its originator. This is how culture works. You contribute to it, but you do not

control it.

What I hope readers of this memoir will understand is that “4” was never meant to be a philosophy. It was a personal productivity hack that became something larger than intended. If there is a lesson in it, the lesson is about the limits of control—how even simple messages can escape their context, how symbols can be repurposed, how the gap between what you say and what is heard can never be fully closed.

The serious ending to this humorous opening is this: do not let the meme prevent you from listening. Ignore FUD, yes. But do not ignore feedback. Do not ignore warnings. Do not ignore the concerns of users, regulators, or critics who raise legitimate issues. The ability to distinguish between noise and signal is one of the most important skills in any field. “4” was meant to help with that distinction, not replace it. If it has sometimes been used to replace it, that is a use I did not intend and do not endorse.

The number remains a part of crypto culture. I still see it in my replies. I still occasionally use it myself, though more sparingly now. It reminds me of both the power and the peril of public communication—the ability to create shared symbols, and the inability to control what they become.

CFTC Lawsuit: First Time Written into a Complaint

The CFTC press release arrived on March 27, 2023, with a headline that felt both momentous and strangely formal: “CFTC Charges Binance and CEO Changpeng Zhao with Willful Evasion of Federal Law.” I had been mentioned in articles before. I had been the subject of investigations, rumors, speculation. But this was different. This was a government agency, in official language, placing me in a legal document that would enter the permanent record.

Reading the complaint was a disorienting experience. I recognized some of the facts described. I recognized many of the communications quoted. But the narrative constructed from these elements was not one I recognized. It was a story of deliberate evasion, of calculated disregard for U.S. law, of profit pursued at the expense of compliance. This was not how I experienced the events described. But my experience was not what mattered. What mattered was what could be proven, what could be argued, what a court might find.

The regulatory language of the complaint had a quality I had not encountered before. It did not discuss vision. It did not acknowledge the complexity of building a global business in an uncertain regulatory environment. It did not engage with the questions of how to interpret laws written decades before cryptocurrency existed. It simply stated: these are the rules, you

broke them, here is the evidence.

The allegations were extensive. Operating an unregistered exchange. Offering commodity derivatives to U.S. customers without proper registration. Failing to implement adequate anti-money laundering procedures. Knowingly evading U.S. regulations. The complaint cited Signal messages, internal documents, customer communications—all assembled into a case that portrayed Binance as a company that knew what the law required and chose to ignore it.

I need to address this portrayal directly. Did we know that U.S. regulations were complex? Yes. Did we know that our platform was accessible to U.S. users despite our terms of service prohibiting them? Yes. Did we discuss how to address these issues? Yes. But the gap between knowing about a problem and deliberately evading the law is significant, and I do not believe we crossed it. We were trying to navigate a gray area, not operate outside the law entirely.

The complaint's use of my Signal messages was particularly striking. Messages I had sent years earlier, in what I believed to be private communications, were now public evidence. I had encouraged the use of Signal for security reasons—I believed, and still believe, that encrypted communication is a legitimate protection against surveillance. But the CFTC presented this as evidence of intent to hide wrongdoing. Security consciousness had become evidence of consciousness of guilt.

This transformation of normal behavior into suspicious activity is a feature of regulatory complaints, not a bug. When investigators look backward with knowledge of outcomes, ordinary decisions can appear nefarious. A message about restricting U.S. access becomes evidence of knowing violation. A discussion about compliance gaps becomes evidence of deliberate neglect. The same facts support multiple interpretations, and the complaint chooses the most damaging one.

I do not blame the CFTC for this. Their job is to enforce the law as they understand it. They gathered evidence, constructed a narrative, and presented their case. This is how the system works. But I do want to acknowledge the psychological weight of being on the receiving end. To

have your words quoted back at you, stripped of context, arranged to support a story of wrongdoing—it creates a feeling of powerlessness that is difficult to describe.

The complaint also highlighted something I had not fully appreciated: the gap between how we saw ourselves and how regulators saw us. We thought of Binance as a technology company building infrastructure for a new financial system. The CFTC saw us as a derivatives exchange subject to decades-old regulations. Both perspectives have merit. But they lead to very different conclusions about what is required.

I responded publicly the day after the complaint was filed. I stated that Binance had cooperated with the CFTC for over two years and that we disagreed with many of the characterizations in the complaint. I noted that the filing seemed to contain “incomplete recitation of facts.” This was careful language, vetted by lawyers, designed to neither admit nor deny the allegations while signaling our intent to defend ourselves.

What I could not say publicly was how heavy the complaint felt. Not just its legal implications, though those were significant. But its weight as a document, as a statement by a powerful government agency that my conduct had been found wanting according to standards I had not fully understood. The feeling was not guilt, exactly. It was more like the recognition that I had been operating in a system whose rules I had not fully grasped, and that this ignorance was now being treated as culpable.

The months following the complaint were consumed by legal process. Meetings with lawyers. Review of documents. Strategy sessions about how to respond. The business continued—users traded, products launched, the industry moved forward—but my attention was increasingly consumed by the case. This was its own form of punishment, regardless of the eventual outcome.

I want to be clear that I am not complaining about being held accountable. If we violated regulations, we should face consequences. The question is what regulations we violated and whether those regulations were clear at the time. This is the kind of question that courts exist to answer. But the process of getting to that answer is itself consequential, regardless of the

final judgment.

What I learned from being written into a complaint is that regulatory language has its own logic, its own way of constructing reality. It does not care about your intentions, only about whether your actions fit within its categories. It does not acknowledge the complexity of building in an uncertain environment. It simply applies its framework and produces its conclusions.

This is not a criticism of the CFTC. They are doing their job. But it is a recognition that the job they are doing is different from the job I was doing. I was trying to build something new. They were trying to apply something old. The collision between these two projects was inevitable, and I was naive to think we could avoid it indefinitely.

The complaint changed how I thought about my position. I was no longer just a CEO building a company. I was a defendant in a legal action that could result in significant penalties, possibly even personal liability. This shift in identity was not welcome, but it was real. I had to adjust my thinking, my behavior, my expectations about the future.

What I tried to maintain throughout was a sense of proportion. The complaint was serious, but it was not the end of the world. Binance would continue operating. Users would continue trading. The industry would continue evolving. The legal process would run its course. This perspective did not eliminate the stress, but it helped manage it.

The CFTC lawsuit was the first time I was written into a formal complaint by a U.S. regulator. It would not be the last. But the first time has a particular quality—the shock of recognition that the abstract possibility of regulatory action has become concrete reality. That recognition stays with you, changes you, makes you see the world differently than you did before.

SEC Lawsuit: Another Language in Washington

The SEC announcement came on June 5, 2023, two months after the CFTC complaint. Thirteen charges. The language was different from the CFTC's—different agency, different statutory framework, different set of concerns—but the underlying message was similar: Binance had operated outside the law, and I was personally responsible.

Reading the SEC's core allegations, I felt something different than I had with the CFTC complaint. The CFTC case had felt like a regulatory disagreement—serious, consequential, but ultimately about the interpretation of commodity derivatives regulations. The SEC case felt more fundamental. It was about whether the products we offered were securities. It was about whether our entire business model was built on selling unregistered investment contracts. It was, in a sense, about whether what we had built was legitimate at all.

The SEC's allegations can be summarized as follows: Binance operated as an unregistered securities exchange, broker, and clearing agency. We offered and sold securities without registration, including BNB, BUSD, and various other tokens. We engaged in fraudulent activities, including commingling customer funds and misrepresenting our compliance controls. We allowed U.S. customers to access our international platform despite claiming to block

them. And I personally controlled both Binance and Binance.US despite claims of independence.

The last allegation struck at something deeper than regulatory compliance. It struck at identity. The SEC was saying that I was not who I claimed to be—not a builder of infrastructure, not a technologist creating new financial rails, but an operator of an unregistered securities business who had misled investors about the nature of his operations. The accusation was not just that we had broken rules. It was that our entire story was false.

I felt anger reading this. Not the hot anger of immediate reaction, but a colder, more sustained feeling. The SEC was not just challenging our conduct. It was challenging our narrative, our self-understanding, the meaning we had constructed around our work. And it was doing so using a framework that felt fundamentally mismatched to what we had actually built.

The securities laws the SEC cited were written in the 1930s. They were designed for a world of stock certificates and broker-dealers, of centralized exchanges with physical trading floors. Applying them to cryptocurrency required analogies—tokens are like stocks, staking is like investment contracts, decentralized finance is like traditional finance but with different names. These analogies were contestable. They were being contested. But the SEC acted as if they were obvious.

What made me angry was not the enforcement action itself. I understood that the SEC had a mandate to protect investors and that they viewed crypto as a space rife with fraud and manipulation. What made me angry was the certainty with which they applied their framework, the refusal to acknowledge that the analogies might not fit, the implication that anyone who disagreed was either stupid or criminal.

I had spent years building something I believed in. I had made genuine sacrifices—sold my house, worked endless hours, navigated regulatory uncertainty that would have driven less committed people to safer careers. I had done this because I believed cryptocurrency could expand financial access, reduce the power of intermediaries, create opportunities for people excluded from traditional finance. The SEC's complaint did not acknowledge any of this. It simply recited violations.

The anger was complicated by recognition that some of the allegations had merit. Our controls for preventing U.S. users from accessing the international platform were imperfect. Our communications about the relationship between Binance and Binance.US could have been clearer. We had grown fast, and in growing fast, we had made mistakes. I was not angry because I believed we were flawless. I was angry because the complaint treated our flaws as evidence of fraud, our growth as evidence of greed, our innovation as evidence of evasion.

There is a particular feeling that comes from being defined by someone else's language. You spend years constructing a narrative about who you are and what you do. You believe this narrative. You live it. And then a government agency produces a document that tells a different story, using words you would never choose, emphasizing facts you would not highlight, drawing conclusions you do not accept. The document has power. It can result in fines, penalties, restrictions on your activities. But its deeper power is definitional. It says: this is who you are, regardless of who you think you are.

I resisted this definition. I still resist it. But I have come to understand that resistance is not enough. The SEC's language has its own reality. It shapes how judges think, how legislators act, how the public understands crypto. Whether I agree with it or not, I must engage with it. I must learn to speak it, even as I try to change it.

The months following the SEC lawsuit were consumed by legal strategy. The CFTC case was still pending. Now we had a second front. The allegations overlapped in some areas and diverged in others. We needed to respond to both while continuing to operate the business, maintaining user confidence, and planning for a future that suddenly seemed much less certain.

I tried to channel my anger into productive action. Anger can be motivating if it is directed properly. I focused on what we could control: improving our compliance systems, clarifying our corporate structures, building the kind of transparency that would make future allegations harder to sustain. I could not change the SEC's framework, but I could change how we operated within it.

But I also allowed myself to feel the anger, to acknowledge its validity. I was being accused of things I did not believe I had done. My work was being characterized in ways I found distorting. The system I was operating in seemed designed to produce this outcome—regulators with broad discretion, laws written for different technologies, incentives that encouraged enforcement over dialogue. These were legitimate grievances, and acknowledging them helped me maintain my sense of self.

What I tried to avoid was letting the anger become bitterness. Bitterness is anger that has lost its purpose, that circles back on itself, that poisons the person feeling it more than anyone else. I had seen this in others who had faced regulatory action—the endless relitigation of grievances, the inability to move forward, the transformation of legitimate complaint into consuming resentment. I did not want this for myself.

The SEC lawsuit taught me something about power. The SEC has it. I do not, at least not in the same way. They can define categories, bring charges, shape markets. I can only respond, defend, try to persuade. This asymmetry is real, and pretending it does not exist would be foolish. But I also learned that power is not everything. The SEC can define, but they cannot control how their definitions are received. They can charge, but they cannot determine the outcome. They can shape markets, but they cannot eliminate the demand for what crypto offers.

The fire I felt reading the SEC's complaint was real. It was justified. But it was not the whole story. The whole story included the users who continued to trust us, the developers who continued to build on our platform, the industry that continued to grow despite regulatory pressure. The whole story included the possibility that we would prevail in court, that the framework would evolve, that the future would be different from the present.

I write this not to dismiss the SEC's concerns. They have a job to do, and some of their concerns are valid. I write it to capture what it felt like to be on the receiving end of their enforcement action—the anger, the sense of being defined by language you do not accept, the struggle to maintain your sense of self in the face of powerful institutional opposition. These feelings are part of the story too. They are part of my story.

Crypto Winter

Winter does not announce itself with a single event. It arrives gradually, a series of cold days that eventually convince you the season has changed. The crypto winter of 2022 was similar. It did not begin with Terra's collapse in May, though that was the most dramatic moment. It began earlier, with the slow withdrawal of liquidity, the gradual recognition that the pandemic-era excesses could not continue, the accumulating evidence that many of the projects celebrated in 2021 had no sustainable foundation.

I remember the feeling in early 2022. The market was still near its highs, but the momentum had shifted. The Federal Reserve had made clear its intention to raise rates. The easy money that had flowed into every speculative asset was being withdrawn. I wrote internal memos suggesting we prepare for a prolonged downturn. Not everyone believed it would come. The bull market psychology was still strong—every dip was a buying opportunity, every correction was temporary, the only direction was up.

The Terra collapse changed this psychology permanently. In May 2022, Terra's algorithmic stablecoin UST lost its peg to the dollar. The mechanism that was supposed to maintain the peg—a mint-and-burn relationship with Terra's native token LUNA—entered a death spiral. As UST holders rushed to exit, more LUNA was minted, diluting its value, which further undermined confidence in UST, which accelerated the exit. Within days, approximately \$60 billion in value had been destroyed. Reuters coverage from the time

documented the speed of the collapse: “The collapse of Terra’s token set off panic across cryptocurrency markets creating a ‘run on the bank’ resulting in over \$450 billion in cryptocurrency asset value being destroyed between May and June.”

The immediate trigger was a large withdrawal from Anchor Protocol, Terra’s lending platform, which offered an unsustainable 19.5% yield on UST deposits. On May 7, two large addresses withdrew approximately 375 million UST. This started the depegging. But the vulnerability had been building for months. The yield was subsidized by Terra’s treasury, not generated by lending activity. The subsidy was running out. The system was fragile, and the fragility was known to those who looked closely.

What followed was contagion. Three Arrows Capital, one of the largest crypto hedge funds, had significant exposure to Terra. When Terra collapsed, 3AC faced margin calls it could not meet. Its lenders included Celsius Network, Voyager Digital, BlockFi—names that would soon become synonymous with the winter’s casualties. Celsius froze withdrawals on June 12. Three Arrows Capital entered liquidation on June 27. Voyager filed for bankruptcy on July 5. Celsius followed on July 13. The dominoes fell in sequence, each collapse revealing new interconnections, new leverage, new fragility.

The total market capitalization of cryptocurrency fell from over \$3 trillion in November 2021 to under \$1 trillion by June 2022. Bitcoin declined from \$69,000 to below \$18,000. Ethereum fell from \$4,800 to below \$900. The correlation between assets approached one—everything moved together, suggesting that the selling was driven by forced liquidations rather than project-specific concerns. When leveraged positions are unwound, distinctions between assets disappear. Everything is sold to meet margin calls.

I watched this unfold with a mixture of horror and grim recognition. Horror at the human cost—retail investors who had believed the promises of stable yields, who had put savings into products they did not understand, who were now facing losses they could not afford. Recognition because I had seen similar patterns before, in traditional finance, in earlier crypto cycles.

The details were different, but the dynamics were familiar. Leverage builds during booms. Fragility accumulates invisibly. The trigger that reveals the fragility is often unpredictable. The collapse, once started, is difficult to stop.

Binance was not immune to the winter's effects. We experienced significant outflows as users moved to self-custody. Our BNB token declined with the broader market. The projects building on BNB Chain faced the same funding challenges as projects everywhere. But we survived when others did not. I have spent considerable time thinking about why.

The first reason is that our business model was simple. We charged fees for trading. We did not promise yields we could not generate. We did not lend customer funds to generate returns. We did not take proprietary positions that could be wiped out by market movements. This simplicity was not accidental. I have always been skeptical of complexity in finance. The more moving parts a system has, the more ways it can fail. Our business had few moving parts.

The second reason is that we had built reserves. We did not operate at the edge of solvency. We maintained significant holdings of major cryptocurrencies, and we did not leverage these holdings. When the market declined, our reserves declined in value, but they did not disappear. We could meet all withdrawal requests. This sounds like a low bar—of course an exchange should be able to meet withdrawal requests—but the winter revealed how many institutions had failed to clear it.

The third reason is luck. We had no direct exposure to Terra. We had not lent to 3AC. We had not offered the yield products that collapsed. These absences were partly the result of conservative risk management and partly the result of fortunate timing. If we had been approached to participate in Terra's ecosystem at the right moment, we might have said yes. If 3AC had asked for a loan when our balance sheet was flush, we might have extended credit. The fact that we did not was not entirely the result of wisdom.

The winter taught me three lessons that I carry with me.

First: do not worship scale. The institutions that failed in 2022 were among the largest in crypto. Three Arrows Capital managed billions. Celsius held

over \$11 billion in assets. Terra reached a \$40 billion market capitalization. Size provided no protection against collapse. In some cases, it accelerated it—large institutions had more leverage, more interconnectedness, more distance between their public image and their actual condition. Scale is not safety. Scale is often the opposite of safety.

Second: do not worship relationships. The crypto industry in 2021 was built on relationships—founders who knew each other from earlier cycles, investors who had backed multiple projects, executives who moved between companies. These relationships created trust, but they also created blind spots. People believed in Terra because they believed in Do Kwon. They believed in 3AC because they believed in Su Zhu and Kyle Davies. When the relationships proved to be based on incomplete information, the trust evaporated quickly. Due diligence matters more than connections.

Third: do not worship judgment over reality. Many smart people believed in Terra. Many sophisticated investors held 3AC. Many experienced analysts thought Celsius was sound. Their judgment was wrong. The winter revealed that intelligence and experience provide no immunity to cognitive biases, to the desire to believe in good stories, to the fear of missing out that drives participation in bubbles. Reality is the final arbiter. When reality conflicts with judgment, reality wins.

The crypto winter of 2022 was not the first. It will not be the last. Markets cycle between greed and fear, between excess and correction, between belief and disillusionment. What matters is what is built during the winter. The projects that survive are those with genuine utility, sustainable economics, and the financial reserves to weather the downturn. The founders who survive are those who remain focused on building rather than promoting, who use the quiet period to improve their products, who recognize that winter is not the end but a phase.

I continued working through the winter. The regulatory pressure intensified, adding legal challenges to market challenges. But the fundamentals of what we were building remained sound. Users still needed to trade. Developers still needed infrastructure. The vision of a more open financial system remained valid, even if the path to it was longer and more difficult

than we had hoped.

By early 2023, there were signs that the worst had passed. Bitcoin had found a floor. New projects were launching. The builders who had survived were stronger for the experience. The winter had cleared out the excesses of 2021, leaving behind a foundation that was more solid, if less exciting.

I do not romanticize the winter. People lost money. People lost faith. Some left the industry permanently. The damage was real and should not be minimized. But I also do not despair about it. Winter is part of the cycle. It is necessary. It clears the ground for new growth.

The three lessons I learned—about scale, relationships, and judgment—are not unique to crypto. They apply to any field where humans make decisions under uncertainty. The winter taught them to me in a particularly vivid way, through the collapse of institutions I knew, the failure of people I respected, the recognition of my own good fortune in avoiding their mistakes.

Crypto winter is cold. It is hard. It is necessary. And it ends.

FTX's Three Days: LOI, Due Diligence, and Exit

November 8, 2022. I remember the timestamp. 9:47 AM. A message arrived that would compress three years of industry drama into seventy-two hours.

Sam was asking for help.

The number was \$8 billion. Not a typo. Eight billion dollars in customer funds, unaccounted for, evaporated somewhere between trading algorithms and balance sheets that didn't balance. I stared at the screen. The same screen where I'd watched a thousand charts move. This one didn't move. It just sat there, demanding a decision.

I called a meeting. Small. Trusted. The kind of meeting where nobody takes notes because nobody wants notes to exist. The room filled with people who had been with me through crises before—the 2019 hack, the 2021 regulatory challenges, the countless moments when the company had teetered on the edge and we'd pulled it back. They knew my rhythms, my tells, the way I processed information under pressure.

"We can do this," someone said. "We're the only ones big enough."

That was the logic. Simple arithmetic of survival. If FTX collapsed, the contagion would spread. Not metaphorically. Actually. Every exchange would face withdrawals. Every lender would freeze. The industry we'd spent five years building would unravel in weeks. The trust we'd worked so hard to

establish would evaporate like the \$8 billion that had already disappeared.

I asked questions. The kind of questions that reveal whether you understand the problem or are just reacting to it. How liquid was FTX, really? What assets did they hold? What liabilities were hidden? Who else knew about this? How long had Sam known?

The answers were incomplete. They always are in a crisis. But they were enough to suggest that the situation was dire, that without intervention, FTX would fail within days, and that the failure would cascade through the entire ecosystem.

The pressure was immediate and immense. Every decision felt like walking on thin ice. One wrong step and we could be pulled into the abyss with them. But standing still wasn't an option either. The ice was cracking regardless of what we did.

I signed the letter of intent at 2:15 PM. Non-binding. A handshake in digital form. Reuters would later publish a timeline showing how the plan unfolded—how we announced intent to acquire, how markets briefly stabilized, how hope lasted approximately six hours before the next shoe dropped. The headline would read “Binance to Acquire FTX” and for a brief moment, it looked like we might actually prevent the disaster everyone feared.

I didn't feel hopeful. I felt like I was walking on ice that was already cracking.

The due diligence began that evening. Teams deployed. Data requested. I stayed in my office, monitoring feeds, answering questions I didn't want to answer. The first reports came back within hours. They were worse than expected.

“There's a hole,” the analyst said. “Not a gap. A hole.”

I asked for specifics. The specifics made me close my laptop and look out the window for ten minutes. I don't remember what I saw. I remember thinking about the customers. The ones who'd trusted FTX with their savings, their trading profits, their belief that this system was different from the old one. The ones who didn't know that their funds had been moved, used as collateral, lent to a trading firm that happened to share an office and

a founder.

By November 9, the picture had sharpened into something grotesque. Customer funds had been moved. Used as collateral. Lent to Alameda Research, the trading firm that shared more than just an office with FTX—they shared leadership, vision, and apparently, a complete disregard for the boundaries that are supposed to separate customer assets from company operations.

The walls between entities weren't just thin. They were imaginary. The separation that was supposed to protect customers had never existed. The compliance that was supposed to ensure accountability had been treated as optional. The entire structure was built on foundations of sand, and the tide was coming in fast.

I called Sam. The conversation lasted four minutes. I asked direct questions. I got answers that weren't answers. I heard confidence in his voice, the same confidence I'd heard a hundred times at conferences, in interviews, in the assurance that everything was fine, that the math worked, that the skeptics just didn't understand.

I understood now. That was the problem.

The decision to exit came on November 10. Not from me alone. From the team that had spent forty-eight hours staring into an abyss and realizing we couldn't fill it. Not with \$8 billion. Not with any amount. The hole wasn't financial. It was structural. A company built on foundations that weren't foundations at all.

We announced the withdrawal publicly. Reuters documented the reversal—the letter of intent becoming a letter of regret. Markets reacted accordingly. FTX filed for bankruptcy within hours. The contagion I'd feared began spreading anyway.

I didn't sleep that night. I sat in a chair and watched the sun rise over a city that didn't know yet how much would change. The industry I'd helped build was entering a winter that would freeze more than prices. It would freeze trust. Freeze optimism. Freeze the belief that we were building something better.

The three days taught me something I didn't want to learn. That some-

times the right decision is the one that saves you from the wrong one. That due diligence isn't bureaucracy—it's the difference between responsibility and complicity. That walking away can be braver than staying.

But it also taught me about limits. About the gap between what we can do and what we should do. About the weight of being big enough to matter, and the responsibility that comes with that weight.

In the months that followed, I would be asked why we even considered the acquisition. Why we signed the LOI. Why we let hope override caution for even seventy-two hours.

The answer is simple. Because I believed, in those first hours, that we could prevent something worse. That the industry needed a stabilizing force, and we were positioned to provide it. That sometimes you have to act before you have all the information, because waiting means watching everything burn.

I was wrong about what we could prevent. But I wasn't wrong about why we tried.

The ice cracked. We didn't fall through. That was luck as much as judgment. The due diligence that revealed FTX's true state also revealed how close we'd come to being pulled into the hole with them. How a well-intentioned rescue could have become a shared catastrophe.

I think about those three days often. Not with pride. Not exactly with shame. With the recognition that every decision at scale carries consequences you can't fully predict. That good intentions aren't protection against bad outcomes. That the line between hero and fool is drawn in retrospect, by people who weren't in the room when the decision had to be made.

The LOI expired unfulfilled. The due diligence became evidence. The exit became history.

I was still standing. That would have to be enough.

But standing wasn't the same as being unaffected. The FTX collapse changed everything. It changed how regulators viewed the industry. It changed how users viewed exchanges. It changed how I viewed my own responsibilities. The three days were a pivot point, a moment when the

trajectory of the entire space shifted, and I was there, at the center, making decisions that would be analyzed and criticized for years to come.

The analysis would come later. In those seventy-two hours, there was only the moment. The ice. The cracking. The decision to step back before the fall.

Every decision felt like walking on thin ice. The weight of each choice pressing down, threatening to break through to the cold water below. I had to move carefully, deliberately, knowing that one misstep could send us all plunging.

The urgency was suffocating. Information coming in faster than it could be processed. Decisions required before all the facts were known. The classic crisis scenario where action and inaction both carried risks that couldn't be fully calculated.

I relied on my team. On their expertise, their judgment, their ability to see patterns I might miss. We worked through the night, the second night, fueled by caffeine and adrenaline and the knowledge that millions of people were depending on us to make the right call.

The right call. As if there were such a thing. As if the complexity of the situation could be reduced to a binary choice between right and wrong.

What we faced was a spectrum of wrong choices, each with different costs. Acquire FTX and potentially inherit its problems. Walk away and watch the contagion spread. Try to help in limited ways that might satisfy no one.

We chose the middle path. The LOI as gesture, as possibility, as time to understand what we were really dealing with. And when understanding came, we chose to walk away.

Some called it betrayal. Said we'd used the LOI to destroy a competitor. Others called it wisdom. Said we'd avoided a trap that would have destroyed us both.

The truth is simpler and more complicated. We tried to help. We discovered we couldn't. We withdrew. The motivations were genuine even if the outcome was messy.

The three days haunt me still. Not because I think we made the wrong decisions, but because I know how close we came to making different ones.

How easily we could have been drawn into the hole, how narrowly we escaped, how much depended on factors we couldn't control.

That is the nature of crisis. The illusion of control dissolves, and you are left with your best judgment in moments when judgment is most compromised.

We survived. That is the fact. The interpretation of how and why will continue to evolve, shaped by outcomes and narratives and the endless revision of history.

I am at peace with what we did. Not satisfied, but at peace. We acted with the information we had, adjusted when new information emerged, and ultimately made the decision that preserved what we could preserve.

The LOI, the due diligence, the exit. Three acts in a drama that continues to reverberate through the industry. I was there. I made the choices. I accept the consequences, whatever they may be.

Recovery Fund: Firefighting and Boundaries

The phone rang at 3 AM. Again.

In the weeks following FTX's collapse in November 2022, my sleep schedule had become a theoretical concept rather than a practice. The crypto industry was burning, and everyone seemed to think Binance had the fire hose.

I stared at the ceiling of my hotel room, the blue light of my phone illuminating the darkness. Another exchange was in trouble. Another founder asking for help. Another voice on the line expecting me to make a decision that could save—or destroy—their company.

This was the reality of being the largest player in a small, interconnected industry. When one domino falls, everyone holds their breath, wondering if they're next. And when you're the biggest domino, people assume you can stop the chain reaction.

I had announced the Industry Recovery Fund on November 14, 2022, via Twitter. The response was immediate and overwhelming. Within hours, our inboxes were flooded with requests. Projects that were “otherwise strong,

but in a liquidity crisis”—that was the criteria I had set. But what did that actually mean?

The truth is, I didn’t fully know.

The morning after another sleepless night, I sat in a conference room with our Binance Labs team. The whiteboard was covered with names, numbers, and question marks. So many question marks.

“How do we decide who qualifies?” someone asked.

I didn’t have a good answer. The criteria I had tweeted — “otherwise strong, but in a liquidity crisis” — sounded reasonable in theory. In practice, it was hopelessly vague. What constituted “strong”? What defined a “liquidity crisis” versus insolvency? And who was I to make those judgments?

This was the fundamental problem with the position we found ourselves in. Binance hadn’t asked to become the industry’s backstop. But when FTX fell, the vacuum was immediate and terrifying. Someone had to do something. And because we were the largest, most visible, most capitalized exchange, that someone became us.

I thought about the traditional financial system. When banks fail, there are mechanisms—deposit insurance, central banks, regulatory frameworks that exist precisely for these moments. Crypto had none of that. We had built an alternative financial system without building alternative safety nets.

Was a recovery fund the right answer? I genuinely didn’t know. But doing nothing felt worse.

The calls kept coming. Founders I had known for years. Founders I had never met. Venture capitalists acting as intermediaries, trying to package deals, trying to create urgency where there was only anxiety.

Each conversation followed a similar pattern. First, the founder would explain why their project was fundamentally sound. The technology worked. The user base was real. The tokenomics were solid—if you looked past the current market conditions. Then would come the liquidity problem. A lender had pulled credit lines. A major investor had withdrawn. The market had turned, and they needed bridge capital to survive until the inevitable recovery.

I listened to all of them. I said no to most of them.

This was the part nobody saw. The part that kept me awake at night. Every “no” felt like a death sentence for someone’s dream. Every “yes” carried the risk of throwing good money after bad, of rewarding failure, of creating moral hazard that would haunt the industry for years.

There was no clean answer. There never is in a crisis.

The questions that haunted me weren’t financial. They were philosophical. Ethical. Existential.

Who should be saved? By what right did I—or Binance—get to decide? Did saving a project equal endorsing it? If we provided capital to a company that later failed, would we be blamed for giving false hope? If we refused, would we be blamed for letting a viable project die?

I thought about the traditional concept of “too big to fail.” In traditional finance, governments made these decisions. Elected officials, regulatory bodies, institutions with democratic legitimacy. In crypto, there was no such legitimacy. There was only market position and available capital.

Was that enough? I wasn’t sure.

What I did know was this: the industry was at an inflection point. The wild west era was ending. Regulators were circling. The public was watching. How we handled this crisis would shape perceptions of crypto for years to come.

If we let everything burn, we would prove the critics right. Crypto was a casino. A Ponzi scheme. A house of cards that deserved to collapse.

If we saved everything, we would prove something else. That crypto was too interconnected to function as a true market. That failure wasn’t allowed. That the largest players would always step in, creating implicit guarantees that distorted risk-taking.

Neither outcome felt right.

I found myself thinking about boundaries. Personal boundaries. Professional boundaries. The lines that separate responsible intervention from dangerous overreach.

In the early days of Binance, I had made a conscious decision not to invest in other exchanges. It created conflicts of interest. It blurred lines. If we invested in a competitor, were we supporting them or monitoring them?

Were we partners or potential acquirers?

Now those boundaries were being tested daily. The recovery fund wasn't about investing in competitors—it was about preventing systemic collapse. But the principle felt similar. Where did Binance end and the industry begin? What was our responsibility to the ecosystem versus our responsibility to our users and shareholders?

I kept coming back to the same uncomfortable truth: there was no clean philosophical framework for what we were doing. We were making it up as we went along, guided by instinct and incomplete information, hoping that our intentions mattered more than our inevitable mistakes.

By early 2023, the fund had deployed approximately \$30 million according to Bloomberg reporting. Far less than the \$1 billion we had initially pledged. Some saw this as a failure. As evidence that the fund was more PR than substance.

They weren't entirely wrong. The fund was partly PR. In a crisis, perception matters as much as reality. Announcing a billion-dollar fund sent a signal to the market: Binance was strong. The industry had a backstop. Panic was unnecessary.

But the slow deployment was also a feature, not a bug. We were being careful. Perhaps too careful. Every potential investment went through extensive due diligence. Every founder was scrutinized. Every deal was structured to protect Binance's interests while providing genuine help.

Was this the right approach? History will judge. What I can say is this: we didn't throw money at problems hoping they would go away. We tried to be disciplined. We tried to be responsible. We tried to balance the immediate need for stability against the long-term need for a healthy, functioning market where failure was possible.

The hardest part was the personal toll. Every founder who came to me with a desperate plea was a human being with employees, families, dreams. I had been that founder once. I knew what it felt like to bet everything on an idea and watch it crumble.

But I also knew what it felt like to build something real. Something sustainable. Something that could weather storms. And I had learned—

sometimes painfully—that not every dream deserves to survive. Markets work because they separate viable ideas from non-viable ones. Capital flows to projects that create value. It flees from projects that destroy it.

Interfering with that process, even with the best intentions, carries consequences. Saved companies that should have failed. Prolonged agony for projects that would eventually collapse anyway. Created expectations that would distort behavior in the next cycle.

I thought about all of this as I sat in meetings, reviewed proposals, made decisions that would shape lives and careers. There was no winning. Only different kinds of losing.

Looking back, the recovery fund taught me something important about leadership in a decentralized industry. In traditional finance, there are established protocols for crisis management. Central banks act as lenders of last resort. Governments provide backstops. The system is designed—imperfectly, but designed—to handle failure.

Crypto had none of that. We were building the plane while flying it, and sometimes the wings fell off mid-flight.

The recovery fund was an attempt to fill that gap. An imperfect, improvised, controversial attempt. But an attempt nonetheless.

Did it work? Depends on how you measure success. Did it prevent a worse collapse? Probably. Did it create moral hazard? Probably. Did it establish Binance as a de facto central bank for crypto? Maybe. Was that a good thing? I'm still not sure.

What I learned was this: boundaries matter. The line between helping and enabling is thinner than it appears. The difference between supporting the industry and controlling it is easy to cross without realizing. And the weight of deciding who lives and who dies—in a business sense—is heavier than anyone who hasn't carried it can imagine.

I set out to help. I hope I did more good than harm. But I'll never know for certain. That's the nature of decisions made in crisis. You act with incomplete information, accept the consequences, and hope that history is kind.

History isn't always kind. But it's always watching.

RECOVERY FUND: FIREFIGHTING AND BOUNDARIES

Sources: Bloomberg reporting on recovery fund deployment (October 2023); Fortune coverage of Binance recovery fund announcement (November 14, 2022); CZ Twitter posts from November 2022.

November 21, 2023: Guilty Plea, Resignation, and “Let It Go”

The date is fixed now. November 21, 2023. I will remember it the way people remember where they were when they heard news that changed everything.

I was in a conference room. Seattle. The same city where I’d started, in a way. Full circle, though circles imply completion and nothing about this felt complete.

The document in front of me had my name at the top. Below it, words I never expected to sign. Admission of failure. Acknowledgment of what I hadn’t done. What I should have done.

The DOJ settlement was \$4.3 billion. The largest corporate fine in the history of financial enforcement. A number that sounds abstract until you realize it represents every transaction, every user, every decision made over six years of building.

I signed.

The pen felt heavy. Not metaphorically. Actually. My hand moved slowly, deliberately, as if the speed of signing could affect the weight of what I was accepting.

Then I wrote the resignation letter.

“Today, I stepped down as CEO of Binance.”

Eleven words. Each one cost something.

The full text would be published, shared, analyzed by thousands of people who would never understand the hours that went into those paragraphs. The attempt to be clear without being defensive. To accept responsibility without accepting definitions I didn't believe were fair. To say goodbye to something I'd built from nothing.

"Admittedly, it was not easy to let go emotionally. But I knew it was the right thing to do."

That was true. Both parts. The emotion and the knowledge, running on parallel tracks that never quite converged.

"I made mistakes, and I must take responsibility."

Mistakes. The word is small for what it describes. It suggests miscalculation, error, the kind of thing that happens when you're not paying attention. But I had been paying attention. Just not to the right things. Not to the compliance frameworks that seemed bureaucratic until they weren't. Not to the regulatory relationships that seemed optional until they became existential.

"This is best for our community, for Binance, and for myself."

The order mattered. Community first. The millions of users who'd trusted the platform. Then Binance, the entity that would continue without me. Then myself. Last. As it should be.

But the line that would be quoted, analyzed, remembered came near the end:

"I am confident that Binance will continue to thrive and grow with the principles I instilled in it. It is time for me to let it walk and run."

"Let it walk and run."

I wrote that phrase. Chose it carefully. It meant something specific, something I couldn't fully explain in the letter's constrained format.

It meant I'd built something that didn't need me anymore. That was the goal, always. Systems that functioned independently of any individual. Processes that continued regardless of who was in charge. A company that could survive its founder's departure because the founder had designed it that way.

But it also meant something else. Something harder to admit.

It meant letting go of control. Of influence. Of the daily decisions that had structured my existence for six years. The product reviews, the strategic calls, the hiring decisions, the firefighting. The texture of a life organized around a single enterprise.

“Let it walk and run” meant accepting that my creation would evolve in directions I couldn’t predict. That new leadership would make choices I wouldn’t make. That the principles I’d instilled would be interpreted, adapted, perhaps even abandoned by people who hadn’t been there when those principles were formed.

The split feeling was constant. Protective instinct warring with acceptance. Wanting to shield the company from consequences while acknowledging that consequences were necessary. Believing in what we’d built while admitting that how we’d built it had been flawed.

I am not a person who dwells in contradiction comfortably. Engineers seek resolution. Code either runs or it doesn’t. Systems either work or they fail. The gray area is for debugging, not for living.

But November 21 was all gray area. The settlement was finalized. The fine was agreed. The resignation was submitted. And I sat in that conference room feeling both relieved and destroyed, both lighter and heavier than I’d felt in years.

The DOJ press release called it a “historic settlement.” The word “historic” felt like a verdict. Not just on my actions, but on the entire experiment of building financial infrastructure outside traditional frameworks. The message was clear: the old rules applied, even to the new world. Innovation didn’t grant immunity.

I understood that. Had understood it, intellectually, for months. But understanding and accepting are different muscles. One exercises the mind. The other exercises something deeper.

My team asked what I wanted to do next. I didn’t have an answer. For six years, the answer had always been obvious: build Binance, grow Binance, protect Binance. Now the question was open in a way I hadn’t experienced since before the company existed.

“Let it walk and run.”

The phrase echoed. I’d written it about Binance, but it applied to me too. I had to let myself walk and run. Into whatever came next. Without the structure that had defined my days, my decisions, my identity.

The public reaction was predictable in its range. Supporters called me a martyr, a scapegoat, a victim of regulatory overreach. Critics called me a criminal who got off easy, a fraud who should face prison, a symbol of everything wrong with crypto’s cowboy culture.

Both were wrong. Both were right. The truth doesn’t fit neatly into narratives constructed for public consumption.

What I had done was fail to build compliance systems commensurate with the scale of what we were operating. That failure had consequences. Real ones. The \$4.3 billion fine was the measurable consequence. The resignation was another. The damage to reputation, to trust, to the industry’s legitimacy—those were harder to quantify but no less real.

What I hadn’t done was steal. Hadn’t defrauded users. Hadn’t built a house of cards designed to enrich me at others’ expense. The distinction mattered to me, even if it didn’t matter to everyone else.

November 21 ended. The sun set on Seattle, rose on a new day. Binance continued operating. Users continued trading. The world continued turning.

I was no longer CEO. The title I’d held longer than any other in my life, gone. The identity I’d constructed around it, dissolved. What remained was a person who had built something significant, made significant mistakes, and was now facing the question of who to be next.

“Let it walk and run.”

The words were about Binance. They were also about me. About accepting that control is an illusion we construct to feel safe, and that real growth requires releasing it. About trusting that what you’ve built is sturdy enough to survive without you. About trusting that you are sturdy enough to survive without what you’ve built.

I am still learning that trust. Still learning to walk and run without the structure that carried me for so long. The lesson of November 21 is that endings are also beginnings, even when the beginning looks like emptiness.

Especially then.

The emptiness was real. The days that followed were strange, unstructured, without the urgency that had driven me for years. I woke without meetings to attend. I made decisions that affected only myself. I was, for the first time in a long time, simply a person.

It would take time to learn what that meant. To discover who I was without the title, the company, the constant demands of leadership. To find purpose in a life that no longer had a built-in mission.

“Let it walk and run.”

The phrase became a mantra. A reminder that release is not failure. That letting go is sometimes the strongest thing you can do. That the measure of what you’ve built is not how much it needs you, but how well it functions without you.

Binance was walking. Running, even. Growing, adapting, evolving under new leadership. The principles I’d instilled were being tested, refined, applied to challenges I couldn’t have predicted.

And I was learning to walk too. Step by uncertain step. Into a future I couldn’t see clearly, guided by values I was still discovering.

November 21 was an ending. But it was also a beginning. The start of a different kind of journey, one that would teach me things I couldn’t have learned while I was still running the company.

The settlement was paid. The resignation was accepted. The company moved on.

And so did I. Slowly. Uncertainly. But moving.

The fractured feeling persisted. Heavy, short, hard. Minimal explanation possible for what I was experiencing. The gap between what I felt and what I could express.

I had failed. That was the fact. The interpretation of how and why would be debated endlessly, but the fact remained. I had built something significant and I had failed to build it properly. The consequences were mine to bear.

“Let it walk and run.”

The words were the best I could do. An attempt to capture something that couldn’t be fully captured. The complexity of wanting to protect what you’ve built while accepting that you can’t. The pain of separation mixed with the

relief of release.

I am still processing November 21. Still understanding what it meant, what it means, what it will mean as time passes and perspective shifts.

But I know this: I did what I believed was right. Not easy, not comfortable, not without cost. But right. For the company. For the community. For myself.

That has to be enough.

Richard Teng and Handover: I Handed Over the Keys

The announcement came on November 21, the same day as my resignation. Richard Teng would become CEO. Media reports described him as a former regulator, a steady hand, someone who could navigate the compliance landscape that had become my undoing.

All true. But incomplete.

Richard had been with Binance since 2021. Head of Regional Markets, then broader responsibilities. I'd watched him work, watched him build relationships I'd failed to build, watched him approach problems with a patience I sometimes lacked.

He was the right choice. I knew that when I recommended him to the board. Know it still.

But knowing and feeling are different countries, and I was traveling between them without a map.

The handover process took weeks. Not the public transition—that was a single announcement, a press release, a changing of the guard captured in headlines. The real handover happened in meetings, in documents, in the gradual transfer of access and authority that nobody sees but everyone depends on.

I gave Richard the keys. Literally, in some cases. Digital access codes.

Signature authorities. Relationships with partners who'd known only me for years.

Each transfer felt like a small amputation. Not painful, exactly. Numb. The kind of sensation that tells you something is gone before your mind has fully processed the loss.

I'd spent six years building systems designed to function without me. Decentralized decision-making. Clear hierarchies. Documented processes. The theory was that no single person should be irreplaceable, including the founder.

The theory worked. That was the problem.

When the time came to step back, there was no technical reason I needed to stay involved. The machine I'd constructed ran smoothly without my hand on the controls. Richard understood the business. The team understood their roles. Users continued using the platform without noticing any interruption.

I should have felt proud. Instead, I felt lost.

The management restrictions that came with the settlement added another layer. I couldn't be involved in day-to-day operations. Couldn't make decisions about products, about strategy, about personnel. My role was reduced to shareholder, advisor, observer—titles that sounded important but felt hollow.

I found myself reaching for things that were no longer mine to touch. An email about a new feature launch. A question about a partnership negotiation. A concern about a competitor's move.

Each time, I had to stop myself. Remember the boundaries. Respect the transfer of authority I'd initiated.

It was like training yourself not to reach for a tool you'd used every day. The muscle memory persisted even when the permission didn't.

Richard was gracious. He included me in conversations where appropriate, sought my perspective on strategic questions, made clear that my experience was valued even if my authority was limited.

But I could see the distance growing. The necessary distance between a former CEO and the person now holding the position. He needed to establish his own leadership, make his own decisions, build his own relationships. My

presence, however well-intentioned, could only complicate that process.

So I stepped further back. Attended fewer meetings. Asked fewer questions. Tried to find a new role that didn't interfere with the role I'd left behind.

The media coverage of Richard's appointment focused on his regulatory background. The narrative was clear: Binance was changing, maturing, becoming the kind of institution that regulators could work with rather than against.

That narrative was accurate, as far as it went. But it missed the personal dimension. The human cost of that maturation. The founder who had to step aside so the company could grow into something he couldn't have built himself.

I don't regret choosing Richard. Don't regret the handover. The company is stronger with him leading it, more stable, more prepared for the regulatory environment that defines modern finance.

But I do regret, sometimes, that I couldn't be the one to lead that transformation. That my failures made my continued leadership impossible. That the skills I had—building, growing, innovating—were less valuable than the skills I lacked—navigating, complying, accommodating.

The keys are his now. The doors they open, the rooms they access, the decisions they enable—all beyond my reach.

I built the house. I don't live in it anymore.

That's not tragedy. That's succession. The natural order of things. Organizations that outlast their founders are the ones that succeed. Founders who step aside gracefully are the ones who demonstrate true leadership.

I know these truths. Repeat them to myself when the loss feels acute. But knowing doesn't eliminate feeling. It just gives feeling a context, a frame, a way of being acknowledged without being indulged.

Richard sends updates occasionally. Not obligations—courtesies. I appreciate them more than I can express. The connection to something that still matters, even if it no longer matters primarily through me.

The handover is complete. Has been for months. But some part of me is still standing in that doorway, keys in hand, wondering what comes next.

I handed them over. That's what matters. The rest is just adjustment.

The adjustment is ongoing. I am learning to be someone who doesn't run a company. Who doesn't make decisions that affect millions. Who doesn't wake up to a inbox full of urgent problems requiring immediate attention.

It is quieter. Slower. More introspective. Not worse, necessarily. Just different.

Richard is doing well. The company is thriving. The transition that seemed so monumental from the inside looks, from the outside, like the natural evolution it was always meant to be.

I am proud of what I built. Proud that it could survive without me. Proud that I had the wisdom—eventually—to let it go.

The keys were never really mine. They were always the company's. I just held them for a while.

Now someone else holds them. And the house continues to stand.

Me in Court Documents: What's Being Sentenced Isn't Code

The document arrived by encrypted email. 36 pages. Single-spaced. My name on every page, but someone else's version of me.

I was sitting in a conference room in Seattle when my lawyer slid the sentencing memo across the table. The Department of Justice's official position on who I was and what I deserved. I had known it was coming. We all had. But reading it was different from knowing about it.

"Given the magnitude of Zhao's willful violation of U.S. law and its consequences, an above-guideline sentence of 36 months is warranted."

Three years.

I read the sentence twice. Then a third time. The words didn't change.

I have spent my career in systems where intelligence matters. Where understanding complexity gives you an advantage. Where being able to see patterns others miss is the difference between success and failure.

Code doesn't care who you are. Markets don't care about your intentions. Algorithms execute based on inputs and logic, not on whether the programmer is a good person.

I had built my life around this truth. In technology, merit is measurable. Performance is quantifiable. Smart people who build good products win. It's not always fair, but it's usually legible.

The court document in front of me described a different world. A world where my technical achievements were irrelevant. Where the sophistication of Binance's systems counted for nothing. Where my understanding of distributed systems, of market microstructure, of the complex interplay between global regulatory frameworks—all of it was beside the point.

What mattered was simpler. Did I fulfill my legal obligations? Did I implement adequate anti-money laundering controls? Did I report suspicious transactions as required by law?

The answer, as I had already admitted, was no.

I kept reading. The prose was clinical, precise, devastating in its restraint.

"Zhao reaped vast rewards for his violation of U.S. law, and the price of that violation must be significant to effectively punish Zhao for his criminal acts and to deter others who are tempted to build fortunes and business empires by breaking U.S. law."

The document painted a picture of me that I barely recognized. A calculating businessman who had made a deliberate decision to violate the law. Someone who understood the rules and chose to ignore them because compliance was inconvenient, expensive, competitive disadvantageous.

Was that me? I didn't think so. But I had learned that my perspective on myself wasn't the one that mattered.

The prosecutors had evidence. Internal communications where I acknowledged the regulatory risks. Conversations where I discussed the trade-offs between growth and compliance. The infamous "better to ask for forgiveness than permission" message, which had been quoted in every article about the case.

Reading it in the government's filing, stripped of context, it sounded damning. In context—well, context doesn't matter much in court documents.

What struck me most was the gap between what I had built and what was being judged.

Binance processed millions of transactions daily. We built systems that handled extreme volatility, that remained operational during market crashes that broke other exchanges, that served users in countries where traditional financial services were unavailable or untrustworthy.

None of that was in the document.

The document talked about what we failed to do. The suspicious transactions we didn't report. The sanctions we didn't enforce. The compliance program we didn't build.

It was all true. Every word of it. But it was also incomplete. It was one side of a story that had many sides.

I thought about the engineers who had worked 80-hour weeks to keep the platform running during the 2021 bull market. The customer service team that handled millions of support tickets. The compliance staff who did their best with limited resources and unclear guidance.

None of them were in the document either.

The request for 36 months was double the federal guidelines. The prosecutors were explicit about why: deterrence. They wanted to send a message not just to me, but to the entire crypto industry.

"The sentence in this case will not just send a message to Zhao but also to the world."

I understood the logic. I had built a company that became larger than I ever imagined. With that scale came scrutiny. With that scrutiny came consequences. The government was using my case to establish boundaries for an industry that had operated with few of them.

But understanding doesn't make it easier to read about yourself as an example. As a cautionary tale. As a name that will appear in law school case studies about what not to do.

I thought about the other cases. Arthur Hayes. The BitMEX founders. They had received probation and house arrest for similar violations. The prosecutors acknowledged this in their filing, then argued that my case was different because of the scale of Binance's operations.

Scale. That was the word that kept appearing. Everything came back to size. The violations were the same in kind but different in magnitude. And magnitude, in the eyes of the law, justified harsher punishment.

There was a section about my character. Testimonials from colleagues, friends, family. My sister, my son, my mother—all had written letters to the judge describing the person they knew. The person who wasn't defined by

this one failure.

The prosecutors acknowledged these letters. Then they dismissed them.

“While the defendant’s supporters describe a different side of his character, the Court must focus on the conduct at issue in this case.”

It was fair. It was also brutal. The people who knew me best, who had seen me at my most human, who could testify to decades of behavior that wasn’t captured in compliance failures—their perspectives were noted and set aside.

The law has a narrow lens. It looks at specific acts, specific times, specific violations. The rest is context, and context has limited weight.

I spent that evening alone in my hotel room, reading the document again and again. Not because I expected to find something I had missed, but because I was trying to understand how I had arrived here.

The technical part of my brain kept intervening. I wanted to argue. To explain the complexity of building a global financial platform. To describe the impossible position of trying to comply with regulations that hadn’t been written for crypto, in jurisdictions that didn’t agree on what crypto even was.

But that wasn’t the point. The point was simpler, and I had known it for months.

I was the CEO. The responsibility stopped with me. Whether the compliance failures were intentional or negligent, whether they were the result of calculated decisions or overwhelmed systems, they happened on my watch. That was the only fact that mattered.

The law doesn’t care how smart you are. It doesn’t care how hard you worked. It doesn’t care about the complexity of the problems you were trying to solve. It cares about one thing: did you fulfill your obligations?

I hadn’t.

There was a strange relief in accepting this. For months, I had been caught between two stories. The story I told myself about building something important, something that provided real value to millions of people. And the story the government told, about violations and failures and consequences.

Both stories were true. But only one of them was relevant to what came

next.

I thought about the engineers I had worked with over the years. The ones who spent their careers optimizing systems, reducing latency, eliminating bugs. They understood something I was only now fully grasping: the system doesn't care about your intentions. It only cares about outputs.

The legal system is a system like any other. It has inputs (evidence, testimony, precedent) and outputs (verdicts, sentences, consequences). It runs on rules that exist independently of any individual case. And it produces results that can feel arbitrary, unfair, disconnected from the complexity of real human experience.

But it's the system we have. And I had failed to account for it properly.

The document requested 36 months. Three years of my life, reduced to a number in a government filing.

I thought about what those months would mean. The projects I couldn't build. The people I couldn't help. The time with my family that I would miss. The person I would become after months of incarceration.

All of it was speculative. The judge would decide. The guidelines suggested 12 to 18 months. The prosecutors wanted 36. My lawyers would argue for less.

But the range itself was striking. Eighteen months of uncertainty. The difference between a manageable disruption and a life-altering punishment, all depending on how one person interpreted the same set of facts.

This is the part of the legal system that technical people struggle with. In engineering, there's usually a right answer. The code either works or it doesn't. The system either scales or it doesn't. Ambiguity is a problem to be solved, not a feature to be accepted.

In law, ambiguity is everywhere. Discretion is built into the system. Judges have latitude. Prosecutors have discretion. The same facts can produce different outcomes depending on context, timing, presentation.

I had to accept that my fate was not determined by objective metrics. It would be determined by human judgment. By whether the judge believed I was remorseful. By whether he thought I was likely to reoffend. By whether he wanted to make an example of me or show mercy.

These were not questions with technical answers.

I wrote a letter to the judge that night. Not my lawyers—me. I needed to say something in my own words, not through the filter of legal strategy.

“Words cannot explain how deeply I regret my choices that result in me being before the Court,” I wrote. “Please accept my assurance that this will be my only encounter with the criminal justice system.”

It was true. Every word of it. Whether it would matter, I didn't know.

What I did know was this: the person described in the government's filing was someone I recognized, even if I didn't fully accept the characterization. I had made mistakes. I had prioritized growth over compliance in ways that were wrong. I had told myself stories about the complexity of our situation that were partly true and partly rationalization.

The law doesn't care about the difference between true complexity and rationalization. It only cares about results.

I put down my pen and looked out the window at the Seattle skyline. Somewhere in this city, in six days, a judge would read these documents and decide my future.

The system was running. The inputs were submitted. Soon, there would be an output.

I had spent my career building systems. Now I was subject to one. And I was learning, in the hardest possible way, that being smart doesn't exempt you from consequences. Being successful doesn't shield you from judgment. Building something valuable doesn't excuse you from following the rules.

The document on the table said I deserved 36 months. I hoped the judge would see something the prosecutors hadn't. But I knew, finally, that what I hoped mattered less than what I had done.

That's the lesson. That's what the court documents taught me. Not in the words they contained, but in the gap between who I thought I was and what I was being judged for.

The code I wrote, the systems I built, the company I created—none of it mattered in that room. What mattered was simpler, and harder: did I fulfill my obligations?

I didn't. And now I would pay for that failure, in ways I was only beginning

to understand.

Sources: DOJ Sentencing Memo (April 23, 2024); Reuters reporting on prosecution request; Fortune coverage of sentencing filings; CZ letter to Judge Richard Jones (April 24, 2024).

Letters of Support and Personal Debts: What I'm Least Good At

The request came from my lawyers. Letters of support. Character references. People who knew me, who could speak to who I was beyond the court documents, who could help the judge see a human being rather than a case number.

I understood the purpose. The legal strategy was clear. But the personal dimension felt foreign, uncomfortable, like being asked to perform an emotion I wasn't sure I could access.

I am not good at asking for help. This is not false modesty. It is a pattern I have observed in myself over decades. The preference for solving problems independently. The discomfort with vulnerability. The belief that competence means not needing assistance.

Now I needed to ask. Not for help with a technical problem, but for something more intimate. For people to speak on my behalf. To vouch for my character. To ask a judge for mercy based on their knowledge of who I am.

The letters that came back were more than I expected. Longer, more detailed, more personal. Colleagues wrote about years of working together, about moments of integrity they'd observed, about the culture I'd tried to build. Friends wrote about my family, my values, my treatment of people

regardless of their status.

Reading them felt like looking in a mirror I hadn't known existed. These people saw things in me I didn't see in myself. Or saw them more clearly, more generously, than I could.

The public letter texts, submitted to the court, became part of the record. I won't quote them here—they belong to their authors, not to me. But I will say what they represented.

They represented relationships I'd built without calculating their future value. Connections formed through shared work, shared challenges, shared time. The kind of relationships that persist even when circumstances change, even when the power dynamics shift, even when there's nothing obvious to be gained.

I am grateful for those letters. More grateful than I can adequately express. But gratitude, for me, has always been complicated.

I was trained to express appreciation through action rather than words. To show gratitude by being useful, by delivering results, by solving problems. The direct expression of emotion—"thank you," "I appreciate this," "this means a lot to me"—feels insufficient, almost embarrassing.

The letters forced me to confront this limitation. To recognize that some debts can't be repaid through competence, that some gratitude must be spoken rather than demonstrated, that the people who stood up for me deserved acknowledgment I wasn't naturally equipped to give.

I wrote to each of them. Individual notes, not form letters. Tried to say what their support meant, even when the words felt inadequate. Tried to be personal in a way that doesn't come naturally to me.

Some of the letter writers were people I'd disagreed with over the years. Colleagues with whom I'd had heated debates, strategic differences, moments of tension. Their willingness to write despite those conflicts said something about the relationships we'd built. Something about forgiveness, or perspective, or the ability to see beyond specific disputes to underlying character.

I am not sure I would have done the same in their position. That is part of what I am least good at. The extension of benefit of the doubt, the assumption

of good faith, the willingness to advocate for someone despite their mistakes.

The letters also revealed gaps. People I might have asked who I didn't. Relationships that weren't as strong as I'd assumed, or that I'd neglected, or that had been damaged by decisions I made without considering their human cost.

Those gaps are instructive. They show me who I am through who I couldn't ask. Through the support I didn't receive because I hadn't invested in receiving it.

I don't dwell on those gaps. The letters I received were sufficient, generous, more than I had any right to expect. But I note them. Store them as data about the person I've been and the person I might become.

The court would weigh these letters alongside everything else. The prosecution's arguments, the defense's counterarguments, the guidelines and precedents and factors that determine sentences. I don't know how much the letters mattered. Whether they changed anything, or merely confirmed what the judge had already decided.

But they mattered to me. That is the personal debt I acknowledge. The debt to people who saw me at my best and chose to remember it, who saw me at my worst and chose to contextualize it, who wrote words that will outlast the moment they were needed.

I am not good at this. At accepting help, at expressing gratitude, at acknowledging dependence on others. But I am learning. The letters were teachers, showing me what community looks like when you actually need it.

The personal debts accumulate. Not financial debts. Something more valuable. The obligation to be worthy of the support I received. To become someone who would write such letters for others, who would stand up when standing up matters, who would extend the grace that was extended to me.

That is the work ahead. The work of becoming someone who doesn't just receive support gracefully but gives it generously. Who understands that relationships are not transactions but investments, not in what you can get but in who you can be.

The letters are filed now. Part of the record, the history, the story of this moment. I read them occasionally, not for comfort but for reminder.

Reminder of who I am to people who know me. Reminder that identity is not self-determined but socially constructed, formed through the eyes of others as much as through my own self-conception.

I am grateful. The words feel small for what I mean. But they are the words I have. And perhaps, in their inadequacy, they are more honest than eloquence would be.

The inadequacy is part of the lesson. I am learning that perfection in expression is not required for sincerity. That the attempt to communicate gratitude matters, even when the communication falls short.

Each letter I received taught me something about the person who wrote it. About what they valued, what they remembered, what they chose to emphasize when asked to describe who I am.

Some focused on professional achievements. Others on personal qualities. Still others on specific moments that had revealed character. Together, they formed a portrait more complete than any single perspective could provide.

I am humbled by their generosity. By the time people took, the thought they invested, the willingness to attach their names and reputations to my cause.

This is what community means. Not the transactional networks we build for professional advancement. Not the social media connections we accumulate for visibility. But the people who show up when it matters, who stand by you when standing has a cost, who believe in you even when you've given them reasons not to.

I am learning to be that kind of person. To show up, to stand by, to believe in others even when it's inconvenient. The letters taught me what that looks like from the receiving end. Now I must learn what it looks like from the giving end.

The personal debts will take a lifetime to repay. That is as it should be. Some debts are not meant to be settled quickly. They are meant to shape who we become.

Sentencing Day: Four Months and Fifty Million

The courtroom was smaller than I expected.

I had imagined something grander. Something that matched the scale of what was being decided. But the United States District Court for the Western District of Washington looked like any other government building—fluorescent lights, beige walls, the faint smell of industrial cleaner.

I sat at the defense table, my lawyers on either side. Behind me, I could feel the presence of my family. My mother. My sister. My son. They had flown in from different parts of the world to be here. Their support was the only thing that felt solid in a room where everything else was uncertain.

April 30, 2024. The date I had been dreading and waiting for in equal measure.

The judge entered. Judge Richard A. Jones. I had researched him, as I research everything. Former prosecutor. Appointed to the bench in 2007. Reputation for being fair, thorough, unswayed by public pressure.

He looked at me. Not with hostility, not with sympathy. Just with the professional assessment of a man who had seen thousands of defendants and would see thousands more.

The prosecutor began. I had read their memo. I knew what they would say. But hearing it spoken aloud, in this room, with my future hanging in

the balance—it was different.

“Zhao willfully violated U.S. law on an unprecedented scale.” The same words from the filing, now delivered with the weight of performance. “He put U.S. customers, the U.S. financial system, and U.S. national security at risk.”

I listened without expression. This was the performance expected of me. Show respect. Show remorse. Don’t argue. Don’t defend. Let the lawyers do their work.

But inside, something was shifting. The words that had kept me awake at night—the accusations, the characterizations, the narrative of deliberate wrongdoing—were losing their power. Not because they were wrong, but because they were incomplete. And incompleteness, I was learning, was something you had to accept.

My lawyer spoke next. The defense we had prepared, the arguments we had refined over months. No precedent for incarceration in similar cases. Extraordinary cooperation. Genuine remorse. A lifetime of positive contributions. A man who had already lost his position, his reputation, his ability to lead the company he built.

I watched the judge as he listened. His face gave nothing away. This was his job, after all. To hear both sides. To weigh the evidence. To make a decision that would be scrutinized by journalists, legal scholars, the entire crypto industry.

I thought about the weight of that responsibility. I had made decisions that affected millions of users, billions of dollars. But I had never made a decision that would determine another person’s freedom. Not directly. Not personally.

Judges do this every day. I tried to imagine what that felt like. I couldn’t. Then it was my turn to speak.

I had prepared remarks. My lawyers had reviewed them, edited them, approved them. But when I stood, I found myself departing from the script.

“Your Honor,” I said, “I want to take responsibility. Not just legally, but genuinely. I made mistakes. I prioritized growth over compliance. I told myself stories about the complexity of our situation that were partly true

and partly excuses.”

The courtroom was silent. I could hear my own breathing.

“I’m sorry. I believe the first step in taking responsibility is to fully recognize the mistakes. Here I failed to implement an adequate anti-money laundering program. I realize now the seriousness of that mistake.”

The words felt inadequate. How do you compress years of decisions, thousands of employees, millions of users, billions of transactions—how do you compress all of that into an apology that fits in a few minutes of speaking time?

You can’t. But you try anyway.

The judge spoke.

“There needs to be an effort by this court to impose a sentence that’s appropriate and reasonable.”

I leaned forward. This was it.

“Your conduct does not warrant a 36-month sentence.”

I felt something release in my chest. Not relief, exactly. More like the end of a particular kind of tension. The worst-case scenario—three years—was off the table.

But what remained was still unknown.

The judge continued. He spoke about the seriousness of the violations. About the need for deterrence. About the scale of Binance’s operations and the consequences of inadequate compliance.

Then he spoke about me. About the letters of support. About my charitable work. About the absence of evidence that I had been directly informed of specific illegal activities.

“I have never seen such a large amount of uniformly laudatory testimonials about a defendant.”

I thought about the people who had written those letters. Former colleagues. Industry peers. Family members. People who knew me not as “CZ” the public figure, but as Changpeng, the person. Their words had mattered. In a system that often feels impersonal, their personal testimony had carried weight.

“Four months.”

The words hung in the air. I processed them slowly, as if translating from a language I didn't fully speak.

Four months. Not 36. Not 18. Not the 12 that the guidelines suggested. Four.

It was less than I had feared. More than I had hoped. The number felt arbitrary and inevitable at the same time.

And then: "\$50 million fine."

The personal fine. Separate from the \$4.3 billion Binance had already agreed to pay. A number that would have been devastating to almost anyone else. To me, it was manageable. Almost insultingly small in proportion to my wealth. But the symbolism mattered. The government was taking something personal. Making this about me, not just my company.

I sat back in my chair. The hearing continued—discussions of reporting dates, of where I would serve my sentence, of the conditions of my supervised release. But the essential decision had been made.

Four months. Fifty million dollars.

I thought about what this meant. In one sense, I had gotten off lightly. The prosecutors had asked for three years. The guidelines suggested more than I received. By the standards of white-collar criminal cases, four months was minimal.

But in another sense, the sentence was devastating. I would be incarcerated. I would lose my freedom, even temporarily. I would enter a system designed to strip away the autonomy and control that had defined my adult life.

The real sentence, I was beginning to understand, wasn't about time. It was about identity.

After the hearing, I walked out of the courthouse into the Seattle spring. Cameras flashed. Reporters shouted questions. I kept walking.

My family surrounded me. My mother, who had worried about me since I was a child. My sister, who had testified to my character. My son, who was watching his father become something new—a felon, an inmate, a cautionary tale.

We didn't speak much. What was there to say? The decision had been made. The path forward was clear, even if the experience of walking it was

not.

I thought about the night I had first learned about Bitcoin. The apartment I sold. The friends who thought I was crazy. The decade of building, of taking risks, of believing that technology could create a better financial system.

None of that was erased by this sentence. But it was complicated by it. Forever after, my story would have this chapter. The founder who built something extraordinary and then went to prison for how he built it.

Was that fair? I still don't know. Fairness is a complicated concept when applied to your own life.

That evening, alone in my hotel room, I thought about what came next.

Four months. It was a number I could comprehend. Not so long that it felt abstract. Long enough to be real.

I would report to a federal facility. I would become Inmate 88087-510. I would sleep in a dormitory or a cell, eat institutional food, follow schedules I didn't set, submit to searches and counts and rules designed for people very different from me.

And then I would be released. With a felony record. With a lifetime ban from managing Binance. With a reputation transformed by this experience.

The sentence wasn't just four months. The sentence was permanent.

I thought about the phrase that kept appearing in my mind: "finally paying for long-neglected problems."

The compliance failures at Binance hadn't happened in a day. They had accumulated over years. Small decisions, made in the pressure of rapid growth, that compounded into something much larger. The lack of a formal headquarters. The limited compliance staff. The prioritization of product development over regulatory engagement.

Each of these had seemed reasonable at the time. Necessary, even. We were building something new. The old rules didn't fit. We would figure it out as we grew.

But "figuring it out as we grew" meant that real people—users in sanctioned countries, victims of scams, targets of money laundering—were harmed by our inadequacy. Not intentionally. Not maliciously. But harmed nonetheless.

The sentence was my payment for that harm. Not a complete payment. Nothing could fully compensate for the consequences of our failures. But a payment nonetheless.

I looked at my phone. Messages from colleagues, from friends, from people I hadn't spoken to in years. The news had spread instantly, as news does now.

Some messages were supportive. "You got off light." "Four months is nothing." "You'll be back stronger."

Others were more somber. "I'm sorry." "Thinking of you." "Let me know if you need anything."

I appreciated all of them. But none of them quite captured what I was feeling.

This wasn't about getting off light or heavy. It wasn't about coming back stronger or weaker. It was about something more fundamental: the recognition that actions have consequences, that responsibility cannot be delegated away, that success does not exempt you from accountability.

I had built my career on the idea that smart people who build good things deserve to succeed. That merit matters. That the system rewards value creation.

What I was learning was that merit and value creation are necessary but not sufficient. You also have to follow the rules. Not because the rules are always right, but because they're the rules. And when you don't, there are consequences, regardless of how smart you are or how much value you've created.

The next morning, I woke up to a different world.

Not literally, of course. The same Seattle rain. The same hotel room. The same reality of what was coming.

But something had shifted. The uncertainty was over. The waiting, the speculation, the anxiety about what the judge would decide—all of that was finished.

Now there was only the doing. Reporting to prison. Serving the sentence. Emerging on the other side.

I thought about the projects I wouldn't be able to work on. The decisions

I wouldn't be able to make. The daily life of running a company that I had lived for seven years, now permanently behind me.

And I thought about what I might gain. Time to think. Time to read. Time to be someone other than the CEO of the world's largest crypto exchange.

It was a strange kind of gift, this forced pause. I didn't want it. But I would try to use it.

Four months and fifty million dollars.

The numbers would be in every article about me forever. The shorthand for my failure. The metrics of my punishment.

But the real sentence was something else. It was the loss of a particular kind of future. The future where I continued building Binance, where I remained at the center of the crypto industry, where my identity was defined by what I created rather than what I failed to prevent.

That future was gone. What replaced it was still unclear.

I packed my bag. I checked out of the hotel. I walked through the Seattle streets one more time as a free man, knowing that the next time I walked these streets, I would be different.

The sentence was four months. The transformation would last forever.

Sources: Court records from April 30, 2024 sentencing; Reuters reporting; New York Times coverage; Wired reporting; Fortune coverage of sentencing; Judge Richard Jones statements as reported by journalists present.

Before Reporting: From CEO to Inmate

The month between sentencing and reporting felt like living in a dream where you know you're dreaming but can't wake up.

I went through the motions of normal life. I ate meals. I took calls. I answered emails. But everything was filtered through the knowledge that it was temporary. That in a specific number of days, I would walk into a federal facility and everything would change.

The Bureau of Prisons had designated my facility: FCI Lompoc II, a low-security federal correctional institution on the California coast. I researched it, of course. I research everything. Two thousand inmates. Non-violent offenders. Drug crimes, white-collar crimes, immigration violations. A world I had never imagined being part of.

My lawyers gave me advice. Practical advice, the kind that doesn't appear in movies about prison.

Bring a watch. Not an Apple Watch, not a smart watch. A simple, cheap watch. Time becomes important when you don't control it.

Bring comfortable shoes. The commissary sells sneakers, but they're not good quality.

Bring a list of phone numbers. You'll be able to make calls, but only to approved numbers. Decide now who matters enough to be on that list.

Don't bring anything valuable. It will be taken, stored, or stolen.

I listened to all of it. I took notes. I tried to treat it like preparing for a

business trip to a country with unfamiliar customs.

But it wasn't a business trip. And the customs I was learning weren't cultural—they were institutional. Designed for control. Designed for security. Designed for people who had lost the right to make their own choices.

I spent time with my family. More time than I had in years. There was an urgency to it, a consciousness that these moments were finite and precious.

My children asked questions. Some I could answer. Some I couldn't.

"How long will you be gone?" Four months. But four months to a child is different from four months to an adult. It's a season. A school semester. A period of growth that I would miss.

"Will you be safe?" Yes. Low-security facilities are for non-violent offenders. But safety is a relative concept. I would be safe from physical harm, probably. Safe from the psychological toll of incarceration? That remained to be seen.

"Can we visit?" Yes. But visiting a federal prison is not like visiting an office. There are procedures, restrictions, limits on physical contact. I would see my family through glass or across a table, supervised by guards, aware that our time together was measured and monitored.

I tried to be reassuring. For them, if not for myself.

The identity shift was the hardest part to process.

For seven years, I had been CEO of Binance. The title had become part of my name. People introduced me as "CZ, CEO of Binance." I introduced myself that way. The company and the person had merged in the public mind, and in my own.

Now I was former CEO. Convicted felon. Soon-to-be inmate.

The labels felt foreign. Wrong, somehow. Not because they were inaccurate—they were legally precise—but because they didn't capture the complexity of who I was. Or who I thought I was.

I kept coming back to the same question: when identity is stripped away, what keeps you standing?

I had defined myself through work for so long. Through building things. Through solving problems. Through the constant motion of entrepreneur-

ship. What would be left when all of that was removed?

I thought about other people who had faced similar transitions. Executives who had gone to prison. Founders who had lost their companies. People who had built identities around their careers and then watched those careers end.

Some of them had emerged stronger. More reflective. More focused on what really mattered. Others had never recovered. The loss of identity had led to depression, addiction, worse.

I didn't know which category I would fall into. I still don't.

But I knew I had to prepare. Not just practically, but psychologically. I had to find something to hold onto when everything else was taken away.

I started reading about prison. Memoirs, mostly. People who had gone through this and written about it.

The common themes surprised me. Not the violence or the danger that movies emphasize, but the boredom. The waiting. The slow erosion of self that comes from having no control over your daily life.

"The hardest part is the time," one writer said. "Not the length of it, but the quality. Time moves differently inside. A day can feel like a week. A month can feel like a day. You lose your sense of rhythm, of progress, of moving forward."

I thought about my relationship with time. As an entrepreneur, time had always been my enemy and my tool. There was never enough of it. I had to optimize every minute, batch tasks, eliminate inefficiencies. Time was a resource to be managed, like capital or talent.

In prison, time would be something else. Something that happened to me rather than something I used. I would have too much of it and no control over how it passed.

How do you prepare for that? I wasn't sure.

I made lists. Lists of books I wanted to read. Lists of projects I wanted to think about. Lists of people I wanted to write to.

Giggle Academy, the educational platform I had announced before sentencing, became a focus. I couldn't work on it directly from prison. No computers, no internet, no ability to build or code or manage. But I could think. I could plan. I could emerge with a clearer vision of what I wanted to

create.

This became my strategy. Not to endure prison, but to use it. To treat the time as a forced sabbatical, a retreat from the world that would allow me to think more deeply than I had in years.

Whether this was realistic or self-deception, I didn't know. But I needed a narrative that made the experience meaningful. That turned punishment into opportunity. That gave me something to hold onto when the reality of incarceration became overwhelming.

The physical preparation was easier than the psychological.

I bought the watch. The simple, cheap watch that would become my most important possession. I broke in a pair of sneakers that I could wear for months. I gathered the photos I was allowed to bring—small, laminated pictures of family that would be my only decoration, my only connection to the world outside.

I said goodbye to colleagues. Some of them I had worked with for years. Others I barely knew. The company would continue without me. Richard Teng, the new CEO, was capable and prepared. Binance was bigger than any one person, including me.

This was supposed to be comforting. It was, in a way. But it was also strange to realize how quickly I would become irrelevant to the daily operations of the company I had founded. The machine I had built would keep running. The people I had hired would keep working. The users I had served would keep trading.

I was replaceable. This is true of everyone, but most of us don't have to confront it so directly.

The night before I reported, I couldn't sleep.

I lay in bed, watching the numbers on my phone change. 1 AM. 2 AM. 3 AM. Each hour bringing me closer to something I couldn't fully imagine.

I thought about the person I had been seven years ago. The entrepreneur who had launched Binance with a small team and a big vision. Who had worked 20-hour days and slept on office couches. Who had believed that technology could democratize finance, that crypto could create a more open and accessible financial system.

That person had made mistakes. Serious mistakes. Mistakes that had led to this moment.

But that person had also built something real. Something that employed thousands of people. Something that served millions of users. Something that had changed the financial landscape, for better and for worse.

I didn't know how to reconcile these two truths. The builder and the criminal. The visionary and the violator. They were both me. They would both be walking into that prison tomorrow.

In the early morning hours, I got up and wrote a letter. To myself. To read later, when I needed perspective.

"You are not your title. You are not your company. You are not your net worth or your reputation or your Twitter following. You are a person who made mistakes and is paying for them. But you are also a person who built things, who helped people, who tried to create value in the world. Both of these are true. Hold onto both."

I sealed the envelope and put it in my bag. A message from my free self to my incarcerated self. A lifeline across time.

The drive to Lompoc took four hours. My lawyer drove with me. We didn't talk much. What was there to say?

I watched the landscape change. Seattle's green gave way to California's brown. Cities gave way to farmland. The coast appeared, then disappeared, then appeared again.

I thought about the last time I had been truly free of responsibility. Childhood, maybe. Before the drive to achieve, to build, to prove something to the world. I couldn't remember what that felt like.

Maybe I would find out. Or maybe I would discover that freedom without purpose is just another kind of prison.

We arrived at 10 AM. The facility looked like a college campus from a distance. Low buildings, open spaces, a fence that was more suggestion than barrier. Low-security, they called it. For people who weren't dangerous. For people who could be trusted not to run.

I said goodbye to my lawyer. He wished me luck. We shook hands. Then I walked toward the entrance, carrying a small bag of approved items, wearing

my cheap watch and my broken-in sneakers.

The door closed behind me. The process began.

I was no longer a CEO. I was Inmate 88087-510.

The transformation was complete.

Sources: CNBC reporting on CZ prison reporting; Fortune coverage of sentencing and prison designation; general information about FCI Lompoc II from Federal Bureau of Prisons records.

Behind Iron Gates: First Week in Prison

The intake process took six hours.

Six hours of waiting in lines, answering questions, being searched, being processed. Six hours of watching my belongings disappear into plastic bags and storage lockers. Six hours of learning that I was no longer a person who owned things, but a person who was owned by the system.

They took my clothes. My watch. My photos. My letter to myself. Everything went into inventory, to be returned when I left—if I left—four months later.

They gave me khaki pants. A khaki shirt. White socks. Cheap sneakers. An identification card with my number: 88087-510. A number that would be my name for the duration.

I changed in a room with no privacy. A guard watched. Not with hostility, not with interest. Just with the professional detachment of someone who had watched thousands of people do this before.

The dormitory was larger than I expected. Fifty beds in rows. Metal frames, thin mattresses, small lockers. Some men were sleeping. Some were reading. Some were playing cards at a table in the corner.

No one looked up when I entered.

I found my assigned bed. Bottom bunk. I sat on the edge and waited for instructions. There was nothing else to do.

Time moved differently here. In the outside world, I had measured time

in tasks completed, meetings attended, decisions made. Here, time was measured in counts. The guards counted us five times a day. Stand by your bed. Wait. Be counted. Return to what you were doing.

The first count happened at 4 PM. I stood by my bed, like the others. The guard walked through, checking numbers against a list. He didn't make eye contact. I was a data point. A check mark. Nothing more.

Dinner was at 5 PM. We walked to the cafeteria in a line. No talking. The food was institutional—starch, protein, vegetables in various shades of brown and green. Edible. Not enjoyable.

I ate alone. Not because I was ostracized, but because no one knew who I was, and I didn't know who they were. The silence felt safer than conversation.

After dinner, more waiting. The television was on in the common area. A sports game. I didn't follow sports. I sat on a plastic chair and watched men watch television. This was how the evening would pass. This was how every evening would pass.

At 9 PM, another count. Then lights out at 10 PM.

I lay in the dark, listening to the sounds of fifty men breathing, snoring, shifting in their sleep. The dormitory never fully quieted. There was always someone awake, someone moving, someone coughing or talking in their sleep.

I thought about my bed at home. My family, asleep in different time zones. The life I had lived that morning, which now felt like years ago.

Sleep came slowly. When it came, it was shallow and interrupted.

The first morning, I woke to a whistle at 6 AM.

Breakfast was at 6:30. The same routine. Line up. Walk. Eat. Return.

I had read about prison routines. The structure was supposed to be comforting. Predictable. But what I felt wasn't comfort. It was the absence of choice.

Every moment was scheduled. Every action was prescribed. I couldn't decide when to wake, when to eat, when to sleep. I couldn't choose what to wear, where to go, what to do with my time.

This was the reality of incarceration. Not the violence of movies. Not the

danger of maximum security. Just the slow, grinding removal of autonomy. The transformation from a person who made decisions to a person who followed instructions.

I met my case manager on the second day.

She was professional, efficient. She explained the rules. The programs available. The path to “good time”—reduced sentence for good behavior. The expectations for conduct.

“You’re in a low-security facility,” she said. “That means you’re trusted not to cause problems. Don’t prove us wrong.”

I nodded. I had no intention of causing problems. I had no intention of doing anything, really. Just surviving. Just getting through.

She gave me a job assignment. Kitchen duty. Three hours a day, preparing meals for the facility. It was better than nothing. Better than sitting in the dormitory, watching time pass.

The kitchen was hot and loud. Industrial equipment, industrial quantities of food, industrial pace of work.

I was assigned to vegetable prep. Chopping onions, peeling potatoes, washing lettuce. Manual labor I hadn’t done since I was a teenager.

My hands blistered. My back ached. But there was something almost comforting about the work. It was concrete. Measurable. I could see the results of my effort in the piles of prepared vegetables, in the meals that would be served.

The other kitchen workers were mostly drug offenders. Young men, mostly. Some older. A few white-collar criminals like me, though I didn’t advertise my background.

We didn’t talk much. The work didn’t allow for conversation, and even if it had, I wasn’t sure what I would say. “I used to run a cryptocurrency exchange worth billions of dollars. Now I’m chopping onions with you.”

It sounded absurd even in my head.

By the third day, I had learned the rhythm of the facility.

Wake at 6. Breakfast at 6:30. Work at 8. Lunch at 11. Count at 4. Dinner at 5. Count at 9. Lights out at 10.

The days were long but identical. The sameness was both a comfort and a

torment. No surprises meant no danger. But it also meant no variation, no novelty, no sense of progress.

I started reading. The facility had a small library—paperbacks, mostly, donated by various sources. I read a thriller. Then a biography. Then a book about meditation that I found in the spirituality section.

The meditation book helped. It taught techniques for being present, for accepting what is rather than wishing for what isn't. I had never been good at this. My whole career had been about wishing for what isn't and then building it.

Now I had to learn a different skill.

The fourth day, I had my first visitor.

My lawyer. He sat across from me in the visiting room, separated by a table but no glass. Low-security privilege.

"How are you doing?" he asked.

I didn't know how to answer. Physically, I was fine. The food was adequate. The bed was uncomfortable but not unbearable. I had no injuries, no illnesses, no immediate threats to my safety.

Psychologically? I was still processing.

"I'm surviving," I said. It was the most honest answer I could give.

He updated me on the outside world. Binance was operating normally. The crypto markets were volatile, as always. My family was well.

It felt like news from another planet. Relevant but distant. The concerns that had dominated my life for years—market movements, regulatory developments, competitive threats—seemed abstract now. Theoretical.

What mattered here was simpler. The count. The meals. The work assignment. The small interactions with other inmates that determined whether your day was peaceful or difficult.

The fifth day, something shifted.

I was in the kitchen, chopping onions, when I realized I had stopped thinking about the outside world. Not deliberately. Just gradually. My mind had adjusted to the scope of my new reality.

This was dangerous, I knew. If I adapted too well, I might lose something essential. The drive, the ambition, the sense of purpose that had defined my

adult life.

But it was also necessary. Survival required adaptation. The person who couldn't adjust to prison would suffer more than the person who could.

I thought about freedom. What it meant. What I had taken for granted.

Freedom wasn't just the ability to go where you want, do what you want, be who you want. It was the ability to decide your own time. To wake when you choose, eat when you choose, work on what matters to you. To structure your day around your priorities rather than someone else's.

I had lost that. And in losing it, I was understanding its value for the first time.

The sixth day, I started talking to other inmates.

Not about my past. Just about the present. The routine. The food. The guards who were reasonable and the guards who weren't.

Most of them were there for drug offenses. Mandatory minimums, many of them. Years in prison for crimes that seemed less harmful than what I had done.

I didn't say this out loud. It wasn't a competition. But I was aware of the disparity. My four months for violations that affected millions of people. Their years for possessing or selling substances.

The justice system isn't consistent. Everyone in prison knows this. No one is surprised by it.

The seventh day. A full week.

I lay in my bunk after lights out, reviewing the days behind me. They felt longer than a week. They felt like a month, a season, a different life.

I had survived. That was the achievement. I had learned the rules, found my place, established a routine that made the days pass.

But survival wasn't the same as living. I was existing. Waiting. Marking time until I could return to the world I understood.

Was this the lesson I was supposed to learn? The value of freedom? The consequences of my actions? The humility that comes from losing control?

Maybe. Or maybe there was no lesson. Maybe prison was just punishment, plain and simple. Not designed to teach or reform, but to hurt. To take away what matters most and see if you can endure the loss.

I thought about the letter I had written to myself. The one in storage, that I couldn't access. I tried to remember what I had said. Something about holding onto both truths—the mistakes and the achievements. The person who had failed and the person who had built.

I couldn't remember the exact words. But I remembered the intention. To stay whole. To not let this experience reduce me to a single story. The criminal. The inmate. The cautionary tale.

I was more than that. I knew I was more than that. But knowing it and feeling it were different things.

The week ended with another count. Another day marked off the calendar. Another small step toward release.

I had 15 weeks left. Fifteen more weeks of this rhythm, this routine, this removal from the world I had known.

I thought about what I would do when I got out. The projects I would pursue. The people I would reconnect with. The life I would try to rebuild.

But those thoughts felt distant. Abstract. The immediate reality was here: the dormitory, the counts, the kitchen, the books, the slow passage of time.

This was my life now. For a while.

I closed my eyes and waited for sleep. Tomorrow would be the same as today. The same as yesterday. The same as the day before.

In prison, sameness is the point. The system doesn't want you to change or grow. It wants you to conform, to follow rules, to become predictable.

I understood this now. I accepted it, even as I resisted it internally. The part of me that was still free—the part that thought, that planned, that dreamed of what came next—that part was private. Hidden. Safe from the system's reach.

They could control my body. My time. My daily routine.

But they couldn't control what I thought about. What I planned for. Who I decided to become when this was over.

That was still mine. That would always be mine.

The first week was the hardest, I had been told. The adjustment. The shock of the new reality.

If that was true, then I had survived the worst. The weeks ahead would be

easier. More routine. More manageable.

But I knew, even as I thought this, that the hardest part wasn't the first week. The hardest part was the cumulative weight of all the weeks together. The slow realization that this was real, that it was happening, that I was paying for my mistakes in the most concrete way possible.

Freedom, I was learning, isn't just a condition. It's a feeling. And I wouldn't feel it again for a long time.

Sources: CNBC reporting on CZ prison entry (June 2024); general information about FCI Lompoc II conditions from Federal Bureau of Prisons records; CZ post-release reflections at Binance Blockchain Week Dubai (October 2024).

The Texture of Time: Prison Routine and Self-Discipline

By August 2024, I had been in prison for two months. The halfway point. The point where I could look back at what I had endured and forward at what remained, and see that the balance was shifting in my favor.

I was no longer the new inmate, uncertain of the rules and the rhythms. I was a fixture now, someone who knew the system, who could navigate it, who had found a way to exist within its constraints.

The routine had become automatic. Wake at 6:00, breakfast at 6:30, work at 7:30. The education department had become my domain—I spent my mornings helping other inmates learn basic computer skills, showing them how to navigate software, how to use the limited internet access available for educational purposes, how to prepare for the technological world they would reenter on release.

It was satisfying work. Many of the inmates I taught had never used computers extensively. They were older, or from backgrounds where technology had not been part of their daily lives. Watching them learn, seeing the moment when a concept clicked, was genuinely rewarding. It reminded me of why I had gotten into technology in the first place—not for the money or the status, but for the ability to solve problems, to help people, to make things work better.

The afternoons were mine. I spent them reading—technical papers, books on blockchain and cryptography, the occasional novel for variety. I wrote in my notebook, organizing thoughts that had been scattered by years of constant motion. I exercised in the small yard, running laps, doing calisthenics, maintaining the physical fitness that had always been important to me.

I had also developed relationships with other inmates. Not friendships, exactly—prison relationships are complicated by the context in which they form. But connections. People I could talk to, eat with, pass time with. Other white-collar offenders who understood the strange journey from success to incarceration. Men who were serving their time with dignity, planning their returns to society, refusing to let their sentences define them.

We talked about our cases sometimes, comparing notes on what had gone wrong, what we would do differently, what we planned to do when we got out. These conversations were therapeutic in their way—acknowledging our mistakes without being consumed by them, looking forward without denying the past.

I also thought about the outside world. Crypto had continued to evolve in my absence. Bitcoin had gone through its halving. New projects had launched. Old projects had failed. The regulatory environment had continued to shift, with new rules and new enforcement actions shaping the industry I had helped create.

I received this information through letters and occasional phone calls—limited, monitored, but better than nothing. Binance was doing well under Richard Teng's leadership. The compliance investments were paying off. The company was becoming the kind of institution I had always wanted it to be, even if I was no longer there to see it.

This was the strange duality of my situation. I was proud of what Binance was becoming, even as I was serving time for the mistakes I had made while building it. I had created something that would outlast my involvement, that was evolving beyond my vision, that would continue to exist and grow long after I was gone.

The halfway point also brought thoughts of release. I would not serve

my full four months in prison. Like most federal inmates, I was eligible for placement in a halfway house for the final portion of my sentence—a transitional facility where I would have more freedom, more responsibility, more preparation for full reentry into society.

The exact timing of my transfer to the halfway house was not publicly disclosed. The Bureau of Prisons makes these decisions based on various factors—bed availability, behavior in prison, readiness for transition. I expected to be transferred sometime in late August or early September, but the exact date was uncertain.

This uncertainty was frustrating. In the outside world, I had been used to controlling my schedule, making my own decisions about where to be and when. In prison, those decisions were made for me. I could request a transfer date, but I couldn't demand one. I could prepare for the transition, but I couldn't control when it would happen.

I dealt with this frustration the same way I dealt with everything in prison—by focusing on what I could control. I continued my work in the education department. I continued my reading and writing. I continued my exercise routine. And I prepared mentally for the transition to the halfway house, which would bring its own challenges.

The halfway house would be different from prison. More freedom, but also more responsibility. I would be expected to find work, to contribute to the costs of my stay, to follow rules that were less restrictive but still binding. It would be a test of whether I was ready to reenter society, whether I had learned the lessons that prison was supposed to teach.

I was confident I would pass that test. Not because I was special or different from other inmates, but because I had resources—education, experience, a network of supporters—that would help me navigate the transition. I had made mistakes, but I had also built skills and relationships that would serve me well on release.

The texture of time in prison is different from the outside world. Days blur together in their sameness, yet each day is also distinct, marked by small variations in routine, in interactions, in thoughts. I kept track of the days on a calendar, crossing them off one by one, watching the count of days served

grow and the count of days remaining shrink.

It was a strange way to live, measuring time in increments of incarceration. But it was also clarifying. It stripped away the distractions of the outside world and forced me to focus on what mattered. My health. My relationships. My plans for the future. The person I wanted to become when this chapter ended.

I thought often about the concept of freedom. Not just physical freedom—the ability to go where I wanted, when I wanted. But mental freedom. The freedom to choose my own path, to make my own decisions, to live according to my own values.

Prison had taken away my physical freedom, but it couldn't take away my mental freedom unless I let it. I could choose how to respond to my situation. I could choose to learn from it, to grow from it, to use it as an opportunity for reflection and growth. Or I could choose to be bitter, to blame others, to let my sentence consume me.

I chose the former. Not because it was easy—it wasn't. But because it was the only choice that made sense. I had made mistakes. I was serving my sentence. The only question was what I would do with the time I had, how I would emerge on the other side.

By late August, I had settled into a rhythm that was almost comfortable. Not happy—I was not happy in prison. But functional. Productive. Meaningful in its own limited way.

The transfer to the halfway house came suddenly, as these things do. One day I was told to pack my belongings, to prepare for transport. The next day I was on a bus, leaving the prison behind, heading toward the next phase of my sentence.

The halfway house was in a different location—I'm not publicly disclosing where. It was less institutional than the prison, more like a dormitory or a budget hotel. I had a room, not a bunk in a crowded dorm. I had more freedom of movement, more ability to make my own schedule, more responsibility for my own life.

But I was still an inmate. Still subject to rules and regulations. Still counting down the days until my full release.

The texture of time changed in the halfway house. Days were less structured, more variable. I had to find work, which I did—consulting on blockchain projects, using the skills I had developed over decades. I had to contribute to the costs of my stay, which I did. I had to check in with staff, follow curfews, submit to drug tests.

It was a transition, a bridge between incarceration and full freedom. And it was working. I was adapting, adjusting, preparing for the day when my sentence would be complete and I would be fully free.

That day was coming. Not immediately, but soon. And when it came, I would be ready. Not the same person who had entered prison in June, but someone who had learned, grown, changed. Someone who had served his time and was prepared to move forward.

The texture of time in prison and the halfway house was different from anything I had experienced before. It was slower, more deliberate, more focused on the present moment. And it had taught me something about patience, about endurance, about the ability to find meaning in difficult circumstances.

I was not grateful for my sentence. I would not have chosen to spend months of my life in prison. But I was grateful for what I had learned, for the clarity I had gained, for the person I was becoming.

The journey from CEO to inmate to whatever came next was not over. But I could see the end now. And I was ready to meet it.

Learning and Silence: Being a Student Again in Prison

There is a strange thing that happens when you lose the ability to make decisions. At first, it feels like suffocation. Every instinct in your body—every habit formed over decades of building companies, managing teams, responding to crises—screams at you to *do something*. To send an email. To make a call. To fix whatever is broken.

But you can't. The rules are clear. The walls are real. And after some time—I'm not sure exactly how long, because one of the peculiarities of incarceration is that time moves differently—you begin to understand something that sounds like a cliché but isn't: when you cannot change your environment, you can at least change how you see it.

I became a student again. Not in any formal sense. There were no classrooms in the facility where I was held, no professors, no curriculum. But there was time. More time than I had experienced since perhaps my childhood in Jiangsu, before the internet, before computers, before the constant hum of connectivity that had defined my adult life.

I read. This is not unusual for people in my situation. What I read, however, might surprise those who imagine me poring over legal documents or cryptocurrency whitepapers. I read about education systems. About how children learn in different parts of the world. About the gaps between what

schools teach and what children actually need. About gamification, adaptive learning, the psychology of motivation.

The irony was not lost on me. Here I was, someone who had built one of the largest financial platforms in history, thinking about first-grade mathematics. Someone who had processed billions of dollars in transactions, wondering how to make multiplication tables engaging for an eight-year-old who had never held a textbook.

But that is what silence does. It strips away the noise until you can hear what you actually care about.

The Giggle Academy concept did not emerge fully formed during those months. That would be too neat a narrative, and I have learned to be suspicious of neat narratives. The seeds were there, planted years earlier in conversations I had dismissed as idle speculation. “Someone should fix education,” I had said to colleagues more than once, the way people say “someone should fix traffic” or “someone should fix healthcare”—acknowledging a problem without any real intention of addressing it.

What changed was the silence. Without the constant pressure of operational decisions, without the endless stream of messages and meetings and emergencies, I could follow a thought to its conclusion. I could ask: what would it actually take? Not in the abstract. In reality. What infrastructure? What team? What content? What technology?

I made notes. Physical notes, on paper, because that was what was available. Pages and pages of them, written in a hand that had grown rusty from decades of typing. Some of the notes were technical—architecture diagrams for adaptive learning systems, flowcharts for gamification mechanics. Others were more personal, reflections on my own education, on what had worked and what hadn’t, on the teachers who had mattered and the ones who hadn’t.

There is a particular quality to thinking in an environment where you cannot act on your thoughts immediately. In the outside world, an idea leads to a search, which leads to a conversation, which leads to a decision, which leads to action. The chain is short. The feedback is immediate. You never really sit with an idea long enough to understand whether it is good or merely

exciting.

In silence, the chain is broken. An idea has nowhere to go. It must justify itself on its own terms, without the validation of external response. This is uncomfortable. It is also valuable.

I thought about failure. This was unavoidable, given my circumstances. But I tried to think about it precisely, not melodramatically. What had I actually done wrong? What had I failed to anticipate? What assumptions had I made that turned out to be incorrect? The answers were not simple, and they were not the answers that appeared in headlines. The headlines had their own narrative requirements.

I thought about success, too. What had Binance actually achieved? Not in terms of volume or valuation, but in terms of what it had made possible for people around the world. I received letters—some forwarded through legal channels, some not—describing how access to financial services had changed individual lives. A vendor in Nigeria who could finally receive payment for goods sold internationally. A family in Venezuela who had preserved some savings despite currency collapse. A student in the Philippines who had learned to trade and eventually started a business.

These stories were not the whole truth. They were part of it. The other part involved people who had lost money, who had been scammed, who had made poor decisions in volatile markets. I did not forget that part. But in the silence, I could hold both parts at once without the pressure to resolve them into a single verdict.

The value of silence, I came to understand, is not that it provides answers. It is that it allows you to hold questions open longer than you would in normal life. In normal life, questions want to be answered. They push toward resolution, toward action, toward closure. In silence, they can simply exist, and you can observe them without rushing to judgment.

When I posted on X after my release—“A few quick updates...Giggle Academy...”—the response was predictably mixed. Some saw it as a distraction, a public relations move, an attempt to change the subject. Others were genuinely curious about what a cryptocurrency exchange founder might bring to education.

I understood both reactions. I had been in the public eye long enough to know that my actions would be interpreted through whatever lens people had already formed. There was nothing I could do about that. What I could do was continue the work that had begun in silence, now with the ability to act on it.

The transition was not immediate. There is a strange liminal period after incarceration when you are technically free but not actually free. Your mind moves at a different speed than the world around you. Things that should feel urgent don't. Things that should feel simple feel complicated. You have learned to operate without choices, and suddenly having them again is disorienting.

But the work helped. Giggle Academy gave me something to focus on that was neither defensive nor nostalgic. It was forward-looking without being grandiose. The goal was specific: free basic education for grades 1-12, delivered through technology, made engaging through gamification, personalized through adaptive systems. Not revolutionary. Just useful.

I had learned in silence that useful is enough. That not everything needs to change the world. That sometimes the most important thing you can do is address a specific problem for specific people in a specific way.

The person who emerged from that period was not fundamentally different from the person who entered it. I do not believe in transformation narratives. People change gradually, imperceptibly, through accumulation of small adjustments rather than dramatic conversions. But I was, perhaps, more deliberate. More aware of the cost of attention. More careful about what I committed to.

Being a student again taught me that learning is not about acquiring information. It is about developing the capacity to hold uncertainty. To sit with not knowing. To resist the comfort of premature conclusion.

In prison, I had no choice but to sit with uncertainty. The uncertainty of my legal situation. The uncertainty of my company's future. The uncertainty of my own identity, stripped of the roles and responsibilities that had defined me for years. It was uncomfortable. It was also, in retrospect, valuable.

I would not recommend it as a method of personal development. There are

less costly ways to learn silence. But since it was my path, I tried to extract whatever value it offered. That is all any of us can do with circumstances we did not choose: find what they teach us, even if the lesson comes at a price we would not have willingly paid.

Giggle Academy continues. The work continues. I continue, different in ways I can articulate and ways I cannot. The silence taught me that much, at least: we are always more mysterious to ourselves than we pretend to be.

Chapter 52: Halfway House: Freedom Just One Street Away

There is a particular cruelty to the halfway house. I do not mean that the facilities are cruel—though some are, and mine was not exceptional in its comforts. I mean the psychological structure of the thing. The door is open. You can see the street. You could, physically, walk out. But you cannot walk out. The rules say you must stay. And so you stay, in a space that looks like freedom but functions like confinement.

I arrived at the halfway house in August 2024. Reuters reported it. Coindesk reported it. The cryptocurrency community, ever hungry for narrative, treated it as a milestone. “CZ is out,” some said, not quite accurately. I was out of prison. I was not out of the system.

The details of the facility are not important. It was a residential reentry center, one of many operated under contract with the federal government. The purpose, in theory, is to help inmates transition back to society. In practice, it is a liminal space where you are neither fully free nor fully confined, trusted with just enough responsibility to remind you of what you still cannot do.

I had a bed. I had meals at scheduled times. I had a curfew. I had required activities—job search programs, counseling sessions, check-ins with case managers. I also had, for the first time in months, access to the internet. Limited access. Supervised access. But access.

The first time I checked my email, I felt something I had not expected: paralysis. There were thousands of messages. Newsletters I had subscribed

to years ago and never unsubscribed from. Automated alerts from services I no longer used. Personal messages from people who did not know where I was or how to reach me. Business proposals. Legal communications. Spam.

I closed the browser. I would return to it later. But that moment of paralysis taught me something about what incarceration does to the mind. You adapt to limits. The adaptation is not conscious. It happens below the level of decision, a gradual recalibration of what seems possible. And when the limits are suddenly loosened, the mind does not immediately expand to fill the new space. It stays small, cautious, waiting for the boundaries to reassert themselves.

The halfway house was, in this sense, a training ground for freedom. Not freedom itself, but preparation for it. The rules were designed to force gradual reengagement with the world outside. You could leave for approved purposes—work, medical appointments, family visits—but you had to return. You could use the internet, but not freely. You could make phone calls, but they were monitored.

I tried to use the time productively. I continued the work I had begun in silence, now with the ability to research, to communicate, to plan. Giggle Academy moved from concept to project. I reached out to people I had worked with in the past, people I trusted, people who understood that I was not yet fully available but would be soon.

But there was another process happening simultaneously, one that was harder to articulate. I was learning to be in the world again. Not the world of headlines and trading screens and constant crisis management. The ordinary world. Walking to a convenience store. Choosing what to eat for dinner. Having a conversation that was not about business or legal strategy.

These things felt strange. Not difficult, exactly, but unfamiliar, like returning to a language you once spoke fluently but have not used in years. The grammar is still there, but the fluency is gone. You search for words. You misjudge social cues. You are, in small ways, a foreigner in your own life.

The other residents of the halfway house were a mixed group. Some were returning from long sentences and found the relative freedom overwhelming.

Some were there for short stints and treated it as a minor inconvenience. We did not discuss our crimes, by unspoken agreement. We discussed television shows, sports, the quality of the food. Normal things. It was a relief.

I did not tell most of them what I had done. Not out of shame, exactly, though there was some of that. More out of weariness. The story was so large, so freighted with public meaning, that it felt exhausting to introduce into casual conversation. “I ran a cryptocurrency exchange.” “Oh, are you that guy?” Yes. I was that guy. The conversation would then become about cryptocurrency, about regulation, about whether Bitcoin was a good investment. I had had that conversation thousands of times. I did not want to have it in the halfway house.

So I was quiet. I listened more than I spoke. I observed the rhythms of the place, the unwritten rules, the social hierarchies that formed and dissolved. It was, in its way, another form of education. Every community has its own logic. Understanding that logic is the first step to functioning within it.

September arrived. The date of my early release approached: September 27, 2024. The media reported it as a countdown. I experienced it differently. Time in the halfway house was not linear. It expanded and contracted depending on the day, the hour, the mood. Some days felt endless. Others disappeared before I noticed them.

I prepared. Not in any dramatic way. I arranged where I would go, who I would see, what I would do first. But I also prepared myself for the strangeness of full freedom. I knew from conversations with others who had been through the process that the transition was often harder than expected. The mind does not simply flip from “confined” to “free.” It moves gradually, with setbacks, with moments of panic when the openness becomes too much.

The day itself was anticlimactic. There was paperwork. There were signatures. There was a brief conversation with a case manager about my obligations going forward—reporting requirements, restrictions, the conditions of my supervised release. Then I walked out. The door was open. I walked through it. That was all.

I had imagined this moment many times. In my imagination, it was cinematic. Sunlight. Deep breaths. A sense of profound transformation. The

reality was more mundane. It was afternoon. The weather was unremarkable. I was carrying a bag with my few possessions. I walked to a car that was waiting for me. I got in. We drove away.

The feeling came later. Not freedom, exactly. More like the absence of something that had been present for so long I had stopped noticing it. The absence of surveillance. The absence of scheduled meals. The absence of permission required for basic actions. I could go where I wanted. I could eat what I wanted. I could stay up as late as I wanted.

This should have been exhilarating. Instead, it was disorienting. I found myself defaulting to the patterns of confinement. Eating at the same times. Going to bed early. Staying in small spaces. The freedom was there, but I did not yet know how to use it.

That is the thing about doors. They can be open without you being ready to walk through them. Freedom comes fast, in the sense that the legal status changes in a moment. But adaptation is slow. The mind has its own timeline, and it does not synchronize with court orders.

I spent the first days of my release in a kind of haze. I did the things I had planned to do. I saw the people I had planned to see. I started the projects I had planned to start. But there was a lag, a sense of watching myself from slightly outside my body. I was performing freedom before I had fully internalized it.

This passed. It always passes. The human mind is adaptable, more so than we often give it credit for. Gradually, the new patterns replaced the old. I began to make decisions without consulting a schedule or a rulebook. I began to trust that the freedom was real, that it would not be suddenly revoked.

But I never forgot the lesson of the halfway house. Freedom is not just the absence of confinement. It is the capacity to use that absence well. The door can be open. You still have to choose to walk through it. And walking through it is harder than it looks.

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Back on Stage: First Public Appearance October 2024

The invitation came, and I accepted it before I had fully thought through what it would mean. This is a pattern in my life—saying yes to opportunities and figuring out the implications later. It has served me well in some contexts and poorly in others. This time, I was not sure which it would be.

The event was in Dubai, in October 2024. I will not name the specific conference, because the details are less important than the experience. It was a blockchain industry gathering, the kind I had attended dozens of times before my legal troubles began. The same hotels, the same conference centers, the same mix of genuine builders and opportunists and curious onlookers.

What was different was me. Or rather, my relationship to the event. In the past, I had been a central figure. The founder of Binance, the largest cryptocurrency exchange in the world. The person everyone wanted to meet, to photograph, to quote. I had grown accustomed to that role, perhaps too accustomed. It had become part of my identity.

Now I was something else. Still “CZ,” still recognized, still of interest to the media and the industry. But the context had shifted. I was no longer the CEO of a major company. I was a former CEO who had served time in federal prison. The headlines would reflect this. The questions would reflect this.

The way people looked at me would reflect this.

I arrived in Dubai a day early. I wanted time to adjust, to walk around the city, to remember what it felt like to be in public without the structure of the halfway house or the restrictions of supervised release. Dubai was familiar. I had been there many times. But everything looked slightly different now, filtered through the lens of my changed circumstances.

The morning of the event, I spent longer than usual preparing. Not because I was nervous, exactly. I do not experience nervousness the way some people do. But I was aware of the performance aspect of what I was about to do. I would be on stage. I would be watched. I would be judged. And I needed to decide, consciously, how I wanted to present myself.

I chose restraint. This was not a moment for grand pronouncements or dramatic gestures. It was a moment for presence, for showing up, for demonstrating that I was still engaged with the industry I had helped build. The content of what I said mattered less than the fact of my being there.

The room was full. This surprised me, though it should not have. Curiosity is a powerful force. People wanted to see what I would look like, what I would say, whether I had changed. I understood this curiosity because I had felt it myself, watching other public figures navigate their own falls and attempted returns.

The moderator asked the expected questions. About my time in prison. About my reflections on what had happened. About my plans for the future. I answered them as directly as I could, which was not very directly. Some things I could not discuss for legal reasons. Some things I did not fully understand myself. Some things were simply private.

What I said, in essence, was this: I had made mistakes. I had paid a price. I was moving forward. This was true, as far as it went. But it was also a performance, a narrative shaped for public consumption. The real story was more complicated, and I was not prepared to tell it in that setting.

The strangeness I had anticipated arrived, but not in the form I expected. It was not the questions that felt strange, or the attention, or the cameras. It was the role reversal. For years, I had been the protagonist of my own story, the central figure around whom events revolved. Now I was a supporting

character in a larger narrative about cryptocurrency, regulation, and the future of finance. People were interested in me, but they were interested in me as a symbol, not as a person.

This is a difficult thing to accept. We all want to believe that we are the protagonists of our own lives, that our choices matter, that our stories have meaning. And they do, but not always in the ways we imagine. Sometimes we are primarily interesting for what we represent to others, not for who we actually are.

I watched the other speakers, the panels, the networking sessions. The industry had continued without me, as industries do. New projects had launched. New controversies had emerged. New leaders had risen to prominence. I was not irrelevant, but I was no longer central. This was neither good nor bad. It was simply true.

After my session, people approached me. Some wanted selfies. Some wanted advice. Some wanted to pitch projects. I engaged with them as I always had—politely, briefly, trying to be helpful without making commitments I could not keep. But there was a distance now that had not been there before. I was no longer one of them, exactly. I was something else. A cautionary tale, perhaps. Or a survivor. Or just a person who had been through something difficult and was still figuring out what came next.

The media coverage was predictable. “CZ Returns,” some headlines read. “Former Binance CEO Makes First Public Appearance Since Prison.” The photographs showed me looking serious, or thoughtful, or whatever expression I had happened to have when the camera clicked. I did not read most of the articles. I had learned that lesson long ago: the media version of events rarely matches the lived experience.

What stayed with me was not the event itself but the feeling of being watched without being understood. The audience saw what they expected to see. The journalists wrote what fit their narratives. The industry participants processed my presence through their own frameworks of opportunity and threat. And I stood in the middle of it all, aware of the gap between how I was perceived and who I actually was.

This is not a complaint. It is simply an observation about the nature

of public life. We are all, to some degree, prisoners of other people's perceptions. The difference for someone in my position is the scale. Millions of people have an opinion about me based on fragments of information, headlines and tweets and secondhand accounts. They believe they know me. They do not.

I left Dubai with a clearer sense of what my public role would be going forward. Not absent—I was not prepared to disappear entirely. But limited. Carefully chosen. I would appear when I had something specific to say or do. I would not chase the spotlight. I had learned that the costs of visibility were higher than I had once understood.

The cautious tone I tried to strike in that first appearance has persisted. I am not euphoric about my return. I am not bitter about what happened. I am simply present, doing what I can with the circumstances I have. This is not a dramatic narrative. It is, I believe, an honest one.

Facing the camera again was strange, but not for the reasons I expected. The strangeness was not in the attention itself. It was in recognizing that I was no longer the protagonist of the story being told. I was a character in someone else's narrative, and my job was to play that role with as much integrity as I could muster, even when the script did not match my experience.

Giggle Academy

In March 2024, while I was still in the facility in California, I released a concept document. It was brief—just a few paragraphs and some bullet points. The title was “Giggle Academy,” a name that sounded light, almost playful, which was intentional. I wanted to signal that this was not another cryptocurrency project. It was something different. Something, I hoped, simpler and more direct.

The concept was straightforward: free basic education for grades 1–12, delivered through technology, made engaging through gamification, personalized through adaptive learning systems. No revenue model. No token. No blockchain, except perhaps as a credentialing mechanism in the future. Just education, available to anyone with a device and an internet connection.

The response was mixed, as responses always are. Some people were genuinely interested in the educational possibilities. Others saw it as a distraction, a public relations move, an attempt to change the subject from my legal troubles. A few wondered aloud why a cryptocurrency exchange founder would pivot to elementary school mathematics.

These reactions were fair. I would have had similar questions in their position. What I could not explain at the time, because I was still figuring it out myself, was how directly the project emerged from my experience of losing freedom.

When you cannot control your environment—when you cannot choose where you sleep, what you eat, how you spend your time—you are forced to recalculate what matters. This is not a philosophical exercise. It is a practical necessity. The mind needs something to focus on, something to work toward, something that gives the days meaning beyond mere endurance.

I thought about my own education. I had been fortunate. I grew up in a family that valued learning. I had access to books, to teachers, to opportunities. Not everyone has these things. The gap between those who do and those who do not is not just unfair. It is wasteful. Human potential is distributed randomly across geography and circumstance. Education is the tool we have to capture more of that potential.

This is not a new insight. People have been saying versions of it for centuries. But there is a difference between acknowledging an idea and feeling compelled to act on it. My compulsion came from the specific circumstances of my confinement. I had time to think. I had time to read. I had time to imagine what might be possible if the right resources were applied in the right way.

The Gigggle Academy concept that emerged was pragmatic, not utopian. I did not imagine that technology alone could solve the problems of education. I did not believe that an app could replace teachers, or that gamification could make learning effortless. What I believed—what I still believe—is that technology can extend the reach of good educational practices, can make them available to people who would otherwise have no access, can adapt to individual learners in ways that traditional classrooms often cannot.

The original announcement stated the core principles clearly: “Free basic education for grades 1–12. No revenue. Gamified. Adaptive.” These were not afterthoughts. They were central to the design. The decision to forgo revenue was particularly important to me. I had spent my career building businesses. I understood the pressure that revenue requirements create, the way they shape decision-making, sometimes in directions that conflict with the underlying mission. I wanted Gigggle Academy to be free from that pressure.

After my release, I was able to move from concept to implementation. This

was not a rapid process. Building anything of quality takes time, and I was determined not to rush. I had seen what happened when speed took priority over care. I was not going to make that mistake again.

The team came together gradually. Some were people I had worked with before, who understood my methods and my standards. Others were new, drawn by the mission rather than by any personal connection to me. This was important. I did not want Giggle Academy to be “CZ’s project.” I wanted it to be a genuine educational initiative, judged on its own merits.

We started with mathematics and language arts, the foundational subjects that everything else builds on. We focused on the early grades, where the gap between students who receive quality instruction and those who do not is most pronounced. We tested, iterated, tested again. The gamification elements went through dozens of revisions. What motivates a six-year-old is not the same as what motivates a twelve-year-old. What works in one cultural context does not work in another.

The adaptive systems were perhaps the most technically challenging aspect. True personalization requires understanding not just what a student knows but how they learn—what kinds of explanations resonate, what kinds of practice are most effective, what kinds of feedback produce improvement. This is difficult to achieve at scale. We are still working on it.

Throughout this process, I tried to maintain the perspective I had developed in silence. Not everything needs to be big. Not everything needs to grow exponentially. Some things can simply be useful, can help some people in some ways, and that is enough. This was a difficult adjustment for me. I had spent my career pursuing scale, measuring success in millions of users and billions of transactions. Giggle Academy required a different metric.

The question I ask now is simpler: is a child learning something they would not have learned otherwise? If the answer is yes, even for a small number of children, the project has value. This is not how venture capital thinks. It is not how I thought for most of my career. But it is how I think now.

The warmth I feel toward this project is not sentimental. It is practical. I have seen what happens when people receive education they thought was out of reach. I have read the messages from parents in countries where quality

schooling is unavailable or unaffordable. I have watched the usage data show real engagement, real progress, real learning. These are not dramatic transformations. They are small, incremental improvements in individual lives. But they accumulate.

There is a temptation, when discussing education, to become grandiose. To speak of changing the world, of solving global problems, of creating a better future. I resist this temptation. Not because I do not believe in the importance of education—I do. But because I have learned that grandiosity often masks a lack of specificity. It is easier to talk about changing the world than to figure out how to teach fractions effectively to a child who has never seen a physical representation of a number.

Giggle Academy is specific. It is focused on concrete skills, concrete learners, concrete improvements. The technology is a means, not an end. The gamification is a tool, not a gimmick. The adaptivity is a method, not a magic solution. Everything is designed to serve the basic goal: helping children learn.

This is the work I do now. It is quieter than running a cryptocurrency exchange. It generates fewer headlines, attracts less controversy, produces smaller numbers. But it feels aligned with something I discovered in confinement: the value of doing something useful, something that helps people directly, something that does not require constant defense or explanation.

When you lose your freedom, you recalculate what matters most. For me, that recalculation led here. Not to a dramatic new chapter or a bold reinvention. Just to a simple project, trying to do something worthwhile. That is enough.

Turning Binance Labs into Family Office: YZi Labs' New Role

On January 23, 2025, an announcement was made on X that marked a formal transition. Binance Labs, the venture arm I had established years earlier to invest in promising cryptocurrency projects, would be rebranded as YZi Labs. The name was simpler, more personal. The mission was broader, extending beyond blockchain into artificial intelligence and biotechnology. And the structure was different—operating as a family office, independent from Binance, with me as the primary decision-maker.

The official post emphasized this independence. It was not a subsidiary. It was not a division. It was a separate entity, making its own choices, bearing its own risks, accountable to no one but itself and its investors. This distinction mattered to me. I had learned something about the costs of operating at scale, about the scrutiny that comes with being part of a large organization, about the ways that public attention can distort decision-making.

The transition from operator to investor is not unique to my situation. Many entrepreneurs eventually step back from day-to-day management to focus on capital allocation. They discover, or so the conventional narrative goes, that their skills are better suited to identifying opportunities than to executing them. That they can create more value by backing others than by

doing the work themselves.

This narrative is partially true. But it is also incomplete. The shift from operator to investor is not just about optimizing skills or maximizing returns. It is about a different relationship to control. When you run a company, you control everything—or at least, you try to. The product, the team, the culture, the strategy. The successes are yours. The failures are yours. The identity of the organization and your personal identity become intertwined in ways that are difficult to untangle.

When you invest, you give up that control. You provide capital, advice, connections. But the execution belongs to someone else. The product decisions, the hiring, the day-to-day crises—you are not there for them. You watch from a distance. You offer guidance when asked. You hope that your judgment was sound.

This is a different kind of work. It requires patience in ways that operating does not. When you are building something, there is always something to do. A fire to put out. A feature to launch. A competitor to respond to. The pace is relentless, but it is also engaging. You are constantly in motion.

Investing is slower. You make a decision, you write a check, and then you wait. Months pass. Years pass. Some investments fail quietly. Others succeed in ways you did not anticipate. The feedback loop is extended, sometimes to the point where you cannot clearly connect your actions to outcomes.

I have had to learn this rhythm. It does not come naturally to me. I am accustomed to moving fast, to seeing results quickly, to adjusting course based on immediate feedback. The pace of YZi Labs is different. We evaluate opportunities carefully. We conduct due diligence. We think about fit, about team, about market, about timing. And then we commit, knowing that the real test will not come for years.

The expansion into AI and biotech reflects this longer-term thinking. These are not sectors where you can build a product in weeks and launch it to millions of users. They require deep expertise, extended development cycles, regulatory navigation. The returns, if they come, may take a decade or more. This is a different kind of investing than the cryptocurrency space I came from, where projects could go from concept to market in months.

But it is also, I believe, a more sustainable kind. The hype cycles of crypto taught me something about the relationship between speed and durability. Things that grow fast can also collapse fast. Foundations that are built slowly, carefully, with attention to fundamentals, tend to last longer.

The family office structure supports this approach. Without external limited partners to report to, without the pressure to deploy capital on a specific timeline, we can be selective. We can wait for the right opportunity rather than forcing investments to meet arbitrary targets. We can support companies through difficult periods without worrying about quarterly returns.

This is not to say that we are passive. The companies we invest in receive significant attention. I meet with founders regularly. I offer what I have learned from my own experiences, both the successes and the failures. I try to be useful without being controlling. This is a balance I am still learning to strike.

The psychology of this role is complex. On one hand, there is relief in not being responsible for everything. In not waking up to crises that require immediate response. In not having my name attached to every decision, every controversy, every mistake. The distance provides a kind of protection.

On the other hand, there is a loss. The intensity of building something, the camaraderie of a team working toward a common goal, the satisfaction of seeing your vision realized—these are not easily replicated in the investor role. You are adjacent to the action, not in the middle of it. You celebrate others' victories rather than your own.

I am coming to terms with this trade-off. It is the trade-off I have chosen, deliberately, as part of my changed circumstances. I could have tried to build another operating company. I could have attempted to replicate what I did with Binance. But I did not want to. The costs were too high, and not just the legal costs. The personal costs. The cost of being constantly visible, constantly accountable, constantly under pressure.

YZi Labs allows me to stay engaged with technology and innovation without bearing the full weight of public attention. It allows me to support projects I believe in without needing to control them. It allows me to work

at a pace that feels sustainable, that leaves room for other things—family, health, the education work that has become increasingly important to me.

The transformation is not dramatic. I am still working long hours. I am still thinking about markets and technology and competitive dynamics. I am still making decisions that affect other people's lives and livelihoods. But the context is different. The stakes are different. The relationship between my work and my identity is different.

From operator to investor. From control to influence. From speed to patience. These are the shifts that YZi Labs represents. They are not better or worse than what came before. They are simply what is possible now, given where I am and what I have learned. And they are enough.

SEC Dismissal: End of a Lawsuit

On May 29, 2025, the Securities and Exchange Commission filed a notice of voluntary dismissal with prejudice. The words have specific legal meaning. “Voluntary” means the SEC chose to end the case. “With prejudice” means they cannot refile it. The lawsuit was over. The allegations would not be pursued. The matter was closed.

I learned about it the way most people learn about legal developments affecting them—through my attorneys, who called with the news. There was a formality to the conversation that did not match the significance of what was being communicated. Years of litigation, millions of dollars in legal fees, countless hours of preparation and deposition and negotiation, all ending with a procedural filing and a phone call.

My reaction was not what I might have expected. There was relief, certainly. The weight of an active lawsuit is not something you consciously carry, but it is always there, in the background, affecting decisions, limiting options, creating a low-grade anxiety that becomes so familiar you stop noticing it. When it lifts, you feel lighter without quite knowing why.

But there was no celebration. I did not gather friends to toast the victory. I did not post triumphant messages on social media. I did not allow myself to feel vindicated, because I was not vindicated. The dismissal was not a finding of innocence. It was not a declaration that I had done nothing wrong. It was simply an end.

This distinction matters. In the public narrative of legal proceedings, there is a tendency to treat outcomes as verdicts on character. If charges are dropped, the person must be innocent. If someone settles, they must be guilty. But the legal system does not work this way. Cases end for many reasons—resource constraints, strategic calculations, changes in enforcement priorities, assessments of likely outcomes. The end of a case reveals little about the underlying conduct.

The SEC's decision to dismiss "with prejudice" was significant. It meant they were not preserving the option to refile later, not keeping the threat alive for future leverage. They were walking away completely. This suggested a definitive assessment that continuing the case was not worth the cost, or that the legal theory was weaker than initially believed, or that priorities had shifted at the agency.

What it did not suggest was that I had been proven right. I had made mistakes in how Binance operated. I had acknowledged some of them in my plea agreement. The dismissal did not erase those mistakes. It simply meant that this particular legal vehicle for addressing them was no longer in motion.

I thought about the other parties involved. The SEC attorneys who had worked on the case, who had devoted years of their careers to building theories and gathering evidence, who now had to explain to their supervisors why the case was being abandoned. The judges who had managed the litigation, who had issued rulings and managed schedules and tried to move the parties toward resolution. The journalists who had covered the proceedings, who had built narratives around the conflict that would now need to be revised.

Legal proceedings create their own ecosystems. They employ people. They generate content. They shape public understanding. When they end, the ecosystem collapses. The participants move on to other matters. The public attention shifts elsewhere. What seemed like a defining struggle becomes a footnote.

I tried to avoid the temptation to interpret the dismissal as a validation of my position. This was difficult. The human mind wants to create coherent

narratives, to connect events in ways that support our self-image. The dismissal could easily be folded into a story about perseverance, about truth ultimately prevailing, about the resilience of someone who refused to be defeated.

But that story would be false. Or at least, it would be incomplete. The truth is that I do not know why the SEC chose to dismiss the case. The reasons were not publicly disclosed in detail. I can speculate, but speculation is not knowledge. And building a narrative on speculation is a form of self-deception.

What I know is this: the lawsuit is over. I am no longer defending against these particular allegations. The resources that were devoted to that defense can now be directed elsewhere. The uncertainty that hung over my future has been reduced, though not eliminated. There are other legal matters, other jurisdictions, other potential challenges. But this one is finished.

The feeling is complex. Relief mixed with something else—perhaps a kind of emptiness. When you have been fighting something for a long time, the fight becomes part of your identity. You organize your life around it. You develop habits of vigilance, of defensiveness, of constant preparation for the next attack. When the fight ends, those habits do not immediately dissolve. They persist, searching for new objects, new threats to anticipate.

I am working on letting go. On accepting that this chapter is closed without needing to assign it a moral meaning. On recognizing that the end of a lawsuit is not the end of consequences, that the things I did and the choices I made will continue to shape my life in ways I cannot fully predict or control.

The dismissal is not a victory. It is not a defeat. It is simply a fact, a change in legal status that alters my options without resolving the underlying questions about what happened and why. I am trying to hold that complexity, to resist the pressure to simplify it into something more emotionally satisfying.

There will be no victory declaration. No statement of vindication. No attempt to rewrite history in my favor. Just this: the case is closed. I am moving forward. The work continues.

Pardon: When Power Turns the Case File Over

The news arrived in late October 2025. October 21, some reports said. October 23, others claimed. The exact date is less important than what it signified: a presidential pardon had been granted, wiping clean the federal conviction that had shadowed my life for more than a year.

The document itself was brief, as pardon documents are. It stated that I was “granted a full and unconditional pardon” for my conviction. The language was formal, almost mechanical. The power it represented was anything but.

A pardon is a strange legal instrument. It does not declare that the conviction was wrong. It does not find that the defendant was innocent. It simply sets aside the legal consequence, as if the crime had never occurred in the eyes of the law. The conviction is erased. The rights are restored. The slate, in a very specific sense, is wiped clean.

But the slate is not actually clean. This is the complexity that I have struggled to articulate, even to myself. A pardon changes legal status. It does not change history. It does not change what I did or did not do. It does not change the experiences of the people affected by my actions. It does not change the lessons I learned or failed to learn.

The public reaction was immediate and divided. Supporters saw the

pardon as justice delayed but finally delivered. Critics saw it as evidence of improper influence, of wealth buying outcomes, of a broken system that treats powerful people differently. Both views contained elements of truth. Neither captured the full picture.

I felt relief. This is the honest response, and I see no reason to disguise it. The pardon removed a significant legal disability. It restored rights that had been restricted. It closed a chapter that had been open for too long. The relief was real and immediate.

But I also felt unease. The pardon came from power, exercised through a process that is inherently political. It was not the outcome of a judicial review that found errors in my case. It was not the result of new evidence that exonerated me. It was a decision made by one person, for reasons that were not fully explained, using authority that is essentially unchecked.

This is how the pardon power works. It is designed to be arbitrary, to allow mercy where the law might be too rigid, to correct injustices that the normal legal process cannot address. But its arbitrariness is also its limitation. A pardon does not provide the satisfaction of vindication through process. It provides only the result, disconnected from any finding of merit.

I am grateful for the result. I am also aware of what it cost, not in money but in something less tangible. The pardon places me in a category of people who received special treatment, who were able to access a remedy unavailable to most. This is not something I requested or engineered. But it is something I accepted, and accepting it has consequences for how I am perceived and how I perceive myself.

The controversy surrounding the pardon was predictable. In a polarized political environment, any action by a president becomes fodder for partisan argument. My case was no exception. Supporters of the administration praised the decision as correcting an overreach by the previous administration's enforcement apparatus. Critics condemned it as corrupt, as evidence that the justice system favors the wealthy and well-connected.

I have no comment on these political interpretations. They are not about me, ultimately. They are about larger conflicts that my case happens to intersect with. I am a symbol in these arguments, not a participant. The

actual person I am—my intentions, my regrets, my efforts to learn from my mistakes—is largely irrelevant to the narrative being constructed.

What I can speak to is my own experience of receiving a pardon. The document arrives, and suddenly legal categories shift. You are no longer a felon. You can vote. You can serve on a jury. You can hold certain licenses and positions that were previously barred. The law no longer sees you as having committed the crime for which you were convicted.

But you still remember. You still know what you did. You still carry the weight of the choices you made, the people you affected, the consequences that flowed from your actions. A pardon does not erase memory. It does not erase consequence. It changes legal status, but it does not change the past.

I have tried to hold both of these truths at once. The pardon is a gift, unearned and unexpected, that improves my legal position and expands my options. It is also a reminder of the arbitrary nature of power, of how outcomes can depend on factors entirely outside one's control, of how justice and mercy are not the same thing.

The relief and unease coexist. They are not contradictory. They are simply different aspects of a complex reality. I am relieved to have this legal burden removed. I am uneasy about how it was removed. Both feelings are valid. Both are true.

I have not made a public display of gratitude. This is not because I am ungrateful. It is because gratitude in this context is complicated. To whom am I grateful? For what, exactly? The pardon was not a personal favor. It was an exercise of constitutional authority, made for reasons I do not fully know and cannot properly assess. Expressing gratitude would feel like performing a role, adopting a narrative that does not match my actual experience.

What I can say is this: the pardon changes my legal status, but it does not change my commitment to the work I have undertaken since my release. Giggle Academy continues. YZi Labs continues. The projects I am involved in, the people I am trying to help, the lessons I am trying to apply—none of this depends on my legal status. It depends on my choices, my effort, my willingness to keep going even when the path is uncertain.

The case file has been turned over. The legal chapter is closed. But the

story continues, and I am still writing it. That is the only power I have—the power to choose what I do next, how I respond to the circumstances I find myself in, what kind of person I try to become. The pardon gives me more freedom to make those choices. It does not make the choices for me.

Reputation Battle: Suing WSJ and New Round of Questions

In March 2026, my attorneys filed a defamation lawsuit against the Wall Street Journal. The specific allegations are a matter of public record, available to anyone who wishes to review the court filings. I will not detail them here. The lawsuit speaks for itself, in the language that lawsuits use—careful, precise, burdened with the need to meet legal standards rather than narrative ones.

What I want to explain is why. Not the legal theory, which is my attorneys' domain. But the personal calculus. The decision to sue a major media organization is not one made lightly. It is expensive, time-consuming, and likely to generate more coverage of the very claims you are trying to correct. Most people in my position choose to ignore negative coverage, to let it fade into the background noise of public life. I had done this many times before.

What changed was my understanding of what reputation is and why it matters. For most of my career, I treated reputation as a secondary concern. The important thing was building something useful, creating value, solving problems. If people misunderstood me or my intentions, that was unfortunate but not critical. The work would speak for itself.

This view was naive. Reputation is not separate from work. It is the context in which work is received. A good reputation opens doors, attracts

partners, creates opportunities. A damaged reputation closes doors, drives away potential collaborators, limits what is possible. The work does not speak for itself. It is heard through the filter of who people believe you to be.

I learned this lesson slowly, through experience. After my legal troubles began, I noticed how the coverage of Binance shifted. The same actions that had been portrayed as innovative were now portrayed as reckless. The same growth that had been celebrated was now treated as suspicious. The facts had not changed. The filter had.

This is not a complaint about media bias. The media reports what seems newsworthy, and legal problems are inherently newsworthy. The framing reflects genuine uncertainty about what my actions meant, what they revealed about my character, whether I could be trusted. I understand the questions. I have asked similar questions about others in my position.

But there is a difference between legitimate questioning and false claims. Between skepticism and fabrication. Between reporting that challenges your narrative and reporting that invents facts to support a predetermined conclusion. When the Wall Street Journal published its article, I believed it crossed that line.

The decision to sue was not about revenge. It was not about punishing the publication or the reporters. It was about establishing a boundary. There are limits to what can be said about a person, even a public person, even a person who has made mistakes. When those limits are crossed, there must be consequences. Otherwise, the limits mean nothing.

The lawsuit was filed in March 2026. Reuters reported it. The Guardian reported it. The coverage was predictable—another chapter in the ongoing saga of CZ versus the media, another example of a wealthy person using the courts to silence criticism. These framings are not accurate, but they are not surprising. They fit existing narratives. They require less effort than engaging with the specifics of the case.

What happened next was also predictable. The defendants moved to dismiss. They argued that the claims did not meet the legal standards for defamation, that the statements were protected opinion, that the public interest justified broad latitude in reporting. These are standard defenses.

They are raised in almost every defamation case.

The court's decision came later. The civil case was dismissed, though with leave to refile. This is a technical outcome that means different things in different contexts. In this case, it meant that the court found issues with how the claims were pleaded, but did not foreclose the possibility of proceeding with amended allegations. The door was not closed. It was simply not open yet.

I am not going to interpret this outcome as a victory or a defeat. It is a procedural step in a longer process. The legal system moves slowly. It requires patience. It rarely provides the clear resolutions that narrative demands.

What I have learned from this experience is something about the nature of reputation in the digital age. It is more fragile than I understood. More easily damaged. More difficult to repair. A single article can shape millions of perceptions. A single false claim can travel farther than any correction. The asymmetry between accusation and defense is profound.

This is not a reason to abandon the effort. It is a reason to be more strategic about it. To choose battles carefully. To recognize that not every slight requires response, but that some do. To understand that reputation is an asset that requires protection, not through constant self-promotion but through the willingness to stand up when important lines are crossed.

I thought for a long time that I did not care what people said about me. This was a form of self-protection, a way of insulating myself from the pain of public criticism. But I have come to understand that caring is not weakness. It is realism. What people believe about you affects what you can do. Ignoring that fact does not make it less true.

The lawsuit against the Wall Street Journal is an expression of this care. It says that there are limits. That accuracy matters. That even someone who has made mistakes deserves to have those mistakes reported accurately, not embellished for effect. That the power of the press carries responsibility.

Whether the lawsuit succeeds is not entirely within my control. The legal process will unfold according to its own logic. I have made my case. I will continue to make it, through the channels that are available to me. And I will

continue to do the work that matters to me, regardless of how this particular battle ends.

Reputation is another asset. Like any asset, it can be damaged. Like any asset, it can be protected. The question is not whether to care about it. The question is how to care about it wisely, without becoming consumed by it, without losing sight of what really matters. I am still learning the answer.

The Freedom I Really Want: Money, Time, and Boundaries

On my personal mission page, there is a statement in Chinese that I wrote after my release. It says something like this: freedom is not about escaping rules, but about maintaining choice after understanding rules. The exact wording is there for anyone to read. The idea behind it has taken me years to fully grasp.

When I started in cryptocurrency, I thought freedom meant something different. It meant operating outside traditional financial systems. It meant bypassing intermediaries. It meant creating options that did not exist before. These are real forms of freedom, and Binance provided them to millions of people. But they are not the only forms, and they are not the most important ones.

What I have come to understand is that freedom has dimensions that are not captured by the technical ability to transfer value without permission. There is the freedom of time—the ability to choose how you spend your days, who you spend them with, what you work on and why. There is the freedom of attention—the ability to focus on what matters without constant distraction, without the pressure to respond to every demand immediately. There is the freedom of boundaries—the ability to say no, to limit your commitments, to protect space for rest and reflection.

These freedoms are harder to achieve than the technical ones. They require something more than clever code or efficient systems. They require discipline. They require saying no to opportunities that are genuinely attractive. They require accepting limits that are self-imposed rather than externally enforced.

I did not have these freedoms when I was running Binance. I had money, certainly. More than I needed. But I did not have time. My days were scheduled in fifteen-minute increments. My attention was constantly fragmented by emergencies and demands. My boundaries were porous—I was always available, always responding, always trying to stay ahead of the next crisis.

This was not sustainable. I knew it at the time, but I did not act on the knowledge. The momentum of the organization carried me forward. The sense of responsibility to users, to employees, to the industry kept me working even when I was exhausted. I told myself that I would rest later, that the current crisis was temporary, that things would calm down eventually.

They did not calm down. Organizations at scale do not calm down. They generate their own urgency, their own crises, their own demands. The only way to create space is to step back deliberately, to establish boundaries and defend them, to accept that some things will not get done and that this is okay.

I learned this lesson through forced removal. Prison and the halfway house created boundaries that I could not cross. The restrictions were external, not chosen. But they had an unexpected effect: they taught me what boundaries felt like. They showed me that life continued even when I was not constantly managing it. That the world did not collapse when I was not immediately available to respond.

This was a revelation. I had built my identity around responsiveness, around the ability to handle anything that came up, around being the person who could solve problems others could not. Letting go of that identity was painful. But it was also liberating.

Now, I am trying to create boundaries by choice rather than by necessity. This is harder than it sounds. The habits of constant availability are deeply

ingrained. The fear that something important will be missed is persistent. The temptation to check one more message, to respond to one more request, to solve one more problem is always there.

But I am learning. I schedule time that is not for work. I turn off notifications. I let some emails go unanswered. I say no to opportunities that do not align with my priorities, even when they are genuinely attractive. I am building a life that has space in it, not just activity.

The freedom of money is real. I do not want to minimize it. Having resources means having options. It means not worrying about basic needs. It means being able to help others, to invest in projects you believe in, to weather setbacks that would destroy someone without a financial cushion.

But money is not sufficient for freedom. It is a tool, not a destination. What matters is what you do with it, how you allocate the time it buys you, whether you use it to create more freedom or just more activity. I spent years using money to create more work for myself. I am trying now to use it to create more space.

The mission statement on my page has evolved. It still includes the goal of advancing financial freedom through technology. That work continues through YZi Labs, through the projects I support, through the advocacy I engage in when appropriate. But it now includes something else: the pursuit of a different kind of freedom, one that is personal rather than systemic, internal rather than external.

This freedom is about maintaining choice after understanding rules. Not breaking the rules. Not ignoring them. Understanding them, accepting them, and then finding the space within them to make choices that align with your values. This is a quieter freedom than the revolutionary kind. It is less dramatic. But it is, I believe, more durable.

The rules I operate under now are different from the ones I operated under before. Some are legal, the residue of my conviction and its aftermath. Some are self-imposed, the boundaries I am trying to establish. Some are simply the rules of being human—the need for rest, for connection, for meaning that cannot be found in constant activity.

Understanding these rules has changed what freedom means to me. It is

no longer about maximizing options. It is about choosing wisely among the options I have. It is not about escaping constraints. It is about finding the freedom that exists within them.

This is the freedom I really want. Not the freedom to do anything, but the freedom to do what matters. Not the freedom from all obligations, but the freedom to choose my obligations deliberately. Not the freedom of infinite possibility, but the freedom of clear purpose.

I am closer to this freedom now than I have been in years. Not because my circumstances are easier—though in many ways they are—but because my understanding is deeper. I know what I want. I know what I am willing to give up to have it. And I am learning, slowly, to actually give those things up.

Freedom of Money

In the year-end reports I used to write for Binance, there was a phrase that appeared regularly: “advance the freedom of money.” It was not just a slogan. It was the organizing principle of everything we built. We believed that financial freedom was a fundamental human right, that access to economic opportunity should not depend on where you were born or what passport you held, that technology could democratize finance in the same way it had democratized information.

I still believe this. The conviction has survived everything—legal troubles, incarceration, public criticism, personal transformation. The freedom of money remains worth pursuing. But my understanding of what that freedom means has deepened, complicated by experience, enriched by loss, tempered by the recognition that freedom always has a price.

The price I have paid is not just the obvious one. Not just the months in federal facilities, the legal fees, the restrictions on my activities. Those are the visible costs, the ones that appear in headlines and court documents. The deeper price is harder to quantify. It is the loss of the identity I had constructed, the narrative I had told myself about who I was and what I was doing. It is the recognition that good intentions are not sufficient protection against bad outcomes. That building something useful does not exempt you from responsibility for its misuse. That freedom for some can mean harm for others.

I have paid this price, and I am still paying it. Not in a spirit of martyrdom—I made choices that led to these consequences, and I accept them. But in a spirit of honesty. If freedom does not cost anything, it is probably an illusion. Real freedom, the kind that changes lives and structures societies, always extracts a price from someone. The question is who pays it and whether the exchange is worth making.

When I started Binance in 2017, I did not think much about these questions. I was focused on the technical challenge—building a system that could handle millions of transactions, that could remain stable under extreme load, that could provide reliable service to users around the world. The political and philosophical dimensions of the work were secondary, if they registered at all.

This was a failure of imagination. Not a unique failure—many technology founders focus on the technical problems first and deal with the social implications later, if ever. But a failure nonetheless. I built a system for moving money across borders without asking deeply enough about who would use it and for what purposes. I created freedom without fully considering its costs.

The years since have been a process of catching up. Of understanding what I built and what it meant. Of accepting responsibility for the consequences, intended and unintended. Of trying to do better, not by abandoning the goal of financial freedom but by pursuing it more thoughtfully, with greater awareness of the trade-offs involved.

The timeline from 2023 to 2026 traces this evolution. The guilty plea in November 2023, the resignation as CEO, the months in California, the halfway house, the release, the pardon, the lawsuits and dismissals and ongoing controversies. Each event taught me something. Each forced me to reconsider what I believed and why.

What I have learned is that the freedom of money is not a single thing. It has multiple dimensions, some of which conflict with others. There is the freedom to transact without permission, which I still believe is fundamental. There is the freedom from surveillance, which matters more to some people than others. There is the freedom to participate in global markets regardless

of local restrictions, which can be liberating for individuals and destabilizing for governments. There is the freedom to innovate without waiting for regulatory approval, which accelerates progress and creates risks.

These freedoms are not automatically compatible. The freedom to transact anonymously can conflict with the freedom to operate in a system free from criminal exploitation. The freedom to innovate quickly can conflict with the freedom of users to be protected from defective products. Navigating these tensions requires judgment, not just technical skill. It requires a willingness to make difficult choices about which freedoms to prioritize and which to limit.

I did not navigate these tensions well enough. This is not false modesty. It is an honest assessment of my performance as CEO of Binance. I moved too fast in some areas, not fast enough in others. I prioritized growth over compliance in ways that created vulnerabilities. I resisted regulation longer than I should have, seeing it as a threat to the mission rather than a necessary framework for sustainable operation.

These mistakes had consequences. Real consequences for real people. Employees who lost jobs. Users who lost access to services. Investors who lost money. Communities that were harmed by scams and frauds that operated on platforms I built. I cannot undo these consequences. I can only acknowledge them and try to do better going forward.

The work I do now—Giggle Academy, YZi Labs, the various projects I support—reflects this attempt to do better. It is not as visible as running a major exchange. It does not generate the same headlines or attract the same attention. But it is, I believe, more aligned with the values that should have guided me all along. Building things that help people directly. Supporting innovation that addresses real problems. Using resources to create opportunity rather than just to create more resources.

The freedom of money is still part of this work. YZi Labs invests in blockchain projects that are advancing financial access in parts of the world where traditional banking has failed. I continue to believe that cryptocurrency has a role to play in creating a more inclusive financial system. But I am more careful now about how that belief is expressed, more

aware of the complexities, more respectful of the legitimate concerns that regulators and critics raise.

If there is a lesson in my experience, it is this: freedom is not the absence of constraint. It is the intelligent navigation of constraint. The cryptocurrency movement was right to challenge the limitations of traditional finance. But it was wrong to imagine that all constraints were illegitimate, that any regulation was oppression, that freedom meant simply doing whatever was technically possible.

Real freedom requires structure. It requires rules that are understood and accepted, even when they limit individual choice. It requires institutions that can enforce those rules fairly and consistently. It requires a balance between innovation and stability, between access and protection, between the new and the established.

Finding this balance is not a technical problem. It is a political problem, a social problem, a human problem. It requires conversation and compromise, the willingness to listen to perspectives different from your own, the humility to recognize that your vision is not the only valid one.

I am trying to practice this humility now. It does not come naturally to me. I have spent most of my life believing that I was right, that my view of the world was correct, that the obstacles I faced were the result of others' misunderstanding or bad faith. This belief served me well in some contexts. It allowed me to persist when others would have given up, to build things that seemed impossible.

But it also blinded me to important truths. To the legitimate concerns of regulators. To the real harms that could flow from the systems I created. To the ways that my own perspective was limited by my experience and position. I am trying to see more clearly now, to hold my beliefs more lightly, to be more open to correction.

The freedom of money that I want to advance now is different from the freedom I pursued in 2017. It is more modest in its claims, more aware of trade-offs, more respectful of the complexity of the world. It is not about replacing traditional finance but about complementing it, about filling gaps rather than destroying systems, about creating options rather than imposing

solutions.

This freedom is worth the price. Not because the price is small—it is not. But because the alternative, a world where financial access is determined by geography and status and connections, is worse. Technology can help change this. It cannot change it alone. It requires people willing to do the hard work of building, regulating, iterating, improving.

I am still doing this work. More quietly than before. More carefully. With greater awareness of what can go wrong and greater commitment to preventing it. The mission has not changed, but the method has. The goal is still to advance the freedom of money. The path to that goal is now more winding than I once believed.

If you have read this far, you may be wondering what to take from my story. I am not sure I have a clear answer. I am still living it, still figuring it out, still making mistakes and trying to learn from them. But if there is one thing I would want to communicate, it is this: freedom is real, it is valuable, and it is costly. Do not pursue it blindly. Do not imagine that it comes without obligation. Do not forget that your freedom can affect others, for better and for worse.

The freedom of money is worth fighting for. I have fought for it. I have paid for it. I will continue to fight for it, in the ways that are available to me now. But I will fight more thoughtfully than I once did, with greater awareness of what is at stake and who is affected. This is the only way I know to honor both the ideal and the reality, the promise and the price.

The story continues. The work continues. I continue, changed by what I have experienced but still committed to what I believe. The freedom of money is not a destination. It is a direction. And I am still walking in that direction, one step at a time.

Supplementary Essays

Additional reflections on access, trust, resilience, leadership, and the long work of building for users.

The pages that follow extend the book without changing the pages that came before them. They return to the same central questions from new angles: how financial freedom is experienced by ordinary people, how organizations earn or lose trust, how communities shape meaning, and how builders can carry ambition with more responsibility than before.

Access Is Experienced Locally

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a student opening a first account. In moments like that, financial freedom only becomes meaningful when ordinary people can use it without humiliation, confusion, or unnecessary delay. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but fees that were technically disclosed but emotionally surprising. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to support paths that reached a human being before frustration turned into abandonment. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

What made the situation difficult was the overlap of responsibilities. While trying to maintain speed and verification, we also faced fragmented feedback coming from users, regulators, and critics at the same time. Under those conditions, organizations often reach for theater: louder language, faster reactions, broader claims. I learned to distrust that instinct. The more durable answer was usually operational: support paths that reached a human being before frustration turned into abandonment; plain language before clever language; and a willingness to keep explaining the same reality until confusion began to shrink. Reliability is less glamorous than velocity, but users remember it longer.

My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. Inclusion is only real when it is understandable. I also believe access fails when it depends on expert interpretation, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time. A durable system is not one that avoids criticism; it is one that learns before criticism becomes catastrophe.

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I came to think about the friction people remember in very practical terms. The test was never whether a principle sounded persuasive in a meeting. The test was whether it held up for a merchant navigating unstable local currency, especially when the day was already complicated by interfaces that demanded confidence before trust had been earned. In those situations, the difference between inclusion and exclusion could be surprisingly small. A delayed explanation, an overloaded page, or a default that assumed too much confidence could quietly change who felt welcome to proceed. Plain language before clever language became more important to me because it turned abstract fairness into visible behavior.

The tension, most days, came from having to hold clarity and urgency at the same time as the temptation to treat short-term noise as long-term truth. Markets invite overreaction, and public narratives punish nuance, so it was tempting to confuse decisiveness with haste. I came to believe the opposite. Decisiveness often looked like plain language before clever language, like defaults that favored safety over excitement, and like writing down the trade-off before pretending there was none. Teams become steadier when they are allowed to admit complexity without surrendering momentum.

I do not think the answer is to become suspicious of progress. I think the answer is to attach progress to consequence more honestly. Access fails when it depends on expert interpretation. Dignity matters in small transactions. The point is not caution for its own sake. The point is to make sure that wider access does not depend on narrower empathy. Real trust is earned in the ordinary moments that most companies are tempted to dismiss as operational detail.

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Discipline Under Pressure

When I revisit the theme of discipline under pressure, I do not start with theory. I start with a family sending a modest remittance home and with the kind of moment shaped by onboarding steps that looked obvious to insiders but felt opaque to newcomers. That is where the rhetoric around freedom meets its operational test. If people have to decode intent before they can act, then the system is asking them to carry too much of the burden. Defaults that favored safety over excitement was valuable because it shifted that burden back to the builder, where more of it belonged.

There was no clean sequence for the work. We had to think about automation and human judgment while adapting to teams that were tired before the day had properly started, and the overlap exposed every weak habit. Under those conditions, even a small routine could matter disproportionately. Defaults that favored safety over excitement provided one kind of stability. Support paths that reached a human being before frustration turned into abandonment provided another. Together they created enough order for better judgment to survive a noisy environment.

Over time I found myself returning to a simpler standard. Dignity matters in small transactions, because users carry real obligations outside the screen. Inclusion is only real when it is understandable, because the cost of a careless decision is rarely limited to a chart or a metric. That standard has become the one I trust most when the environment grows noisy again. The future belongs to builders who can move with conviction without losing contact with consequence.

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What Teams Owe Users became clearer to me each time I watched a student opening a first account encounter fees that were technically disclosed but emotionally surprising. Those were the moments that stripped away vanity. You could see whether a product merely offered access on paper or whether it genuinely made participation easier. For all the sophistication of the industry, the core question stayed simple: did we make the next good decision more available? I trusted support paths that reached a human being before frustration turned into abandonment because it translated that question into something teams could actually do.

I rarely felt that the challenge could be reduced to one headline problem. We were carrying growth and restraint, while also absorbing the constant mismatch between public expectations and operational reality, and that meant every shortcut had a hidden cost. The habits that held up best were not heroic ones. They were operationally humble: support paths that reached a human being before frustration turned into abandonment, then plain language before clever language, then another explanation when the first explanation still left users with doubt. Repetition is not glamorous, but it is often where trust is rebuilt.

Looking back, my view has become narrower and firmer. Inclusion is only real when it is understandable. Access fails when it depends on expert interpretation. When teams remember that real people live on the other side of every dashboard, they stop using growth as an excuse and start treating growth as a responsibility. That shift does not eliminate trade-offs, but it improves the quality of how trade-offs are made. What appears to be product polish from the outside is often moral discipline on the inside.

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In practice, the work was rarely singular. We were balancing openness and abuse prevention while also dealing with the tendency of fast systems to hide slow failures until they became expensive. That combination made slogans feel inadequate. A team could not simply promise to care about users; it needed routines that survived stress. For me, that meant leaning on plain language before clever language, reinforcing defaults that favored safety over excitement, and accepting that some speed had to be exchanged for better judgment. None of this removed risk, but it changed the character of our response. It moved the organization away from performance and toward reliability.

If there is a conclusion I return to here, it is not that builders should move timidly. It is that ambition needs a frame sturdy enough to carry consequence. Access fails when it depends on expert interpretation, and dignity matters in small transactions for the same reason. Once a company understands that each small decision can reshape a person's confidence in the system, operational discipline stops looking optional. Freedom lasts longer when explanation and accountability grow alongside access.

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Products Teach Values

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Trust Is Operational

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a team lead reviewing an incident after midnight. In moments like that, trust is not an abstract sentiment but the cumulative result of routines, response times, and whether promises survive contact with stress. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but status pages that said little when users most needed specificity. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to incident notes written for understanding rather than self-protection. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

What made the situation difficult was the overlap of responsibilities. While trying to maintain openness and abuse prevention, we also faced the tendency of fast systems to hide slow failures until they became expensive. Under those conditions, organizations often reach for theater: louder language, faster reactions, broader claims. I learned to distrust that instinct. The more durable answer was usually operational: incident notes written for understanding rather than self-protection; measurable service standards that survived bad weeks as well as good ones; and a willingness to keep explaining the same reality until confusion began to shrink. Reliability is less glamorous than velocity, but users remember it longer.

My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. Trust compounds through repetition. I also believe operational ambiguity eventually becomes user anxiety, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time.

3. Trust Is Operational

The Friction People Remember

I came to think about the friction people remember in very practical terms. The test was never whether a principle sounded persuasive in a meeting. The test was whether it held up for a user waiting on a delayed transfer, especially when the day was already complicated by internal handoffs that turned one problem into three separate queues. In those situations, the difference between inclusion and exclusion could be surprisingly small. A delayed explanation, an overloaded page, or a default that assumed too much confidence could quietly change who felt welcome to proceed. Measurable service standards that survived bad weeks as well as good ones became more important to me because it turned abstract fairness into visible behavior.

The tension, most days, came from having to hold consistency and adaptation at the same time as situations where a small gap in explanation created a much larger gap in trust. Markets invite overreaction, and public narratives punish nuance, so it was tempting to confuse decisiveness with haste. I came to believe the opposite. Decisiveness often looked like measurable service standards that survived bad weeks as well as good ones, like clear escalation paths, and like writing down the trade-off before pretending there was none. Teams become steadier when they are allowed to admit complexity without surrendering momentum.

I do not think the answer is to become suspicious of progress. I think the answer is to attach progress to consequence more honestly. Operational ambiguity eventually becomes user anxiety. Systems earn credibility by behaving well under ordinary strain. The point is not caution for its own sake. The point is to make sure that wider access does not depend on narrower empathy. Real trust is earned in the ordinary moments that most companies are tempted to dismiss as operational detail.

3. Trust Is Operational

Discipline Under Pressure

When I revisit the theme of discipline under pressure, I do not start with theory. I start with a compliance operator checking an edge case and with the kind of moment shaped by moments when policy existed but ownership did not. That is where the rhetoric around freedom meets its operational test. If people have to decode intent before they can act, then the system is asking them to carry too much of the burden. Clear escalation paths was valuable because it shifted that burden back to the builder, where more of it belonged.

There was no clean sequence for the work. We had to think about technical confidence and public humility while adapting to rumors that traveled faster than corrections, and the overlap exposed every weak habit. Under those conditions, even a small routine could matter disproportionately. Clear escalation paths provided one kind of stability. Incident notes written for understanding rather than self-protection provided another. Together they created enough order for better judgment to survive a noisy environment.

Over time I found myself returning to a simpler standard. Systems earn credibility by behaving well under ordinary strain, because users carry real obligations outside the screen. Trust compounds through repetition, because the cost of a careless decision is rarely limited to a chart or a metric. That standard has become the one I trust most when the environment grows noisy again. The future belongs to builders who can move with conviction without losing contact with consequence.

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What Teams Owe Users

What Teams Owe Users became clearer to me each time I watched a team lead reviewing an incident after midnight encounter status pages that said little when users most needed specificity. Those were the moments that stripped away vanity. You could see whether a product merely offered access on paper or whether it genuinely made participation easier. For all the sophistication of the industry, the core question stayed simple: did we make the next good decision more available? I trusted incident notes written for understanding rather than self-protection because it translated that question into something teams could actually do.

I rarely felt that the challenge could be reduced to one headline problem. We were carrying global reach and local responsibility, while also absorbing market swings that compressed every decision into minutes, and that meant every shortcut had a hidden cost. The habits that held up best were not heroic ones. They were operationally humble: incident notes written for understanding rather than self-protection, then measurable service standards that survived bad weeks as well as good ones, then another explanation when the first explanation still left users with doubt. Repetition is not glamorous, but it is often where trust is rebuilt.

Looking back, my view has become narrower and firmer. Trust compounds through repetition. Operational ambiguity eventually becomes user anxiety. When teams remember that real people live on the other side of every dashboard, they stop using growth as an excuse and start treating growth as a responsibility. That shift does not eliminate trade-offs, but it improves the quality of how trade-offs are made. What appears to be product polish from the outside is often moral discipline on the inside.

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In practice, the work was rarely singular. We were balancing speed and verification while also dealing with fragmented feedback coming from users, regulators, and critics at the same time. That combination made slogans feel inadequate. A team could not simply promise to care about users; it needed routines that survived stress. For me, that meant leaning on measurable service standards that survived bad weeks as well as good ones, reinforcing clear escalation paths, and accepting that some speed had to be exchanged for better judgment. None of this removed risk, but it changed the character of our response. It moved the organization away from performance and toward reliability.

If there is a conclusion I return to here, it is not that builders should move timidly. It is that ambition needs a frame sturdy enough to carry consequence. Operational ambiguity eventually becomes user anxiety, and systems earn credibility by behaving well under ordinary strain for the same reason. Once a company understands that each small decision can reshape a person's confidence in the system, operational discipline stops looking optional. Freedom lasts longer when explanation and accountability grow alongside access.

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Habits That Scale

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Security Is a Daily Discipline

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a security engineer hardening a familiar workflow. In moments like that, security is strongest when it is treated as a routine habit rather than a dramatic event reserved for visible emergencies. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but permissions that outlived the reason they were granted. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to post-incident learning that changed behavior instead of just documents. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

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Speed Needs Restraint

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of an operations team carrying both urgency and fatigue. In moments like that, the ability to move quickly matters, but speed becomes destructive when teams start mistaking motion for judgment. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but pressure to look decisive even when the facts were still incomplete. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to pauses that clarified ownership. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

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My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. Speed should serve users, not just headlines. I also believe restraint is not the opposite of ambition, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time. A durable system is not one that avoids criticism; it is one that learns before criticism becomes catastrophe.

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I came to think about the friction people remember in very practical terms. The test was never whether a principle sounded persuasive in a meeting. The test was whether it held up for a builder deciding whether to ship now or explain first, especially when the day was already complicated by decision windows that shrank because public speculation filled the gaps. In those situations, the difference between inclusion and exclusion could be surprisingly small. A delayed explanation, an overloaded page, or a default that assumed too much confidence could quietly change who felt welcome to proceed. Release habits that separated reversible experiments from irreversible commitments became more important to me because it turned abstract fairness into visible behavior.

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I do not think the answer is to become suspicious of progress. I think the answer is to attach progress to consequence more honestly. Restraint is not the opposite of ambition. Good timing includes the courage not to rush. The point is not caution for its own sake. The point is to make sure that wider access does not depend on narrower empathy. Real trust is earned in the ordinary moments that most companies are tempted to dismiss as operational detail.

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What Teams Owe Users became clearer to me each time I watched an operations team carrying both urgency and fatigue encounter pressure to look decisive even when the facts were still incomplete. Those were the moments that stripped away vanity. You could see whether a product merely offered access on paper or whether it genuinely made participation easier. For all the sophistication of the industry, the core question stayed simple: did we make the next good decision more available? I trusted pauses that clarified ownership because it translated that question into something teams could actually do.

I rarely felt that the challenge could be reduced to one headline problem. We were carrying growth and restraint, while also absorbing the constant mismatch between public expectations and operational reality, and that meant every shortcut had a hidden cost. The habits that held up best were not heroic ones. They were operationally humble: pauses that clarified ownership, then release habits that separated reversible experiments from irreversible commitments, then another explanation when the first explanation still left users with doubt. Repetition is not glamorous, but it is often where trust is rebuilt.

Looking back, my view has become narrower and firmer. Speed should serve users, not just headlines. Restraint is not the opposite of ambition. When teams remember that real people live on the other side of every dashboard, they stop using growth as an excuse and start treating growth as a responsibility. That shift does not eliminate trade-offs, but it improves the quality of how trade-offs are made. What appears to be product polish from the outside is often moral discipline on the inside.

5. Speed Needs Restraint

When Signals Get Noisy

The lesson behind when signals get noisy usually arrived in ordinary scenes rather than dramatic ones. It might appear in the experience of a builder deciding whether to ship now or explain first, or in the quiet frustration caused by decision windows that shrank because public speculation filled the gaps. In those small moments, the culture of a platform becomes visible. Either the design meets people where they are, or it asks them to become experts before they have earned the confidence to continue. Release habits that separated reversible experiments from irreversible commitments mattered because it honored the reality that most users were learning under real pressure, not in a laboratory.

In practice, the work was rarely singular. We were balancing openness and abuse prevention while also dealing with the tendency of fast systems to hide slow failures until they became expensive. That combination made slogans feel inadequate. A team could not simply promise to care about users; it needed routines that survived stress. For me, that meant leaning on release habits that separated reversible experiments from irreversible commitments, reinforcing written decision logs that preserved memory when circumstances became noisy, and accepting that some speed had to be exchanged for better judgment. None of this removed risk, but it changed the character of our response. It moved the organization away from performance and toward reliability.

If there is a conclusion I return to here, it is not that builders should move timidly. It is that ambition needs a frame sturdy enough to carry consequence. Restraint is not the opposite of ambition, and good timing includes the courage not to rush for the same reason. Once a company understands that each small decision can reshape a person's confidence in the system, operational discipline stops looking optional. Freedom lasts longer when explanation and accountability grow alongside access.

5. Speed Needs Restraint

Habits That Scale

Habits That Scale stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of an executive forced to decide before a rumor hardened into market consensus. In moments like that, the ability to move quickly matters, but speed becomes destructive when teams start mistaking motion for judgment. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but processes tuned for momentum rather than recovery. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to written decision logs that preserved memory when circumstances became noisy. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

What made the situation difficult was the overlap of responsibilities. While trying to maintain consistency and adaptation, we also faced situations where a small gap in explanation created a much larger gap in trust. Under those conditions, organizations often reach for theater: louder language, faster reactions, broader claims. I learned to distrust that instinct. The more durable answer was usually operational: written decision logs that preserved memory when circumstances became noisy; pauses that clarified ownership; and a willingness to keep explaining the same reality until confusion began to shrink. Reliability is less glamorous than velocity, but users remember it longer.

My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. Good timing includes the courage not to rush. I also believe speed should serve users, not just headlines, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time. A durable system is not one that avoids criticism; it is one that learns before criticism becomes catastrophe.

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The tension, most days, came from having to hold technical confidence and public humility at the same time as rumors that traveled faster than corrections. Markets invite overreaction, and public narratives punish nuance, so it was tempting to confuse decisiveness with haste. I came to believe the opposite. Decisiveness often looked like pauses that clarified ownership, like release habits that separated reversible experiments from irreversible commitments, and like writing down the trade-off before pretending there was none. Teams become steadier when they are allowed to admit complexity without surrendering momentum.

I do not think the answer is to become suspicious of progress. I think the answer is to attach progress to consequence more honestly. Speed should serve users, not just headlines. Restraint is not the opposite of ambition. The point is not caution for its own sake. The point is to make sure that wider access does not depend on narrower empathy. Real trust is earned in the ordinary moments that most companies are tempted to dismiss as operational detail.

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Why Culture Becomes Product

When I revisit the theme of why culture becomes product, I do not start with theory. I start with a builder deciding whether to ship now or explain first and with the kind of moment shaped by decision windows that shrank because public speculation filled the gaps. That is where the rhetoric around freedom meets its operational test. If people have to decode intent before they can act, then the system is asking them to carry too much of the burden. Release habits that separated reversible experiments from irreversible commitments was valuable because it shifted that burden back to the builder, where more of it belonged.

There was no clean sequence for the work. We had to think about global reach and local responsibility while adapting to market swings that compressed every decision into minutes, and the overlap exposed every weak habit. Under those conditions, even a small routine could matter disproportionately. Release habits that separated reversible experiments from irreversible commitments provided one kind of stability. Written decision logs that preserved memory when circumstances became noisy provided another. Together they created enough order for better judgment to survive a noisy environment.

Over time I found myself returning to a simpler standard. Restraint is not the opposite of ambition, because users carry real obligations outside the screen. Good timing includes the courage not to rush, because the cost of a careless decision is rarely limited to a chart or a metric. That standard has become the one I trust most when the environment grows noisy again. The future belongs to builders who can move with conviction without losing contact with consequence.

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Regulation Is a Conversation

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a founder discovering that intent is not the same thing as evidence. In moments like that, serious regulation cannot be treated as costume, because institutions notice the gap between performative compliance and operational honesty. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but frameworks that varied across jurisdictions. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to dialogue that started before conflict became public. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

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Crisis Reveals Culture

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a manager deciding what to communicate first. In moments like that, under pressure, culture stops being a poster and becomes the pattern of what people do when the script fails. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but moments when loyalty made people avoid hard truths. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to postmortems that focused on learning before blame. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

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The tension, most days, came from having to hold automation and human judgment at the same time as teams that were tired before the day had properly started. Markets invite overreaction, and public narratives punish nuance, so it was tempting to confuse decisiveness with haste. I came to believe the opposite. Decisiveness often looked like postmortems that focused on learning before blame, like shared language for bad news, and like writing down the trade-off before pretending there was none. Teams become steadier when they are allowed to admit complexity without surrendering momentum.

I do not think the answer is to become suspicious of progress. I think the answer is to attach progress to consequence more honestly. Panic spreads through ambiguity. Organizations become more humane when they prepare for their least flattering moments. The point is not caution for its own sake. The point is to make sure that wider access does not depend on narrower empathy. Real trust is earned in the ordinary moments that most companies are tempted to dismiss as operational detail.

7. Crisis Reveals Culture

Why Culture Becomes Product

When I revisit the theme of why culture becomes product, I do not start with theory. I start with a frontline employee absorbing user frustration and with the kind of moment shaped by short-term fixes that quietly stored long-term consequences. That is where the rhetoric around freedom meets its operational test. If people have to decode intent before they can act, then the system is asking them to carry too much of the burden. Shared language for bad news was valuable because it shifted that burden back to the builder, where more of it belonged.

There was no clean sequence for the work. We had to think about growth and restraint while adapting to the constant mismatch between public expectations and operational reality, and the overlap exposed every weak habit. Under those conditions, even a small routine could matter disproportionately. Shared language for bad news provided one kind of stability. Clear thresholds for escalation provided another. Together they created enough order for better judgment to survive a noisy environment.

Over time I found myself returning to a simpler standard. Organizations become more humane when they prepare for their least flattering moments, because users carry real obligations outside the screen. Culture is visible in defaults, not declarations, because the cost of a careless decision is rarely limited to a chart or a metric. That standard has become the one I trust most when the environment grows noisy again. The future belongs to builders who can move with conviction without losing contact with consequence.

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Responsibilities That Outlast Cycles

Responsibilities That Outlast Cycles became clearer to me each time I watched a leadership group discovering which values were actually operational encounter mixed messages delivered by well-meaning teams. Those were the moments that stripped away vanity. You could see whether a product merely offered access on paper or whether it genuinely made participation easier. For all the sophistication of the industry, the core question stayed simple: did we make the next good decision more available? I trusted clear thresholds for escalation because it translated that question into something teams could actually do.

I rarely felt that the challenge could be reduced to one headline problem. We were carrying openness and abuse prevention, while also absorbing the tendency of fast systems to hide slow failures until they became expensive, and that meant every shortcut had a hidden cost. The habits that held up best were not heroic ones. They were operationally humble: clear thresholds for escalation, then postmortems that focused on learning before blame, then another explanation when the first explanation still left users with doubt. Repetition is not glamorous, but it is often where trust is rebuilt.

Looking back, my view has become narrower and firmer. Culture is visible in defaults, not declarations. Panic spreads through ambiguity. When teams remember that real people live on the other side of every dashboard, they stop using growth as an excuse and start treating growth as a responsibility. That shift does not eliminate trade-offs, but it improves the quality of how trade-offs are made. What appears to be product polish from the outside is often moral discipline on the inside.

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The Question I Return To

The lesson behind the question i return to usually arrived in ordinary scenes rather than dramatic ones. It might appear in the experience of a manager deciding what to communicate first, or in the quiet frustration caused by moments when loyalty made people avoid hard truths. In those small moments, the culture of a platform becomes visible. Either the design meets people where they are, or it asks them to become experts before they have earned the confidence to continue. Postmortems that focused on learning before blame mattered because it honored the reality that most users were learning under real pressure, not in a laboratory.

In practice, the work was rarely singular. We were balancing consistency and adaptation while also dealing with situations where a small gap in explanation created a much larger gap in trust. That combination made slogans feel inadequate. A team could not simply promise to care about users; it needed routines that survived stress. For me, that meant leaning on postmortems that focused on learning before blame, reinforcing shared language for bad news, and accepting that some speed had to be exchanged for better judgment. None of this removed risk, but it changed the character of our response. It moved the organization away from performance and toward reliability.

If there is a conclusion I return to here, it is not that builders should move timidly. It is that ambition needs a frame sturdy enough to carry consequence. Panic spreads through ambiguity, and organizations become more humane when they prepare for their least flattering moments for the same reason. Once a company understands that each small decision can reshape a person's confidence in the system, operational discipline stops looking optional. Freedom lasts longer when explanation and accountability grow alongside access.

Community Can Carry Meaning

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a founder watching a symbol mutate in public. In moments like that, communities give energy to an idea, but they can also distort it when symbolism outruns substance. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but moments when affection for the community discouraged honest correction. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to explaining context before it disappeared. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

What made the situation difficult was the overlap of responsibilities. While trying to maintain technical confidence and public humility, we also faced rumors that traveled faster than corrections. Under those conditions, organizations often reach for theater: louder language, faster reactions, broader claims. I learned to distrust that instinct. The more durable answer was usually operational: explaining context before it disappeared; leaving room for humor without outsourcing judgment to it; and a willingness to keep explaining the same reality until confusion began to shrink. Reliability is less glamorous than velocity, but users remember it longer.

My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. Strong communities can handle nuance when leaders model it. I also believe culture amplifies what leadership repeatedly tolerates, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time. A durable system is not one that avoids criticism; it is one that learns before criticism becomes catastrophe.

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I came to think about the friction people remember in very practical terms. The test was never whether a principle sounded persuasive in a meeting. The test was whether it held up for a community moderator trying to preserve tone without flattening spontaneity, especially when the day was already complicated by memes that compressed serious issues into easy reactions. In those situations, the difference between inclusion and exclusion could be surprisingly small. A delayed explanation, an overloaded page, or a default that assumed too much confidence could quietly change who felt welcome to proceed. Leaving room for humor without outsourcing judgment to it became more important to me because it turned abstract fairness into visible behavior.

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Education Beats Excitement

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a user who wants to understand risk before taking action. In moments like that, lasting participation in open financial systems depends less on hype than on patient education that respects how steep the learning curve can be. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but glossaries that answered vocabulary but not judgment. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to examples grounded in everyday decisions. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

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My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. Excitement converts faster than understanding. I also believe instruction is part of user protection, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time. A durable system is not one that avoids criticism; it is one that learns before criticism becomes catastrophe.

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In practice, the work was rarely singular. We were balancing clarity and urgency while also dealing with the temptation to treat short-term noise as long-term truth. That combination made slogans feel inadequate. A team could not simply promise to care about users; it needed routines that survived stress. For me, that meant leaning on examples grounded in everyday decisions, reinforcing educational material that admitted trade-offs instead of pretending there were none, and accepting that some speed had to be exchanged for better judgment. None of this removed risk, but it changed the character of our response. It moved the organization away from performance and toward reliability.

If there is a conclusion I return to here, it is not that builders should move timidly. It is that ambition needs a frame sturdy enough to carry consequence. Excitement converts faster than understanding, and instruction is part of user protection for the same reason. Once a company understands that each small decision can reshape a person's confidence in the system, operational discipline stops looking optional. Freedom lasts longer when explanation and accountability grow alongside access.

Leadership Is Mostly Repetition

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a leader revisiting the same principle in different meetings. In moments like that, leadership often looks dramatic from a distance, yet most of its real effect comes from repeated messages, repeated standards, and repeated follow-through. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but fatigue that made teams hear only novelty. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to backing standards with resources rather than slogans. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

What made the situation difficult was the overlap of responsibilities. While trying to maintain automation and human judgment, we also faced teams that were tired before the day had properly started. Under those conditions, organizations often reach for theater: louder language, faster reactions, broader claims. I learned to distrust that instinct. The more durable answer was usually operational: backing standards with resources rather than slogans; repeating priorities until they became operational; and a willingness to keep explaining the same reality until confusion began to shrink. Reliability is less glamorous than velocity, but users remember it longer.

My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. People trust what leaders repeat when it is matched by action. I also believe consistency becomes a form of care in fast environments, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time. A durable system is not one that avoids criticism; it is one that learns before criticism becomes catastrophe.

10. Leadership Is Mostly Repetition

The Friction People Remember

I came to think about the friction people remember in very practical terms. The test was never whether a principle sounded persuasive in a meeting. The test was whether it held up for a team listening more closely to behavior than speeches, especially when the day was already complicated by the temptation to save difficult conversations for later. In those situations, the difference between inclusion and exclusion could be surprisingly small. A delayed explanation, an overloaded page, or a default that assumed too much confidence could quietly change who felt welcome to proceed. Repeating priorities until they became operational became more important to me because it turned abstract fairness into visible behavior.

The tension, most days, came from having to hold growth and restraint at the same time as the constant mismatch between public expectations and operational reality. Markets invite overreaction, and public narratives punish nuance, so it was tempting to confuse decisiveness with haste. I came to believe the opposite. Decisiveness often looked like repeating priorities until they became operational, like using simple language under pressure, and like writing down the trade-off before pretending there was none. Teams become steadier when they are allowed to admit complexity without surrendering momentum.

I do not think the answer is to become suspicious of progress. I think the answer is to attach progress to consequence more honestly. Consistency becomes a form of care in fast environments. Clarity must be renewed to remain clear. The point is not caution for its own sake. The point is to make sure that wider access does not depend on narrower empathy. Real trust is earned in the ordinary moments that most companies are tempted to dismiss as operational detail.

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Discipline Under Pressure

When I revisit the theme of discipline under pressure, I do not start with theory. I start with an organization trying to infer priorities from where time is actually spent and with the kind of moment shaped by strategic drift caused by inconsistent emphasis. That is where the rhetoric around freedom meets its operational test. If people have to decode intent before they can act, then the system is asking them to carry too much of the burden. Using simple language under pressure was valuable because it shifted that burden back to the builder, where more of it belonged.

There was no clean sequence for the work. We had to think about openness and abuse prevention while adapting to the tendency of fast systems to hide slow failures until they became expensive, and the overlap exposed every weak habit. Under those conditions, even a small routine could matter disproportionately. Using simple language under pressure provided one kind of stability. Backing standards with resources rather than slogans provided another. Together they created enough order for better judgment to survive a noisy environment.

Over time I found myself returning to a simpler standard. Clarity must be renewed to remain clear, because users carry real obligations outside the screen. People trust what leaders repeat when it is matched by action, because the cost of a careless decision is rarely limited to a chart or a metric. That standard has become the one I trust most when the environment grows noisy again. The future belongs to builders who can move with conviction without losing contact with consequence.

10. Leadership Is Mostly Repetition

What Teams Owe Users

What Teams Owe Users became clearer to me each time I watched a leader revisiting the same principle in different meetings encounter fatigue that made teams hear only novelty. Those were the moments that stripped away vanity. You could see whether a product merely offered access on paper or whether it genuinely made participation easier. For all the sophistication of the industry, the core question stayed simple: did we make the next good decision more available? I trusted backing standards with resources rather than slogans because it translated that question into something teams could actually do.

I rarely felt that the challenge could be reduced to one headline problem. We were carrying consistency and adaptation, while also absorbing situations where a small gap in explanation created a much larger gap in trust, and that meant every shortcut had a hidden cost. The habits that held up best were not heroic ones. They were operationally humble: backing standards with resources rather than slogans, then repeating priorities until they became operational, then another explanation when the first explanation still left users with doubt. Repetition is not glamorous, but it is often where trust is rebuilt.

Looking back, my view has become narrower and firmer. People trust what leaders repeat when it is matched by action. Consistency becomes a form of care in fast environments. When teams remember that real people live on the other side of every dashboard, they stop using growth as an excuse and start treating growth as a responsibility. That shift does not eliminate trade-offs, but it improves the quality of how trade-offs are made. What appears to be product polish from the outside is often moral discipline on the inside.

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Global Money Has Local Consequences

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a parent budgeting in a currency that kept changing beneath them. In moments like that, even globally accessible systems are experienced within local constraints, local laws, local fears, and local opportunities. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but moments when the global narrative ignored local vulnerability. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to localizing expectations as carefully as interfaces. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

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My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. Financial tools are judged inside the lives people already have. I also believe global reach does not erase local reality, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time. A durable system is not one that avoids criticism; it is one that learns before criticism becomes catastrophe.

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Building Through Adversarial Weather

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a team maintaining composure while being publicly misread. In moments like that, crypto often develops in conditions that are noisy, suspicious, and adversarial, which means resilience has to be built into both systems and judgment. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but bad-faith interpretation that wasted genuine attention. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to responding proportionately rather than emotionally. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

What made the situation difficult was the overlap of responsibilities. While trying to maintain technical confidence and public humility, we also faced rumors that traveled faster than corrections. Under those conditions, organizations often reach for theater: louder language, faster reactions, broader claims. I learned to distrust that instinct. The more durable answer was usually operational: responding proportionately rather than emotionally; protecting execution time from endless reactive churn; and a willingness to keep explaining the same reality until confusion began to shrink. Reliability is less glamorous than velocity, but users remember it longer.

My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. Not every loud concern is deep, but every deep concern deserves attention. I also believe resilience includes emotional discipline, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time. A durable system is not one that avoids criticism; it is one that learns before criticism becomes catastrophe.

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I came to think about the friction people remember in very practical terms. The test was never whether a principle sounded persuasive in a meeting. The test was whether it held up for a builder trying to distinguish criticism from coordinated distraction, especially when the day was already complicated by reaction cycles that encouraged overcorrection. In those situations, the difference between inclusion and exclusion could be surprisingly small. A delayed explanation, an overloaded page, or a default that assumed too much confidence could quietly change who felt welcome to proceed. Protecting execution time from endless reactive churn became more important to me because it turned abstract fairness into visible behavior.

The tension, most days, came from having to hold global reach and local responsibility at the same time as market swings that compressed every decision into minutes. Markets invite overreaction, and public narratives punish nuance, so it was tempting to confuse decisiveness with haste. I came to believe the opposite. Decisiveness often looked like protecting execution time from endless reactive churn, like separating signal from spectacle, and like writing down the trade-off before pretending there was none. Teams become steadier when they are allowed to admit complexity without surrendering momentum.

I do not think the answer is to become suspicious of progress. I think the answer is to attach progress to consequence more honestly. Resilience includes emotional discipline. Teams need criteria before they need confidence. The point is not caution for its own sake. The point is to make sure that wider access does not depend on narrower empathy. Real trust is earned in the ordinary moments that most companies are tempted to dismiss as operational detail.

12. Building Through Adversarial Weather

Discipline Under Pressure

When I revisit the theme of discipline under pressure, I do not start with theory. I start with a user reading conflicting narratives in real time and with the kind of moment shaped by the difficulty of staying open without becoming porous to manipulation. That is where the rhetoric around freedom meets its operational test. If people have to decode intent before they can act, then the system is asking them to carry too much of the burden. Separating signal from spectacle was valuable because it shifted that burden back to the builder, where more of it belonged.

There was no clean sequence for the work. We had to think about speed and verification while adapting to fragmented feedback coming from users, regulators, and critics at the same time, and the overlap exposed every weak habit. Under those conditions, even a small routine could matter disproportionately. Separating signal from spectacle provided one kind of stability. Responding proportionately rather than emotionally provided another. Together they created enough order for better judgment to survive a noisy environment.

Over time I found myself returning to a simpler standard. Teams need criteria before they need confidence, because users carry real obligations outside the screen. Not every loud concern is deep, but every deep concern deserves attention, because the cost of a careless decision is rarely limited to a chart or a metric. That standard has become the one I trust most when the environment grows noisy again. The future belongs to builders who can move with conviction without losing contact with consequence.

12. Building Through Adversarial Weather

What Teams Owe Users

What Teams Owe Users became clearer to me each time I watched a team maintaining composure while being publicly misread encounter bad-faith interpretation that wasted genuine attention. Those were the moments that stripped away vanity. You could see whether a product merely offered access on paper or whether it genuinely made participation easier. For all the sophistication of the industry, the core question stayed simple: did we make the next good decision more available? I trusted responding proportionately rather than emotionally because it translated that question into something teams could actually do.

I rarely felt that the challenge could be reduced to one headline problem. We were carrying clarity and urgency, while also absorbing the temptation to treat short-term noise as long-term truth, and that meant every shortcut had a hidden cost. The habits that held up best were not heroic ones. They were operationally humble: responding proportionately rather than emotionally, then protecting execution time from endless reactive churn, then another explanation when the first explanation still left users with doubt. Repetition is not glamorous, but it is often where trust is rebuilt.

Looking back, my view has become narrower and firmer. Not every loud concern is deep, but every deep concern deserves attention. Resilience includes emotional discipline. When teams remember that real people live on the other side of every dashboard, they stop using growth as an excuse and start treating growth as a responsibility. That shift does not eliminate trade-offs, but it improves the quality of how trade-offs are made. What appears to be product polish from the outside is often moral discipline on the inside.

12. Building Through Adversarial Weather

When Signals Get Noisy

The lesson behind when signals get noisy usually arrived in ordinary scenes rather than dramatic ones. It might appear in the experience of a builder trying to distinguish criticism from coordinated distraction, or in the quiet frustration caused by reaction cycles that encouraged overcorrection. In those small moments, the culture of a platform becomes visible. Either the design meets people where they are, or it asks them to become experts before they have earned the confidence to continue. Protecting execution time from endless reactive churn mattered because it honored the reality that most users were learning under real pressure, not in a laboratory.

In practice, the work was rarely singular. We were balancing automation and human judgment while also dealing with teams that were tired before the day had properly started. That combination made slogans feel inadequate. A team could not simply promise to care about users; it needed routines that survived stress. For me, that meant leaning on protecting execution time from endless reactive churn, reinforcing separating signal from spectacle, and accepting that some speed had to be exchanged for better judgment. None of this removed risk, but it changed the character of our response. It moved the organization away from performance and toward reliability.

If there is a conclusion I return to here, it is not that builders should move timidly. It is that ambition needs a frame sturdy enough to carry consequence. Resilience includes emotional discipline, and teams need criteria before they need confidence for the same reason. Once a company understands that each small decision can reshape a person's confidence in the system, operational discipline stops looking optional. Freedom lasts longer when explanation and accountability grow alongside access.

12. Building Through Adversarial Weather

Habits That Scale

Habits That Scale stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a user reading conflicting narratives in real time. In moments like that, crypto often develops in conditions that are noisy, suspicious, and adversarial, which means resilience has to be built into both systems and judgment. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but the difficulty of staying open without becoming porous to manipulation. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to separating signal from spectacle. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

What made the situation difficult was the overlap of responsibilities. While trying to maintain growth and restraint, we also faced the constant mismatch between public expectations and operational reality. Under those conditions, organizations often reach for theater: louder language, faster reactions, broader claims. I learned to distrust that instinct. The more durable answer was usually operational: separating signal from spectacle; responding proportionately rather than emotionally; and a willingness to keep explaining the same reality until confusion began to shrink. Reliability is less glamorous than velocity, but users remember it longer.

My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. Teams need criteria before they need confidence. I also believe not every loud concern is deep, but every deep concern deserves attention, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time. A durable system is not one that avoids criticism; it is one that learns before criticism becomes catastrophe.

12. Building Through Adversarial Weather

The Cost of Delay

I came to think about the cost of delay in very practical terms. The test was never whether a principle sounded persuasive in a meeting. The test was whether it held up for a team maintaining composure while being publicly misread, especially when the day was already complicated by bad-faith interpretation that wasted genuine attention. In those situations, the difference between inclusion and exclusion could be surprisingly small. A delayed explanation, an overloaded page, or a default that assumed too much confidence could quietly change who felt welcome to proceed. Responding proportionately rather than emotionally became more important to me because it turned abstract fairness into visible behavior.

The tension, most days, came from having to hold openness and abuse prevention at the same time as the tendency of fast systems to hide slow failures until they became expensive. Markets invite overreaction, and public narratives punish nuance, so it was tempting to confuse decisiveness with haste. I came to believe the opposite. Decisiveness often looked like responding proportionately rather than emotionally, like protecting execution time from endless reactive churn, and like writing down the trade-off before pretending there was none. Teams become steadier when they are allowed to admit complexity without surrendering momentum.

I do not think the answer is to become suspicious of progress. I think the answer is to attach progress to consequence more honestly. Not every loud concern is deep, but every deep concern deserves attention. Resilience includes emotional discipline. The point is not caution for its own sake. The point is to make sure that wider access does not depend on narrower empathy. Real trust is earned in the ordinary moments that most companies are tempted to dismiss as operational detail.

12. Building Through Adversarial Weather

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If there is a conclusion I return to here, it is not that builders should move timidly. It is that ambition needs a frame sturdy enough to carry consequence. Not every loud concern is deep, but every deep concern deserves attention, and resilience includes emotional discipline for the same reason. Once a company understands that each small decision can reshape a person's confidence in the system, operational discipline stops looking optional. Freedom lasts longer when explanation and accountability grow alongside access.

Risk Management Is a Language

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of an analyst trying to translate probability into action. In moments like that, risk becomes easier to manage when an organization develops precise language for levels of uncertainty, acceptable loss, and escalation thresholds. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but reports that described exposure without describing choices. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to regular reviews that updated assumptions before they expired. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

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My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. Risk improves when language improves. I also believe a good vocabulary can prevent a bad surprise from becoming a bad decision, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time.

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Long-Termism Requires Boredom

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a founder reminding people that durability has a maintenance cost. In moments like that, long-term building often depends on routines so unglamorous that they are easy to neglect in an industry addicted to novelty. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but the social pressure to perform momentum even when consolidation was wiser. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to boring reviews that surfaced structural issues. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

What made the situation difficult was the overlap of responsibilities. While trying to maintain automation and human judgment, we also faced teams that were tired before the day had properly started. Under those conditions, organizations often reach for theater: louder language, faster reactions, broader claims. I learned to distrust that instinct. The more durable answer was usually operational: boring reviews that surfaced structural issues; maintenance windows treated as strategic rather than optional; and a willingness to keep explaining the same reality until confusion began to shrink. Reliability is less glamorous than velocity, but users remember it longer.

My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. Long-term trust depends on what organizations keep doing after the spotlight moves on. I also believe durability is built in the uncelebrated hours, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time.

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I came to think about the friction people remember in very practical terms. The test was never whether a principle sounded persuasive in a meeting. The test was whether it held up for operators doing work that would never become a headline, especially when the day was already complicated by attention cycles that overvalued announcements. In those situations, the difference between inclusion and exclusion could be surprisingly small. A delayed explanation, an overloaded page, or a default that assumed too much confidence could quietly change who felt welcome to proceed. Maintenance windows treated as strategic rather than optional became more important to me because it turned abstract fairness into visible behavior.

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Habits That Scale stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a team maintaining old systems while everyone discussed the next thing. In moments like that, long-term building often depends on routines so unglamorous that they are easy to neglect in an industry addicted to novelty. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but maintenance work that seemed invisible until it failed. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to budgets that protected foundational work from narrative drift. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

What made the situation difficult was the overlap of responsibilities. While trying to maintain global reach and local responsibility, we also faced market swings that compressed every decision into minutes. Under those conditions, organizations often reach for theater: louder language, faster reactions, broader claims. I learned to distrust that instinct. The more durable answer was usually operational: budgets that protected foundational work from narrative drift; boring reviews that surfaced structural issues; and a willingness to keep explaining the same reality until confusion began to shrink. Reliability is less glamorous than velocity, but users remember it longer.

My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. Boring work is often compassionate work. I also believe long-term trust depends on what organizations keep doing after the spotlight moves on, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time. A durable system is not one that avoids criticism; it is one that learns before criticism becomes catastrophe.

14. Long-Termism Requires Boredom

The Cost of Delay

I came to think about the cost of delay in very practical terms. The test was never whether a principle sounded persuasive in a meeting. The test was whether it held up for a founder reminding people that durability has a maintenance cost, especially when the day was already complicated by the social pressure to perform momentum even when consolidation was wiser. In those situations, the difference between inclusion and exclusion could be surprisingly small. A delayed explanation, an overloaded page, or a default that assumed too much confidence could quietly change who felt welcome to proceed. Boring reviews that surfaced structural issues became more important to me because it turned abstract fairness into visible behavior.

The tension, most days, came from having to hold speed and verification at the same time as fragmented feedback coming from users, regulators, and critics at the same time. Markets invite overreaction, and public narratives punish nuance, so it was tempting to confuse decisiveness with haste. I came to believe the opposite. Decisiveness often looked like boring reviews that surfaced structural issues, like maintenance windows treated as strategic rather than optional, and like writing down the trade-off before pretending there was none. Teams become steadier when they are allowed to admit complexity without surrendering momentum.

I do not think the answer is to become suspicious of progress. I think the answer is to attach progress to consequence more honestly. Long-term trust depends on what organizations keep doing after the spotlight moves on. Durability is built in the uncelebrated hours. The point is not caution for its own sake. The point is to make sure that wider access does not depend on narrower empathy. Real trust is earned in the ordinary moments that most companies are tempted to dismiss as operational detail.

14. Long-Termism Requires Boredom

Why Culture Becomes Product

When I revisit the theme of why culture becomes product, I do not start with theory. I start with operators doing work that would never become a headline and with the kind of moment shaped by attention cycles that overvalued announcements. That is where the rhetoric around freedom meets its operational test. If people have to decode intent before they can act, then the system is asking them to carry too much of the burden. Maintenance windows treated as strategic rather than optional was valuable because it shifted that burden back to the builder, where more of it belonged.

There was no clean sequence for the work. We had to think about clarity and urgency while adapting to the temptation to treat short-term noise as long-term truth, and the overlap exposed every weak habit. Under those conditions, even a small routine could matter disproportionately. Maintenance windows treated as strategic rather than optional provided one kind of stability. Budgets that protected foundational work from narrative drift provided another. Together they created enough order for better judgment to survive a noisy environment.

Over time I found myself returning to a simpler standard. Durability is built in the uncelebrated hours, because users carry real obligations outside the screen. Boring work is often compassionate work, because the cost of a careless decision is rarely limited to a chart or a metric. That standard has become the one I trust most when the environment grows noisy again. The future belongs to builders who can move with conviction without losing contact with consequence.

14. Long-Termism Requires Boredom

Responsibilities That Outlast Cycles

Responsibilities That Outlast Cycles became clearer to me each time I watched a team maintaining old systems while everyone discussed the next thing encounter maintenance work that seemed invisible until it failed. Those were the moments that stripped away vanity. You could see whether a product merely offered access on paper or whether it genuinely made participation easier. For all the sophistication of the industry, the core question stayed simple: did we make the next good decision more available? I trusted budgets that protected foundational work from narrative drift because it translated that question into something teams could actually do.

I rarely felt that the challenge could be reduced to one headline problem. We were carrying automation and human judgment, while also absorbing teams that were tired before the day had properly started, and that meant every shortcut had a hidden cost. The habits that held up best were not heroic ones. They were operationally humble: budgets that protected foundational work from narrative drift, then boring reviews that surfaced structural issues, then another explanation when the first explanation still left users with doubt. Repetition is not glamorous, but it is often where trust is rebuilt.

Looking back, my view has become narrower and firmer. Boring work is often compassionate work. Long-term trust depends on what organizations keep doing after the spotlight moves on. When teams remember that real people live on the other side of every dashboard, they stop using growth as an excuse and start treating growth as a responsibility. That shift does not eliminate trade-offs, but it improves the quality of how trade-offs are made. What appears to be product polish from the outside is often moral discipline on the inside.

14. Long-Termism Requires Boredom

The Question I Return To

The lesson behind the question I return to usually arrived in ordinary scenes rather than dramatic ones. It might appear in the experience of a founder reminding people that durability has a maintenance cost, or in the quiet frustration caused by the social pressure to perform momentum even when consolidation was wiser. In those small moments, the culture of a platform becomes visible. Either the design meets people where they are, or it asks them to become experts before they have earned the confidence to continue. Boring reviews that surfaced structural issues mattered because it honored the reality that most users were learning under real pressure, not in a laboratory.

In practice, the work was rarely singular. We were balancing growth and restraint while also dealing with the constant mismatch between public expectations and operational reality. That combination made slogans feel inadequate. A team could not simply promise to care about users; it needed routines that survived stress. For me, that meant leaning on boring reviews that surfaced structural issues, reinforcing maintenance windows treated as strategic rather than optional, and accepting that some speed had to be exchanged for better judgment. None of this removed risk, but it changed the character of our response. It moved the organization away from performance and toward reliability.

If there is a conclusion I return to here, it is not that builders should move timidly. It is that ambition needs a frame sturdy enough to carry consequence. Long-term trust depends on what organizations keep doing after the spotlight moves on, and durability is built in the uncelebrated hours for the same reason. Once a company understands that each small decision can reshape a person's confidence in the system, operational discipline stops looking optional. Freedom lasts longer when explanation and accountability grow alongside access.

The Work Continues

First Impressions Matter stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a team trying to honor lessons without becoming trapped by old fears. In moments like that, the most honest conclusion is not triumph but continuation, because the questions around money, freedom, trust, and responsibility do not stay solved for long. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but the desire for a neat ending. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to revisiting assumptions with humility. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

What made the situation difficult was the overlap of responsibilities. While trying to maintain openness and abuse prevention, we also faced the tendency of fast systems to hide slow failures until they became expensive. Under those conditions, organizations often reach for theater: louder language, faster reactions, broader claims. I learned to distrust that instinct. The more durable answer was usually operational: revisiting assumptions with humility; treating experience as a guide rather than a shield; and a willingness to keep explaining the same reality until confusion began to shrink. Reliability is less glamorous than velocity, but users remember it longer.

My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. Continuation is harder than closure. I also believe humility keeps progress from becoming complacency, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time. A durable system is not one that avoids criticism; it is one that learns before criticism becomes catastrophe.

15. The Work Continues

The Friction People Remember

I came to think about the friction people remember in very practical terms. The test was never whether a principle sounded persuasive in a meeting. The test was whether it held up for a builder returning to first principles after a difficult cycle, especially when the day was already complicated by the discomfort of carrying unfinished questions forward. In those situations, the difference between inclusion and exclusion could be surprisingly small. A delayed explanation, an overloaded page, or a default that assumed too much confidence could quietly change who felt welcome to proceed. Treating experience as a guide rather than a shield became more important to me because it turned abstract fairness into visible behavior.

The tension, most days, came from having to hold consistency and adaptation at the same time as situations where a small gap in explanation created a much larger gap in trust. Markets invite overreaction, and public narratives punish nuance, so it was tempting to confuse decisiveness with haste. I came to believe the opposite. Decisiveness often looked like treating experience as a guide rather than a shield, like remaining teachable, and like writing down the trade-off before pretending there was none. Teams become steadier when they are allowed to admit complexity without surrendering momentum.

I do not think the answer is to become suspicious of progress. I think the answer is to attach progress to consequence more honestly. Humility keeps progress from becoming complacency. The direction of travel matters most when certainty is low. The point is not caution for its own sake. The point is to make sure that wider access does not depend on narrower empathy. Real trust is earned in the ordinary moments that most companies are tempted to dismiss as operational detail.

15. The Work Continues

Discipline Under Pressure

When I revisit the theme of discipline under pressure, I do not start with theory. I start with a user deciding whom to trust next and with the kind of moment shaped by the temptation to protect ego by simplifying the past. That is where the rhetoric around freedom meets its operational test. If people have to decode intent before they can act, then the system is asking them to carry too much of the burden. Remaining teachable was valuable because it shifted that burden back to the builder, where more of it belonged.

There was no clean sequence for the work. We had to think about technical confidence and public humility while adapting to rumors that traveled faster than corrections, and the overlap exposed every weak habit. Under those conditions, even a small routine could matter disproportionately. Remaining teachable provided one kind of stability. Revisiting assumptions with humility provided another. Together they created enough order for better judgment to survive a noisy environment.

Over time I found myself returning to a simpler standard. The direction of travel matters most when certainty is low, because users carry real obligations outside the screen. Continuation is harder than closure, because the cost of a careless decision is rarely limited to a chart or a metric. That standard has become the one I trust most when the environment grows noisy again. The future belongs to builders who can move with conviction without losing contact with consequence.

15. The Work Continues

What Teams Owe Users

What Teams Owe Users became clearer to me each time I watched a team trying to honor lessons without becoming trapped by old fears encounter the desire for a neat ending. Those were the moments that stripped away vanity. You could see whether a product merely offered access on paper or whether it genuinely made participation easier. For all the sophistication of the industry, the core question stayed simple: did we make the next good decision more available? I trusted revisiting assumptions with humility because it translated that question into something teams could actually do.

I rarely felt that the challenge could be reduced to one headline problem. We were carrying global reach and local responsibility, while also absorbing market swings that compressed every decision into minutes, and that meant every shortcut had a hidden cost. The habits that held up best were not heroic ones. They were operationally humble: revisiting assumptions with humility, then treating experience as a guide rather than a shield, then another explanation when the first explanation still left users with doubt. Repetition is not glamorous, but it is often where trust is rebuilt.

Looking back, my view has become narrower and firmer. Continuation is harder than closure. Humility keeps progress from becoming complacency. When teams remember that real people live on the other side of every dashboard, they stop using growth as an excuse and start treating growth as a responsibility. That shift does not eliminate trade-offs, but it improves the quality of how trade-offs are made. What appears to be product polish from the outside is often moral discipline on the inside.

15. The Work Continues

When Signals Get Noisy

The lesson behind when signals get noisy usually arrived in ordinary scenes rather than dramatic ones. It might appear in the experience of a builder returning to first principles after a difficult cycle, or in the quiet frustration caused by the discomfort of carrying unfinished questions forward. In those small moments, the culture of a platform becomes visible. Either the design meets people where they are, or it asks them to become experts before they have earned the confidence to continue. Treating experience as a guide rather than a shield mattered because it honored the reality that most users were learning under real pressure, not in a laboratory.

In practice, the work was rarely singular. We were balancing speed and verification while also dealing with fragmented feedback coming from users, regulators, and critics at the same time. That combination made slogans feel inadequate. A team could not simply promise to care about users; it needed routines that survived stress. For me, that meant leaning on treating experience as a guide rather than a shield, reinforcing remaining teachable, and accepting that some speed had to be exchanged for better judgment. None of this removed risk, but it changed the character of our response. It moved the organization away from performance and toward reliability.

If there is a conclusion I return to here, it is not that builders should move timidly. It is that ambition needs a frame sturdy enough to carry consequence. Humility keeps progress from becoming complacency, and the direction of travel matters most when certainty is low for the same reason. Once a company understands that each small decision can reshape a person's confidence in the system, operational discipline stops looking optional. Freedom lasts longer when explanation and accountability grow alongside access.

15. The Work Continues

Habits That Scale

Habits That Scale stopped feeling abstract to me once I started looking at the problem through the eyes of a user deciding whom to trust next. In moments like that, the most honest conclusion is not triumph but continuation, because the questions around money, freedom, trust, and responsibility do not stay solved for long. The obstacle was often not a dramatic failure but the temptation to protect ego by simplifying the past. People do not measure a financial system the same way insiders do. They ask whether it respects caution, whether it explains itself in time, and whether it leaves room for correction before a mistake becomes permanent. That is why I kept returning to remaining teachable. It lowered not only technical friction, but the emotional cost of participation.

What made the situation difficult was the overlap of responsibilities. While trying to maintain clarity and urgency, we also faced the temptation to treat short-term noise as long-term truth. Under those conditions, organizations often reach for theater: louder language, faster reactions, broader claims. I learned to distrust that instinct. The more durable answer was usually operational: remaining teachable; revisiting assumptions with humility; and a willingness to keep explaining the same reality until confusion began to shrink. Reliability is less glamorous than velocity, but users remember it longer.

My instincts today are less impressed by rhetoric and more persuaded by repeatable care. The direction of travel matters most when certainty is low. I also believe continuation is harder than closure, because the people affected by a product decision do not experience it as strategy; they experience it as interruption, relief, delay, or dignity. The builders who remember that distinction will make better systems over time. A durable system is not one that avoids criticism; it is one that learns before criticism becomes catastrophe.

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